Beg For Me

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Beg For Me

by n7punk

Summary

Catra never wanted to be chained to a life of corporate monotony, but being a starving artist wasn't all it was cracked up to be. Her day job might not be a traditional one by any means, but it lets her afford her passion and has plenty of downtime. Catra likes being her own boss and she makes good money, at least. Being a professional dominatrix works out well for her up until she gets hired for a bachelorette party and discovers that the maid of honor is her ex – and somehow, her new regular now.
(Adora/Dom Catra Modern AU)

Reintroduction

Chapter Notes

> Disclaimer: I'm not a professional, well, anything, but specifically not a pro domme. I researched what I could. Catra and Adora are about 25.
> I'm pre-emptively adding some kink tags to give a warning/idea for what will be in the fic, but I might end up removing some if something outlined doesn't happen, and I could add more as the story progresses.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You have got to be kidding me," Glimmer says, mouth gaping open. Mermista is sending Adora a *disappointed* look. Adora, rather wisely she thinks, downs her entire glass before anyone can stop her. She knows how she got roped into a conversation about her sex history, but this was not how she expected the bachelorette party preparation to go.

"I really wish I was," Adora mutters, not making eye contact with her friends as she raises her empty glass and whistles. Over by the bar, Sea Hawk brightens, giving her a thumbs up before turning to make her another drink. Bow had his bachelor party in Mermista's bar last night, and now Adora, Glimmer, Mermista, and Sea Hawk have returned a few hours before Glimmer's party to settle the details for the last hurrah before the wedding ceremony tomorrow.

Adora, despite being Glimmer's maid of honor, had very few duties when it came to party planning. Everyone knew better than to trust her when it came to planning a party. She knew Mermista was hiring *someone*, but she was blindsided when Mermista showed her the consent forms that she needed everyone to sign and saw that she hired a *dominatrix* instead of the usual stripper you hear about at these things. Adora had to open her big mouth in her surprise and her friends dug into her startled comment until they ended up with *this* admission.

"*Five years?* No wonder you're such a freak," Mermista muses, not looking up from her phone. Adora grimaces, but she shrugs. They have played drunk Never Have I Ever. Adora doesn't remember much of that night, but she certainly remembers the weeks of teasing and jokes that followed. Bow eventually took pity on her and wrote her a list of the things that he, the most sober among them, remembered her admitting to. He handed it to her at work and ordered her not to read it until she got home.

Adora, of course, read it the instant she was in the privacy of her office. She knew she had admitted sexual stuff, that was obvious from the teasing, but she wasn't expecting the first line to be *ropebunny*. She wasn't expecting the ninth to just be *choked*. There was no context for whether people thought that was sexual - because it *wasn't*, it was broccoli and a poorly-timed joke - but the other stuff on the list spoke for itself. Adora texted Bow for an

emergency meeting. He was judgmental, but he should have known Adora would read it immediately.

It was too late to stop her drunken self, but she just wanted to know how it happened. She had never talked about anything related to sex with her friends. Apparently someone else admitted to having been tied up in bed during the game and Adora, in all her drunken glory, decided the best response to that was *wish that was me*. She launched into an incoherent ranting about some more taboo topics around sex because alright, it had been a five-year dry spell, and she was just as pent up then as she is now.

"Yeah, *no fucking wonder*. You need to get laid," Glimmer agrees, leaning forward with the single-minded intensity of someone who has had no role in the planning of her own wedding and wants to take control of something else. That something is not about to be Adora's sex life. It's not her fault that between Glimmer's mother, her aunt, and Bow's dads, Glimmer hasn't gotten to decide much of the details of her wedding. Adora snorts, rolling her eyes and leaning away from the table to accept her new drink from Sea Hawk as he extends it to her.

"I'm still in love with my ex, too busy for a real relationship, don't trust a stranger in bed, and don't have the time to get to know someone new," Adora lists off, raising a pinky from her glass just to be an asshole as she sips it. She sends Glimmer a challenging look over the top of her drink. Adora would *love* to break the last streak she ever wanted to form, but she is a practical person, and every solution she came up with had issues.

"Adora, your eyes glazed over when Mermista made a joke about you getting a *choker*. It's starting to get obvious. I don't know how we missed it before," Glimmer argues back. Adora flushes, fidgeting a little in her seat. That is *true*, unfortunately, but she was already having a spectacularly rough day at that point. Her emotions were running high organizing things for the wedding and trying not to think about how she always envisioned her own going – and especially not who she pictured it *with*.

"You were convinced I was innocent," Adora counters, because deflecting onto her friends' idiocy might be her only hope of getting out of this conversation. She was just supposed to come pick up the stack of forms and bring them back to the hotel, but instead she is trapped under Glimmer's gaze and a glass of champagne deep while Mermista looks on with no sympathy.

"Babe, the next time we break up, I'm going to take the L and sleep with Adora," Mermista interrupts, looking up to make eye contact with Sea Hawk behind the bar. Adora sputters as Glimmer breaks out cackling. Adora's entire face feels hot. Okay, so she and Mermista kissed *once* when they were both drunk and Mermista was on a break with Sea Hawk, but Adora isn't the type to just sleep with her friends. After her last relationship ended in flames, she knows better than to mess around like that.

"Of course, dear. You're a good friend," Sea Hawk returns, nodding sympathetically and seemingly completely unphased by the declaration. Glimmer's laughter has made her go as red in the face as Adora gapes at her friends. Sea Hawk just continues to prepare the bar for the evening as Mermista looks smug.

“Does no one care what I have to say about this?” Adora hisses, not having enough air to make a real demand. She can’t believe this is happening. Even worse, she knows this is just *foreplay* to the teasing her friends are going to lay on her during the bachelorette party. Adora can’t bail on it. Mermista’s plan or not, Adora is the maid of honor. She has to be there to take care of anything Mermista needs help with so Glimmer can get to just enjoy something about this weekend. Perhaps to torture her, Mermista has put Adora in charge of dealing with the dominatrix once she shows up.

“Nope,” Mermista returns, popping the *p* as she picks up the untouched champagne glass that Sea Hawk brought for *Adora* and sips it. Adora is pretty sure she has never been this red before.

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“Ew,” Catra greets, wrinkling her nose at the scent that hits her nose as soon as she steps into the shared dungeon space. Lonnie laughs from where she is disinfecting their bench.

“He came in his pants like ten minutes into the session. It was pathetic,” Lonnie tells her. They don’t touch their clients like – the goal is subspace and emotional satisfaction, not orgasm – but disinfecting is still important and Catra is thankful for it because the smell of desire in the room kind of *sucks*. There is a reason that Catra only takes the female clients. Not that Lonnie is actually all that interested in much of anyone, least of all men, but she doesn’t mind them begging her.

“Did you tell him that?” Catra asks as she sweeps into the space to pick up her gear from the rack on the wall. They share the more expensive equipment like the bench Lonnie is currently removing the traces of sweat from, but there is no need for them to share things like riding crops. Catra’s job tonight is a party off-site from the dungeon she and Lonnie split the rent on, but all her gear is here, so she is dropping by to pick things up first. Lonnie snickers as she straightens up from the bench.

“*A lot*,” she assures, throwing a wicked smirk over her shoulder in Catra’s direction. Catra chuckles, ducking down to stow away her toys in her bag for transport. Not that the leather romper she is wearing is that subtle, but she can pass for a punk. She doesn’t wear lingerie for her job - it’s not her style nor the *point* - so despite her current outfit being sexier than her typical clothes, it isn’t inappropriate, especially not with the zipper that runs up the entire front zipped up to her neck. She will decide how far she is comfortable unzipping it once she arrives at the party.

She doesn’t do a lot of them. The number one rule of a job like hers is safety. If you aren’t a survival sex worker and can afford to, that means turning down any scenario that puts you at risk. Catra started as a pro dom by working parties at the kinky leather bar that Lonnie used to bartend at though, so a bachelorette gig isn’t that far outside of her comfort zone even if it isn’t her usual fair anymore. There will be the bar workers present as witnesses if the party does get out of hand, at least.

“How long is the party supposed to be?” Lonnie asks, grunting a little as she lifts the end of the bench and drags it to the side of the room. Catra checks that her whip ropes are properly coiled and won't get knotted before she zips up her bag and hauls it over her shoulder. Lonnie never does parties like Catra does, but them looking out for each other extends to this too. Catra texts Lonnie when she arrives and then again when she leaves.

“Hour session, so probably an hour and a half with the set up and cool down,” Catra tells her. Things like that are where they differ as doms. Catra bills her sessions as hourly, but she always sets aside an extra half hour at the end. The sessions themselves usually come in at fifteen under an hour, but she never wants to be rushed when laying out the rules at the beginning and she especially doesn’t want to limit the aftercare and cut someone loose before they’re ready. Parties like this are mostly about doing demonstrations and education, so that shouldn’t be an issue today, but dealing with the logistics of a large group takes time too.

“Alright. Text me if you need anything,” Lonnie tells her as Catra heads for the door. She salutes over her shoulder. They have been doing this for four years now. They have their routine down. Lonnie knows Catra’s safe word – her *real* safe word, not the ones she tells clients to use when they don’t bring their own – and if Catra doesn’t text her or somehow communicates that word, then she will know to call up Rogelio and Scorpia for help.

Catra isn’t worried, though. This bar is just down the block from a hotel that hosts a lot of weddings. The reviews include a lot of satisfied bachelor and bachelorette parties. The venue should be fine, and events like this are usually filled with giggling bridesmaids and blushing brides beginning to doubt their choice in spouse as the night goes on. Catra will show them her tricks, probably deal with a few drunks, and get a fat paycheck for it.

These events leave her less drained that her usual work since they’re a lot less emotional, but it is rare to get a request for them, so she has to mostly make her income off private sessions despite how they are harder on her. She has a bit of a spring in her step as she sets out through the halls of the suspiciously-well soundproofed “tantric yoga” studio where she and Lonnie share rent on a space as “private instructors”. Her only worry about tonight is how drunk everybody will be.

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Adora spends the afternoon running around the hotel and getting everyone in the bridesmaid party to sign the consent form, which isn’t something she really expected a bachelorette party to need, but given that there is a dominatrix coming, she gets the caution. Adora has to sign the form herself, agreeing not to touch the performer or engage in any acts with her unless invited to and certifying that if she volunteers to participate in any of the demonstrations then she will be sober.

It also stipulates that it isn’t the dominatrix’s responsibility to track what they are drinking and that they accept full responsibility for their own actions, drunken or sober. It adds that the demonstrations are education-focused and reiterates that this is not “full-service work”. It is

the kind of form that makes her frown. It seems to be written from a place of experience. Sex work may be legal in Etheria, but that doesn't mean it is easy or holds much respect. The form speaks to clients previously trying to demand more than what they paid for.

Adora can't help but think of the bar Lonnie was working at when they last spoke. It was a leather bar that put on some BDSM-themed events like this. They took no shit there and Adora is determined the performer won't have to put up with any tonight either. Not that she is worried about her friends crossing any lines, but she makes sure everybody who signs the form actually reads it as they do. When people start filtering into the bar that evening, she collects their IDs while Mermista deals with the catering.

She already knows everybody is of-age, but Mermista needs to take a copy of all the IDs for the bar's legal records when it comes to rented-out events, and the dominatrix wants a copy for similar reasons, though centered around the age of consent and not the drinking age. Adora might not have been trusted to come up with fun activities, but she is great with logistics, so she finds herself in the private reception area at the front of the bar – Mermista runs a classy place, but the area is as much a buffer for the bouncers as it is a lobby – waiting to greet the performer as she doublechecks that she has all the papers for her.

With the bar privately rented, the bouncers are running off a guest-list. Adora hears the door open, the heavy wind raging for a moment before it slams shut behind the new arrival. Everybody named on the guest list has already arrived, so that only leaves the performer from the dungeon appropriately named *the Fright Zone*. Adora looks up, opening her mouth to speak, and feels her greeting die in her throat as she comes face-to-face with the last person that she ever expected to see again.

Adora gapes at a leather-clad Catra as her ex-*everything* stares back at her, her fur bristling on her shoulders and her tail steadily poofing out. Even in her shock, Adora registers Catra's claws snapping out. It may have been five years, but she knows her best friend, and that means her emotions are running high. Adora scrambles, taking a step forward and thrusting the consent forms out to her old friend. Catra holds her ground despite how she bristles at Adora's advance.

"I swear I didn't know it was you," Adora rushes out. She knows the accusation was just a moment away from rolling off her tongue. Catra releases a short, cut off hiss, her eyes darting around the room, but it is just them, the rest of the party back in the bar proper. There isn't any secret ambush waiting aside from Adora herself. Adora swallows as she watches Catra run calculations in her mind, her tail lashing behind her.

"It's my friend's wedding. I didn't even know you had moved to Bright Moon," Adora adds on. Her heart is racing, blood pounding in her ears as it sinks in that Catra isn't just here, she is here to *perform*. She is a dominatrix. Alright, Adora needs to take some deep breaths. At least slowly turning red seems to be cutting some of Catra's wariness. She is outright glaring at Adora, but her fur isn't bristling anymore at least.

"What are the chances you give me the forms, walk out of this bar, and pretend you never saw me?" Catra asks, but her tone is sarcastic as she eyes the papers in Adora's hands. Uh, yeah, none and they both know that. Adora takes another deep breath, looking down at the

forms, and then up at the *leather jumpsuit* Catra is wearing. Fuck, Catra really is a dominatrix now. Adora is never going to sleep again. Her skin feels both hot and clammy.

“I’m the maid of honor. I can’t go. The only reason I wasn’t the one planning is because everyone knows I’m not the best person to throw a party,” Adora tells her. That actually makes Catra snort. Okay, it’s more of a scoff, but they both know Adora’s faults. *Fuck* do they both know Adora’s faults. Catra looks up to the ceiling, apparently unable to look at Adora. She raises a hand and drags it down the length of her face, growling softly. Her tail is lashing still, but her fur is lying flat.

That’s progress, probably? Adora doesn’t know. She has never been more out of her depth in her life. She decides to just stay quiet and let Catra think. It gives her time to process herself. The last time they spoke was Catra’s senior year at the community college where she was getting her associates. As dirt poor foster kids, they never had the money for the art supplies Catra needed to build up a portfolio that would let her get accepted to an art college. She planned to spend two years at community college, working part-time, gaining skills, and building a portfolio before transferring to a reputable art school.

Adora was only in her second year of pre-med and dreading grad school. Their relationship had been rocky ever since Adora made the choice to go to the public university in Bright Moon. Catra couldn’t get into their art program yet, so she was stuck back in Thaymor. Their local community college didn’t have any requirements for entry into their art program. Adora knew it would be the best thing for her career to go to the most prestigious university she could get into and that ended up being Bright Moon University.

Despite the future financial security that such a prestigious diploma would give, Catra didn’t want Adora to leave. Adora was sure they could make long distance work. The second Adora refused to listen to Catra’s concerns – and that Catra crumbled instead of telling Adora how much the disregard hurt – their relationship started going downhill. Catra dumped her two months before she graduated from community college for ignoring her and barely calling.

Catra was right that Adora was so focused on schoolwork she put their relationship in the backseat, but fuck was it all a misunderstanding. Adora was struggling in college and thought it just made sense to spend a few years focusing on building a secure future for them anyway – she wanted to provide for them *both,* she never meant to be selfish – but to Catra she was just being taken for granted. She told Adora that over the breakup call where everything that Adora said was too little, too late.

“I can’t fucking do this,” Catra mutters, her hand still covering her face. It breaks Adora out of her reverie. She swallows, staring across at the woman that is the very definition of the one who got away. No, Catra *can* do this. She has to. Adora can’t fuck this up twice, not when fate has managed to bring them together again like this. Adora takes a step closer. Catra immediately stills, not quite stiffening, but her body is alert as she cracks her golden eye open to glare at Adora. Her gaze burns in warning.

“Please stay. I don’t want to make things worse between us, but I also don’t want to ruin my best friend’s wedding. I try to be a better friend than that,” Adora tells her. The unspoken *a better friend than I was* hangs between them. Catra made it clear what the problem was in her leaving speech. Adora was emotional and breaking down – maybe she shot back that Catra

always agreed with her in the end, so she had no way of knowing that it bothered Catra like this when Adora just decided what the best thing would be for them.

Why would I keep fighting to be disregarded? Catra asked her before hanging up the phone. They were both so young and *stupid*. Adora kept trying to call back and found her number blocked. She tried to drive out to Catra's graduation and found her slipping away in the crowd the moment she spotted Adora. She went to Catra's apartment and knocked on the door until her knuckles were bruised, but she never heard a sound from inside. She lost Catra slowly, but she only became aware of it over one tear-filled phone call.

Adora has changed a lot in their years apart – at least, she hopes – and they might just have a chance of making up now if Catra is willing to hear her out. She knows the irony is that their whole problem is Adora was the one who didn't listen or give Catra time before, but it is hard to apologize when the other person won't talk to you. It is also hard to apologize in a bar, while music and laughter filters through the walls from the main room. Adora swallows.

"Please. I won't make your job harder. I don't want to hurt you *again*," Adora tells her. She doesn't miss the miniscule shiver that runs through Catra at those words, her arms wrapping around herself as she crosses her arms tightly. Adora hates seeing her feel like she needs a barrier between herself and Adora of all people. It is ironic how well they know each other's habits but couldn't listen to each other's words. Adora took Catra's at face value, and Catra looked for hidden motivations to cast her aside in Adora's.

"Please, I'm a big girl, Adora," Catra scoffs, her tone dismissive. It is a deflection, but even knowing that, it kind of works on Adora as she glances down at the papers she is still holding out half-heartedly. She has a lot of emotions around Catra she has been letting steer her through this conversation instead of thinking about the *leather* and *consent forms* and, oh yeah, the love of her life is apparently a professional domme now. Catra must catch some shift in her expression because she snorts, but she unfolds her arms and takes the forms from Adora.

Adora lets out a shaking breath, finally letting herself really take in Catra as Catra looks away from her to scan the papers, flipping between the photocopies of the driver's licenses and the page of signatures to check they all match. She looks good, and Adora isn't just talking about the ridiculously sexy outfit that certainly fits her apparent job. Catra has filled out more since Adora last saw her. Her muscles shift as she flicks through the papers. Adora doesn't have the mental bandwidth to process how good she looks with her hair up in a ponytail.

"Hey, horny idiot, we have a job to do," Catra snaps, stacking the pages together and then folding them in half. Adora flushes as Catra reaches for the bag hanging from her shoulder without looking and stores the forms inside. Adora was ogling her, but in her defense, this is a lot to process. Catra just ran into her ex unexpectedly – Adora is going through that *and* finding out that Catra is a dominatrix now. Luckily, Catra looks more amused than angry, though her anxiety is clear too.

"'*We*?'" Adora echoes back, feeling two steps behind. A few minutes ago, Catra seemed ready to walk out. Clearly she has decided to go through with the job, but Adora wasn't expecting Catra to refer to them as *we* so soon after growling at her like that. To her surprise, Catra gets a bit of a vindictive smirk as she reaches into her bag and pulls out a fucking *whip*.

Adora is suddenly reminded of what the S in BDSM stands for as Catra hooks it onto her belt with a twisted leer. Adora *definitely* doesn't clench her thighs where she stands.

"Yes, *we*, sweetheart. Looks like you're going to be my designated helper tonight once the liquor starts going around. Or were you planning to coordinate this party drunk?" Catra asks, her fingers tracing along her whip with deadly promise. Her tone is almost contemptuous. Adora swallows.

She wasn't before, but now she wishes she could.

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In the eighteen years Catra knew her, she never saw Adora look as shocked as she did when Catra walked in the door. Catra was still going to accuse her of somehow planning this whole thing, but the look on her face spoke for itself. Catra can't believe this is her fucking luck. She gets hired for a bridal party maybe twice a year, so of course her first event in four months has to be for one of the friends that Adora picked up to replace her with when she moved to the big city.

Catra knew the bride's name, but she didn't form the connection since she was mostly dealing with her bridesmaid and never called Sparkles by her real name back then. She remembers the gremlin she loathed so much now. It's weird walking into the bar area and seeing her again, five years down the road and matured despite the straight up *glitter* she is wearing as highlighter and the necklace of what appear to be multiracial penises thrown over her neck.

Adora is doing her very best to act normal. Luckily, most of the bridal party is snickering and whispering about *repressed Adora* dealing with the dominatrix. Yeah, right, Adora is a freak, even if she was never comfortable with that side of herself when they were dating. They only really had two summers of getting to be physical with each other leading up to their freshmen and then sophomore years, so they weren't really ready for more than vanilla stuff then, but the idea of Adora being a prude is hilarious.

Unfortunately for Catra, the snickering draws the bride's attention. She turns and Catra watches her face twitch when she sees them. They have met, at least over video chats. Catra might not know the rest of the people here, but Sparkles knows *her*. She watches her gaze dart between Adora and Catra, clearly putting two and two together. Distantly, part of Catra fantasizes about the bride canceling. She won't walk from the job, but if the bride is uncomfortable with her former relationship with her maid of honor, Catra will return her deposit and go home to have a breakdown.

And it was such a *nice* deposit too. She was going to buy a bulk set of canvases with it. The sale runs out next weekend and the bundle will be even further outside of her usual reach than it already is. Fuck, she kind of needs this job. She might have been bluffing when she implied that she was big enough that Adora couldn't hurt her anymore, but she has had five years to

grow, and spending four of them in this line of work taught her more than most people know by the time they're thirty.

Despite the discomfort of Adora being *right there*, Catra can slip into her persona like a second skin. Her posture straightens, her shoulders falling back and elongating her neck as she walks with purpose, chucking her bag of toys onto one of the empty bar tables. Her gaze is hard, projecting strength as she takes the last steps to the bridal party with Adora trailing a few steps behind her. She looks down at them, eyeing each one with a look that asks: *what can I take from you? Are you even worth being used?*

She is met with eyes bright with interest. Sparkles is counted amongst them, though she is shooting Adora questioning, borderline suspicious looks. Without looking, Catra holds out her hand and snaps it, a clear summons. Adora hurries up to her side, grabbing her bag and bringing it for her. Adora looks anxious – go figure, Catra is too, she just knows how to put on a game face – but she doesn't have dawning horror on her face as she realizes what she is really getting into at least. Shockingly, Catra isn't that worried about the party itself. Adora was a shitty girlfriend, but she is still a decent person and Catra is confident she can rely on her to behave and help with crowd control as necessary. No, Catra is worried about afterwards when, with the job done, Adora will no doubt try to corner her into talking. Or maybe she won't. Maybe she has moved on.

Just because Catra hasn't herself doesn't mean that Adora didn't get over her. Catra was the one who broke up with Adora, but only because Adora didn't have the guts to do it herself, instead pushing off her calls with Catra using excuses about schoolwork and all the stupid extracurriculars she took up to pad out her resume. Regardless of who ended things, Adora broke her heart first. She wasn't expecting them to have anything approaching a civil conversation if they ever met again.

She always knew it was a possibility that they would after she moved to Bright Moon to attend the Mystacor Academy of Arts and fell into this weird day job of hers. When she pictured it, it was a lot less amiable than this. It was usually Adora hating her, or falling on her knees and begging for Catra back. Neither were realistic, but she definitely didn't think Adora would be flushing and carefully averting her eyes as Catra pulled a riding crop from her bag. Catra turns back to the party, snapping the crop harshly against the outside of her hip.

She doesn't flinch at all – honestly, she hardly feels it through her clothes and she grew used to stinging pain from a young age – but the leather of her romper produces a loud snapping sound that draws attention to her like a judge banging his gavel. She won't make a scene – well, a scene about her ex, she is *paid* to create scenes – and she is confident that Adora won't either, at least not in front of the bride. As long as Sparkles isn't too uncomfortable with who her friends have hired, Catra should be able to keep this paycheck.

"You can call me *Sir*. I'm here to teach you how to have some real fun, and who knows, maybe even a worthwhile honeymoon," Catra commands, ending with a wink in the bride's direction. It sends a message. Catra will be professional and do her job like she always does as long as Sparkles can handle it. Sparkles darts her gaze between Catra and Adora. Out of

the corner of her eye, Catra watches Adora give the smallest nod to her friend. Adora seems to be on the same page Catra is – get the job done.

With her approval, Sparkles' hesitance seems to fade. There is still doubt in her gaze, but she eyes Catra and her bag with obvious interest. Yeah, she can make this work.

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Adora doesn't think the revelations from today are going to finish sinking in for a *week*, but she thinks she is handling herself remarkably well. Catra uses her like a prop as she gives a speech that includes congratulations for the bride, a review of the information in the consent form, and a surprising number of jokes. Adora has always been drawn in by Catra, but she wouldn't exactly have called her personable. Apparently all she was missing was the ability to order people to their knees – which she does, to Adora, when she is only halfway through what is clearly her opening routine.

When Adora doesn't comply fast enough, Catra flicks her wrist and stings the riding crop against her thigh with a surprising amount of force for so casual of a motion. Adora is flushed, self-conscious as she kneels and Catra doesn't even look at her, reaching out to grab her ponytail and pull her head back to bare her throat. Adora blushes worse as Catra continues her speech without any regard for the woman she has kneeling under her.

"Positions like this can make safe words difficult to say, so if necessary, you should also establish a nonverbal signal, such as tapping or pinching your partner," Catra says, suddenly releasing Adora and causing her head to fall forward. She wasn't ready for – well, for anything that has happened tonight. Catra swats her side with the riding crop again, but this time it is light, not even causing her to sting. That definitely shouldn't disappoint her. She needs the reprieve given everything she is processing.

"Get up," Catra orders, still not looking as Adora hurries to stand. "Since tonight is mostly about demonstration, we won't need precautions like that. The safe word is *mercy*. In large groups, everybody needs to be using the same safe word to avoid confusion," Catra explains. The party is paying attention to her, but they are also glancing at Adora and snickering. Adora knows she is flustered and red in the face, but given what her friends know about her, she doesn't think they should be *surprised*. Her only hope is that Catra spends most of the session focusing on the bride she is here to entertain.

If only Adora hadn't forgotten that her embarrassment amuses Glimmer to no end. Catra asks her if she would prefer to participate or watch and Glimmer, the *sadist*, says she prefers to watch with an absolutely wicked grin. She was clearly concerned about Adora when she walked in with Catra, but seeing Catra's professionalism and Adora's fluster seems to have gotten her over any kind of touching sentiment quickly. No, she is more than happy to sit back and watch, well aware she is the only person aside from them who knows what is actually playing out before them.

Some of her other friends know her ex's name, and some of them even know she was a magicat, but Catra just introduced herself as Sir – which totally didn't make Adora hot at all – so everyone seems to just be amused by Adora seemingly being flustered over a confident woman. Which, well, is also true, but Adora happens to have been underneath and above this particular woman before. She was both anxious and looking forward to this party once she knew what was on the schedule, but she figured she would just lurk in the background and yearn for something like that.

Instead, she finds herself as the default demonstration prop when no one else volunteers, or when the person who does is drunk. The latter happens more as the evening goes on, but the first one is just her friends being assholes. Others do volunteer – Perfuma eagerly raises her hand when Catra busts out the rope to show some safe ties – but they all laugh at her expense when no one else raises their hand. Catra mostly flirts with the crowd, even getting handsy with them despite how unafraid she is to bring down her crop on any hand reaching for her, but she treats Adora like she might as well be a mannequin.

Adora would think it is because Catra hates her – she was certainly angry the last time they spoke – except that she *knows* Catra can pick up that it is turning her on and she still keeps doing it. She seems amused by her reaction. Her smirks are a touch sadistic, but again, that isn't something Adora really has a *problem* with, so she finds herself looking Catra in the eye as Catra experimentally pats her cheek a few times and gives instructions on how to safely slap someone without doing any serious damage.

"You can't just kick down the door, order them to get on their knees, and let loose. Maybe once you've been around the block with them and have muscle memory, but you have to feel out every new face to be certain before you-" Catra keeps talking, but at that moment she draws back and- "let loose," she finishes as Adora lets out a sound somewhere between a moan and a yelp, reaching up to massage at her stinging cheek. Her friends are laughing at her.

"Who's next?" Catra asks, with a grin, turning away from Adora. Some things it would take too long to demonstrate on everyone, like the rope tying, but apparently the bridal party is all too happy to let loose a weekend of wedding anxieties by slapping each other under Catra's watchful eye. They practically partner off for it, Glimmer making grabby hands in Adora's direction as Catra goes around the table giving careful instructions. Adora reluctantly walks over to her and drops into the seat beside her that has remained largely vacant for the last thirty minutes.

"How are you holding up?" Glimmer asks, sipping her drink despite how the slight slur in her voice makes it clear she has had enough already. There is mirth dancing in her eyes. Catra only slapped Adora on one cheek, but both her cheeks are equally red right now. Adora answers by slumping down in her seat and reaching for Glimmer's drink. Glimmer, the asshole, pulls it out of her reach and raises an eyebrow at her.

"Stealing from the bride? Really? You were helping Mermista. You could have prevented this," Glimmer responds, no sympathy for her. Given how drunk she is, it is a miracle she doesn't spill her drink yanking it away from Adora, but that success is probably only because

the glass is well on its way to empty. Adora knows for a fact it isn't her first either – she was drinking some kind of pink cocktail earlier – but she gives up on her attempt to grab for it.

"I didn't know it was *her*," Adora whines, quietly, sinking even lower as she watches Catra, for all her badass dom act, catch the hand of a drunk bridesmaid and gently chastise her. Her grip is harsh, but her manner and words walk the line of fitting in with the persona and also not making the drunk girl cry. It is kind of stunning to watch. Catra has been at this for a while, clearly. That isn't a skill you walk in with on day one, especially not when dealing with strangers.

"Did Mermista?" Glimmer slurs. Adora blinks, tearing her eyes away from Catra to stare up at Glimmer. Glimmer is a few inches shorter than her, but Adora has almost sunken beneath the table with her slouching. She was just starting to wonder if she could get away with staying back here by insisting the drunk Glimmer needs babysitting, but now all other thoughts go out the window except *no*. The problem is Glimmer could be right. Mermista knows the name of Adora's ex and her general description.

The consent form just referred to Catra as *the pro domme* after it defined what that meant in the beginning, but Mermista had to know the name of the person she was hiring. It's possible she forgot about Adora's ex – she had *better* have forgotten – but Mermista is smart despite her act of general disinterest. Glimmer grins, her eyes distant and wasted but her smile wicked. Fuck. Adora can wait until after the party, but then she is absolutely cornering Mermista to see if she intended this.

"Aw, are you sulking?" Catra coos behind her, sending a flash of heat through Adora just before a clawed hand lands on each of her shoulders, squeezing just tight enough to be painful. Adora makes a valiant effort to hold eye contact with Glimmer. It lasts all of three seconds before she is looking up at Catra, who has snuck around the booth while Adora was distracted with thoughts of vengeance and is now leaning over the back of her seat.

"You know, usually I don't like this part because drunken parties can get out of hand with it, but that is the most fun I've had slapping someone in a while," Catra says, conversational and coy, like it's *nothing*. Catra talking about how much she enjoys hitting Adora shouldn't turn her on, but too late, because Catra is looking down at her with a saccharine smile that is disarmingly sweet - and bares her razor-sharp teeth. Adora hasn't stopped being gone for Catra one bit in the last five years. She stares up at her, flushed and a bit dazed, as Catra turns her gaze on Glimmer instead.

"Enjoying the show?" she asks, her tone teasing. It is whiplash from how Catra spat Glimmer's name – her actual name, because she used it for once – in that last real phone call between them. *You spend more time with Glimmer than talking to me already. You won't notice I'm even gone*. Adora swallows. Glimmer, made shockingly cordial by the alcohol, raises her glass a little in a haphazard toasting motion.

"Oh, I'm learning a lot," she slurs, snickering. If she remembers this tomorrow, she actually is. Catra is damn good at what she does, blending genuine education with jokes, flirtatious attention spread throughout the group, a strong persona, and the thrill of taboo moments like a maid of honor tied up on her knees and valiantly trying to keep it cool despite how flushed

she is and the wolf whistles from her friends. It is the kind of thing that could only happen at a bachelorette party.

“You’re a little too drunk to be a volunteer now, but I’m sure your future husband would like you to recreate the experience for him later,” Catra teases. She sounds playful. Adora feels like she has fallen into a parallel dimension watching Glimmer blush and mutter something that Adora doesn’t catch over the music, but that makes Catra laugh as Glimmer quickly hides behind her glass. Catra’s hands are still on Adora’s shoulders. She feels like she is fucking dying. Surely the slap was enough.

“On your feet, little helper. Or your knees, if you want to take a shortcut. I’m *flexible*,” Catra orders her, squeezing Adora’s shoulders just enough to flex her claws into them. Adora doesn’t know what her face must look like, but Glimmer bursts out laughing, so that is enough of an answer on its own. At least she is having fun at her bachelorette party, Adora tells herself. She knows she is going to spend the entire wedding ceremony with images flashing before her eyes of Catra in this leather outfit, smirking and so in control.

At least it will be something interesting for the boring parts of the service. Reluctantly, Adora stands. Her friends start jeering and whistling immediately.

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Adora is a shockingly good sport about the whole thing. Catra suspects she just doesn’t want to ruin her friend’s bachelorette party, but she also doesn’t seem opposed to spending an evening visibly flustered for the amusement of her friends. She is surprisingly relaxed, given the circumstances. The Adora that Catra knew five years ago – alright, seven, those last two years where they were falling apart and drifting away hardly count – wouldn’t have been this calm or subtle about a situation like this, but Adora does her best to take it in stride.

She still takes every opportunity she has to flee back to her seat when someone else volunteers, but she ogles the interactions from the sidelines when she does so. Half the table is turned on and the other half is just impressed as Catra does her demonstration of her whip tricks and Catra can pick up Adora’s scent amongst the others. This part is mostly just her showing off and putting movement into it almost like a dance, but power is a turn-on to some and Catra has always known Adora likes things like this. She isn’t surprised.

She *is* surprised when the tall girl volunteers again for the next demonstration and Adora quickly jumps in to volunteer herself instead, though. She almost seems *jealous*, but Perfuma has started drinking despite Catra’s warning she wouldn’t accept drunk participants, so she crooks her finger to Adora and beckons her closer. Luckily it is the final demonstration for the evening. Catra finishes by circling the bride, going through her usual routine of closing notes, flirtatious comments, and predatory teasing, but she is counting down the moments to when she can escape the watchful and hungry eyes.

She likes parties because they don't involve any real domming except for small moments with volunteers, but this one has been *trying*. She is relieved when she orders Adora to carry her bag for her and see her out, holding onto her persona – and dignity – until the last. She wants to heave a sigh of relief the moment she steps out into the lobby, the door swinging shut behind them and closing off the party, but Adora is still here, trailing just behind her.

Catra's shoulders still slump a little as she reaches up to redo her zipper, which she undid to dip down low on her chest for the party. She takes a deep breath before she turns around to take her bag from Adora. Predictably, Adora is looking at her with those kicked-puppy eyes that Catra absolutely hasn't missed. *No*. She isn't falling for it. She ignores her as she unzips her bag to stow her whip back inside.

"Can we talk?" Adora asks. Her voice is hopeful, but small. She knows the answer to that question. Catra scowls as she fishes her phone out of the bag and types out a message to Lonnie and Scorpia that she is done working for the night and should be home in the next forty minutes. In her periphery, Adora's shoulders fall a little. Whatever, that isn't Catra's problem. She should consider it a favor that Catra didn't walk the moment she saw her and ruin her stupid replacement's wedding celebration.

"I've been in Bright Moon for four years and you've never seen me before today. Here's to hoping for at least another four. I'm not falling back into your arms to be treated like shit again, Adora," Catra dismisses, dropping her phone back into her bag and leveling Adora with a glare. She has to suppress a wince at the flash of pain that crosses Adora's face. Catra is not the one who should be feeling bad here, but despite how Adora treated her, she still loves her.

She wouldn't have walked away if she didn't. If she had loved Adora any less, she wouldn't have had to leave, but it hurt too much to stay and feel like she was fucking nothing to the one person she always thought loved her. Adora still has her heart, but she can't keep repeatedly shattering it as long as she isn't around. Catra prefers the hole in her chest.

"Catra, I'm sorry-"

And nope, that's it, Catra is done. She has needed to have a screaming session with her pillow since the moment she walked through the door and saw Adora's face. She turns on her heel and stalks towards the front door, growling under her breath as Adora scrambles to follow her. "Wait, Catra, please. I swear I just want to talk. I've missed you so-" she tries again. Catra cuts her off with a sharp hiss, turning her head to glare over her shoulder as she grabs the door handle.

"You should have missed me seven fucking years ago, Adora. Move on. I have," Catra spits to her, shoving the door open and fleeing outside as she swears that she sees tears prick in Adora's eyes.

It's the biggest lie she has ever fucking told.

Chapter End Notes

Catra wasn't exactly on her best behavior here (when is she ever) but tbf she was a little in shock lmao.
Technically Catra should be a “pro domme”, but she prefers the masculine “dom” and “sir” to the feminine form or stuff like “mistress”. She uses the feminine form in her consent form just so there isn’t confusion in a legal scenario, but in general she uses dom. Everyone at the bridal party wasn’t familiar with terminology though and so mostly referred to her as a dominatrix.
Catra's leather romper (this was drawn based off a reference I sent).

Aftermath

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra gets home, knocks on Scorpia's door to let her know she has made it back safely, and then barely manages to remember to text Lonnie too before she collapses face-first into her pillow and screams in frustration. Being professional when she had Adora in front of her was nearly impossible. She got to slap her, and that definitely felt good, but it also felt like she was walking on glass the whole time, one wrong move from everything breaking down and getting fired.

Okay, Adora gave Catra the rest of her payment before they walked into the party, and she probably wouldn't yell at Catra, but it was a tense situation. The worst part was when it *wasn't* tense – when Adora would good-naturedly go along with Catra's orders or moan just a little as Catra belittled her. She managed to keep her noises quiet enough that the rest of the party didn't hear most of them aside from her adorable little squeaks, but-

Nope, not thinking about Adora like that. Not thinking about Adora at *all*. Not thinking about how cold her bed has been for the last seven years. Not thinking about how Adora followed all her orders like an overeager puppy, even the ones she knew would hurt. *Definitely* not thinking about how Adora now knows that Catra lives in Bright Moon and seemed eager to reconnect. Not thinking about how it seems Adora's relationships with her new friends have only deepened in the last few years while Catra has been isolated.

Well, Catra hasn't been alone either. Fuck, she is about to make a questionable choice. It won't be the first time – it won't be the fucking last – but she can't force Adora from her mind and she has a solution for nights like this. It is downright cruel to use it, but her job is sadism and sometimes that bleeds into her personal life too. She gets up with a sigh and slips out of her bedroom, padding past the door to Entrapta's room and opening Scorpia's door without so much as knocking.

The room is dark, but Scorpia stayed up to make sure Catra got home safe and she only went to bed a few minutes ago. She lifts her head in surprise when Catra opens the door. The night isn't stronger than Catra's vision. She can see the stupidly hopeful look on Scorpia's face. There is anxiety there too, and for good reason. Scorpia has the expression she always has when Catra needs to fall into someone's arms after a bad day at work.

What will you give this time? What will you take?

Catra has never dommed Scorpia and she never will, but it is the emotional toll of their arrangement that weighs on Scorpia despite how eager she always is for any affection from Catra. Catra swallows and starts forward into the room. They don't really hookup anymore, not unless one of them is really fucking desperate, but when Catra just needs to trick herself into feeling loved, she still crawls into Scorpia's bed for a warm body.

Tonight, she doesn't say a word, settling onto the foot of the bed and balling up next to Scorpia's legs like she used to do with Adora as kids. Scorpia definitely thinks she sleeps at the foot of the bed out of guilt for Scorpia's massive crush on her, but the truth is even crueler – it is easier to pretend Scorpia is someone else entirely this way. This way she can close her eyes and picture the shitty bunk she shared with Adora at the group home. Scorpia always knew that Catra was picturing her ex when they were together, though.

They met through Lonnie when Catra was looking for a place to stay after graduating from her community college. Lonnie already lived in the city and introduced them. Scorpia and Entrapta had a spare room after Entrapta got a real workshop at her job. They have all been living together ever since, but Catra was a fucking wreck. She produced some fantastic art – when she could afford to between her shitty part-time job and rent – but she was self-destructing.

When Scorpia asked her out, Catra told her that she wasn't looking for a relationship and just a rebound. She repeated Adora's mistakes: she didn't question it when Scorpia agreed. She was too caught up in her internal drama to realize that Scorpia was lying. They never dated, not really, but the hookups, random nights cuddling, and desperate make outs when Catra was on a dopamine crash broke Scorpia's heart anyway.

Catra became aware of Scorpia's crush slowly. When she started falling into the BDSM culture through Lonnie's job at the bar, she learned a lot – about herself, about reading people, about looking outward in general. She had the tools – and the time – to finally notice that Scorpia had fallen for her. She never said a word about it, maybe hoping that Catra would fall too, but she didn't. She couldn't. She told Scorpia what she could handle, but Scorpia wanted more.

They were never together, so they never really broke up. Catra just couldn't keep lying to herself that Scorpia was fine with it as time went on and her feelings became more obvious. Their relationship was the same as what she had with Adora but with the roles now reversed. The difference between them is that Scorpia is a pushover. Catra walked when Adora didn't care for her, but she still finds herself slipping into Scorpia's bed occasionally after a bad day and Scorpia always lets her.

Fuck, when she thinks of it like that, it reminds her how young and stupid she and Adora were – how it was all a fucking failure of communication. It puts Adora's mistakes in perspective, and that is the absolute last thing Catra wants to do. It isn't that she needs to lie to herself that Adora meant to hurt her, but she needs to not feed the spark of warmth that lit when Adora looked at her in that lobby like she cared about Catra. She can't invite Adora back into her life again.

It is possible they have both grown and could be friends again, but she couldn't handle it if they haven't. Catra has dulled and numbed the pain over time, but she was a fucking *wreck* when she first came to Bright Moon. As shitty as it is, she has built something here. She has friends, she and Scorpia are even okay despite how they don't acknowledge the elephant in the room between them, and she has a business. It isn't the job that she wants, this isn't the bed she is aching for, and despite the heartbreak being dulled it is still *there*, but she has something now.

She had nothing after losing Adora. She can't go back to that place again. It gives Scorpia false hope when Catra slips into her bed, but if it keeps Catra from having another breakdown, then it will hurt her less in the long run than whatever would go down between them should Catra self-destruct again. It is a mere band-aid when she needs stitches, but the only way to get those is to go back to Adora and talk it out. It is as likely to cut her open again as it is to give her closure. She can't take the chance.

She balls herself up tightly at the foot of the bed, flipping the edge of the comforter over herself, and after a few moments, Scorpia seems to relax in the bed again. She doesn't ask Catra to come up to the head of the bed. She never asks for what she actually wants. If she did, they never would have started hooking up in the first place. If Scorpia ever admitted to wanting more, Catra would have ended it in a heartbeat. Instead, they just kind of stopped when Catra got her shit together.

They still hook up occasionally, usually when Catra is feeling spectacularly shit and briefly forgets that she doesn't want to hurt Scorpia, but it seems like Scorpia is trying to accept that Catra doesn't return her feelings. At least she hopes so. She knows she doesn't help when she does shit like this, but she can't help it. No matter how much she tried to convince herself she could handle being alone, long distance wouldn't have wrecked her the way it did if that were actually true.

If she didn't need to feel like she mattered to someone, she could have handled Adora stepping back to focus on school. Scorpia doesn't say anything, and so Catra doesn't offer it either. She already learned five years ago not to give herself away.

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Adora shouldn't cause a scene at the wedding. She used up all her self-control last night, though. She didn't get to talk to Mermista after the party. She was conspicuously absent while Adora was getting a drunken Glimmer back to her hotel room. She spent the night babysitting her wasted friend. She couldn't leave Glimmer alone in that state and she and Bow weren't allowed to see each other so close to the ceremony, so watching her fell on Adora.

Adora has been trying to find Mermista all morning, but her maid of honor duties have been keeping her busy. She should wait until after the ceremony to confront her, but when she spots a blue braid disappearing around the corner, she immediately stops giving a shit about finding Glimmer's shoes and veers off-course. Mermista spotted her and ran, the coward, but Adora has her trail now and Glimmer's dress is long enough to hide her feet if she has to walk down the aisle barefoot. Adora doesn't *care*.

"*You*," Adora intones, reaching out and grabbing Mermista's braid just before she can round the next corner. Mermista hisses with pain as she draws short, but she watched Adora go through worse last night. Adora would rather grab her hair than her shoulder and risk fucking up her dress. It is so far from Mermista's normal style it's laughable, but Angella was set on

the bridal party matching. As dedicated Adora is to her mission, she isn't about to incur Angella's wrath by fucking up something obvious.

"In my defense, you liked it," Mermista tries. Adora narrows her eyes at her. Mermista doesn't look sheepish, she is too confident in her terrible decisions for that, but she purses her lips, thinking over a new response. As she does so, Mermista reaches up and tugs her braid from Adora's grip, readjusting it a little. Adora maybe crushed the carefully pulled plaits, but it only takes Mermista a few seconds to fix it, so she really doesn't care. After a moment, Mermista seems satisfied and looks her in the eye.

"Look, I found her on accident. I was just trying to hire someone local and her name came up. Given what a blow up it was and that you *still* aren't over it, you two being forced into the same room to talk about it seemed like the only chance for closure. And she was going to be good entertainment even if she turned out to be a different Catra," Mermista tells her, shrugging. She doesn't look apologetic, but there is a wary look to her. It is the same look Catra used to get when she gave a non-apology, unsure if it would be enough.

"You could have *warned me*," Adora hisses back, gesturing at nothing. She just needs to move her hands. Last night was so much. Mermista raises a brow at her.

"You would have been an utter disaster if you had warning, and this way you had plausible deniability. Did it work or not?" Mermista responds. She asks the question like she is expecting confirmation. Adora blinks at her. She doesn't actually know the answer to that. She is still processing everything from last night. She lived in a daze for the entire hour Catra was there. She feels like every time she blinks she sees the burning look in Catra's eyes just before she slapped her. The memory sends a thrill shooting through her.

Last night wasn't a disaster, but Catra stormed out the moment Adora tried to actually talk to her. With every passing minute her hope built throughout the evening, but it seems that Catra's ease in her presence was an act. She was tense and wary when they were alone, utterly closed off. Adora doesn't know how she is just supposed to live her life knowing Catra is here in Bright Moon. She gets caught up before she even gets to the dominatrix part, but that would thoroughly break her if she had the room to worry about it.

"Do you want her website or not?" Mermista asks after Adora just stands silent for a long moment.

Oh. Oh, now she can think about it. Now it is all she is ever going to think of again, actually.

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Catra's Sunday is shit. She didn't expect it not to be. She is craving affection so badly. It's pathetic. Adora didn't even *give* her any last night, but just seeing her kicked off the kind of yearning that sends her crawling into Scorpia's arms. She can't do that two nights in a row, and certainly not during the *day*, so she mopes around her bedroom for most of the day

despite her roommates' obviously being concerned about her and trying to pop in to check on her.

She sighs, staring up at the ceiling and thinking about how long Adora's hair had gotten. She looked good. She looked better than she was the last time Catra saw her, distraught and run down. She is probably standing at an altar right now, watching her friend get married with pride. A bitter taste blooms in Catra's mouth as it occurs to her that Adora could have a plus one to the wedding. She definitely didn't have a girlfriend at the party last night, but that doesn't mean anything. Her girlfriend and Sparkles just might not be close. Catra and Sparkles certainly didn't get along.

Catra, I'm sorry. Is she? Is she really? If she is, would she do better? Adora is a creature of habit. The odds seem low. Catra isn't really considering reaching out, she just misses the hell out of her best friend. No matter how much time passes, she never stops missing her. She has a few friends now – emphasis on *few* – but none of them could ever replace what Adora was to her. She was the one who got away.

Catra tries to remind herself that Adora was actually the one who left her behind, but the words feel hollow. Catra is the one who dumped her and blocked her number. Adora extended an apology last night and she stormed out. What happened five years ago was Adora's fault, she told herself, but she knows the ball is in her court now. Adora can't call her. If they are ever going to talk again, Catra has to decide to do it.

Adora has probably changed her number by now, Catra tells herself. There's certainly no way she checks her school email, if it is even still up. She doesn't have a way to contact Adora. As long as she holds onto that lie, she won't try. There is no point. She sighs and pulls out her phone, checking the art supply store's hours. She is down to her last canvas. She will paint tonight and then go take advantage of the sale first thing in the morning. Focusing on her art will help her forget about Adora.

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Adora does get the shoes to Glimmer before she walks down the aisle. She is distracted for the entire wedding, but she performs her duties. Angella – or worse yet, *George* – would kill her if she fucked up the wedding that they had been planning at a whirlwind pace for the last six months. She knew Glimmer and Bow would be relieved when it was all done with and the pressure of the fairytale wedding both their families wanted was gone, but she didn't expect herself to be equally relieved to be heading home that night.

She has a lot to think about. She never stopped thinking about it, not as she was helping Glimmer get ready, or when they were all standing around the altar, or during the party afterwards. She barely managed to get through her speech at the reception. She only managed to stay on task because she had it written down on her phone. Her rented house may be empty and sad, but at least there are no distractions as she thinks through her options.

She doesn't know that she has more than two. She scrolls through the website on her phone, her bags abandoned beside the couch as she tries to will her libido to stand down. It's hard when she is looking at Catra's picture beside her biography and summary of services. She is wearing a fucking bodysuit and thigh high boots – well, they are the usual magicat stirrup socks at the bottom, but aside from that they look like the kind of boots that would give a nun a foot fetish.

That is on Catra's list of services, actually. It is bewildering to Adora. She is pretty sure she would have noticed if Catra had one of those. This is apparently a job for Catra, though, so her own indifference might not matter. How the hell Catra ended up here is a question Adora is desperate for the answer to. It was always a possibility she would come to Bright Moon – BMU's art program wasn't very good, but there was the Mystacor Academy of Arts – but when they last spoke in March, she hadn't gotten an acceptance letter from them yet.

She definitely missed the first wave of acceptances. It seemed certain that she wouldn't get in unless someone else turned down the offer they received. With Mystacor's reputation, the odds were low. It was another friction point between them since it seemed clear that they wouldn't get to be together in person that fall like they had hoped after all. The wedge between them deepened with two more years of distance likely stretching ahead of them.

Catra said she has lived here for four years, though. Either she got in after all or she never went to get her bachelor's. The website is for both her and *Lonnie*, so maybe she moved here anyway to be with one of the few friends she had. She and Lonnie didn't used to be very close – they actually hated each other in middle school – but now they are in business together. Adora raises a brow at Lonnie's profile picture on the site. She is wearing a high-necked sports bra and ripped jeans. She was always strong, but she has bulked up since they all graduated high school together.

Adora hasn't kept up with her. She knew she was going to Bright Moon University too, but Adora was busy enough already with schoolwork. Apparently she should have called up her old friend. Maybe she wouldn't have spent five years wondering if Catra would ever be willing to contact her again then. She can't do anything about that now, but she can eye the contact page. There is no online booking form, but there are instructions for reaching out to initiate a conversation to get a session set up. Adora bites her lip. Filling it out is either her only chance or going to ruin any chance of Catra calling her on her own.

They have lived in the same city for four years and Catra knew it. She isn't calling. Adora sighs and puts her phone down. She can think about it overnight, but she already knows what she is going to be doing come morning. Looking at the site just before bed is sure to make her dreams interesting. She spent all of last night basically getting *blue-balled* and she is feeling the frustration from it now, need gathering under her skin as she wonders what the hell *sensory play* means and how it earned a spot on Catra's list.

Okay, she is going to spend some time with her hand before bed. She can worry about how the hell to write this email in morning.

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Spending so much money at once is almost painful, but Catra tells herself it is worth it as she hauls the cumbersome bundle of canvases across town to the townhouse that she shares with Entrapta and Scorpia in an old, rundown neighborhood. It has a charming, historical look to it, but most things are in disrepair due to their age. No one in this area has the money to fix things up. Catra doesn't even have the money for a car, and she can't justify calling a cab to transport her things after she just spent so much.

She is drained by the time she gets home. Keeping the canvases from getting damaged wasn't that hard, just annoying, but her emotions are running her down. She hasn't stopped yearning for Adora. She can't pretend that Adora knowing she is in Bright Moon doesn't change things. Maybe it shouldn't, but it does. It makes the proximity between them real in a way that she has been pretending it isn't for years.

She considered reaching out to Adora again many times when she first moved here. Nearly every moment when she felt hollow in an empty bed, actually. At that point, she couldn't remember if Adora brushing her aside felt as bad as she did alone, but surely it couldn't have. Surely getting to hear Adora's voice occasionally was better than the utter numbness in her heart. She was usually too broken to go get her phone in those moments, though.

During her worst one, she would have called Adora if she actually had service, but she was behind on her phone bills and they cut off her service until she caught up. It was a rough year as she adjusted to loneliness. She is used to isolation now. She hates the spark of warmth she felt looking at Adora kneeling for her, anxious but excited too as she followed Catra's orders.

She apologized.

Fuck, nope, intrusive thought. *Kill it*. She isn't calling Adora. She isn't going through all that again. When she is overwhelmed like this, usually she paints as an outlet, but she is too tired for it, and looking at the canvases in the corner reminds her how much money she dropped on them. Despite graduating three years ago, her painting career has gone nowhere. She can't afford to rent space to host a gallery show, and it isn't like anyone would show up anyway, so right now she just lists her paintings online and makes the occasional sale.

She manages to sell her paintings – sometimes – but she never gets jobs or commissions. She knew that she chose a career that didn't make money when she applied to school, though. She thinks that is why Adora was so determined to go to fucking med school and get into a stable career herself. Something about taking care of Catra. Catra didn't want to be taken care of, even if she kind of needed it. She has a day job worked out now and she still gets to paint. Art isn't how she earns her money, but she has enough to buy the supplies for it – mostly – so she can be content.

She doesn't need Adora or her paycheck, but she does need *a* paycheck. Reluctantly, she hauls herself out of bed to sit at her computer. Some weeks she gets lots of bookings. Other weeks she has just one. She pulls up her inbox knowing that she isn't really in a good headspace for having a session soon, but she is hoping there will be a booking request for next week or something that can ease the familiar roiling in her stomach of financial anxiety. Then she can distract herself with painting guilt-free.

There is a booking request. It isn't for next week. It *definitely* doesn't ease the anxiety gnawing at her.

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Adora didn't think about the fact that shoving off the email for Monday meant writing it on, well, *Monday*. She finds it consuming her thoughts as she gets ready for work. She knows she won't be able to focus unless she sends it – otherwise she will just keep writing and rewriting it in her head – but typing it out at work still makes her feel high-strung. She does it on her phone with the wi-fi turned off, but she feels like someone is going to bust down her office door at any moment and catch her.

Angella wouldn't fire her for this anyway, but it is a nerve-wracking twenty minutes as she writes and then *rewrites* the email. She gives up and sends it on the third draft just because she feels guilty for how much work time it is taking. She isn't happy with it. She doesn't think it is good enough, but she doesn't know if there is *anything* that she could write that would be good enough for Catra to respond. She sends it from her spam email so Catra doesn't recognize the address and immediately delete it, but she doesn't lie about who she is, signing off with her real name.

It is pretty obvious anyway when, after asking about booking an introductory session, she adds a paragraph about how she genuinely wants a session and isn't trying to trick Catra into talking to her, though she would like to do that too if Catra is willing to let her apologize. Adora certainly hopes no one else would have cause to send Catra an email like that. She is anxious for the rest of her workday. She checks her phone for an email alerty every twenty minutes, but she turns her volume up just in case too. She doesn't want to miss anything.

Her focus is shot and every document feels like a slog. She keeps having to restart at the beginning of a paragraph when she realizes she hasn't been reading anything on the page before her, thinking about Catra instead, both as she was five years and how she is *now*. She nearly jumps out of her skin when her phone's ringtone blares out without warning. She doesn't even glance at the caller ID, hurrying to pick up the call just so the ringtone will stop.

"Hello?" she asks, a little breathless from the adrenaline jolt. There is a beat of silence. It is long enough that she almost pulls the phone away from her ear to see if it is an unknown robocall since usually that quiet indicates the lag time as the call connects to a phone center, but she freezes when she hears a familiar scoff on the other end of the line.

"What do you think you're playing at? You think I'm really going to believe that you just want a session?" Catra asks. She sounds annoyed. She isn't. Well, okay, maybe she is, but her voice sounds all *wrong*. She is lying, or acting, or something. It isn't sharp enough to be her real annoyance. Adora fucked this up once, but she knows Catra's many moods like the back of her hand. There isn't enough bite in her words for Catra to be genuinely angry. Her tone was much sharper on the breakup call and she wasn't even mad then, just hurt. *Broken*.

“I’m just *asking* for a session. We both know I’ve wanted to talk for five years, but you’ve made your feelings on that clear,” Adora returns, keeping her voice even. She isn’t actually expecting Catra to agree to a session, but she is hoping she will. Her friends weren’t wrong when they said she needed to get laid. Adora never would have considered doing something like this before Saturday night, but she got a taste and now she can’t lie that she wouldn’t be thinking about it even if the domme had been a stranger. This is a chance to get in contact with Catra again, but she is also feeling wound tight and desperate.

“Should have been seven,” Catra mutters. Adora winces. She did *want* to talk seven years ago, she was just busy. Insisting on that during the breakup call didn’t help anything though. It isn’t what Catra wants to hear. Adora swallows, blinking at her computer screen. It might as well be turned off for all that she is paying attention to it, but it still serves as a reminder that she is at work right now. This is the absolute last conversation she should be having. She still isn’t going to encourage Catra to end the call when they’re finally talking.

“I want to apologize. I want to treat you right. I want to *see* you. I also- want what happened on Saturday again. Take your pick,” Adora lists off. Trying to jump straight to the apology didn’t work at the bar and she knows it wouldn’t work over the phone where it is even easier for Catra drop the conversation in a heartbeat. Did she finally unblock Adora’s number? If she had no interest in talking, she would have just ignored the email. Despite her words, this has to be a good sign.

“I’d also take a recommendation if you have one other than Lonnie, though the apology is only on the table for you,” Adora adds. It’s a weak joke. She just doesn’t want Catra to hang up on her. It is, maybe, occurring to her for the first time that this might be crossing a line for more reasons than the breakup. She would certainly never consider hiring Lonnie for this. She is asking her ex to dom her. That definitely isn’t normal. On the other end up the line, Catra lets out a *tch* noise. It isn’t a full hiss, but she isn’t happy. Okay, that didn’t help.

“Are you serious?” Catra asks, her tone heavy with suspicion. Adora feels her brow draw together. Of course she is serious. She may have had five years to grow, but it didn’t magically turn her into a liar.

“Yes? Catra, I miss the hell out of you and I haven’t- uh-” Shit, she’s at work. She finds herself glancing around her office. She is alone, but the walls are thin. “I’m at work. But I’m meant everything I wrote about,” she settles on saying, hoping Catra will decipher the fact that she is censoring herself from necessity and not because she doesn’t want to answer all of Catra’s questions. There is a moment of silence and then, to Adora’s shock, Catra *snickers*.

“Aw, the doctors can handle blood and gore but not that you want your ex to whip you?” Catra coos back. It is demeaning. It makes Adora flush. It reminds her of the five years stretching between them. Her thighs shift in her seat even as her shoulders slump. No, that’s the problem. That goes right back to their problem five years ago, actually.

“Nosy office ladies, actually. I, uh- *fuck*,” Adora trails off. The curse is quiet, but uttering it under her breath can’t hide it from Catra. She didn’t expect all the shame of five years ago to come flooding back. She thought she made peace with this, but admitting it to Catra is another story, apparently. She wanted to do so much for her, *be* so much to her, and instead she ended up here, dealing with reports and management decisions all day. It is good money,

at least after the nepotism that got her the job in the first place lead to her getting promoted quickly once she proved she could handle it, but it isn't helping people like she always wanted.

The reason she ended up in an office instead of in a hospital like she always planned is even worse. Catra is silent on the other end of the line. Adora wishes she could see her and get some kind of impression on how she feels about all this, but Adora hasn't even admitted it yet, not really. She never thought she would be saying this over the phone. Maybe it is for the best this way, though. She doesn't have to see Catra's reaction and Catra can't see the tears threatening to gather in her eyes as she takes in a shaking breath to brace herself.

"I dropped out junior year. Well, failed out, actually," she admits. Her voice is tremulous. It has been five years. She shouldn't still be crying about this. She failed. It happened. She was so fucking ashamed of it she never told Catra just how bad her grades were. She tried to dedicate everything she had to school, certain she could turn things around, but her grades didn't improve and it left nothing for Catra. All she did was lose herself the one thing she really wanted. Her grades weren't good, but she wasn't placed on academic probation until the end of the spring semester, after the breakup.

Her brain wasn't built for med school to begin with. Losing Catra was just the final nail in the coffin. She couldn't muddle her way through it without Catra's support. By the end of fall, she had been on academic probation for two semesters and it was all over. She never would have made it into med school with her grades anyway. Catra is silent now. Adora can feel her panic rising. She knows it must show in the unsteady breaths she is drawing in faster and faster. Quickly, she pulls the phone from her ear and mutes her microphone.

"Adora, it's okay. Turn your mic back on," Catra says, softly. Which is worse, making Catra deal with her panic attack, or ignoring her? Probably the latter. She already knows it is happening anyway. Adora didn't mute herself fast enough. She draws in a deep breath and forces herself to hold it, squeezing her eyes shut as she unmutes the call again. For a moment, it is silent but for her pounding heart. Eventually, she has to breathe. She blows out air, desperately hoping her chest won't start gasping again.

"There you go. If it's an office job, then you'll need an evening session after regular work hours, right?" Catra asks. That certainly derails Adora's brain from panicking. Her anxiety is still through the roof, but she finds herself gaping at her computer screen.

"I- Yeah," she manages, still breathless. For a moment, hope flares, smoldering in her chest before guilt floods through her in a devastating wave of *what if*. "Please don't do this just because of- I don't know, guilt. Pity. It's been five years. I promise I'm fine," Adora adds on. She wants this so bad – she wants Catra, she wants a session, she just *wants* – but Catra doing this because she feels bad would just make things worse between them in the long run. Catra snorts. There isn't much humor in it, but it is an attempt at a scoff.

"I'm a sadist, Adora. I don't do things out of pity. The studio is available tomorrow evening. Does seven work?" Catra asks. Adora's heart is racing in her chest, but her guilt and anxiety ease, at least temporarily. Catra is willing to see her. Maybe not talk, but after nearly breaking down, Adora feels less ready for that than she thought that she was.

“Yeah, that works,” she replies, her voice cracking embarrassingly on the first word and the rest delivered breathlessly. She really is an utter disaster. Getting to a stable place in her life and career couldn’t fix *her*. A moment of silence stretches between them. Adora doesn’t know what to say after, however unintentionally, making Catra talk her down from a panic attack. It certain isn’t going to endear her to Catra again.

“Okay. I’ll email you the instructions,” Catra returns. Her voice is quiet, like it has been ever since Adora’s panic attack began. It recalls the gentle firmness she used with the drunk bridesmaid. The call is obviously wrapping up, but Adora doesn’t want Catra to hang up. She will have to cling to the promise of seeing Catra again – in *person* even – soon.

“I have to get back to work,” Adora forces herself to say. She doesn’t want to.

“Okay. Have a good day, Adora,” Catra tells her. The line goes dead. Adora drops her phone from her ear reluctantly. She tries to calm her still-racing heart as she stares at the unknown number in her call log for a long moment before adding it onto Catra’s old contact. She doesn’t just have Catra’s number now – she has an *appointment*.

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Catra stares up at her ceiling. She was still sitting at her desk when she first called Adora, but after that revelation, she needed to just lay down.

She was afraid Adora was lying to her back then, but despite feeling heartbroken, she believed in her more than that. It didn’t make sense for Adora to be lying unless she was cheating on Catra, and even in her worst moments, Catra didn’t consider that as a possibility. It turns out that she did have something to lie about, though. Suddenly, all the missed calls and Adora’s reluctance to talk make sense. If she wasn’t genuinely busy trying to pull her grades up, she was likely too stressed to risk a phone call.

She can’t lie at the best of times and of course Adora, the group home’s golden child, the one who took it upon herself to get a high-paying job to earn them a comfortable life, would feel the need to hide that she was failing. How many classes do you have to fail to be expelled? How long does it take? It turns out Adora was lying to her, but it also adds new context to everything that went down five years ago. The breakup was ultimately about Adora disregarding her, but this is why she wasn’t answering the calls. She had a reason.

Catra growls, covering her face with her hands. It makes sense, but it doesn’t make things easier. She sighs, feeling her tail thud against the bed. She has been twisting herself into the same knots over Adora for years. Hopefully tomorrow will put some of it to rest. Whether it will actually help, she doesn’t know, but she agreed to do it. She didn’t really expect to, but looking back on it, she is pretty sure her fate was sealed the moment she grabbed her phone to dial the number that Adora listed in the email. She needed answers about the game she was playing.

She isn't playing a game. She is just being Adora. Stupidly sincere – stupidly *horny* – and hopeful. Catra didn't expect that phone call to ease her. Adora caught her off-guard with her admission. Usually Catra hates being surprised. Instead she feels… defused. She has been volatile ever since Saturday night, edgy and approaching a minor breakdown, but now she sighs and gets out of bed, walking to the corner with her canvases.

She is still tired. She blames that on why, when she gets her paint set up, she thinks about Adora and paints something *soft* for the first time in five years.

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If Glimmer and Bow weren't off on their honeymoon, Adora would probably be running to them for advice, but she isn't about to bother them after six months of whirlwind planning and stress. Glimmer actually wanted to get married in the spring, but when it became obvious how obsessive both their families were going to be about planning the wedding, they moved the date up to the first one the venue had open. They hoped that the small timeframe would discourage their families from going overboard.

That backfired tremendously. Angella, Casta, and George set to planning with a vengeance. Lance was the only voice of reason on a planning committee that took the timeframe as a challenge. Glimmer joked about eloping with Bow, but in the end, their family wanted it and were taking care of the details, so they let it happen. Adora isn't going to interrupt their first in peace in months with relationship drama. Glimmer and Bow already picked her up once after Catra broke up with her.

On the morning of the wedding, when Glimmer was only halfway through recovering from the night before, Glimmer turned to Adora and asked if she dreamed that her ex was a dominatrix. Adora had to admit that no, that was real. Glimmer's eyes glazed over for several moments before she remembered to ask Adora how she was doing. Adora said fine and quickly deflected that if they were late, Angella would have her head. They managed to be too busy to talk about it again until Glimmer and Bow were driving off to the airport.

Maybe it is for the best that Glimmer and Bow aren't here, actually. They saw the way Adora self-destructed after Catra dumped her, everything she had planned and been working towards suddenly gone. They would certainly find this decision *questionable*. From a logical standpoint, Adora knows that paying your ex who doesn't even want to talk to you to dom you sounds like a monumentally stupid idea, but she maintains that she and Catra aren't standard exes.

Adora finds herself shifting nervously outside the door to Catra's "studio" on Tuesday night. There is no sign to indicate what is inside, just a suite number beside the door that matches the email that Catra sent her. Adora is dressed in leggings and an activewear top, the email having recommended sportswear or clothes that she didn't mind potentially getting ripped or stained. It seemed like a form email that Catra sends to all bookings, but the possibilities in that recommendation made Adora flush just reading it.

She is early. She was worried about being late if she drove home to change, especially with the evening traffic, so she ended up awkwardly changing in a bathroom stall after work and driving straight here. She doesn't know if she should knock or wait. She doesn't know if she is even ready for this. She doubts Catra is any more certain, though. Adora is just as anxious about the possibility of them talking as she is about the session, but she has a sneaking suspicion only one of those things will be happening today.

The door in front of her swings open without her ever knocking. Adora freezes as if caught. All she is doing is standing in the hall of the yoga studio – at least, that is what it says it is, and it *looks* like that until Catra opens her door and Adora sees into the dungeon over her shoulder. She flushes, determinedly looking Catra in the eye and ignoring the rack of *implements* she can see behind her. Catra looks unimpressed, but at least somewhat amused by her reaction, her gaze traveling along Adora's body for a moment before landing on her face.

"I always pad my sessions by half an hour. If you're only a few minutes early, you can go ahead and knock on the door," Catra tells her, stepping aside and jerking her head back to motion Adora inside. Adora hurries forward, feeling her cheeks heat a little at the implication that Catra expects her to come *back*. As Catra closes the door behind her, she casts her gaze around the yoga studio. It seems to actually be built for yoga, or maybe dance. One wall is entirely covered with mirrors. The rest are oddly draped in black fabric.

Adora turns to ask Catra about the drapings and feels all words die in her throat as she finds herself face-to-face with *herself*. The wall the door is on is also clad in black fabric, but it has a painting hung amongst the drapes. It is a square canvas, showing the bared torso of a naked woman. Her back is arched as a clawed hand reaches around from behind and grips the left breast. A hand can be seen gripping the left hip at the bottom of the painting, holding her in place. It is evocative, and maybe it is just supposed to be *some woman*, but the hand is clearly Catra's and Adora knows what her own tits look like.

She gapes at it, vaguely aware of Catra stiffening out the corner of her eye, her tail lashing. The painting is fucking incredible, the soft brush strokes comparable – at least to Adora's untrained eye – to those of a renaissance painter, but she can't believe Catra painted this and has it hanging in her dungeon. She turns to Catra to find her making a valiant effort not to shrink where she stands, her tail lashing and arms crossed. Everything about her body language is closed off as she looks away from Adora, her cheeks blazing.

"I was going to take it down, but then it felt like lying. It has been there for like a year. If you want me to get rid of it, I will," Catra offers, her voice faux-casual. Adora swallows, turning to look at the painting again. She thinks it might be a violation. She isn't really sure. She feels her heart racing with excitement looking at it – fuck does she want Catra's hands on her like that again – but despite how much she likes the artwork, there is also the fact that it is on display for other people to see. She swallows.

"Does anybody know it's me?" she asks. Catra rolls her eyes in response. She is trying valiantly to act like she doesn't care about Adora's reaction to this, but she clearly knows this is crossing a boundary.

“Of course not. I don’t think Lonnie has even realized. She would ask me to take it down if she did. I did it as a project during a human figure painting class,” Catra tells her. Adora blows out a breath, tilting her head a little. She kind of feels like she can’t look away from it. It is undoubtedly erotic, but if it wasn’t her own body, it wouldn’t really be worthy of inspection. She isn’t mad about it, but she can’t help but remember from the website that Lonnie takes in male clients.

She feels her nose wrinkle. Yeah, she definitely wouldn’t have agreed for Catra to display this, at least not here, if she had asked her. She doesn’t want horny men looking at it. Maybe at an art show or something – after all, it would just be another artistic nude then – but definitely not here. Her expression seems to push Catra into action. She quickly crosses the room, reaching up to take it down without Adora saying another word.

Adora swallows, watching Catra’s tail lash as she lifts it off its hooks and turns it around to lean it against the base of the wall with the artwork hidden. It really is good. Adora doesn’t particularly want to stop looking at it herself – her anxiety is taking a backseat to her libido at just the sight of it – but she also doesn’t want others looking at it. Catra stays standing over it with her back to Adora, her shoulders slumped a little as she looks down at the canvas, now leaned against the wall at her feet.

“I never would have put it up without asking if we were talking. I think I got desensitized to naked bodies between art school and work. I justified it as being okay because it was a moment from my imagination and not real,” Catra explains, not turning to look at her. It is one of her classic non-apologies. Adora swallows, looking down at the back of the canvas where she can see Catra’s signature and a scrawl of a date, title, and a string of letters and numbers. The course number for the class, maybe. From this far back, she can’t decipher Catra’s scrawling handwriting to see what she called it.

“I don’t want it where strangers can look at it. I do, uh, *like* it though. It’s really good,” Adora manages to say. She feels awkward as hell. Okay, so maybe she has a bit of a thing for exhibitionism. She is pretty sure they both knew that a long time ago. Catra’s tail stills, her ears twitching a little to swivel towards Adora instead of being pinned back against her head. Adora feels awkward as hell, her cheeks flushed as she realizes that Catra has probably been looking at this painting for *years*.

“How weird would it be if I bought it from you?” Adora asks. Catra practically startles, turning to blink at her. Adora blinks back, her face flushed as she shrugs a bit helplessly. “I *really* don’t want it hung up for other people to see but it’s, uh. I’d like it,” she trails of, rambling a bit. Adora doesn’t really know what she is feeling, so she has no clue what to *say*. She does know that she wants to be able to look at this painting again and that she wants it off this wall. Buying it seems like a solution.

“… I’ll just give it to you. Seems like the least I can do,” Catra responds after a long moment of staring at her like she can’t tell if she is serious or not. Adora just nods awkwardly. No matter what goes down in the rest of this session, she is going to take a piece of her and Catra home. She doesn’t know what she is going to do with the painting aside from stare at it and wonder what the hell Catra was thinking when she painted it, but she is taking this entire day one step at a time.

“Come on, let’s sit,” Catra prompts, a bit stiffly, clearly hoping to move past the awkwardness as she suddenly breezes past Adora. Sitting means talking – about the session, or about *them* – but at this point, that feels like a reprieve. Adora follows Catra as she walks to the sofa against the opposite wall. It is time to finally find out what she got herself into.

Chapter End Notes

Starting with next chapter, I will be putting CWs for the BDSM scenes at the bottom of the chapters to avoid spoilers. If you want to make sure it isn’t anything too much for you, click the “(See the end of the work for more notes.)” hyperlink at the start of the chapter to jump to the end to read just that note and scroll to the top again to read. If you aren’t worried and/or don’t want spoilers, then just go ahead and read!
Nothing for this chapter since the session couldn’t fit.
Catra's painting (NSFW Twitter link).

The Session

Chapter Notes

If you're new to my fics, magicats are red colorblind.
Very light BDSM scene, but jump to the end of the chapter for a summary.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't really know what to expect from Adora, but she mostly just seems anxious and unsure. Catra probably should have anticipated that. For all Adora's talk of hiring someone else, Catra would put money on her never having done something like this before. The painting distracted them, but Catra had kind of forgotten about its presence until she walked into the dungeon today. Despite how Adora clearly isn't comfortable with it, Catra thinks it might have helped.

She was defensive when she ran into Adora on Saturday night. She felt ambushed. She assumed the email was a trick to get her to talk to Adora up until she called Adora and actually heard her. Catra has been so scared to speak to Adora and find herself cut open all over again, but it turns out that hearing Adora's assurances helps. Her mere presence doesn't cut like Catra feared it would. In fact, despite Adora's obvious nerves as they sit on the couch together, it kind of helps.

Adora has always soothed her, at least when her dismissal didn't make Catra hurt like nothing else. For her entire childhood, everybody dismissed her aside from Adora. Once Adora started doing it too, Catra couldn't take it. Normally Catra doesn't like it when other people are anxious around her, but it shows that Adora cares about how this goes. Catra eyes her for a moment, thinking over how to approach this. This was never going to be a normal introductory session, but despite having a day to think on it, she still doesn't know where to start.

"What are you looking for out of this?" Catra asks, carefully. Adora's face screws up a little at the question. Catra knows it isn't exactly a lowball question, but it is something Adora needs to know the answer to. She sighs, turning a little in her seat to lounge back against the arm of the couch so she can face Adora. Adora hurries to mirror her position, her expression a bit sheepish as they make eye contact. Catra doesn't shy back like she does. The intense eye contact drives home the point she is about to make.

"What I do is intense, Adora. If you want to enjoy yourself and avoid a situation that could hurt you long term, you need to be completely honest with me. About everything. That is my condition for us talking at all. No lies, no 'I'm fines', no telling me what I want to hear," Catra tells her. Their conversation yesterday showed her that more was going on between them than just Adora being distant and dismissive. Adora was going through shit, but she hardly told Catra.

Not that Catra outright told her how bad Adora was making her feel either, but it hurt too much to voice more than her disappointment over Adora not being able to call – again – and ask for her to call her back as soon as she had time. She tried. She told Adora she was disappointed. She didn't hide her building distress, Adora just didn't notice it. Adora winces at her words, looking away and hunching her shoulders a little, but after a moment she takes a deep breath and nods. Catra narrows her eyes at her.

"I'm tired of doubting you. I'm tired of not knowing how you fucking feel. You lie to me once and this is over, understand?" Catra adds. She can't do that guessing game again. She can't sit there staring at a texted rejection and wondering if Adora just doesn't want her anymore. It hurt so much. Adora shrinks a little more, but she nods again. After a moment of carefully looking away, Adora seems to rally a little, straightening back up and making eye contact with Catra again despite how it seems to pain her.

"It was rough and the amount I had to work just to pass my classes took up most of my time, but I wasn't placed on academic probation until after the breakup. I wasn't trying to hide a big secret, I just… didn't want you to see me as a failure, I guess. I tried not to burden you with it," Adora tells her. The words seem to pain her – there is certainly distress in her eyes – but she doesn't look away. In her periphery, Catra can see Adora's hands trembling a little in her lap.

She really is so fucking ashamed of something that Catra doesn't give half a shit about. Catra had no intention of really talking about this today. She isn't ready to. She is glad to have the assurance Adora wasn't trying to lead a double life or anything, and the strength of her reactions are enough for Catra to see that it really is something that Adora felt was bad enough to warrant all the deception, but she wouldn't want Adora to lie to her about anything.

"Adora, you could have told me you killed someone and I would have helped you hide the body. I don't give a shit about your grades and I didn't then. We would have figured something out when you needed to drop out. Just be straight with me from now on," Catra shoots back. The words are dismissive for talking about something that Adora clearly cares about, but that is intentional. She wants Adora to understand that she really doesn't care. She also kind of needs this conversation to be over. Getting emotional right before a session is bad news.

Adora looks a bit awestruck at her indifference. Catra doesn't know why. She has always been whole-heartedly dedicated to Adora. She never would have given half a shit if she dropped out and worked in the fast-food industry for the rest of her life. The only person this is news to is Adora. After a moment of looking at her with wide eyes, Adora swallows and nods. Catra watches her shoulders fall with the motion, but she doesn't seem disappointed. If anything, she seems lighter, offering Catra a small but hopeful smile.

"I'll tell you everything. Well, that matters. I'm sure you don't need to know how many dogs I spotted driving to work or that I spilled coffee on my keyboard, but- you get it. I'll talk to you," Adora rambles a bit, gesturing nervously before she catches herself and draws to a halt with a small, sheepish smile. Catra feels her tail thud against the couch beside her. Fuck, she forgot how cute Adora is when she stumbles over herself and rambles about something.

Fuck, she isn't supposed to be thinking about Adora as cute. She agreed to this because it seemed like Adora really needed it – okay, and because she was jealous at the first mention of Adora going to see someone else – but she promised herself she would be professional about this once they cleared the air enough to have a healthy session.

She didn't fool herself that they would be able to avoid addressing everything – going into a session with resentment is a bad idea – but Catra feels a bit soothed and any further processing will have to wait for later. It was stupid of Adora not to talk to her, and it was a break of trust, but when she is still struggling to talk about it years down the line and with another career established in place of the one she dropped out of school for, it is clear that she was dealing with emotional turmoil just like Catra was. It was a shitty situation for both of them.

"I, um, know you probably don't want to talk about it more, but I just… need to promise you that I'll do better. I'll listen to you and tell you things, if you'll give me the chance," Adora adds on, fidgeting a little in her seat. She is tugging at the edge of her shirt, twisting it in her hands and accidentally snapping the hem against herself when the smooth sweat-wicking fabric slips through her fingers. Catra recognizes the motions despite the material they are applied to. She shifts a little to be sitting with her weight on her hip and sweeps her tail up, dropping it with artful disinterest in Adora's lap.

Adora's eyes light up, her anxiety still present but eased as she reaches down and pets along Catra's tail. She twists her wrist a little with the motion, like she is wringing it out despite how gentle she is. It doesn't hurt. Adora likes to pet Catra and it always helped her when she got too fidgety. In high school, Adora's grades were better in the classes where she sat next to Catra, able to occupy her overactive hands and soothe her mind so she could focus on their teachers. She sends Catra a smile tinged with hope and gratitude.

Catra looks away quickly. She isn't letting Adora in again, not like she did before at least. She can't handle it. She doesn't know if she is even ready for the session, but given what they have talked about so far, she thinks it won't be a problem. She isn't feeling vindictive seeing Adora is just as anxious and twisted up over the breakup as Catra has felt. Adora broke her heart, but clearly she didn't mean to do it. Catra just still doesn't trust that she won't hurt her again.

"I'm fine with sessions. I'm not up to more, not right now," Catra tells her. Adora has to realize how much Catra is giving her already – how much hurt she has opened herself up to with every word she has let Adora speak to her. Despite how she wishes otherwise, Adora's importance to her hasn't faded over the years, and that means she can hurt Catra easily – on accident even, like she apparently did before. She isn't looking at Adora now, but she can see the slight drop of disappointment in her shoulders out of the edge of her vision.

"Okay. If you ever are, I'm here. You have my number. I won't pester you or anything. I'm grateful just being able to see you," Adora returns. She sounds sincere. Catra's heart races a little as she nods. As much as she wishes otherwise, she shares the sentiment. She can't believe Adora dropped out and scrambled her way towards an office job without any college diploma with Catra none the wiser. This entire time, she has been picturing Adora working at

some hospital, comforting herself that she is doing the noble thing with her life any time she did happen to miss Catra.

Of course Catra couldn't compare with her precious, theoretical future patients. In her mind, that was why Adora never spent time on her after going to school. Instead, Adora wasn't able to get to the point of having patients without Catra by her side. Catra takes a deep breath, pushing the thoughts from her mind. They have cleared the air enough. They can move on to the session, which means Catra has to be – relatively – unemotional and levelheaded. She looks back up to Adora, making eye contact with her again.

"Are you sure you're actually ready for this?" Catra asks, her eyes darting all over Adora's face as she asks, looking for any tell. Adora's cheek flush, but she nods. Her embarrassment and nerves are obvious, but there is honest excitement there too. She doesn't smell turned on or anything, but it satisfies Catra. She nods, readjusting in her seat a little to sit fully facing Adora. It pulls her tail out of her hands, but hopefully she won't need soothing for the rest of this conversation.

"This was never going to be a regular session, introductory or otherwise, but we'll go over some rules, what you're interested in exploring in general, and then narrow in on what you want for this session," Catra tells her. Adora bites her lip and nods. Just like that, it isn't just excitement written on her features.

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The rules turn out to be much the same as they were at the bachelorette party. Catra isn't "in character" as she tells them this time, seeming unbothered as she counts them off on her hand. Adora nods along eagerly, feeling overwhelmed not by the rules, but by seeing Catra lounge beside her, relaxed in her presence for the first time in five years. The talk seems to have helped and she isn't worried about Adora disobeying the rules, so she breezes though them with the kind of casualness Adora wasn't sure there could ever be between them again.

"We've already covered being honest, but that includes not just telling me the things you think I want you to say. Maybe if I *order* you to say something specifically, but if I ask you if you like something, I expect an honest answer. If you tell me something hurts and that isn't the point, we can stop or readjust. If it *is* the point and you lie, then I'm just going to go harder and you could end up with a real injury. If you need your safe words, use them," Catra lists off, making pointed eye contact with Adora.

Adora quickly nods. She already agreed to honesty, but clearly Catra feels the need to repeat it. Back then, Adora was so ashamed of failing, especially after she promised Catra that she would get a stable job and then she wouldn't have to worry about being a starving artist, that it never occurred to her Catra would be more bothered by the time they were missing out on than disappointed over Adora failing. Catra narrows her eyes at her for a long moment, but she moves on to her next finger.

“You were at the party, and I *assume* you read the website, but this isn’t actually sex work. I’m not interested in that with clients and it would put my income into a much shittier tax bracket. This is legally entertainment, but many people find it is closer to therapy. The goal is subspace and emotional fulfillment. Under no circumstances are you allowed to touch me, or yourself, or undress unless I order you to. Clients do still orgasm sometimes and there is no shame in that either,” Catra adds.

Adora is pretty sure she is red up to her ears, but she nods. Catra looks amused, her tail flicking and a smirk firmly in place as she eyes Adora. Adora is painfully aware that Catra can tell just how much of a reaction those words elicited in her. She already admitted to being pent up, though. This shouldn’t be a surprise. She knows how good Catra’s senses are. She wasn’t fooled into thinking Adora was merely *flustered* doing the party. Catra spends a moment leering at her, clearly enjoying Adora’s reaction, before she moves on to her next point.

“Usually clients bring their own safe words. I write them on that chalkboard so there is a reminder for us both. I have a default one for clients if you don’t have one yet. And like I said at the party, I prefer to use a set of them for any intense scenes, so it’s best to have them on deck,” Catra explains, gesturing to the end of the rack that Adora has been valiantly ignoring. At the end is a small writing slate hung from one of the pegs with twine. It looks like it would be more fitting in a classroom than a dungeon, but its presence now makes sense to Adora.

“I’m *new* to this, Catra. You know that I’ve thought about it, but I’ve never done anything like this before. I don’t have a safe word,” Adora points out. Catra’s lips twitch, almost a ghost of a smile as she shakes her head a little, seemingly amused. Her expression is a touch condescending, causing Adora to huff. Whenever she has thought about this theoretically, she never fantasized about *needing* a safe word. She knew about them, but she haven’t really thought about what hers would be.

“Then come up with some. Safe words are used during a scene, but they are outside of it. Any orders I’ve given you, especially about what to say or when to speak, don’t matter when you need to use one of your safe words,” Catra explains. Adora nods along, turning it over in her mind. It is surprisingly hard to come up with something that wouldn’t come up during anything BDSM-related, especially because she doesn’t really know what all that will entail yet. Trying to think of something that also doesn’t sound ridiculous and mood-killing to say doesn’t make it easier.

“What are your safe words?” Adora asks, looking up. To her surprise, Catra looks a bit flustered. Her cheeks warm and her gaze darts away for a moment as her tail twitches. The reaction is small – a slight darkening of her cheeks, just a moment’s diversion of her gaze, and the tiniest twitch of her tail – but it might as well be a screaming reaction. Instantly, Adora is hooked, her entire body lighting up as she feels a smile spreading on her face that only makes Catra’s cheeks darken further.

“I tell clients to use ‘mercy’. It’s what the lady I mainly learned from used,” Catra responds, shrugging as she crosses her arms defensively. Adora’s smile doesn’t fade and neither does Catra’s blush. It has been so *long* since they casually teased each other, it feels amazing to be doing it again. Adora just shakes her head, leaning forward and propping her chin up on her

hand despite how the position forces her elbow to dig uncomfortably into her leg where she is braced against it.

"*Your* safe words, not what clients use. I know you have them, even if you've never had call to use them," Adora shoots back. There is no way Catra hasn't thought about it, not when she does this job day-in and day-out. Catra's cheeks are scarlet as she lets out a noise that is clearly supposed to be an indignant scoff but comes way closer to a flustered squeak. Her fur is fluffed up a little, her tail sweeping back and forth as she tries to glare Adora into submission. Adora smiles back.

She isn't letting this go. She wants to know. Catra can't lie that she doesn't have any, not when she is reacting like *this*. There is no trace of the in-control dom from Saturday night. Catra is flustered and downright adorable. Adora's entire chest aches with her affection for the woman before her, tinged with the regret that she missed out on moments like this for five years. Eventually, Catra manages a real scoff and quickly looks way, giving up counting off her rules on her fingers to instead cross her arms and sulk.

"When Lonnie and I are practicing, I use red for stop, pink for slow, and blue for go. We don't do scenes with each other, just practice techniques, so color codes are easiest," Catra mutters, her cheeks still blazing. Her poofed-out tail twitching by her side is so tempting, but this isn't five years ago and Adora can't reach out to gently tug it and earn flustered, turned-on squeaks and growls. She really wants to, but instead she just nods. She likes the idea of using the same ones that Catra does, especially because she can guess why Catra chose them.

"Okay. That works. It's easy to remember," Adora agrees. As teasing as she has been, she knows not to dig after she has gotten Catra to admit something. Catra's tail thumps against the couch, but after a moment of waiting and not being mocked, she relaxes again. She uncrosses her arms, shaking her shoulders out a little as she does so, and looks Adora in the eye again as her fur lies flat.

"If you say red, everything stops. We assess what was too much and move on to aftercare. If there is enough time left and you feel up to it, we may resume again near the end. Calling pink pauses the session, even if it is just for a few seconds. We talk and readjust or stop as needed. Blue doesn't pause anything. It is a greenlight to continue without worrying about what is taking place in the scene. If I prompt you for a color, answer honestly regardless of what orders you have been given for the scene," Catra explains.

The explicit discussion of things like *scenes* and *orders* makes Adora flush, but she nods quickly, trying to ignore how her heartrate has picked up. She can't help her excitement. Things were awkward when she first arrived, but with every passing moment, it is getting more real that she and Catra are really about to do this. Adora has been fantasizing about stuff like this since before she even knew what BDSM was, just *wanting* and not sure how to give it shape.

She would be breathless with anticipation even if it hadn't been five years since she had been intimate – emotionally or otherwise – with Catra. Catra seems amused by her excitement – or maybe just relieved to be back in control – and smirks as she leers at Adora. Adora feels self-conscious, but she can't hide her body's reactions from Catra, so she just looks back with steadily flushing cheeks. Catra sniffs, dismissive but pleased with the reaction.

“What are you interested in exploring? You can give me a range and we pick one for today, or you can tell me a specific fantasy you want,” Catra asks. That gets Adora flushing even more, shrinking back a little. She isn’t ashamed – well, not *really* ashamed – but she also isn’t used to talking about things like this unless she is wasted. She may have failed her primary duty as a client too – she was so worried about how this meeting with Catra would go that thinking about what they were going to do during it took a backseat.

Well, okay, she did have a *few* thoughts yesterday evening, when she was back home and let her thoughts drift in that direction once she was alone, but Adora doesn’t know how to go about voicing them. How do you just spill your guts about your sexual – except *not*, because Catra doesn’t do sex – fantasies to your ex that you still love and are hoping to slowly repair your relationship with? Catra is watching her with amusement, seeming more than willing to wait Adora out.

“I, um, was interested in the stuff you were doing at the bachelor party,” Adora settles on saying. She is also interested in more – a lot more – but that seems like as good of a place to start as any. It isn’t even admitting that much since Catra was more than capable of telling what she was doing to Adora. Catra – like she was Saturday night – seems amused by Adora’s words. She stands, causing Adora to blink in surprise as she walks away from the couch.

Adora watches as she bends down to open the cabinet, pulling out her phone and returning to flop down on the other end of the couch again, completely casual and relaxed despite the subject matter. The new position, with one leg bent up and the other trailing down off the couch cushion, gives Adora a clear view of the leather outfit Catra is wearing again, which doesn’t help her be normal despite how Catra is relaxed with her phone propped up on her stomach as she taps at the screen.

“I’m creating a shared document. It has a bunch of kinks and specific acts listed. It’s a *Will, Want, Won’t* list. Things checked off as *Will* you’re open to but aren’t just free game during any session. I have to check in when we set up the scene before we engage in them. *Want* means you agree that, in general, I can do it in any session without checking. *Won’t* are things you never want me to do. There is also a checkbox for if you agree to it being used as a punishment. We can renegotiate the list whenever you need,” Catra lists off, totally casual.

Adora flushes as she realizes that Catra is about to quiz her on her kinks. Her entire body feels warm as she nods and tries to desperately pretend that she isn’t turned on. She doesn’t fool Catra. Her smirk is predatory, the exact kind that only turns Adora on more. Fuck, she doesn’t know how she is supposed to survive this. She doesn’t feel at all assured when Catra reads off the first heading.

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“Impact play. In general, we’ll get to specifics,” Catra asks Adora. If her ears weren’t already red, Catra is certain Adora would flush deeper. She is a delightful mix of turned on and

embarrassed that makes Catra want to *pounce*, and not even as a dom. No, she wants to hold Adora down on the couch and pin her there as she strips her, teasing and maybe humiliating her a little as the scent of desire in the room only grows. She can't though, and she *won't*. She isn't sure about even being friends again. She certainly isn't having sex with Adora now.

"Want. And it's okay as punishment," Adora responds, the final word coming out as a tiny, flustered squeak. Catra can't help it. She should have more self-control, but Adora isn't the only one affected by this conversation and it has been so long since Catra has *wanted* like this - mostly seeing sex as an outlet and shutting off any kinkier thoughts when it came to her mostly-vanilla fuckbuddy - that she can't stop herself from teasing Adora now she has the chance.

"You're okay with me bending you over and spanking you when you're disobedient? With me forcing you to your knees and whipping you just because I feel like it?" Catra asks, leaning forward as she speaks and Adora *shrinks*, embarrassed despite the way her legs twitch a little trying to hold still. She reeks of desire. Fuck, Catra isn't used to getting a thrill like this from BDSM anymore. She is dedicated to being professional with her clients, so despite enjoying her work, she hasn't felt excitement on this level since the last time she attended a party as an observer rather than a performer.

There is also the factor that this is Adora and not just some random sub, but Catra refuses to acknowledge that part. She leans back in her seat, grinning as she checks off the kink on her phone. She thinks that she might not enjoy BDSM like she does if she was limited to a human range of senses, but when she can smell someone's desire even when a scene calls for them fighting her, she always has the assurance that they are enjoying what she does. Her senses are often a double-edged sword, but in moments like this, when they let her fully appreciate what she does to her sub, she is grateful for them.

She is maybe enjoying this *too* much. She shouldn't get too used to Adora squirming for her. It is a dangerous route to go down. She eases off, containing herself down to pleased tail flicking as she lists off the different forms of impact play they can engage in. She didn't expect Adora to turn any of them down and she isn't disappointed. The only one she even hesitates over is whipping. It breaks through her general fluster as she twists her mouth a little thinking about it.

"Because of possible damage to clothes and injuries, I usually reserve making contact with the whip for special scenes. We could put it in the *Will* list for now and reassess its position after you have experienced it, though. I like to carry it often even if I have no plans to use it," Catra offers. Adora's indecision vanishes as she nods, smiling a little as if grateful. Her fluster has been cut as she is forced to actually think something over, but it all comes back when Catra grins and asks, "Bondage?"

Catra already knows how Adora feels about half this list. If she didn't know from before, then she saw her reactions at the party. She enjoys making Adora admit it though, and a good dom never assumes, even with ample evidence. Once an act has been agreed on, she can go off reactions and do what feels right in the moment, but she needs that initial confirmation, especially when dealing with things as intense as she is laying out here. It also leads to some amusing moments, like when Catra gets to foot fetish and Adora pulls a face.

“Not interested. Why is that on your website? I thought you hated the way humans treat hybrids who don’t wear shoes,” Adora asks. Catra snorts as she checks off the exact box that she expected that kink to fall under before she even asked.

“Because this is a business, Adora. If they want to rub my feet, I’m not bothered. If they start making gross comments about how I’m *basically walking around naked* and *turning them on in the grocery store* or whatever, then I ban them,” Catra returns, shrugging. Adora actually pouts a bit at those words, though Catra doesn’t really know why. She raises a brow at Adora. Adora blushes, seeming to realize she was pouting, and straightens out her shoulders. It’s a good thing too, because that pout makes Catra want to bite her bottom lip. She forces down a blush at her own thoughts.

Shit like this is exactly why this is *dangerous*. Logically, she never should have agreed to this, but she has always been intensely emotional. She had no plans of agreeing until their phone call, but she couldn’t reject Adora completely after that. Sessions may be a raw and vulnerable thing in general, but they are still a way to feel Adora out while keeping her at arm’s length. It can be a professional arrangement while Catra works out how she feels and what she wants for them personally. She just has to stay as professional as she can while she figures that out.

It is easier said than done.

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Adora makes a bit of a fool of herself when she asks what breath play is – well, specifically when she asks if it is breathing on each other and Catra almost falls off the couch laughing – but it ends up in the *Will* column as something she might be okay with trying in the future. She doesn’t walk out of the negotiation with her dignity intact, but she does finish with Catra still relaxed and amused, so she counts it as a win. She got ridiculously turned on as Catra laid out everything that they could do.

She feels worked up, half an hour into their session and having been teased for nearly every minute of it. Catra can definitely pick up on it, smirking a little as she saves the document and puts her phone away. When she straightens from stowing her phone in the cabinet, Adora watches with a dry mouth as Catra reaches up to the rack and selects a red and black riding crop with a heart-shaped end from the wall, hooking it onto her belt and turning back to Adora with a grin. Adora is painfully aware she agreed that Catra could use that on her wherever, whenever, without warning.

“Are you ready to tell me what you want today?” Catra asks, striding back over to the couch. She doesn’t drop down on it this time, standing over Adora with a downright smug smirk. Adora flushes, tearing her eyes away from the crop to look up and meet Catra’s eyes. Yeah, that isn’t better. The pleased light dancing in Catra’s eyes kind of sets her soul on fire. All Adora feels up to is squeaking out *I don’t know*, but the problem is that she agreed to be explicitly honest from now on.

Catra reaches down, catching Adora's chin in her hand. Adora's breath hitches, palpitations squeezing her chest as she blinks up at Catra with wide eyes. Catra tilts her chin back, forcing their eyes to meet despite how Adora wasn't going to look away. Fuck is she hot right now. She can't stop her legs from shifting a little, which only turns Catra's smirk more victorious. Her tail is flicking with satisfaction behind her as Adora struggles to breathe normally.

"Tell me what you need, *princess*," Catra orders in a satisfied purr. Adora just barely resists whining. The nickname was in the rules. Catra told Adora to call her sir while they were in a scene as long as she felt that Catra had earned the respect as her dom. She then leered at Adora before deciding she would be princess. Adora doesn't even know where Catra pulled that from, but it made her flush on the spot, which instantly sealed her fate. Now, she blinks up at Catra, trying to figure how the hell to admit what she wants.

"Just… I like when you're in charge. Tell me what to do," she manages, her voice a bit breathless. Catra blinks, not quite startled, but Adora sees a flash of *something* pass across her face before her smirk settles firmly back in place. Catra tilts her chin back further, stretching Adora's head back to just the limit of where it is outright uncomfortable to hold the position, but Adora feels her eyes drift closed. The position might not be the best, but it makes her relax. It feels good to be directed.

"Maybe I have a lot of guilt about before. I want to feel like I'm pleasing you," she manages, her words a strained whisper. It feels downright dangerous to admit, bringing up the thing that Catra clearly doesn't want to talk about, but it is the truth. It isn't just what she wants – it is what she *needs*. Catra is silent above her. Adora doesn't dare open her eyes, swallowing thickly despite the strained position. Catra's hand is as firm on her chin as ever.

"Please. I need it," she adds on. She feels kind of pathetic, but it isn't because she is begging. She failed at school. She has gotten used to that idea and at least started to make peace with it, even if thinking about it can still bring up all those old emotions. What she hasn't at all processed was failing as a girlfriend – failing *Catra*. She knows she did it, she even knows how she did it, but she isn't capable of accepting it and moving on. She needs to fix it in some way.

"Okay. Good girl," Catra breathes, her voice soft. Adora swallows. There is emotion in those tones, but she doesn't know what it is. Catra is agreeing to this, but Adora still doesn't know if she has overstepped, and she is scared to open her eyes and find out. She is shocked when she feels a soft brush against the tip of her nose as Catra gives her the ghost of a kiss there. Adora's eyes fly open as Catra pulls back, blinking up to find Catra's eyes dark and her expression unreadable.

"We'll focus on taking control away. I'll give you orders - non-explitic ones, things like certain ways to move - telling you what you are going to experience and do. We'll probably experiment with some mild impact play and mental bondage, keeping things light. Does that sound good? Remember, if an order is too much or things get too intense, you need to use your words," Catra outlines. Her voice is still soft, but there is a quiet strength to it. She is laying out what will happen, but fuck, it almost sounds like *caring*.

Adora isn't in a great position for nodding, but she feels more prepared to do that then speak, so she nods a little against Catra's hand. She wishes she could read the look in Catra's eye as

she eases her grip on Adora's chin, easing it back down before she lets go. Adora swallows, her throat feeling a bit raw, though she doesn't think it is a result of the position. Despite the edge into territory that was just a bit too emotional, her heart is still beating heavily with her excitement.

She wants this as much as she needs it, but it is time to finally find out if she can handle it.

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Catra prepares a water bottle for Adora before they really get started and writes her words on the chalkboard as a reminder. Armed with the kink contract and some more thorough explanations, she should be ready for this, but knowing why Adora wants it kind of blindsided her. She knew Adora always liked pleasing her partner, so she assumed that was why she asked Catra to give her orders until she elaborated. Catra was grateful Adora had her eyes closed, because gaping at her sub kind of breaks the in-charge dom illusion.

Despite her initial surprise, it makes perfect sense to her. Adora's greatest fear in life seems to be failing people. Of course she wants to make up for not listening to Catra before. It makes Catra's heart squeeze painfully and her mind kind of scream, but she forces her emotions down. She can do this. Adora isn't her first client to need orders and she won't be her last. Catra has her walk to the center of the room, running her hand along her riding crop and deciding how she wants to approach this as she slowly circles Adora.

Adora fidgets a little where she stands, her eyes bright and inquisitive as they follow Catra's circling movements. The fidgeting gives Catra an idea. Given the nature of this request and how Adora was barely able to ask for it, Catra doesn't think that punishment is the way to go here. Adora likes the pain - she admitted that ten different ways before they even got to masochism on the list and Adora gave her a flat, unimpressed look as Catra grinned – but with something this sensitive, there are better routes to go that can still reach subspace just as fast.

"Hands at your side, princess," Catra orders, drawing to a halt behind Adora. Adora hurries to drop her hands, just like she always did when one of their teachers who didn't like Adora's fidgeting caught her. Catra doesn't mind it – obviously, or she wouldn't have given Adora her tail earlier – but the point isn't Adora stopping the behavior, it's just telling her what to do. Catra steps up behind Adora, just close enough to lean over her shoulder and whisper in her ear, their bodies not touching but the heat radiating out so Adora can acutely feel Catra's presence behind her.

"Shoulders back. I want to see your head held high, proud to be following my orders," Catra breathes to her. She watches a minute shiver run through Adora before she drops her shoulders back, stretching up to stand like a statue with perfect posture in the middle of the room. She starts to turn her head as if to look over her shoulder at Catra, but she quickly snatches her hand out to grip the base of Adora's neck and squeeze, holding her in place. It makes Adora's breath hitch, but Adora freezes in place for her.

“You won’t move at all unless I tell you to. You won’t close your eyes, or open them, unless I tell you to. You may breathe freely. Everything else is under my orders. You will speak only when prompted or necessary. Do you understand?” Catra orders her. If this weren’t the first session, she wouldn’t even mention that Adora has the right to decide she needs to speak for her own, but she doesn’t want Adora to forget about her words. She still tries to frame it in a way that reduces Adora’s autonomy in the situation as she reminds her.

Adora’s breathing has turned harsh, excitement quivering through her body despite how she is following Catra’s orders and holding completely still. She doesn’t answer right away, clearly processing the order and her reaction to it. Adora already agreed to this as the focus of today’s session though, which means she doesn’t get time to consider Catra’s order right now – she follows them, or she calls her words, and this reaction means the only color that could possibly be on her mind is *blue*.

“You only speak when prompted, but you *always* answer. A prompt is an order and you follow mine. Now tell me, do you understand, or do I need to punish you for disobedience?” Catra asks, squeezing her hand a little on the back of Adora’s neck. She is careful not to be too harsh, but she lets her claws slide out, the tips teasing Adora’s neck. She won’t really use them – the claws are on the *want* list, but anything that breaks skin is on the *will* and Catra has no intention of doing something that intense for Adora’s first time – but the thrill that the teasing pressuring points send through Adora is palpable.

“Yes, sir,” she replies breathlessly, her body seeming to quiver slightly beneath Catra’s hands, but otherwise staying still. Small, involuntary reactions like this are far from against the rules – Catra *lives* for them, heat pooling in her gut at the sight of Adora so eager for her. She has been getting more and more worked up. Catra is pretty sure she was edging into the level of horny where higher thought starts shutting down by the time they reached the end of the contract. It is exactly where Catra wants her.

Catra grins to herself, instantly releasing Adora’s neck and stepping back to watch the subtle sway Adora does in her absence, otherwise holding still in the center of the room. She is so susceptible right now. Catra doesn’t doubt that getting Adora into subspace won’t be much of a challenge when she is this worked up and eager to give herself over. She stays behind her, remaining out of Adora’s sight as she begins to slowly pace in a semi-circle, walking to where she just enters Adora’s periphery and then turning back to circle around her other side.

“I am going to give you orders for moving specific parts of your body. You do not have the autonomy to move any others. If I tell you to move your head, you don't even move your eyes unless I say to. I don’t want to punish you. I want to reward you for being good. Behave for me,” Catra orders. She watches Adora swallow, her breath hitching again and her head twitching in the beginnings of an aborted head nod. Catra instantly draws to a stop, halting her pacing. Adora seems to realize her mistake. The flare of tension in her body is obvious despite how she holds herself still from scrambling.

“Yes, sir,” Adora agrees, quickly. Her voice is just as breathless as before, an underlying current of anxiety and anticipation there. She knows she almost just disobeyed an order. Catra narrows her eyes at the side of Adora’s head, her tail flicking to the side. The deviation was an accident, but it still took place. Adora is only beginning to learn, and there is a curve to

easy obedience in these moments. If Catra's entire goal wasn't stripping her autonomy for thirty minutes, it certainly wouldn't be worthy of punishment – she kind of *likes* when subs disobey her and get defiant – but Catra also needs to establish her place as Adora's dom when they don't have a relationship like that built up yet.

"Eyes fixed ahead, tilt your chin down," Catra orders. Adora lets out a slow breath as she does so, her eyebrows raising to accommodate her gaze fixed on the wall opposite her. Punishment isn't always the way to correct behavior – sometimes giving a sub the chance to prove they can be obedient works just as well. "Good girl. Look down at the ground, just before your feet. Nothing else moves. I didn't order it to," Catra commands.

There is that tremor again. It is delicious, the tiniest jump of Adora's shoulders as her gaze drags down to fix on the polished wood floor of the studio before her. Catra smirks to herself as she turns her semicircle into a full circle. She watches Adora's eyes widen slightly as she keeps her gaze fixed down, only able to see Catra in the edges of her vision despite how she is passing right in front of her now. She is so eager to be given orders and follow them. Catra's own heart is beating quickly.

"Keep looking at that spot. Kneel," Catra orders. Excitement flares in Adora, along with an answering heat inside Catra as she lowers herself down to the ground. "You like being on your knees for me. You like being *mine*," Catra says to her. It isn't a question – there is no point when Catra knows the answer, but it is part of the scene. Telling Adora not only what to do, but what to feel. The faster she removes her autonomy, the faster she can get her to subspace. She isn't relying on orders alone to get her there, though.

Catra draws to a halt behind Adora again, struggling to keep her own breath even as Adora struggles to breathe at all. She seems to be having an internal conflict, likely unsure if she is supposed to answer or if it would be speaking out of turn. Catra smiles to herself as she crouches behind Adora, reaching for the crop at her belt. Adora draws in a sharp breath as Catra gently places the heart end on her back and drags it down slowly.

"Feel that, princess? That is what is waiting for you if you misbehave. But I know you won't. You want to be good for me," Catra tells her. Adora's next breath contains a quiet, thin whine. Her hands, still hanging at her sides, fist as she contains herself. Catra tuts, flicking her hand and bringing her crop in a light sting against Adora's forearm, where it will hurt but not damage her. Adora's entire body jolts and she releases another quiet noise, this one closer to a moan.

"I didn't say you could move your hands, princess. Behave. Flatten your hands and place your palms on your thighs," Catra orders her. Over Adora's shoulder, she watches the line of her throat bob as she moves to fulfill the orders. Adora's heartbeat is loud, an excited flutter that has worked its way out of her chest and into the room at large. She reeks of desire. Catra grins to herself as she straightens and circles around to Adora's front. She reaches out with her crop again, stroking along Adora's cheeks and watching Adora's eyelids flutter dangerously. She manages to keep them open and fixed down on the floor, but it is a close thing.

"Shift your thighs further apart. I want you kneeled with your legs spread," Catra orders. Adora's jaw flexes, a tense shiver running through her body for a long moment before she

carefully shifts her legs apart, edging her knees out with her hands still on her thighs. Adora doesn't have the best balance, but she manages to shift her knees apart. As she does so, the scent of desire in the room only thickens, her clenched thighs no longer able to dampen it. Catra grins down at Adora, well aware she can see the feral look in her periphery.

"*Good girl*. This is exactly how I want you," Catra praises, tucking the crop back onto her belt and reaching out with her hand now to softly brush some flyaway hairs out of Adora's face. Adora's eyelids flutter again, a bit of the desperate tension in her body easing. That praise is exactly what she was craving. Catra purrs softly to herself, watching Adora struggle to keep herself perfectly still for Catra. She keeps having to tense her body to follow Catra's orders, but Catra wants her more relaxed than that.

"Close your eyes for me. Focus on breathing," Catra tells her, her voice soft. Adora's eyes flutter shut almost *gratefully*.

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Adora started out lightheaded just from the intensity of holding back. By the time Catra finishes walking her through breathing exercises, syncing them up until Adora doesn't even breathe on her own, she feels like she is floating. She knows she is probably swaying where she is kneeled, but Catra never corrects her on it, instead praising her for following orders. Every bit of praise washes over Adora, making her only more eager to get another order so she can be praised again.

"Good girl. You've done so well. You can breathe on your own again," Catra tells her, softly stroking Adora's arms as she releases her. The part of Adora's brain that is still capable of wondering about anything outside of what Catra will tell her to do next suspects that Catra is holding her up to some degree since she is definitely wavering in her kneeled position, but most of her is just focused on its disappointment that Catra is releasing her.

"Shh, you're a good sub. You're so well-behaved, princess. I'm giving you autonomy back because I know you can be trusted with it," Catra assures her, despite how Adora didn't say *anything*. At some point during the process, she became so thoroughly Catra's that it seems she began to sense her thoughts. Adora swallows, the floating feeling only intensified by Catra's words. She is being good. She focuses on keeping her breaths slow and deep like Catra was walking her through.

"There you go. Open your eyes, princess. I want to see you," Catra tells her. Adora's breath hitches as she cautiously flutters her eyes open. They have been closed for so long as she focused on nothing but Catra's voice that she finds herself squinting a bit as she looks up into Catra's face. Her expression is warm, *gentle*, and that is its own kind of praise to Adora. She was good enough to earn that look from Catra. Her body is a bit stiff, but she feels utterly relaxed where she is kneeled. Catra's eyes are soft as she gazes back at Adora.

“You can look wherever you want now, princess,” Catra tells her. Adora’s eyes don’t move. Why would she want to look anywhere but into Catra’s eyes? Catra smiles softly, stroking her hands on Adora’s arms in a soothing gesture. “Good girl. Do you feel good?” Catra asks. Adora doesn’t know why she is asking the question – surely she knows the answer – but maybe she just wants to hear Adora say it. She has hardly spoken except to repeat phrases like *I’m a good girl* at Catra’s instruction.

She swallows, clearing her disused throat a little as she does so. She doesn’t know how long she sat in the center of the floor, getting totally lost in Catra’s voice, but she can guess that Catra is releasing her because the session is over, so it must have been awhile. She can feel some part of her coming back down to Etheria and she kind of doesn’t like it. The floating feels incredible. The session has to end eventually though.

“Floaty in a good way,” she manages. Her throat feels dry, but that thought stops mattering to her when Catra smiles, genuine and pleased, at her words. Her hands on Adora’s arms squeeze for a moment before she resumes petting down her just firmly enough to keep her stable and upright. Adora finally looks away from Catra’s eyes just to look at her beautiful smile, drinking in her happiness even as the corner of her lips pulls into a smirk in response to Adora’s staring.

“That’s exactly how I want you to feel. You were a good sub for me. You’re released. You can speak and move if you want to, but don’t try to stand quite yet. I’m going to help you,” Catra tells her, squeezing her arms again as if to hold her down on her knees. A bit jerkily, Adora nods her head. At one point Catra had her loll her head around and roll her shoulders. At the time, Adora assumed Catra was having her do it just to exert her control over Adora’s body, but now she realizes it was to keep her from being even stiffer than she already is.

It feels wrong to be back in control of her own body. Giving all direction over to Catra felt *right*. Catra was responsible with her power. Adora doesn’t particularly want it back. She is having trouble thinking about anything except how good that felt. Being back in her body means welcoming back the anxiety that follows her around so often as she wonders if she is fucking everything up. She can’t be fucking things up with Catra if Catra is the one telling her what to do.

Adora draws in a few deep breaths as she rolls her shoulders, taking stock of her body as she slowly grounds herself again. Her knees hurt and her legs are definitely stiff, but aside from that, she still feels good. Catra’s expression is soft as she stands up, staying leaned over so she can keep her hands on Adora. Adora actually really needs to stand now that she thinks about it, her legs almost to the point of locking up. Catra stopped them just in time.

“Come on. We’ll go over to the couch and cuddle as you come down,” Catra tells her. Adora perks up, her heart leaping as she tries not to react too obviously. She definitely fails, but with her autonomy restored, she doesn’t have to look Catra in the face as she smirks over Adora’s excitement. Adora can’t help it. She has desperately missed holding her best friend.

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This isn't how aftercare *usually* goes with a client, but there was never going to be anything usual about this session. Catra lounges on the center of the sofa as Adora sprawls out beside her, half in her lap and half curling around her torso to bury her face in Catra's shoulder as Catra purrs for her. Catra murmurs soft assurances that she was perfectly behaved as she gently runs one hand up and down Adora's back and massages at her sore thigh with the other.

Adora's legs were shaky when she stood. Catra considered getting her a pillow for her knees a few moments in, but she seemed to be lost already at that point and she didn't want to ruin the effect by disappearing back to the cabinet to fetch one. She kept an eye on the clock, aware that the limit of what Adora should do would line up pretty well with when the session should end anyway. Eight passed a few minutes ago, along with the theoretical end of their session, but Catra just keeps soothing Adora.

It was her first time. Catra isn't going to cut her loose while she is still in subspace. Catra picked a session time so soon after their phone call partially so she wouldn't have time to doubt her choices, but mostly because it was just barely outside of their usual twenty-four-hour notice policy and that meant that there shouldn't be any other last-minute bookings coming in right after it either. They have as long as they need.

Maybe she also didn't want Lonnie to check their shared calendar for the studio and see Adora's name. There would have been questions. At the time, she didn't have the answer to them. Now, she is pretty sure she does. That session felt incredible. She doesn't usually let herself get into them like that, but domming Adora is different. She doesn't have to be professional with her ex-everything. She can enjoy Adora's squirming just as much as Adora seems to enjoy giving herself over.

"Feeling more grounded?" Catra asks, bending forward to rest her forehead against Adora's head for a moment before pulling back. Adora releases a noise that falls solidly under reluctant agreement. Catra feels her lips quirk as she keeps petting down her back. "We won't stop until you're ready. I'm just checking in," Catra reminds her. This time, the soft grunt Adora gives is more content. She nuzzles against Catra's shoulder for a moment before she reluctantly lifts her head and squints at Catra as her eyes adjust to the light again.

"Yeah. That was really fucking good, Catra. I don't know that I've ever felt… like that," Adora tells her, apparently unable to describe exactly what *that* felt like. Catra feels her heartrate pick up, excitement beating through her as she twists her grin into a confident smirk despite how what she really feels at that statement is just *happiness*. This is the part of domming that she loves. There are downsides and negative effects to it too, but moments like this are what she lives for.

"Good. I'm glad you enjoyed yourself, Adora," Catra assures her, reaching up to cup her jaw and stroke her thumb along Adora's cheek before she can stop herself. Adora doesn't seem bothered by how tender the gesture is between exes though, sighing softly with contentment and leaning into the touch. The fact that she is choosing to do things for herself shows that she is coming out of it, even if the things she is choosing to do are cuddle up with Catra further.

That kind of means nothing. Catra is pretty sure she would have done that while they were talking at the beginning if she thought that Catra would allow it. Adora's heartbeat is steady and calm, her contentment obvious as she hums a little. Catra gently strokes her thumb over Adora's cheek – she seems to like that – just waiting for Adora to tell her she is ready to stand on her own. Eventually Adora's eyes flutter open, her gaze traveling lazily over Catra's face until finally they are looking each other in the eyes again.

"I want to do that again. *Often*," Adora tells her. Her voice is determined, but it is the kind of determined that makes it clear she thinks Catra might protest. The very idea makes Catra scoff. For a split second, panic crosses Adora's face, but it eases when Catra throws her a cocky smirk.

"You can have it as often as you can afford it, princess," Catra throws back. To her relief, the tension slips out of Adora's expression and she chuckles a little to herself as she melts once more in Catra's hands.

"You're worth the price," Adora says, softly, casually, like it's *nothing*. Catra feels herself blush, her fur fluffing up as her tail thuds softly against the couch. Fuck, what has she gotten herself into?

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: Taking away control. Light impact play with a riding crop, but mostly orders and autonomy removal with the goal of reaching subspace.
There will be plenty of stuff that is more of what you "traditionally" think of as BDSM, but this first session was a softer introduction for Adora's sake. I skipped over the breathing part because honestly reading/writing that shit makes me hyper aware of my own body and causes me panic attacks, but it seemed like a good soft introduction for them.

Good Girl

Chapter Notes

> Skip to end note for smut warnings. Light CWs related to the tags already on the fic, and one kink that isn't tagged because it's only halfsies and kind of covered by another tag. I know the convention is to always capitalize Dom and lowercase sub and I know why, but I think it looks bizarre to have them not match in case and it bothers my OCD so they're both lowercase in this fic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora realizes the painting of her is titled *Ecstasy* when she goes to hang it up the morning after. She was a bit *busy* when she got home last night, just leaning it against the wall while she hurried to her bed because fuck did she need to get off after all that. She flushes, staring at the painting that she put on her bedroom wall. It feels a bit odd to hang an erotic painting of herself there, but where else is she supposed to put it? It isn't like she stared at it as she got off last night.

What they ended up doing wasn't even sexual, but with the anticipation and build up of going though the list of kinks, Adora was worked up. The experience of giving herself over to Catra felt incredible. If Catra gets half of what Adora felt out of domming, then Adora sees why she chose to pursue this career. She really wishes she knew how that happened though. She doesn't know how Catra went from a community college art student to a dom. She said the painting was done for a class and had hung up for a year, but if she did get into an art college, she should have graduated three years ago.

Was the painting just in storage ever since she did it for a class, or did Catra take a gap after her associates and was still in class for her bachelor's a year ago? Adora wants nothing more than to call Catra up and just talk. Now that she has gotten the hard part of admitting what happened in last few years for her out of the way, she desperately wants to know what it was like for Catra. Clearly she is still pursuing painting in some way – not that Adora ever thought she would stop – but Adora is pretty certain that Catra's primary income comes from domming.

She could call Catra and ask, but she is pretty sure she would just get hung up on and make things worse. Catra said she was ready to have Adora as a client but not more. If Adora pushes too hard now, she might ruin things. She can't risk it. She has a shot at being something to Catra again, if she plays her cards right. Catra wasn't as harsh or cagey as she was Saturday night. Adora is hopeful that come the end of winter, Catra will be happy to crawl into her arms again and purr as Adora pets her not only as aftercare, but just because.

Adora wants to get back together, but more than anything she just wants Catra back in her life. If Catra doesn't want to date again, Adora will be fine with that as long as they are

friends. They were best friends for the fifteen years they knew each other before they aged out of the group home and could finally act on the building tension between them that their guardian never approved of. Adora would be happy to have that again.

As long as she has Catra, she will be happier than she has been in five years – seven, really. Long distance was brutal. Adora wasn't any happier with it than Catra was, she just pushed her feelings aside. Now they are in the same city and can hold each other again, Adora is determined to overcome the distance that grew between them. She just has to convince Catra to let her.

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Lonnie texts Catra on Wednesday night that she is eyeing some new equipment and Catra jumps on the chance to meet up and talk about it. She really can't afford to front half the cost of a big new piece right now, but it gives them a chance to meet up and talk. Catra usually has no desire to do that *ever*, but in this case, they really don't have a choice. Catra eyes their shared calendar and sees Lonnie doesn't have another session until Friday, so she invites Lonnie to come over that night.

It gives her time to sort out her thoughts before they have to have a talk about this. So far Catra hasn't told anyone about Adora. Her roommates know something is up between the general moping and Catra sneaking into Scorpia's bed Saturday night, but aside from Scorpia being extra clingy and Entrapta petting Catra every time she walks past her, they have been letting her deal with it on her own. After five years, they know Catra has mood swings.

The problem is that her mood swings aren't random. Well, not entirely. Sometimes she feels depressed or anxious with no obvious cause, but all-too-often there *is* a reason. Catra can't deny that she loves BDSM – both for how it makes her feel and how she knows she is truly helping some of her clients – but doing it as a job is tough. It requires a lot of mental presence and emotional labor on her part, both during the session and afterwards. After some sessions, her depression gets bad.

She struggles to fall asleep that night, already bracing herself to wake up on a downswing, but she wakes up and she feels… fine. Better than that, actually, because she feels a bit inspired and heads straight for her paints. She doesn't really have a plan, so of course it turns into another painting of Adora. Her subjects often end up to be Adora when she paints supposedly-indistinct humans.

This one could be justified due to its abstract nature and the blanket of the sea most of the body is wrapped in, but she still is going to show it to Adora for approval before she tries to display or sell it anywhere. She has never sold something that was truly or obviously Adora – even if the only people it would be obvious to were her or Adora herself – but her brush tends to follow the sweep of her curves when she is outlining a woman. There is no body she knows better than Adora's except her own, so it is the body that comes through in her art most often.

She stops only when Lonnie texts that she is on her way. It's easier to turn her brain off and paint than confront the truth she doesn't want to admit: she wants Adora now the same way she did five years ago, and she doesn't know how much time would have to pass for that to stop being true. Doing more than they are now would be a bad idea – even doing this much is – but Catra isn't going to turn down Adora when she tries to book again, which Catra doesn't doubt she will do as often as she can afford to. Adora is persistent like that.

So is Lonnie, because everyone in Catra's life has to be a bit of an asshole. Scorpia lets her in when Catra is in the middle of putting away her equipment. Lonnie sees her new painting - still far from finished but Catra can already tell she is going to like it and that annoys her given the subject matter – while she waits for Catra to finish and lead her away from the easel and up to her bedroom. Of course Lonnie gives her shit about the nudity in the painting, commenting about how Catra is a sex worker and yet she still can't get enough of it in her personal life.

It's a half-naked woman. It is no more about sex than her job truly is, but that isn't going to silence Lonnie, so Catra refrains from snapping at her about it and tells her to just set up her laptop so they can finish and she can get back to painting. It turns out that the new equipment is a new set of sound-dampening curtains to replace the ones along the wall they share with a neighbor who actually *does* do tantric yoga and has complained about the noise from their sessions a time or two.

It isn't as expensive as getting a new bench or anything, so Catra agrees to think it over. She doesn't say anything about what they actually need to talk about until Lonnie is struggling to shove her laptop back into her backpack that is just slightly too small to accommodate it. Catra clears her throat, ignoring the way Lonnie instantly narrows her eyes down at her bag.

"I sold *Ecstasy* to a client, so don't be surprised when it's missing," Catra tells her. Lonnie narrows her eyes further, raising her gaze to eye Catra for a moment. That isn't worthy of her hesitance on its own, and it's kind of obvious that Catra was waiting until the last minute to broach a subject..

"… Okay," Lonnie replies, clearly waiting for more. Catra forces herself to hold her gaze.

"And we need a new safe word," she adds. Lonnie's eyebrows rocket up to her hairline as she stares at Catra with confusion before it apparently *clicks* and her eyes widen.

"No way. You aren't speaking again," Lonnie shoots back, incredulous. Catra's fur bristles a little, already defensive. She scoffs, looking away as she does so. She didn't lie to Adora when she told her what her safe words were, it is just that she has more than one set. When she and Lonnie practice, they use the color system. When they need to check in with each other after off-site sessions or first appointments with new clients, however, their code is very different.

"Look, mentioning Adora as our safe word just isn't going to work, that's all. I wouldn't say we're speaking," Catra huffs, crossing her arms. It was always easy to slip in to conversation before when one of them knew to watch for it, but now Catra could be telling the truth when she says Adora is coming to pick her up – though that exact scenario is still unlikely. After a long moment of gaping at her, Lonnie finally manages to close her mouth.

“Listen, I always said your breakup was stupid, I just didn’t think either of you would ever swallow your pride and admit that,” Lonnie returns. Catra hisses, her ears flattening against her head. Lonnie knows a lot – more than anyone else in Catra’s life, actually – but she still can’t know what it was *like*. She can’t know what Catra felt. She knew them in high school before they got the opportunity to try to be together and she knew Catra after, but she wasn’t there *during*.

“It wasn’t stupid, *she* was. And now she’s paying me, so I don’t really care,” Catra shoots back. The disinterest is a terrible act and it can’t distract Lonnie. Catra has never seen her look more disbelieving before, not even when Catra told her that she and Adora broke up. Catra was a wreck then, though, so it was pretty obvious something big had happened. She is surprisingly calm about this whole thing, even she can admit that, so Lonnie’s shock is warranted.

“Fucking hell. Why are you so terrible at making good decisions? Are you seriously domming *Adora*?” Lonnie asks. Catra glares at her, feeling her heart beat a bit too fast. Fuck, the anger is coming. She hates that. It used to be all she had, but she learned to control it more when she got into BDSM and learned that you should never, ever engage in it when you are genuinely upset. She had to get a better handle on her emotions to do it professionally, but anything around Adora always makes her highly emotional.

“Sorry, do you want me to let her go to someone *else*?” she shoots back, bitter and sarcastic. To her annoyance, Lonnie isn’t cowed, narrowing her eyes in response.

“Yeah, I would, because then they can be impartial and actually have healthy sessions. What the fuck, Catra. You know better than to do anything with someone you’re mad at,” Lonnie shoots back. The words hit Catra like ice. She snarls a little, anger flaring to try to chase out the cold emotion, but it doesn’t work. It never does, but not now especially, when Lonnie is right. Catra swallows, flexing her hands on her folded arms and gripping tight as she forces down her growl.

“I’m not mad at her. We talked some. I can be professional. I’ll treat her like any other client before I send her to someone else,” Catra responds. She shouldn’t have to justify herself to Lonnie, but she knows she would be yelling at Lonnie too if she agreed to a session while she and Rogelio were fighting. Not that she and Rogelio ever fight, but BDSM isn’t healthy when anger is involved. You can’t give someone with a vendetta a riding crop. Catra doesn’t *have* a vendetta, though.

Sure, she enjoyed slapping Adora at the party, but she enjoys slapping people anyway. She doesn’t quite trust Adora to treat her better, but she doesn’t want to hurt Adora. Clearly Adora has already been hurt by this. BDSM is about healing as much as it is about enjoying yourself – at least it should be. It is for Catra when she can help a client reach that blissful state, and going to subspace is its own kind of therapy. She isn’t trying to hurt Adora. If anything, she is feeling her out to figure out where they stand now.

Lonnie purses her lips. She doesn’t look convinced. Catra doubts there is anything she can say that would convince her, actually, but she doesn’t get to make the call. Adora is the one booking sessions. Unless Lonnie wants to keep an eye on their calendar and show up to crash

the party when she sees Adora's name, she can't do anything about who Catra decides to take on as a client. Her eyes are still narrowed.

"You know, saying that you don't want her to see someone else is the opposite of treating her like any other client," Lonnie points out. Catra hisses, her tail lashing beside her. That doesn't fucking count. Adora isn't here and this isn't a session.

"I'm not hurting her or mad at her. We're working on it. Leave us alone and let us figure it out," Catra shoots back. It is admitting too much about the things she doesn't even want to admit to herself – she isn't supposed to want Adora back in her life like this – but it seems to work at least. Lonnie doesn't look more convinced, but she sighs and turns back to shoving her laptop back in her backpack.

"Messy ass lesbians," she mutters under her breath. Catra narrows her eyes at her friend.

"Remind me how many boyfriends you have?" she shoots back, because she knows that even Lonnie isn't sure if the answer to that is one or two. She definitely has Rogelio, but then Rogelio has *his* boyfriend, and the trio all live together, so where does it really end? Lonnie isn't interested in sex for the most part, so the fact that she isn't physical with Kyle doesn't mean anything when she isn't with Rogelio either. Catra has never been able to figure out where the bounds of Lonnie's relationship end, but she knows for a fact that Lonnie doesn't know either.

"Even if we don't know what to call ourselves, we know how we feel because we *talk* about it and shit," Lonnie shoots back as she hauls her bag over her shoulder. Catra snarls. It's a worse sound than the last one. This time it is raw, Catra quickly looking away as pain flares in her chest. She tried to talk about it. She asked Adora to call her more often and she didn't. She told Adora she couldn't stand to keep missing time together and it didn't change.

Adora is the one who pulled away. She had her reasons, Catra knows that now, but how could she have known before when Adora's shame was so great that she hid them? This wasn't Catra's fucking fault. She tried. She gave everything she had and Adora gave her nothing. Lonnie seems to realize she has gone too far, wincing a little and sighing. Catra doesn't look at her, glaring at the wall across from her to keep from opening her mouth and yelling.

"Just be careful," Lonnie says. Catra sniffs and doesn't reply. She was going to be anyway. She refuses to let this be five years ago. They won't make those mistakes again. The only question is if they will make new ones.

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Adora muddles her way through her work week. She kind of wants nothing more than to call Catra again. It doesn't help that work is boring, her two best friends are out of town for three weeks, and Tuesday night was kind of the best that she has felt since… Okay, she doesn't know that she has *ever* felt like she did Tuesday night, floating with Catra's hands on her and

her voice gentle in her ear. The world seemed to slow and revolve on a pin around the one person Adora has always wanted back.

How desperate would it be to email Catra again before the week is up? Can she pass it off just as her wanting to reconnect? She *does* want that and she doesn't see it happening without her scheduling another session, but she also just wants another session. After work on Friday, she pulls up her bank account and stares at it, first trying to do mental math and then giving up and pulling out a sticky note pad. Catra's rates are far from cheap, which is good for her business but terrible for how badly Adora feels like she needs this.

She hates admitting that Glimmer was right, but given the way she finds herself bouncing her knee as she works out how often her extra spending money will allow her to book with Catra, she suspects that she had a point when she said that Adora needs to get laid. It was never going to happen until Catra walked through the bar door – and, well, it still isn't – but she probably wouldn't be craving the release that Catra gave her is she had any other way to relax other than her own hand. Adora feels a bit ruined, like she has seen the other side and can't imagine going back.

Going once a week is pushing her finances to the limit. Adora frowns down at the paper. She doesn't even want to wait until next week, she doesn't know how she is supposed to do this just two or three times a month. Maybe going once a week only at the beginning? She doesn't spend a lot on herself usually. She has a little extra she can use as cushion for this first month, and then she can start spacing them out more once she has taken the edge off.

Regardless of what her body is craving, her heart wants Catra. If they can repair their relationship by seeing each other during these sessions and start actually spending time as friends outside of them, then it will be a lot easier for Adora to go longer between them. She can take a week – or even two – off if she still gets to see Catra in that time, maybe hold her close and listen to that soft purr of hers that was so soothing to feel again after the session.

Adora glares at her scribbled post-its and drops her pen reluctantly. Yeah, waiting isn't going to *work*. It has been a few days. It wouldn't be that desperate to message Catra and ask about scheduling an appointment for next week. Adora has no way of knowing what her *usual* availability is like and if it's necessary to book ahead.

She pulls out her phone and sends off a text emphasizing that she doesn't know how far ahead she should book, but that she had a lot of fun and she would like another session next week. Preferably on the weekend, because fuck were her thoughts not work-appropriate the next day – though she doesn't add that last part. She held open a door for someone at work and was disappointed when they didn't praise her for it. The thought was mortifying when she realized she was having it.

Wow, desperate much?

Well, okay, *yes*, but Catra doesn't have to say it. Adora huffs, grateful that Catra can't see her right now. It's easier to lie over text – that is why Adora dodged Catra's calls on the nights when she was so stressed she was on the verge of a breakdown over her grades, tears oncoming and a headache pounding against her skull. She wouldn't be able to lie that she was fine, not to Catra.

I don't know how this works.

And I miss you.

She adds the second message after a moment of debate, but she isn't ashamed of how badly she wants to see Catra again and she is *kind of* embarrassed by how much of her wants their next meeting to involve getting on her knees. Catra has read receipts on so Adora can *see* that she read the messages, but for a solid minute there isn't even a typing bubble. Adora really needs a typing bubble. Maybe she is just checking her calendar? Adora really hopes that is the case. Another minute ticks by. Fuck. Did she overstep?

The weekend is kinda busy, princess. Everyone wants to show off their sexy costume for Halloween like I give a shit. Friday night work?

Adora breathes a sigh of relief. Okay, so Catra *was* checking her calendar. Focusing on the relief of that almost lets Adora ignore the weird bubbling in her chest, like heartburn wanting to come up. Adora doesn't really know why she doesn't like the idea of Catra's clients dressing up for her. What they did during the session was incredible, but it is nothing to be jealous over. No, Adora's problem is with the implication that Catra's clients are expecting her to have interest in them – to find them sexy, or maybe even accept their advances.

Does she normally get harassed? Adora really wants to ask Catra how the hell any of this usually goes and how she ended up in this career. She wants to ask what happened to painting and if she got her bachelor's. Those aren't questions for your dom, though. They are questions for a friend, and Adora doesn't know if she is allowed to consider them that yet.

Yeah, as long as it's after seven. I just want to be able to relax the next day.

I have a six already anyway. Seven-thirty or eight work?

Eight.

Adora doesn't get another text, but two minutes later she gets an email notification. It is almost the exact same email as she got last time, just with a different date and time on it. Adora's annoyance at Catra's other clients fades, replaced with the pounding of her heart as she accepts the invitation and the reality sinks in that in a week she is going to be back in Catra's dungeon again. She is a bit surprised when she gets another text from Catra a few minutes after the last.

> Don't need to answer right now, but think about what you want to do for the session. Tell me sometime in the next few days so I can prepare for it. We can do the same thing, get more intense with it, or explore something else from your list.

Right. I'll get back to you on that.

Adora's heart is beating too fast and that is the only reason her skin feels so flushed. Catra emailed her a PDF copy of her *list* Wednesday morning near one AM. If they were on friendly terms, Adora would have chided her for being up so late, but Catra doesn't seem to have a normal nine-to-five to wake up for and Adora was up too, staring at her ceiling, flushed from the afterglow, and feeling a *lot,* so there wasn't much she could do but download the contract and flush as she read through everything.

She told Catra she would get back to her to give herself an excuse to text her again as much as she needed time to come up with an answer, but as she scans through the list and she thinks about Catra's comment on *dressing up*, an idea strikes her that has her sinking down in her desk chair despite how no one can see her embarrassment. She doesn't have a real Halloween costume – it was never a part of their lives growing up at the group home, and she is a bit old to get into it now – but she does have *something.*

Not something sexy – at least, not out of this specific context – because she refuses to be like Catra's other clients and not respect boundaries, but she needed a quick go-to costume to throw on for Perfuma's annual Halloween party and this was the most low-effort thing she could acquire four years back when she started going to them. It could certainly be *repurposed* for this. The idea of asking for Catra to do this is kind of mortifying, though.

Adora gave herself an excuse to talk to Catra later and she will use it to gather her courage if nothing else.

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Catra burst out laughing when Adora finally got her shit together and texted her again Tuesday night, but Adora didn't see it, so what she doesn't know won't hurt her. After her initial gut-reaction, though, Catra can't deny that she is excited, even if she tried to send back

an entirely neutral and nonjudgmental text confirming she has a collar for clients to use. Catra has done this before – there isn't a lot you can do without undressing that she hasn't – but doing it with Adora will be a special kind of fun.

Catra wouldn't want to be on the receiving end of something like this, but holding the leash? *That* she likes, and the idea of Adora being the one she is leading is even more exciting. It feels good to be looking forward to a session, but it also proves Lonnie's point somewhat. Catra can see that Lonnie's concern makes sense, but she maintains that she isn't going to mistreat Adora. She couldn't fucking take it if she did, and having a dom that knows her so well will make the experience better for Adora. Catra certainly doesn't trust anyone else with her, jealousy aside.

Despite having agreed to this and prepared for it, Catra feels caught off-guard when she opens the door to her dungeon and sees what Adora is wearing. Her ears twitch involuntarily – unlike Adora's, which *can't* since they're just on the headband she is wearing – as she stares at Adora, whose sheepish expression is only growing more embarrassed for every moment that Catra is staring at her. Adora is wearing normal clothes outside of the headband, but all Adora said in her text was that she wanted to try collar play, so Catra is caught off-guard.

"I can't believe you wore that in *public*," Catra greets as she steps aside to let Adora in. Adora flushes, fidgeting a little with her hands as she hurries inside. Catra honestly didn't think she would dress up at all, especially not after she bitched about her clients doing so, but she doesn't mind. This is a far cry from one of her fetishist clients showing up dressed as a sexy cat and making bids for attention and approval, Catra just can't believe Adora walked through the halls with the ears on.

"It seemed fitting. Other people are dressing up for early Halloween parties before everything kicks off next weekend anyway. It isn't like anyone else knows what it is for," Adora defends, her cheeks blazing. Catra snorts as she locks the door, turning around to send Adora an incredulous look. Adora's blush deepens as she looks back with an indignant pout. Catra can't believe how naïve she is being. She is a grown ass woman and Catra knows she has decent logic skills. She should put two and two together.

"People *here* will know what it's for. You might as well have written *bottom* across your forehead," Catra responds, a grin curling at her lips as Adora turns a delightful shade of *just-kill-me-now* embarrassed, squeaking a little and giving a full body twitch with her indignation. Adora sputters for a moment, but Catra is right.

"I am *not*," is the best comeback that Adora can come up with. Catra is having too much fun. She chuckles as she shakes her head, stepping forward into Adora's personal space. Adora's ears are darkening now, perhaps with embarrassment, but it could also be something more fun as she blinks with wide eyes at Catra's leer.

"No, you're not. But being so submissive for me isn't better. If I order you to your knees, you will drop in an instant. Now tell me what a big bad top you are," Catra returns, cooing the last sentence a little. Adora, despite her indignant squeak, *likes* it. She shifts a little where she stands, desire hitting the air as she opens and closes her mouth a few times. She doesn't have a comeback. Catra is right, after all. Adora might have mainly gotten off on taking care of

Catra, but it seems the thing she was missing to bottom out of the gate was a firm hand to guide her.

“On your knees, Adora. Prove me wrong,” Catra orders, a satisfied curl to her voice as her tail sweeps slowly behind her. They haven’t technically started yet, but there’s nothing wrong with working Adora up before they do their last negotiation and get started. Catra isn’t usually flirty like this before a session, but Adora tends to break her rules. A thrill of excitement shoots through her as Adora, flushed from indignation and desire, stares at her for a moment before she lowers herself down to her knees.

Catra purrs to herself as Adora, apparently taking advantage of having autonomy this time, eagerly reaches up and places her hands low on the back of Catra’s thighs, tugging slightly to encourage Catra to step closer. Catra’s tail curls with satisfaction as she reaches down and slices through Adora’s ponytail holder. Adora’s eyelids flutter, a small shiver running through her before she manages to look up to Catra, her gaze darkened with desire. Her expression is eager.

If Adora can afford to book sessions with her, then she can afford some new hair ties. Catra likes asserting her dominance, and she likes how Adora looks with her hair down. It’s still held out of her face by the headband with plushy golden dog ears affixed that is crowning her head right now. Catra doesn’t give in to Adora’s tugging, staying rooted in her spot, but she pets through her hair as she looks down and holds eye contact with her.

“Good *puppy*,” Catra coos to her, entirely condescending. Adora’s desire is obvious, flushing her skin and causing her legs to shift beneath her as she eagerly leans into Catra’s hand. She really is such a sub, her indignation otherwise is ridiculous. Sure, Catra is turned on just seeing Adora on her knees and eager to please her, but Catra has never denied that she likes being in charge. Adora may like it too, but not like this – not like their plans for today.

“Come on, let’s talk,” Catra suggest, tugging on her hair a little to encourage her to stand. Adora pouts – “*Bottom*,” Catra snickers at her – but she stands reluctantly. Catra is still chuckling to herself as she sets off for the couch. When she sits, she pats the couch cushion beside her like she is calling a dog over to hop up beside her. Adora is flushed a violent shade, but she follows and sits on the couch, right in the spot that Catra indicated.

Okay, she is *definitely* using that as an excuse to sit closer than before, but Catra can leer about her obedience and pretend she is oblivious enough to think that is the only reason, so she allows it. It is her fault for patting the couch so close to her anyway. One of the first things you have to learn as a dom is not to punish a sub for your own mistakes or unclear orders. They are only going to be on the couch while they define the rules for this session anyway. After that, the real fun starts.

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Adora is a lot braver over text than she is in person. After she pays and Catra has her repeat her safe words a few times, Catra asks her what all she wants from this. Adora mumbles that she already texted her because fuck is it *embarrassing* to say out loud. Mumbling is a show of weakness, and that turns out to be a fatal mistake. Catra's eyes light up and then her claws slide out. Adora barely has time to wonder why before Catra is leaning over her with a predatory smile.

"No, princess, you're going to have to admit it if you want to get it," Catra tells her, reaching out to trace her claws along the edge of Adora's jaw and causing her to shiver. She resists the urge to shift her legs despite how the idea of humiliation *apparently* does something for her. She only put it on her *will* list because she wasn't sure how she felt about it, but Catra had a knowing look in her eyes when she went to mark it off. Maybe everything else she put on there spoke for itself.

The problem is she doesn't really know how to verbalize this. She isn't quite sure what she is getting into, just that the vague shape of it in her mind excites her. Catra shifts above her, swinging her leg up and settling firmly over Adora's lap. She casually walks the tips of her claws back up Adora's jaw to the base of her ear and then lightly drags them down again. She is settling in to wait Adora out, she realizes.

She doesn't know how she is supposed to figure out how to ask when Catra is touching her like *this*. Adora tries her best to ignore the warmth of Catra's body radiating through her leggings, her dangerous smile that makes Adora want to kiss her more than anything else, and the thrilling touch along her jaw that, fuck her, makes her miss the sting of the riding crop against her. Catra's eyes are bright, watching her like a predatory tracking its prey's every movement.

"I, um, want the collar we talked about. Trying out the pet play kinda stuff, though I don't *actually* want to pretend to be a dog. That's too much. Just the obedience and ownership stuff, I guess," Adora manages, fixing her eyes on Catra's shoulder and staring at it with steadfast determination. There is plenty of stuff that she could admit to easily, but this one is pretty fucking embarrassing for just their second session. If it wasn't for how good giving up control in the last session felt, she wouldn't be bringing it up now.

She can see Catra's grin in her periphery. Catra's fingertips skate down her jaw once more, causing Adora to shiver again. This time Catra doesn't walk her fingers back up, instead placing them just under Adora's chin and pressing firmling, tilting her chin back in a clear instruction for Adora to look up. When her gaze locks with Catra's, she sees an almost *proud* satisfaction lighting her gaze that takes Adora's gaze away.

"Good girl. That wasn't so hard, was it?" she purrs to her. It absolutely was, but Adora just makes a somewhat strangled noise of agreement. Her chin isn't tilted back that far, but it is still slightly strained like this. She isn't flexible by any means, but she will move into any position that Catra wants her. "Anything else before we get started, princess?" Catra asks, her gaze traveling over Adora's face as if searching for signs of deception. Adora swallows.

"The riding crop. It feels good. Giving away control last time felt amazing, so just more of that stuff," she returns, shrugging a little. Catra nods, her expression thoughtful as she pulls her hand away, leaving Adora to drop her chin back down.

“Alright, princess, let’s make you a fantasy,” Catra promises her. Adora’s heart pounds as Catra slides out of her lap to walk over to the cabinet and collect her gear.

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Catra only has one collar for clients that she shares with Lonnie, but clients usually bring their own, sometimes even bravely wearing them around their neck when they walk in – much like Adora did with the ears, though they at least *know* that the accessory means people are going to clock them as a sub. The collar is simple black leather, finished on the inside as well as the outside so it is easy to disinfect and clean between sessions. Adora’s eyes dilate when they land on the collar, and she happily kneels when Catra orders her to. Catra smirks as she clips the collar’s matching leash onto it, collar still in-hand.

“Once this collar goes on, the session starts. You become my sub, my *puppy*. Look to the board if you forget your words. Are you ready?” Catra asks her, opening the collar buckle and holding it in front of her, ready to wrap it around her neck. Adora, already on her knees and turned on just from her excitement, eyes the collar eagerly and nods. Catra grins to herself, her tail sweeping back and forth behind her.

“Good girl. Bend your head forward. Show me your neck,” Catra orders. Adora complies immediately, even reaching up to brush her hair aside and get it out of the way. Catra would have preferred to order her to do it, but given that their plans involve punishment this time, she doesn’t want to strip Adora’s autonomy like before. She would rather Adora be an eager and active participant so she can be sure Adora is enjoying herself and it isn’t going too far.

The pain will probably be enough to get her to subspace on its own anyway. She certainly seemed to get there easily last week. Everybody is different, needing their own time and methods to achieve it. It is a lot like sex in that way, needing to find the right way to touch someone to get them off, and even then some people need longer than others. It seems that Adora has one way she can reach it easily, but Catra wants to see if they can find others too.

She feels her own little thrill as she bends and fastens the collar around Adora’s neck, testing notches and asking Adora for her opinion before she settles on a notch to use. Adora tries to straighten her head after Catra fastens it and she immediately places her hand on the back of Adora’s head, forcing it back down as Adora squeaks with surprise. She likes it, though. Her thighs quiver a little where she is kneeled. Adora has always been a bit of a gym rat and still has an impressive amount of muscle despite her office job. Catra has had clients who are uncomfortable after kneeling for a few moments, but that wasn’t a quiver from muscle exhaustion.

“I didn’t say you could get up yet, pup. Eyes on the ground,” Catra orders. Adora gives a tiny – but fuck is it *audible* – moan as she dutifully ducks her head again. Catra purrs in satisfaction as she switches to petting through Adora’s hair instead of holding her head in place. “Good girl. I’m going to have you do some *tricks* for me, and if you’re good, you’ll get a treat,” Catra purrs to her. It’s leaning a little harder into pet play than Adora asked for, but

she is confident Adora will enjoy it once they get started. She certainly swallows thickly at the words.

“Yes, sir. I’ll be good,” she responds, her voice low and rough. Her hair is falling like a curtain around her, leaving her only view Catra’s feet and the ground that she is being forced to stare at. Catra grins, dropping to crouch in front of Adora. Adora’s eyes dart up to meet hers instantly, though she manages to mostly keep her head in place despite it tilting back slightly. Catra reaches out, trailing her fingertips along Adora’s jaw like she did back on the couch.

Her breath hitches, but she doesn’t give a full body shiver like she did when Catra was tracing with her claws. She likes the pain – the promise of it, the thrill of waiting for it, and the lightning bolt of endorphins it brings. The contact is light and soft, something she likes but that doesn’t break her down to her base components like pain does. It is a good opener for what is about to happen. Catra makes eye contact with her, letting her grin fall to communicate that what she is about to say is serious.

“You can’t, princess. You’re going to fail, and when you do, I’m going to punish you. Only because you asked. If it gets to be too much, use your words,” Catra tells her, her voice low. Adora’s eyes go wide, her breathing becoming rough. Catra doesn’t break eye contact, her gaze intense. “Stop me if you aren’t enjoying yourself. I only like it as long as you are,” Catra adds. She doesn’t normally mention how any of this makes her feel with clients, but given Adora’s *history*, Catra doesn’t trust her to call stop if she thinks it will upset Catra.

Adora swallows, but her gaze sets with determination and she nods. Catra blows out a breath, standing and not correcting Adora as her head tilts back so her gaze can follow her. With a tug of her leash, she directs Adora to follow her to the center of the room. Time for the real play to begin.

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Catra said she was setting up an excuse to punish her and she wasn’t *kidding*. She drags Adora by the leash – which turns her on *way more* than she thought it would – and orders her into impossible positions. Maybe Catra could pull them off, but Catra seems to be having fun ordering Adora to put herself into revealing positions and bringing the riding crop down in a harsh sting against the body parts she has her *presenting*. Some of the positions are actually possible, but not to hold for a minute like Catra orders her to do.

Adora isn’t sure if this is yoga or pilates or if they’re outright sex positions that she just isn’t familiar with, but she has never been flexible. The minute of waiting is both excruciating and ecstasy, her form getting more and more wavering as the seconds tick by while she just *waits* for when it gets sloppy enough for the sting of the crop to come down harshly on her and send a bolt of jumbled pain-pleasure responses shooting through her.

Catra follows up every hit with a praise for taking the pain well and instructions for a new position so she can try again, softening the harshness of the punishment despite how Adora knows she will fail the next one too. There is an entire wall of mirrors, but despite Catra positioning her to face them, Adora isn't allowed to look and use them for guidance on how she should be holding herself to correct her position and avoid the punishment that she doesn't *really* want to avoid, she is just getting worked up into a fever and part of her always needs to be doing things right.

That internal drive keeps pushing her to glance up at the mirror. Every time she does, half of them on accident and half of them stolen glances trying to see how she is doing or if Catra is preparing to strike, the crop comes down on her again and she gasps out, her core clenching and her skin stinging. Sometimes she looks on purpose just to get the sting and feel like she is choosing it, making defiant eye contact with Catra and sighing as much as whimpering when the crop comes down on her.

The longer it goes on, the less of her glances are purposeful. She is still enjoying every second of it and she *knows* it is an act, but she just wants to get one position right, to get praise for something other than her pain. She is getting hazy, her skin flushed and burning with mixed signals. Her underwear is soaked through and her leggings are clinging to her. Catra hasn't let go of the leash despite how some positions leave the collar tugging – gently, but still very *present* – against her neck. Catra was careful not to buckle the collar too tight, but what once felt almost disappointingly loose is now tight, *restrictive*.

She likes that too, but it feels like every part of her body is sending her brain a conflicting signal. She is turned on, and yet she is in pain. She is free from having to worry about anything except Catra's orders, and yet the collar is choking her. She has plenty of air and Catra never yanks so pressure will be placed on the front of her throat – her tugs in general are soft, with slowly building pressure – but Adora feels like the pain-pleasure response is filling her to the brim and causing the collar to press too-tightly on her.

She sneaks a glance along the bottom edge of the mirror. She just wants to see herself. She wants to do this position right and get a soothing pet and praise, maybe even permission to look up and see that the collar isn't digging into her neck. Catra catches her. She doesn't scold Adora verbally – Adora couldn't take that – but the crop comes down hard against the back of her thighs, exposed by Adora lifting her legs up into the air as she lies on her back. Her legs are spread and it is hard to hold both her legs in place. This position has to be a pilates thing, because it takes a surprising amount of strength to hold.

The pain shoots through her, causing her to cry out softly as she gasps for air and her body jerks, instinctively trying to curl away from the hit. Her skin is burning. She is so turned on that she feels kind of delirious. This isn't the peaceful subspace she slipped into before. It is competing chemical responses, endorphins running like a high that makes her gasp for breath as she turns her head and blinks up at where Catra stands over her. That in itself is a disobedience. She was ordered to look at the floor right in front of the mirror.

The riding crop comes down again, just a little lower than it did before. Adora's legs folded down with the last hit and made her thighs a poor target, so the strike area moves against her ass. She moans, feeling tears spring into her eyes, though she isn't crying. Her body is just so

on edge, unsure of what is going on or what it wants, that she feels her eyes watering as she moans under her breath and pants desperately. She squints up at Catra through her swimming vision, feeling beyond words. She just knows that she needs to see her face.

“You’re doing so well. Give me your color, princess,” Catra prompts, her voice low. Adora’s skin, still stinging, now thrums with joy. Her breath hitches at the words. She doesn’t know if she moves other than to pant for breath, but she feels like her entire body is straining forwards towards the source of the praise. It is everything that she wanted. The pain is so good, but the endorphins stay while the lingering sting is soothed by the praise.

Color. Catra asked for a color. She is looking down at Adora with bright eyes, alert as she watches her. Adora can see a slight crease forming in her brow the longer Adora takes to respond. She needs to reply, she just also needs to breathe. Adora closes her eyes, taking a second to draw in breath. Catra won’t hit her while she is waiting for a color. Adora can just breathe. The assurance she gets from that thought is her answer, though.

“Pink,” she manages, still panting. Fuck, she is so hot, she feels like she is burning from the inside out. She is still turned on. None of this is a bad thing, it is just so *much.* She hears a shift, and then there is a slight thud as Catra drops down to her knees beside her. A moment later, a soft hand pets through Adora’s hair. She whimpers quietly, leaning into the touch and feeling how it instantly soothes her body that is screaming with its confusion.

“Good girl. You did really well, Adora. Do you want me to put the riding crop away now?” Catra asks. Adora is still breathless, so she just nods. The pain felt so fucking good, but her body is at its limit. She thinks she probably reached it embarrassingly quickly – she wanted to last longer than this – but it feels like an hour of this delicious torment has passed for her and she can’t really tell how long it has actually been. Her blood is pounding in her ears, but a moment later she feels a second hand in her hair.

“Do you want the collar off?” Catra asks, her voice just as soft and coaxing as before. Adora releases an instinctual noise of disagreement, shaking her head a little and then freezing from discomfort. She swallows, feeling how the leather presses against her neck as the line of her throat bobs.

“Loosen it a little,” she breathes back. Catra’s hands instantly leave her hair. Adora blinks her hazy eyes open, staring vaguely above her before she turns her head and looks out at the mirror, this time looking right in it as Catra’s hands fly to the now-exposed back of her neck to undo the buckle. Adora blinks, taking stock of her body as Catra carefully loosens the collar a notch. It tightens a bit in the process of undoing and redoing the buckle, causing Adora’s breath to hitch, but once it is fastened in place it settles loosened around her neck.

The tightness adjusted makes it feel more like how it felt when she first put it on. It is a relief as much as a disappointment. Adora takes a few slow breaths as Catra returns to petting through her hair. Fuck does that feel good. Her entire body feels shaky from the endorphins, like a really intense afterglow. She still is ridiculously turned on. She is going to fuck herself desperately when she gets home tonight. A few spots echo with the pain of the stings, but Catra is skilled with her crop, and she didn’t damage her.

Overall, she feels fucking *incredible*. She would be disappointed by the intensity easing off if it wasn't all so much she can hardly breathe. The contrast of Catra's soft hands on her makes her shudder a little as she rolls over onto her side, trying to curl closer to her. Catra purrs softly for her, causing Adora to shiver and her eyes to flutter as everything in her seeks out that soothing sound.

"Do you want to switch to aftercare now, Adora? It has been half an hour. We can stop if you need to," Catra asks, her voice still soft and gentle. Adora swallows. She wants aftercare. She wants to crawl into Catra's arms and get soft affection in return. She also is already missing the adrenaline high. Her body can't take more of the pain, but she isn't up to taking off the collar either. It is a comforting weight around her neck, especially now that it is loosened and doesn't feel like it is digging into her.

"Dunno. Felt good, just really intense. I want- I still want to be your puppy," she mumbles, her eyes still shut. She nudges her head to rest against Catra's thigh. Catra's hands keep petting over her, soothing relief replacing the sting of pain. Catra's purr is gentle and soothing as Adora buries her face in Catra's lap. She doesn't want the collar to come off. Then it is over and the peace of knowing all she has to do is follow Catra's orders goes away.

"You can still be my puppy. You can have the collar on and follow the leash. People *usually* shower their dogs in affection and praise," Catra returns, her voice still gentle, like she is trying to convince Adora to let her praise her. Actually, that is exactly what she is doing. Adora feels flushed, a small quiver of excitement shooting through her. Well, when Catra puts it like that, how can she resist?

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The scent of Adora's desire never fades. It assures her that Adora really is enjoying herself as she pets her and offers her soft praises down on the floor before she is settled enough to stand. She leads Adora by the leash across the room. Adora liked the pain – she fucking *loved* it, looking like she had been through marathon sex by the end like only a true masochist can – but it is always intense when it's more than just the occasional sting of the crop like what she experienced back at the bachelorette party.

Adora follows on her hands and knees as Catra walks back to the rack and puts away her riding crop. She loops the leash around her wrist and praises Adora as she pulls a water bottle out of the cabinet and helps Adora drink it, one hand steady on her shoulder to stabilize her as she sits back to drink in a kneeled position. Adora isn't pretending to be a dog or anything – and despite Catra domming clients like that in the past, she finds it a bit hard to take seriously – but she is a massive fucking sub and likes being on the floor for Catra as much as she likes being dragged around by her.

Catra leads her to the couch next, having Adora start on the floor with her head in Catra's lap for a few minutes as she pets through her hair, occasionally scratching at her scalp. After she seems settled like that, Catra pats the couch and Adora gladly joins her on it, cuddling into

Catra as she continues the soft affection and praises of *good girl* and *you took it so well*. A few *I had fun with you*s slip in too, which isn't something she normally says to clients, but it is true. They spend fifteen minutes on aftercare with the collar on before Catra gently prompts Adora that it has been on for long enough and Adora reluctantly offers Catra her neck to remove it.

"Good girl. I just don't want you to hurt yourself. We can stay here as long as you need," Catra assures as she drops the collar back down onto the cushion beside her. She will have to disinfect it – and the riding crop, plus cleaning the floor – after Adora leaves, but that can wait for later. It is just about time for Adora to pack up and leave, but Catra isn't going to rush her when she softly sighs and happily leans into her touch at those words.

She finds Adora's attachment to the collar a bit endearing. She lives for it, *loves* it. She is one of those people who feels freed by it rather than restricted. She should have her own if she likes it that much, but she is new to this and just hasn't had cause to buy one yet. Catra reaches up and lightly drag her fingers along the back of Adora's neck, running them through the stray baby hairs there and tracing along where the collar rested. Adora shivers a little in response.

They stay like that for awhile before Adora reluctantly pulls back and mutters that she should get going. The session was supposed to end nearly ten minutes ago and Catra suspects that she would have no desire to go if it weren't for the fact that she only paid for an hour. Catra doesn't mention it, though, just bringing Adora a water bottle to make sure she drinks before she shrugs on her jacket, collects her dog ear headband that got dislodged in the cuddling and ended up sitting on the couch cushion, and waves goodbye to Catra.

Catra's heart is beating loudly in her chest as she watches Adora go. The session was good, but she feels a bit on edge watching Adora leave. She got a little too comfortable cuddling with her afterwards. She was focused and professional during the session, but it has stirred up a lot of emotions in her chest that she usually tries to ignore. She has a lot to think about.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: "Pet play" (specifically puppy, but mostly centered around the collar play and Adora isn't acting like a dog) with masochism/punishment/riding crop use.
Yeah it's just as important for Adora to Fail and see the world didn't end as it is for her to succeed.

Work of Art

Chapter Notes

> BDSM is related to the tags already on the fic. Skip to the end for a more detailed warning. Unrelated to this chapter's BDSM scene:
> **CW**: implied/referenced past child abuse, depression, endorphin highs and crashes, and grappling with guilt.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had been dabbling in BDSM for almost a year - largely as an observer to events and then as an apprentice who helped with large parties - before she really heard the phrase *dom drop*. She met Huntara at the leather bar Lonnie was working at when Lonnie, trying to prod Catra out of her depression hole and maybe even seeing the direction things were heading with Scorpia and trying to head it off, invited Catra in for one of their recurring BDSM nights.

Huntara is a ringmaster. She is a very different kind of domme than Catra, but Catra was hooked seeing the way she commanded a room. She saw the rush happening and she wanted it – at that point in her life, she *needed* it. She started regularly attending and watching from a distance. A dom's job is to constantly be observant and attentive to the needs of their sub. Huntara noticed Catra showing up and she wasn't surprised when she approached her one evening.

Catra had done research online, but she still wanted to know more. The internet couldn't tell her if this would help her. Given everything she read about being careful, she didn't trust herself. That should have been Huntara's first clue that Catra had mental blocks around domming, but Catra wasn't exactly forthcoming with the information. It wasn't until Catra had been learning about the tricks of the trade and helping as an assistant at the parties for months until Huntara pulled her aside and asked her how she felt not just during scenes, but after.

Catra was stunned that someone else recognized the endorphin crash she struggled with. She still doesn't like to think about it – Huntara said the reason she never asked before is because expecting it makes it more likely to manifest – but she knows the signs now, and she is used to the pattern of its appearance. Whenever she does a really intense scene, especially anything involving sadism and physical punishment, she knows there is a risk of it rearing its head.

She blames it, like most things wrong with her mentally, on how she grew up. The group foster home was no stranger to punishment. Sometimes it was from a switch, sometimes it was withholding food for slights – real or imagined – and sometimes it was insidious barbs. Catra got some of the worst of it. They went through hell there until she and Adora turned

eighteen and aged out, and she hates the idea of ever making someone feel like she did back then.

Most of the time, the logical part of her brain assures her that she *isn't* doing that and her sub likes what is happening, but other times her brain can't remember anything but the pain signals pouring off her sub as a strike leaves another stinging red imprint on their skin. She doesn't see them, she sees herself quivering in fear for the next hit that no transgression a child could have committed could be bad enough to earn. People *pay* her to do this and she can tell that they like it as much as she does in the moment, but the guilt in the comedown can still be a struggle.

Sometimes she lies in bed and wonders why she is like this. Other times she fears she knows exactly why. It is all consensual, but she knows the phrase *cycle of abuse* and she is terrified of perpetuating it. She hates seeing fear in her sub's eyes and she knows that sets her apart from the bitch who hurt her, but a part of her mind – a part that sounds suspiciously like her – whispers that she is just as evil at her core.

She gets off on causing other's pain, after all. She wouldn't if they didn't enjoy it too – she already struggles with feeling like this sometimes when they *do* – but logic has no place in the emotional valley that follows such a spike in endorphins. Of course dom drop sets in after her session with Adora. Adora was ridiculously turned on for the entire session, but a part of Catra whispers *you wouldn't have stopped if she wasn't*.

She would have. She stopped even with the scent of desire filling the room, Adora twitching from the cocktail of pain and endorphins. Adora was fucking *desperate* for it, but her eyes were hazy and she is new to this, so Catra stopped and checked in. She felt her heart drop when Adora's answer was *pink*. She was so glad she said it, but she hates getting the answer of slow or stop when she had to ask for a color. It means things were building for the sub but they didn't say anything.

The reality is that sometimes things are building to such a crescendo that they can't think to voice it on their own. Those are often great sessions for the sub, but the big downside to doing this professionally is that after the session, the sub leaves. Catra doesn't get to find out how they felt in the come-down until the next time they book a session, and in that time, the doubt sets in and she fears that she went too hard, too *far*, and she hurt them not just physically like they asked, but emotionally.

She wakes up on Saturday feeling sluggish, her heart wavering in her chest. Adora asked for it, she repeats like a mantra as she hauls herself out of bed and brushes her teeth. Adora said she wanted to do it again, she reminds herself as she fixes breakfast despite not being hungry. "You have to eat," were the first words Scorpia said to her when she bumped into Catra in the hall. Scorpia doesn't know the source of Catra's depression episodes, but she can recognize them by now even when they don't make Catra go crawling into her bed.

Actually, she might end up doing that tonight. She groans to herself as she picks half-heartedly at her meal. She really shouldn't do that to Scorpia. She likes her job most days, but days like this she just struggles with it. If this was a real relationship, she would be able to stay with her sub afterwards, check in on them, and assure herself that they really are happy. If they weren't, she would be able to assure them, soothing both of them in the process.

Instead she just has to cut them loose after the best aftercare that they had time for and hope for the best.

She glares down at her mostly-full plate. Fuck her, but she knows what she is about to do. She might not be in a relationship right now, but she once was with the sub she had last night, and it means she can do things she wouldn't with a normal client. She has four bookings today. She can't be in a dark headspace for that. She would never take it out on her client – she *couldn't* – but ultimately it will make her overly-cautious. Subs don't come to her for her to stay her hand.

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Adora wakes up to her phone ringing. She is used to waking up to an alarm, but not a ringtone. She fumbles around her nightstand for her phone, taking so long she worries that the call will go to voicemail. She doesn't take the time to check caller ID, picking up the phone and murmuring a sleepy "Hello?"

On the other end of the line, there are several seconds of silence.

"It's almost noon. Were you seriously asleep? What happened to being an early riser?" Catra asks, her voice sarcastic. Adora blinks up at her bedroom ceiling in shock, pulling the phone away to squint at the screen and confirm that Catra really did just called her out of the blue.

"I went to college and stopped sleeping for the most part. I get up early for work during the week. Weekends are catchup time," Adora returns, shaking out her body a little and sitting up. She wants to be awake. Catra is talking to her. She can't say something stupid because she is groggy and has poor judgement. On the other end of the line, Catra snorts.

"I had a six AM class for my master's program all about painting with morning light. I learned that you should get up at the same time on the weekends because inconsistency just makes your sleep worse," Catra tells her. Adora blinks at her bedroom wall. It is right in front of her, so it is easy to blink in shock at it, but *Ecstasy* is also hanging there. Adora feels like she has fallen into a parallel dimension, and not just because Catra is talking to her casually and giving her sleeping advice.

"It's probably different for magicats. Partially nocturnal species could have different rules. You have a master's?" Adora asks. She is pretty sure Catra actually is right, but she doesn't give a shit about sleep. She has so many questions – about *everything*, including why Catra is calling her – and the phone call gives her hope that Catra might actually answer them. There is a moment of silence on the other end of the line. Adora bites her lip, still staring at the painting across from her. She is an idiot about art, she can admit that, but it is masterfully done. She can say that both as an observer and as the subject.

"Yeah, I do. I only graduated with it last year," Catra admits, her voice oddly hesitant. Adora's heart beats oddly heavily. She doesn't know if Catra just doesn't want to talk to her

about her personal life or if it is the subject causing her hesitance. If it's the subject, is she holding back for her own reasons or just because of what Adora told her about her experience with school? Adora is sensitive about her own failure, but it only puts her more in awe about Catra managing to complete a *master's*.

"Tell me about it? Why you chose a master's and where you went?" Adora asks. Her voice is hopeful, nearly pleading, but she wants to know. It makes her ache that there are so many years stretching between them. On the other end of the line, Catra sighs, but it isn't an annoyed huff. Adora swears it is relieved, or maybe *fond*.

"I'm in the middle of breakfast you know. I was just supposed to call to check on how you felt after yesterday," Catra responds, her voice *definitely* fond and relieved. Adora's heart skips in her chest, attempting to leap right out of her chest to go running into Catra's arms. Adora smiles to herself as she leans back and lays down again, now thoroughly awake but wanting to sink into the softness of her bed as she hums lightly to herself.

"Well I just woke up. Felt a bit sore when I was going to bed last night, but it's a good soreness. It would be made *better* if I got to listen to you talk," Adora tells her. Catra lets out a soft breath that quickly turns into a chuckle. Adora can picture her shaking her head in disbelief, though this behavior is *completely* believable on her part.

"You're such a needy sub," Catra chuckles. Adora grins a little to herself. Catra sounds relaxed and at ease compared to how she started the call. In the background, she hears an unfamiliar woman's voice and a soft, questioning trill from Catra that drops off as she pulls the phone away from her ear. Adora's heart drops. Catra wouldn't be calling if she was working with another client, and that doesn't sound like Lonnie. She also wouldn't call Adora about this if she was out, which leaves just one place for her to be – at home, with another woman.

"She's a friend," she hears Catra say, though not to her. Adora swallows. Fuck, that stings. If she had called Adora that before she knew that Catra lived with someone, it would have felt like progress in the right direction. Now it is a smarting reminder that they aren't together anymore – and that seemingly someone else has taken up that roll in Catra's life. She can hear laughing and joking happening on the other end of the line.

"One sec, my roommates don't want me talking sex at the dining table," Catra says to her, her voice light. In an instant, a crushing weight falls off Adora's shoulders. Adora doesn't get to respond before there's the scraping of a chair being pulled out and more vague voices. A moment later, she hears Catra playfully calling *prude* and then the slam of a door. Catra is chuckling when her voice returns to the receiver.

"Okay, I just didn't want her to keep sending me those looks. I don't live with actual prudes. Entrapta hasn't heard of fucking towels. She'll walk from the bathroom to her bedroom naked if the 'good towels' aren't clean. You get used to it," Catra tells her. Adora hears the slight clink of a plate and then the unmistakable sighs of Catra settling back down. "Sorry, where were we?" Catra asks. Adora swallows. Her panic has been averted. They really should get back to their previous conversation so she can actually learn what the last few years have been like.

“You were about to spill your guts about everything related to college,” Adora returns. Catra snorts, sounding amused. Catra turns the phone away, but Adora can still tell when she takes a bite. Either she’s hungry or she is delaying, but when she swallows she speaks up again.

“I got into Mystacor incredibly last minute. I was in the last set of admittances they sent out that year. It left me scrambling to find a place in the city. Lonnie introduced me to some acquaintances and I’ve been living with them ever since. They’re good friends,” Catra tells her. Adora hums, feeling her heart rest easy in her chest. It’s such a relief to know Catra has been somewhere stable in her living situation and that she got into the school she really wanted to go to.

“How was Mystacor? Everything you dreamed? You know how much I ended up hating BMU, but Bright Moon itself is great,” Adora returns. She mostly hated BMU because the pre-med program there is brutal and she was never cut out to go into medicine despite how their foster guardian and her high school counselor pushed her in that direction, but BMU had an extremely competitive and high-standard academic environment that she would have struggled in regardless of major.

“I liked it well enough,” Catra returns. Adora frowns. That isn’t exactly a glowing review. Catra is taking another bite, but when she finishes, she sighs. “One or two teachers were prejudiced against the hybrid students. Called us *handicapped* and shit. My advisor was honest with me and told me that magicats often don’t go far in careers in art. She told me that it wasn’t fair, but I likely wouldn’t get a job unless I got a master’s with a concentration in color theory to prove I could accommodate my vision,” Catra elaborates. Her tone is heavy, bitter but resigned.

She has been dealing with this for years, but it’s new information to Adora, and she is kind of *outraged*. In middle school, some of the kids at school found out about Catra’s colorblindness and started writing notes they thought she couldn’t see and holding them up to each other to gossip about her in front of her. It was multilayered, bullying her about her vision and something else that she knew was bad but wasn’t supposed to be able to read all at the same time.

The only good thing about the situation was that Catra is red colorblind, like all magicats. The kids just looked up colorblindness and found the most common type in most species, red-green colorblind. They used colored paper and markers that Catra could still very much see, and when she turned to one of the kids and parried his scrawled insult with a comeback, Adora got to watch the look on his face when he realized she could still see it.

Part of Catra’s determination to be an artist came from their art classes going all the way back to elementary school, where some kids would make fun of her coloring for looking bizarre. She stopped using color for a long time, drawing in monochromes or just with different shades of the colors she can see. When their foster guardian caught her drawing, secretly practicing, she mocked her for it. She didn’t think it was a worthwhile career, but she also said Catra could never succeed in it being *what she is*.

Catra thrives off spite. Adora is fairly certain that exact moment was what made her determined to be an artist. She sketched everywhere she could, hid pages or ripped them up and threw them away before they were found and mocked. Adora always felt so privileged to

be the only person Catra showed her drawings to before she destroyed them, but what she really wanted to do was paint. To her, there was no running from color while painting. Succeeding at painting would prove that she really could do it despite her "handicap."

Adora realizes she has been silent for a long time, just glaring up at her ceiling with her jaw clenched and a righteous anger beating through her chest. She blows out a slow breath. Catra gives the smallest snort of amusement around her mouthful. She started eating while she waited Adora. She knows her, and she knows how Adora gets angry on her behalf a lot. She was hoping she wouldn't have to do that anymore once they aged out of the home.

In general, society is accepting of all races but not always the best at accommodating any specialized needs. Humans and elves have pretty much identical needs and are the majority in most places. It leaves more unique and specialized races out in the cold. Magicats don't even have the worst of it, that honor probably falls to lizardfolk, but the microaggressions – or outright bullying, like what happened at their school – add up.

"Breathe, Adora. I got my master's. I showed them. Unfortunately, my advisor was right. Companies that serve the general public are reluctant to hire colorblind hybrids, but I didn't really want to go corporate anyway. I just haven't had any break-through moment that lets me make real money off selling my paintings yet. I still get to make them, and I like my day job. I'll get there one day," Catra tells her. Adora wishes she could have that kind of confidence, but she sighs and nods.

"The painting you gave me really is amazing. That kind of work *deserves* to be known. But I know it takes the right things lining up," Adora tells her. Even without prejudice, there is a fair bit of luck involved in making it in this kind of career. Catra purrs, the sound distorted by the call but still distinct. It makes Adora yearn, just like it did every time she heard it over the phone back when they were long distance.

"I'm working on another one of you. Less, hm, *obvious*, but I think you'll like it. Now we're talking, I was going to get you to approve it before I showed it to others, though my roommates have seen it already. I paint in our laundry room to keep the fumes from filling up my bedroom, so they can see anything I'm working on," Catra tells her. Adora can't deny that the words make her heart leap in her chest. Her anger isn't forgotten, but it certainly distracts her.

"Can I come over to see it?" she asks, a bit too eager. She knows she is pushing her luck, but she has been doing it all morning and Catra has been letting her. Catra snorts, seeming amused by her pushiness. It's a dismissive sound, but at least she isn't hanging up on her.

"I know what you're doing. No. I'll text you a picture after breakfast. Which I do need to finish, by the way, I have appointments starting at one," Catra tells her. Adora wilts a little, but she knew she was pushing it. She knows more, at least, and Catra opened up a little. Adora bites her lip, weighing the ramifications of being desperate with those of letting Catra go without another meeting set up.

"Do you have space left next weekend? I feel, well, sore as hell, but really good. I want to do something like that again," Adora asks, fidgeting with her comforter a bit. On the other end of the line, Catra purrs. Adora doesn't mean to hum to answer her, but her eyes drift closed

and she does it instinctively. She used to do this when they were long distance to feel closer to Catra.

“Like I said, needy sub,” Catra snickers to her, but she doesn’t say *no*. Adora blushes, huffing a little as she hears shifting on the other end of the line.

“Well, how often do people *normally* book? Things will have to start being more infrequent next month, but that really felt incredible. I’ve never felt so *intensely* like that,” Adora tells her. Catra doesn’t respond, just purring for several long seconds. Adora can hear the light tapping of her claws on the phone screen.

“Next weekend has a lot less going on because of Halloween parties. I’m pretty much open,” Catra tells her. Adora notices she hasn’t answered her question about how often she is supposed to book, but maybe that’s a good thing? If people don’t usually book so frequently, maybe she doesn’t want Adora to feel like she has to slow down. That would be a great sign if it were true. It could definitely be projection on her part.

“Saturday evening, then? I want to hand out candy on Halloween,” Adora tells her. For the past several years, Glimmer and Bow have dragged her to Perfuma’s Halloween party, but they are out-of-town and she can finally get away with a quiet evening at home. Catra chuckles on the other end of the line.

“I’ll block off six for you. Are you coming dressed up again?” Catra teases, her voice sparkling with amusement. Adora feels herself make a deep, content sigh just hearing it. Catra is clearly wrapping up the call, but she is unguarded as she does so.

“No, I don’t think so. I want to do something new. There’s so much I’ve always wanted to try. I haven’t really thought about it yet. I’ll text you when I come up with something,” Adora returns. Catra hums an acknowledgement as she continues tapping at her screen.

“Alright, I sent you a booking confirmation. I need to finish breakfast. Make sure to drink water, stretch, and go light at the gym. Are you sure you’re feeling alright?” Catra asks. Adora smiles at her ceiling, the concern warming her chest like a candle lighting up in her ribcage.

“I feel fantastic,” She returns, honest and earnest, so subby it validates every time Catra snickered at her down the line, but Catra doesn’t laugh this time. She just lets out a soft breath and begins to purr.

“Good girl. Take care of yourself today,” Catra tells her. Adora shivers a little in her bed, caught off-guard but *loving* it.

“I will,” she breathes back. She almost finishes it with *sir*, but despite Catra using the praise outside of a session, she is pretty sure her using the title would make it a little too real. Catra is purring. Adora doesn’t want to ruin the moment by pushing too hard.

Catra doesn’t stop purring as they say goodbye. The call ends and Adora settles back into her bed with a happy sigh. She is definitely sore, but it is the good kind of deep muscle soreness that comes after a good workout. She went to bed with a deep sense of contentment from the

earlier buzz of the day – alright, and an afterglow she was soaking in after a desperate session with her hand when she got home – and now she has woken up to the sound of Catra's voice.

It's a good day. With another session lined up for next Saturday, she dares say it is going to be a good *week*.

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"What are you going to be?" Scorpia asks, a bright smile on her face but the question a bit probing – probably because Catra has on a fantastic expression of disinterest on her face as her roommates try on Halloween costumes. Apparently one of Entrapta's friends invited her to a Halloween party a week ago, but Scorpia conveniently forgot to tell Catra that the invitation had been extended to them too until today. It is highly suspicious that Scorpia suddenly remembered on the day where Catra was having an obvious depression spike.

She was hanging around just to make sure Catra actually ate her food when she called Adora. Catra fled to her room mostly for privacy for them both after Scorpia made a *face* upon realizing Catra was calling one of her subs. When she explained that she was calling a friend who had booked with her, Scorpia's expression got even worse. Catra wasn't about to justify herself to Scorpia, so she fled to her room until she had to leave for her first session.

She feels infinitely better after the assurance of the call with Adora. She feels kind of bad for not being totally honest with Adora when Adora promised to be honest with her, but she also didn't lie. She hasn't told anyone about how she struggles with dom drop, and while Adora hasn't said shit about Catra's day job yet, Catra doesn't need her trying to *save her* or something. Catra likes domming. She would prefer to do it in a relationship than professionally if only because then she could get the assurance that she pathetically needs, but she isn't in one and it pays well. She built something for herself here, and with Adora's assurance, she has a good Saturday.

She headed to work with her shoulders feeling lighter, the terrible voice in the back of her head quieted. She was able to do her sessions without too much trouble, though they were still draining. Scorpia seemed to take her exhaustion for continued depression when she got back – privately, Catra thinks that is *projection*, because Scorpia has never been able to handle that Catra doesn't want to go to her for her emotional needs, so of course she doesn't want to imagine a short phone call with someone else lifted Catra's spirits – and she dragged Catra into helping her and Entrapta build their outfits for the Halloween party.

Catra does like spending time with her roommates, but she is tired and uninterested in the holiday in general, so she has mostly been lounging on Scorpia's bed and watching her and Entrapta flutter about to go digging in closets for that last piece that will tie their looks together. So far, Entrapta has added two "last pieces" and Scorpia is up to five. Catra is convinced they will never be finished, but it is amusing to watch at least. Scorpia is laden with every cutesy thing she owns but doesn't have a reason to wear on the typical day, not trying to emulate any character but rather just have fun.

Catra is just in her pajamas and has no intention of changing after spending all day in ripped black jeans and a leather top. She is comfortable, she is tired, and she doesn't care about finding a costume anyway. She is only going to the party next weekend because both her friends are and she doesn't want to sit alone at home with the lights off, ignoring the doorbell being rung by precocious trick-or-treaters who won't be deterred.

"What, is dom too risque? I was just going to wear my leather," Catra returns dryly. She likes parties, but not human ones. Unless there are a decent number of other hybrids present or the host is particularly accommodating, Catra can pretty much guarantee the music is going to hurt her ears. From the "come along and invite your friends too" attitude the host seems to have, Catra assumes this is going to be a rager.

"No, but Halloween is about being something you usually aren't!" Entrapta insists. She is currently trying to fashion together a costume from a dress, shirt, leggings, and a wrap skirt that Catra isn't convinced isn't meant to be an apron. Catra doesn't know where half the shit came from, and the stuff she does recognize is mostly Scorpia's. Entrapta has a rule about making her own costumes from what she can find lying around the house. Honestly, the artificial challenge Entrapta has created seems like funnest part of the holiday to Catra.

Halloween wasn't a part of her childhood. She was never a big fan of the concept – candy and magicats don't really mix - and the holiday was all but banned at the group home due to its expense and indulgence. Catra does kind of like dressing up, but not in costumes. She likes opportunities to put on suits and clean up. She likes putting on something that makes people drop their jaws when they see her and curse when they realize she is unattainable. She likes an ego stroke, alright, and that's not what Halloween is about.

She isn't sure what Entrapta's costume is. Some kind of galactic empress fighting a rebellion is all she gathered from Entrapta's passionate speech. Catra tends to tune out when Entrapta starts talking about sci-fi. Catra doesn't know the character, so she can't say how accurate the costume is, but apparently Entrapta is going to put her hair in dozens of braids for the actual party – *like jellyfish tentacles!* she proudly proclaimed – so maybe it will start looking more futuristic then.

"They don't need to know that. If costumes weren't mandatory, I wouldn't wear one at all," Catra returns. Entrapta and Scorpia both pout at her. Catra blinks back. No. She isn't caving to this. She always broke for Adora's puppy eyes, but she has matured over the years and her two friends aren't nearly as good at it as Adora was. They aren't going to melt her ice heart. Scorpia looks absolutely ridiculous pouting in her gothic Lolita look, and Entrapta has an edge of a shaming look in her eyes.

Catra cracks like a goddamn egg. She heaves a huge sigh and pushes off the couch with a sigh. Scorpia and Entrapta both cheer in victory and high-five. It sounds like a fucking gunshot with how hard Entrapta slaps the side of Scorpia's pincer, but Catra is kind of used to the sound by now. Scorpia knows her strength – as long as she is sober, at least – but Entrapta is deceptively ripped from hauling around computer parts and she pulls no punches.

"I don't own a costume and I'm not going to buy one," Catra points out as she leads her friends into her room and opens her closet. Entrapta scoffs, shooting Catra an almost pitying look. She seems offended by the very notion of buying a costume despite how Catra is pretty

sure that is what most people do. Scorpia bought her Lolita look at a thrift store over the summer, she just hasn't had the courage to wear it casually in her daily life thus far. She is using Halloween as an excuse to pull it out of the closet.

"Please, you have plenty of pieces to put together something here. Especially if we pool our closets together!" Entrapta tells her. Catra glances between her, dressed half in clothes and half in random arrangements of fabric, and Scorpia, with her layers of black and purple frills and bows.

"Scorpia is like two feet taller than me, everything you own smells of oil or burning, and I'm not wearing household items. Your limit is this closet," Catra tells her. Entrapta pouts, but she seems determined. She pounds one of her fists against her other hand, palm open, as she turns to the closet, much like a judge calling court to order with a gavel.

"*I can do this*," she responds.

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Adora does have a great week. She texts Catra on Tuesday after staring at the painting on her wall with flushed cheeks. She likes it for a lot of reasons, but it reminds her of the conversation they had on Saturday about Catra still wanting to pursue art but being unable to make money in it as a career. She would really like to just go over to Catra's place and see her paintings, gushing to her about them just like she used to, but Catra already shot that down.

Scrolling through the PDF Catra sent over to her of the kink contract she approved, though, her eyes stuck on one point. There are ways to be artistic even within BDSM, and wax play even allows Adora to get to experience that pain high again she had last week. She loved the feeling, but she thinks the punishment aspect of it made it more overwhelming. This won't be due to failures – her body will be the canvas, and the paint is just a side effect of the medium.

Catra seems excited by the proposition. She replies right away this time, texting back *that's one of my favorites* before a booking confirmation email comes through. It makes Adora even more excited to try it. She shows up to Catra's studio on Saturday bouncing on her heels. Catra raises a brow at her eagerness, but she smiles a little as she lets Adora into the studio. Adora takes it as a good sign.

Catra is relaxed, smiling with her eyes and twitching or outright lashing her tail with anticipation as she talks Adora through the general procedure and gets things set up. Apparently there is a decent amount of prep work, which Adora definitely should have anticipated, but she was too caught up in how hot the idea made her feel to think about the logistics. There have always been some folding benches propped up in the corner, but today Catra takes one down and reveals it to be a fold-out massage table as she talks her through it.

“That one’s a sex bench and the other one is a frame, but this is useful both for punishments and for fun,” Catra tells her with a bit of leer as she pats the massage table before returning to the corner to fetch a fold-out tray. On it she places her candles, lighter, and a piece of cardboard. She also places a small jar candle on the table that Adora can’t imagine is skin safe. There is a cup of water too, though Adora doesn’t know if that is for drinking, soothing burns, or putting out potential fires.

Catra eyes the set up for a long moment before walking over to the cabinet. For a second, Adora’s heartrate picks up, expecting her to select something from the rack despite how Adora doesn’t know how well something like a riding crop pairs with burning wax, but instead she just gestures to the couch with one hand as she bends down to rummage through the cabinet.

“The jacket has to go, but you can take off your shirt or your pants depending on where you want me to work. If you haven’t shaved your legs, I recommend the shirt. Lonnie says removing the wax tugs on body hair like a milder version of taking off a band-aid,” Catra tells her. Adora rolls her eyes as she heads to the couch and shrugs off her old letterman jacket that she has been dragging around ever since she found it in a thrift store during high school. After wearing it for so long, the jacket has almost become comforting to her. She wanted to have something comfortable to cover up with for this session.

Catra warned her via text that wax play would involve some level of undressing at this time of year unless she was willing to brave the chill in shorts. Adora texted back *I don’t mind* and waited for several anxious seconds before Catra just responded with the candle emoji. Apparently Catra does this with strangers, so part of Adora insisted that it would be fine with her while the rest of her was worried about crossing a line, especially after it seemed like Catra was starting to open up to her. She didn’t want her to close off again.

“You know I don’t shave,” Adora scoffs as she carefully folds her jacket and then tugs her shirt off over her head. She hears Catra chuckle as she straightens from the cabinet. Adora lowers her shirt to find Catra completely unsubtly eyeing her. Adora is still covered by her bra, but she feels herself flush under Catra’s gaze. She wasn’t expecting that. Does she do things like this with all her clients? Fuck, Adora hopes not.

“If you end up liking this, you’ll want to. It’s really good on inner thighs. Subs usually get *loud*,” Catra tells her. The statement sends a small shiver down Adora’s back, her heartrate picking up in chest at the very idea. As good as the sounds, she is a bit distracted by how Catra is obviously ogling her. Adora’s cheeks feel hot as she awkwardly shifts a little where she stands. Alright, consider her interested.

“You know, you can take your bra off too. Sometimes I let clients do that. Wax on the tits is almost as good as the thighs. Better for some,” Catra adds on, grinning when Adora goes red up to her ears. Catra just shrugs casually, turning away to walk back to the massage table and leaving Adora by the couch to contemplate *that*. It isn’t like Catra hasn’t seen her naked. Even before they got together, they shared a bunk bed at the foster home. They have never been shy about each other’s bodies.

Catra is very pointedly busy in the center of the room. She got a rag and a bottle – lotion or something – from the cabinet and now she is rearranging her space so everything is to her

liking. Adora isn't fooled by her act of disinterest. Her ears are twitched back, listening to Adora by the couch. She is waiting to see what she does. Adora turns back to the couch, reaching into her pocket to pull out and silence her phone to buy her time. She doesn't really know why she is delaying. She isn't anxious about being topless in front of Catra.

She is acutely aware of how exposed she is about to be under a candle flame, though. She places her phone on top of her clothes and then reaches for her bra's band. She sneaks a glance over her shoulder as she pulls her sports bra off over her head. Catra has one ear straining back towards Adora and her tail lashing behind her. Adora's doubt vanishes.

It's going to be new, and maybe painful, but it will also be fun.

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"We're not going to be acting for this one, princess. Honest communication. Tell me when it's too much. You should be using your words frequently unless you turn out to be a crazy pain freak or something. Just say 'pink' and I'll pull the candle away until you say blue," Catra tells Adora as she directs her to lay down. Adora is completely topless and blushing as she stretches out on the table.

Catra would have been happy doing this with the bra on or off, but off gives her more room to work with and some exciting possibilities, so she is glad Adora agreed to it. Plus, she gets to look at Adora's tits for an hour. She will probably wait awhile before really putting wax on them, both so Adora can adjust and so she can enjoy the view. Catra had to return to the cabinet to get Adora a pillow, but now they are ready. This is fun with any sub, but Catra is thrumming with excitement as she picks up the lotion and waves the bottle at Adora.

"This is optional. It helps keep the wax and heat from drying your skin out too much. I can put it on you and make sure it's everywhere I'm going to get wax, but if you aren't comfortable with that you can do it yourself, or we can skip it entirely," Catra tells her. Yes, she is asking to feel Adora up, but for good reason. She has done this with other regular clients that she was comfortable with before. It's probably one of the most explicit things she does since it involves touching a semi-naked person, even if she doesn't touch the average client anywhere important.

If she doesn't want to interact with a client like that, she orders them to do it for themselves. It is easy to make it part of the dom act, but she isn't interested in acting at all today. No, today she just *is* in charge of Adora, taking her pain and her pleasure into her hands as she guides her through an experience that she knows Adora is going to love. She is already flushing with interest – and embarrassment, but her scent is unmistakable – just watching Catra set up.

"That's, um, okay with me," Adora manages, stammering a little, but Catra doesn't comment on it. She purrs a little to herself as she starts at the middle of Adora's torso, massaging the lotion over her skin and heading down to get her stomach and hips before she works back up

to her chest. As she rubs the lotion in, she inclines her head to her table to point out the things on it so she can explain the process.

“Don’t let the water make you nervous. I’ve never burned anyone but myself from holding a candle stub too long. I prefer to be cautious though, and the water is filtered if you need a drink. Sometimes people find they are too sensitive to enjoy wax play, especially in certain areas or if they have an injury, so placing a rag soaked with cool water over the area helps soothe it if that happens,” Catra explains. It’s the kind of thing she would say to a regular client, a moment of professionalism in the middle of what is likely going to be her least professional session ever.

Adora is flushed, nodding quickly as Catra reaches her chest and rubs the lotion in. She smiles to herself, not even trying to hold her tail still as she watches Adora’s breathing become uneven and her body strain to hold still as Catra touches her. Fuck, she has missed the hell out of Adora quivering for her touch. Every part of her wants to pounce, pinching and licking and biting until Adora is shaking beneath her and keening. However, if she does the wax right, she will get Adora like that without ever having to cross the gap between them to properly touch her. Catra is careful to be thorough in her lotioning. The massage feels nice and getting the blood flowing will make the first hits of wax less of a shock. Adora squirms – barely, clearly trying not to react and make it weird – beneath her hands, her body straining for more.

“I use the cardboard to drip the wax on when you need to breathe. Keeps things from getting too messy. You say pink and I’ll jerk the candle over to it instead so you can take as long as you need to recover. The jar candle is here so I can frequently blow out and relight the wax play candles on it without needing a hand for the lighter,” Catra explains as she sets to massaging lotion into Adora’s arms. She doesn’t actually plan to get wax there on purpose, but it might splash, and it gives her an excuse to feel up Adora’s biceps.

She has definitely been spending time at the gym. She has more definition now than ever before, abdominal muscles visible when she clenches her core. Catra remembers how excited she was by BMU’s student gyms. From the size of her deltoids, she has clearly found a new one to go to since she dropped out. Catra has always liked Adora’s body, but she could spend all evening feeling up her new tone. She would be disappointed to pull away if she weren’t so excited for what comes next.

“Do you have any questions, princess, or are you ready to get started?” she asks, grinning down at Adora. She is more than ready to get started, but she has had clients be excited and still nervous about getting burned. It won’t happen, not with the unscented paraffin candles she uses, but that doesn’t mean it won’t hurt, and sometimes the brain has trouble making peace with the idea of *painful molten wax* and *safe*. Adora’s cheeks are flushed as she glances at the end table.

“Why do you have so many candles? Are you going to go through them all?” she asks. Either she just wants to know, or she is delaying. Catra shakes her head, reaching out and selecting a deep blue one that is vivid against the skin.

“No, I won’t. Half of these are already used, see? I need the different colors to turn your skin into art, princess,” Catra tells her, holding up the candle so Adora can see the burnt fuse and

partially-melted end. Adora's flush deepens as she looks at the candle for a long moment before her gaze refocuses on Catra behind it. Catra feels her own cheeks heat at the intensity in Adora's gaze as she looks at her.

"Okay, I'm ready," Adora tells her, dropping her head back against the pillow. They are the words Catra has been waiting for. She reaches for her lighter with a grin.

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The anticipation before the first wax drip is the longest Adora has ever felt in her life, unsure how bad it will be. What if she doesn't like it at all? Adora trusts Catra, but her mention of some people being too sensitive for it has Adora nervous. Catra is obviously excited to do this and Adora doesn't want to let her down by not being able to take it. The first drop falls, stinging heat not dissimilar to the strike of the crop, and Adora instinctively jerks a little, a hiss escaping between her teeth. Instantly, Catra is moving the candle away to hover over the TV tray. She blows it out as she watches Adora's reaction intently.

"There you go, princess. Lift your head and take a look. The wax has already cooled," Catra promises her, reaching out to place a hand on her arm and squeeze gently. Adora flushes, but she lifts her head and finds that the drop near the middle of her stomach has in fact cooled, a flattened round splash of indigo wax a bit smaller than a dime clinging to her skin. A bit fascinated, she reaches up and touches it, feeling the smoothness of the wax, no warmer than her own skin now.

Catra dripped it from high above Adora, and apparently the molten candle cooled a lot on the way down. It hurt, but she is satisfied now it won't damage her. Adora drops her head back against the pillow, feeling heat flush through her body. Now she has felt it – and felt that it is similar to something she knows she likes – she can already feel her body gearing up for more. She gives a jerky nod to Catra.

"You can do it again. It's not bad," she tells her. A smile quirks at the edge of Catra's mouth as she dips the candle down to the tea light, relighting it and bringing it to hover over Adora's torso again.

"By the time I'm done, you'll be begging for me to keep going until my candles are stubs," Catra tells her. Adora flushes, but before she can think of a reply, the still-warmed candle drips down onto her again. Adora hisses again, jerking beneath the sting. Fuck, it feels *good*. It hurts, but it sends a jolt of adrenaline through her entire body that makes her feel alive on the table. She opens her mouth and barely gets to suck in a breath before another drop falls. Adora's eyes flutter, and when she opens them again, Catra is blowing out the candle again.

"You're doing well, princess. It can't burn you, not with its melting point. Just enjoy the pain," Catra assures her. Adora resigns herself to uneven breathing for the rest of the session. There is no way she is getting it back under control. Fuck, she didn't think about how good the praise would be when elevated by pain. Catra did praise her for taking the punishments

well last time, but it wasn't the same as this attentive care as Catra relights the candle and holds it over Adora again.

"I'm not going to stop this time until you tell me to. Don't forget your words. Just say pink when it's building too high," Catra tells her, making eye contact with Adora. Her expression is serious and she holds it even as another drop falls and Adora's body gives a small jolt at the white-hot point on her skin. That one was on her ribs, which apparently are more sensitive to-

Fuck. Another, in the same spot or near to it. Adora doesn't know how it is so intense, so fast. All her muscles feel jerky. She spasms a little as another drop falls a little further down her ribs this time. Adora gasps out. That spot feels *good*. It still hurts, but fuck, there is something special about how it hits right here.

"There feels- *fuck*," Adora cuts off in a curse that turns into a bit of a whine when another drop falls. She swears they're getting faster. When she manages to open her eyes and find Catra's face again, she is grinning. Fuck, she looks so predatory and pleased.

"Finish your sentence, princess. More there, or less?" she asks, shifting the candle to hold it over the middle of Adora's stomach again. Adora whines, closing her eyes. Words feel hard when her breath won't come evenly, another drop falling and sending a bolt of *something*, adrenaline or endorphins or just pure desire, through her body. It almost feels like the moment before orgasm, making her body tremble.

"More there," Adora manages to whine out, screwing up her eyes as Catra quickly moves and another drop falls from the movement, hitting her side. Fuck, it's so much. How can it feel like this much after only a few seconds? How is she supposed to last an hour underneath this kind of onslaught? Another drop falls, hitting that area that feels so good and makes her whine, shifting her thighs on the table. She managed not to jerk her entire body this time at least.

"Good girl. You take the pain so well," Catra praises. Her voice is fucking genuine and Adora swears she almost sobs as another drop hits her. She feels like her entire body is on fucking *fire*, like the next drop will set her alight and burn her down completely. "Your word, Adora. You don't need to show me how much-" Catra cuts off – or maybe keeps talking and it just isn't audible over Adora's keen – when another drop hits Adora and she strains up, her hands fisting at her sides.

"*Pink*," she gasps out. It feels so fucking good, but it is so intense. She needs *air*. Instantly, she is met with purring loud enough to be heard over her gasping. For a moment, she just breathes. Then she feels Catra's soft hand petting soothingly down her arm, stroking along her in a slow, repetitive motion.

"Good girl. You did *so well*," Catra praises, her tone glowing. She sounds proud. It's enough to have Adora whining as she catches her breath. Her entire body still feels twitchy, heat flushing her, but the crescendo that was building softens gradually, the edge taken off as she draws in a few deep breaths, still not ready to open her eyes.

“Good girl. Just like that. We have all evening, we don’t have to do so much at once. I want you to *last* for me, princess,” Catra tells her, still gently petting her arm. Adora shivers, her eyes fluttering open to find Catra grinning down at her. It’s unmistakably horny, but she looks as excited as she does predatory. She really does love making Adora shake from the intensity of the sensations assaulting her. Adora swallows, her mouth suddenly very dry.

“You’d better not set anything on fire, because I’m going to drink that entire water by the time we’re done,” Adora tells her. Catra’s grin only grows wider as she sets down the candle on the cardboard and reaches for the glass instead without Adora even having to ask for it directly.

“*Good*,” she returns.

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Adora comes ten minutes in. She doesn’t tell Catra, but it is kind of obvious. Sometimes Adora is able to take the wax drops without much movement or sound, and sometimes she is whining and moaning as Catra praises her and tells her how well she is doing. After the initial test of her limits, Catra starts pulling the candle aside on her own again. Adora clearly likes to go a little further at once than Catra is inclined to, but her caution is mostly so Adora doesn’t get to a state where she is so worked up she can’t say her words.

Adora likes that state and Catra doesn’t blame her – it must feel incredible to be so lost in endorphins you lose the ability to think about talking – but Catra never likes taking risks with such a state. She always wants her sub to be able to say their safe words. Adora’s excitement to explore so much of BDSM right out the gate is understandable – she has clearly been fantasizing about it for years and wants to experience it now she has the chance – but she is skipping some of the smaller steps that help teach her how important her safe words are.

She does use them, though. She gets better at calling them as she writhes and gasps – and eventually moans and comes. Catra sets the candle down quickly, petting down her arms as Adora gasps, her eyes screwed up and tears of exertion gathered at the corners of her lashes. Slight whines tinge every breath, her body reeking of hormones and desire and *need*.

“Good girl. There you go. Just enjoy it. We can go again when you’re ready. You’ve done so well for me. You’re going to be a work of art at the end of this,” Catra assures her, sliding her hands down Adora’s arms and taking her hand in her own to drop a soothing kiss to the back of it. Adora is fucking gorgeous beneath her already, slick with sweat and covered in drops of blue in two different shades. Catra is going back to her roots and working mostly in blue monochrome today, but she *learned* at art school and she has some pinks, purples, and reds to throw in as small splashes of colour to make the final product richer.

Adora’s chest heaves as she gasps for breath and cautiously cracks her eye open, peering up at Catra with blazing cheeks. That is the first time she has come in a session, but Catra bets she can get two more out of her before they are done. The thought stokes the fire burning

between her own thighs. She is ridiculously turned on having Adora half-naked, turned on, and writhing for her. Catra smiles softly at her, raising the glass of water with one hand and holding Adora's with the other.

"Take a drink for me, princess. I don't want you to burn out. I'm having too much fun playing with you," Catra instructs her. Adora shivers, her eyes fluttering as lust darkens them, but she dutifully strains up to take a drink without curling her torso and cracking the wax on it that Catra is so carefully covering her in. Catra already chided her for it twice – gently, because a soft hand is required with so many conflicting pain signals going.

Adora drinks greedily before her muscles give out and she collapses back against the table. Catra squeezes her hand as she puts the glass back down and then reaches up to brush Adora's flyaway hairs out of her face and stroke her cheek. Her ponytail has gotten messy, pulled out a little from shaking her head when the pain hits. Adora whimpers softly, a sound both desperate and grateful as she turns her face into the touch eagerly.

"You're such a good sub for me. You're doing so well," Catra praises again. Adora, like she has every time Catra has spoken, shivers on the table. She lives for the praise as much as the pain. Coming down from an orgasm like that takes some time. Catra is happy to praise her until she is ready.

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Adora has no clue how many times she comes. It is honestly hard to tell with the intensity that overtakes her at times. It's probably twice – but maybe three or six times. Maybe. All she knows is that after an eternity, Catra blows out not only her pillar candle, but her jar one as well. She tells Adora to hold still on the table as she leaves to get her more water. Adora whines at the idea of Catra leaving, so she stays, a small smile on her face as she murmurs assurances to Adora until she has come out of it enough that she doesn't protest when Catra asks if she can slip down the hall to get her more water.

Adora *really* needs water. The first glass wasn't nearly enough. She drinks the second one Catra brings her greedily despite how she has to sit up carefully to not ruin the wax. After she has drained the glass, she lays back again so Catra can take photos of her torso. She assures Adora that she won't get her face in the shots and that the photos are just for the two of them. Adora wasn't worried in the first place. As Catra takes the pictures, Adora lets her eyes drift closed and breathes slowly after the intense assault of the session. It was maybe the best thing she has ever experienced.

"The riding crop is good, but I liked that better than last time. That was fucking *incredible*," Adora gushes to Catra, still a bit breathless, as Catra slowly peels the wax off of her. It comes off easily, though Adora can feel it tugging on her baby hairs. Catra is especially careful with removing it from her chest – it took Catra a bit to start putting wax there, but once she did, Adora nearly came on the spot. Adora puts her care down to it probably being painful to

remove recklessly until Catra holds up a large chunk that amounts to a wax cast of her nipple and asks if she wants it.

“What, do you want to put one of each on a friendship necklace?” Adora jokes as she reaches out and takes it, her cheeks blazing. She absolutely does want to keep it, and call her weird, but she does kind of want Catra to keep the other one. It is just because it would mean something for their relationship and its progress towards repairing. Catra rolls her eyes, but she is grinning as she sets to finding small leftover bits of wax clinging to Adora and pulling them off.

“Sometimes people like to keep the casts as mementos,” Catra returns with a shrug. She straightens and steps back, apparently satisfied with Adora’s lack of wax. She definitely still has a few small flecks here and there, but they will come off when she showers tonight. She needs it after sweating like that. Catra holds her hands out to her. Adora takes them eagerly, a little desperate for the contact. Catra squeezes her hands as she guides her to hop down from the table and towards the couch again.

Adora finally realizes she is topless when she spots her clothes folded on the seat. She was so lost in the endorphins and adrenaline that it was the furthest thing from her mind. As she came back to herself – even as Catra peeled the cooled wax from her – she didn’t really think about it. Catra guides her to the cushion beside her clothes. Adora is reluctant to let her hand go, but she does need to get dressed again. Catra stands beside the couch as Adora pulls on her bra and then her shirt.

Her phone, tucked into her jacket and on silent mode, has multiple missed calls from Glimmer, but from the whining texts interspersed, it definitely isn’t anything urgent and more likely that some honeymoon activity got canceled and she is trying to pester Adora because she is bored. Adora has no qualms about ignoring her friend when Catra climbs into her lap for their post-session cuddles. Adora tucks her phone into her pocket and wraps her arms around Catra.

Catra begins purring. Adora sighs happily, tucking her face into Catra’s neck. Her fur is soft against her face, a stark contrast to the stinging heat of the wax. The vibrations are strong, soft comfort surrounding her as she nuzzles in against Catra. She has missed moments like this terribly. Catra is in her lap, the relief of the contact made all the more intense by the hormones still thrumming through her from the session. Catra wraps one arm around Adora’s shoulders, lightly stroking the back of her head with her other hand.

“You did so well for me. You took the pain so well, and the wax turned out beautiful,” Catra assures her, tucking Adora under her chin. Adora shivers a little at the compliment, happily rubbing her face against Catra’s neck. She wonders if she can nudge up and get away with rubbing against Catra’s cheek and getting her scent on her. She misses that. She misses walking around knowing Catra has marked Adora as hers. She misses *being* Catra’s. All she can think about is how much she loves holding her again.

“Can you send me the photos?” she asks, a mumble into Catra’s neck. She wants them. It will be nice to have the photo and wax casting as proof that this happened – and more importantly, could happen again. She also wants to get a good look at what Catra did. Catra

praised her for how well she was taking it and how beautiful she looked a *lot*, only contributing to the high Adora had going on by the end.

"I'll sort through them when I get home tonight and send you the ones that didn't turn out blurry. Just relax for now princess. You've earned it," Catra promises her. Adora hums softly. The implication is there that Catra isn't moving to pull out her phone. It's time for aftercare, after all, and there is nothing that makes Adora feel better after a session than holding Catra. She happily quiets down, just soaking in the comfort of Catra in her lap, her tail sweeping with slow content where it is draped past their knees.

It is a great way to end the week.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: Waxplay/masochism & praise kink.
Scorpia's Halloween costume is the Lolita dress she tried on for Princess Prom.
An art of Catra's leather romper has been added to the end note on chapter 1! It's exquisite. I highly recommend checking it out. A link to a fanart of her painting has been added to the end note of chapter 2 as well.

Halloween

Chapter Notes

> No kink warnings. My outline is very loose and breezy for this one, but this chapter is like 1/4th of the way through it, so make of that what you will. I'm hoping to keep this no longer than 20 chapters XD That said, maybe it will be as few as like 14! (Probably not)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"*Adora Eleanor Grayskull*," is Glimmer's greeting when Adora finally calls her back the next morning. Adora texted her that she was not dead, just busy, and that she would call her in the morning when she went to bed last night, which only unleashed a new volley of texts from Glimmer and another two missed calls, but Adora had her phone on silent and was in bed, so she missed all of them until she got up this morning.

"I've done nothing," Adora replies, because that's an accusation if she has ever heard one. How was she supposed to know that last night would be the night that Glimmer got fed up with her honeymoon or whatever happened and persistently tried to contact her? They've only texted every few days since she and Bow left, Adora popping into their group chat to ask how things are going and texting back that things are the same as usual when Glimmer or Bow asks despite how it is *decidedly* untrue.

"'Nothing' took up three hours last night? Nothing made you ignore your phone on a Saturday night? You weren't doing nothing, Grayskull, I *know* it," Glimmer replies. Adora blinks down at the breakfast she was in the middle of eating. Glimmer has a manic energy to her which means she has gotten suddenly obsessed with something and nothing in the world will dissuade her. Adora doesn't know why she is on the receiving end of this when they aren't even in the same timezone.

After a moment of silent consideration, Adora hangs up the phone. She manages to pull up Bow's contact before Glimmer tries to call her again. It only takes two rings for Bow to pick up her call.

"Hi, Adora," Bow answers, cheerily. In the background, Adora can hear Glimmer pause in the middle of cursing her out for hanging up. Glimmer lets out an indignant squeak that makes Adora snort when she hears Bow say her name.

"Hey, is something going on over there? I didn't think the texts looked urgent," Adora asks, because everybody knows Bow is the reasonable one. Glimmer is still going on an indignant rant in the background, seemingly trying to raise her voice so Adora can hear the whole thing, but Bow laughs with amusement. Not urgent, then.

“No. Glimmer was calling just because and she got worried when you didn’t answer. It turned into a conspiracy theory once you said you were busy on a Saturday night,” Bow tells her. Adora snorts. Alright, yeah, that’s what she *thought* – Glimmer usually reserves this manic energy for things that aren’t urgent, or even important – but she wanted to check. “Glimmer, *no*,” she hears Bow scold in the background, but he sounds amused. Adora can hear him laughing and the sound of fumbling.

“Glimmer, yes. You know I texted Perfuma when you said you were busy, but she said not only did she not move her Halloween party up a day, but you haven’t even RSVP’d? Who were you with, hm? Because I asked *Mermista* and she said that you haven’t spent time with anyone in the last three weeks – and that she gave you some very interesting contact information at the wedding,” Glimmer says right in her ear, apparently having snatched Bow’s phone from him.

Adora is suddenly grateful that her friends took almost an entire month for their honeymoon. Adora kind of admires Glimmer's moods like this – she gets really invested in things, and Adora likes seeing her passionate – but not when they are directed at her kind of-sex life. At least Glimmer can’t see her face or grab her by the shoulders and stare her down right now like Adora knows she would if they were in the same room instead of talking over the phone.

“I’m talking with Catra. I wouldn’t say we’re friends again, but we’re working on it, going slow and stuff. That’s the adult way to go about it, Glimmer. Everything is fine,” Adora returns. Glimmer does *not* need to know about the sessions. She will sleep perfectly fine thinking they just met up to talk last night. Glimmer lets out a noise that could be a crow of victory, except there is mirth and seeming concern in it too.

“Adora, we were roommates during the breakup. You could hide from everyone else, but I saw what it did to you. Forgive me for being worried. I’m also excited, good for you, but *Adora*,” Glimmer chides. She really can’t seem to decide where she stands. Adora snorts, finally giving up on her breakfast and putting down her fork. She will have to reheat it whenever Glimmer calms down enough to end the call. She certainly isn’t going to get to go back to it anytime soon.

“I reached out and apologized. I told her everything that was going on then and about dropping out. We’ve been talking a bit. She’s still cagey, but things have been good so far,” Adora tells her. She hesitates to mention the drop out, but Glimmer was there. She is right that she saw it all happen because she was Adora’s roommate - and then she *wasn’t* when Adora had to withdraw between semesters. Adora is so lucky that Glimmer talked to her mom and helped Adora get a job after failing out.

Adora does her work well – she was determined that *this* she would succeed at, she owed it to her friend who stuck her neck out for her – but she never would have gotten hired for this kind of position without a college degree if she hadn’t had Angella’s recommendation. Angella didn’t even really know if Adora would do the job well, all she had was her word and Glimmer’s assurance that she had worked day and night when she was in school. Adora couldn’t let her down. On the other end of the line, Glimmer is shockingly silent for several long moments.

“Okay. I know that had to be hard for you. I’m proud of you for finally talking about it,” Glimmer responds. She does sound proud. Adora blows out a slow breath. Glimmer seems to have been brought down from her mania by the admission. She is *really* lucky this is happening over the phone and Glimmer can’t see her reactions and get tipped off that more has been going on than talking – the mania would be back in full swing - but for now Adora has a reprieve.

“It’s been good. Like, really good. We’re making progress. I think we’ll be friends again at least,” Adora tells her, fiddling with her fork and flipping it over on her plate just for something to do. Her fidgeting stopped being as much of an issue after she graduated high school, but it never stopped being one of her preferred coping mechanisms. Adora isn’t anxious about this conversation per se, but she really needs her friends to just give them space to work things out. Glimmer makes an almost suspicious *hmm*.

“And is that all you want to be? You never got over her, Adora. I assumed you were quiet because you were processing seeing her again still. I can’t believe you reconnected with her and didn’t call us,” she replies. She doesn’t sound accusing – well, not *very* accusing – but Adora has to admit that she has a point. If Glimmer and Bow had been in town, there is no way that they wouldn’t know exactly what has been going on, but it was easy to keep quiet when they have just been keeping up via text on occasion.

“I wanted time that was just us to feel things out. I would have second-guessed everything if I had to explain it to other people. I won’t deny that I want to be more again, but I’m not expecting it. I’ll be happy as long as we’re friends,” Adora explains. It feels good to be talking about Catra – it especially feels good to be *smiling* while doing so. She really does think they’re going to be fine. Catra needs her space to get there, but last night was so much fun, and Catra seemed to love it just as much as Adora did.

Adora isn’t lying when she says she would be fine as just friends, but the truth is that a part of her *does* think that they’ll get together again. She won’t push Catra for anything like that unless she gives her an overt signal that she is open to it again though. She definitely isn’t right now. Their sessions are good, but BDSM is also Catra’s job. Maybe some people would be more bothered to be doing something like that with their ex, but Catra clearly is still comfortable with Adora – at least when it comes to stuff like BDSM that involves personal safety – and so she doesn’t mind having her as a client. She would have shut Adora down right away if it bothered her.

“Fine, I’ll let it go for now, but we are *going* to talk about this when we get back. Promise you’ll text if you need to talk or anything,” Glimmer tells her. The words come out like pulling teeth. She doesn’t want to let this go, but she also knows how sensitive the topic is. Adora is kind of relieved, putting down her fork now she doesn’t need to fidget to ease her anxiety. She was anxious about her friend berating her for this. Then again, Glimmer doesn’t know yet that they aren’t *just* talking.

Adora doesn’t really want to talk about what she is doing with Catra with anyone else – forgive her for wanting to keep her almost-sex life private – but she also doesn’t want to outright lie to her friends. It took her almost a year after the breakup to realize that while everyone feels guilt, the level that she feels it on isn’t normal. Adora never thought Catra

would hate her, or be ashamed of her, or breakup with her if she failed out of school, but she did think she would be disappointed in her and she couldn't handle the very idea of it.

She didn't think she had a right to have long-term issues from the way they were brought up when Catra had everything so much worse, but the fact that she would trust Catra with her life but still couldn't handle admitting her failure was proof enough that she had some things to work through. She has been trying to be honest ever since, even before she promised Catra that she would, but there's a difference between honesty and things you should say in polite company. Not that Glimmer could ever be qualified as polite unless her mom is hanging around, but Adora still has boundaries, especially now she isn't in a dry streak anymore.

"I will, but I don't really know what to say about it except that she's getting more comfortable. I'm just trying to show her that I'll be better to her now," Adora tells her, shrugging a little even though Glimmer can't see it. Glimmer *hmphs* down the line. She probably has an opinion about that, but Adora knows that she wasn't a good girlfriend. Glimmer saw how much Adora loved Catra, and she heard her gushing about when they would spend the summers together and everything was perfect, but the months of the school year are when they felt apart despite how much Adora cared. Glimmer couldn't see the growing distance.

"I just don't want you to get your heart broken again, especially when I'm not there to help," Glimmer replies. Adora feels her face spasm, torn between being touched and wincing at the statement. She is determined not to break anyone's heart again whether it is Catra's or her own. That is why, despite wanting nothing more than to wake up with Catra every day like she has always wanted, she isn't pushing anything. She has hated being without her best friend for so long. Any contact between them will be good enough for Adora.

"I'm being careful. We both are. I promise everything is fine. I would have called you otherwise," Adora tells her. It is true. If Catra had rejected her completely, Adora would have called begging for advice, or at least comfort. Everything has been going well though, and in addition to wanting to keep her activities with Catra private, she didn't want to bother her friends on their honeymoon. Glimmer sighs a little, but she doesn't sound disappointed.

"Okay. Just do me one favor?" Glimmer asks her. When Glimmer uses that tone of voice, a little pleading and whining, Adora struggles to say no. It usually leads to them doing something questionable together and Bow having to pull their asses out of the fire.

"What do you need?" Adora asks, just a little suspicious. She has good right to be. Glimmer snorts in response.

"Go to Perfuma's party. I called her last night and I had to end up swearing that you were planning to come to the party and just forgot to RSVP," Glimmer tells her. Adora sighs, and then groans a little.

"Glimmer," she whines, slumping in her seat. She loves Perfuma – she is eccentric, but very sweet and surprisingly wise – but she doesn't like parties in general. Perfuma's are a long way from Adora's scene. She was excited to be able to skip this year since Glimmer and Bow wouldn't be there. Mermista and Sea Hawk always have an overwhelming crowd at the bar on Halloween, so Adora will be on her own with Perfuma's other friends.

“Maybe I’m still worried about you and want to make sure you touch base with one of your friends. Please? You can remind her you have work tomorrow and dip after an hour,” Glimmer responds. Adora groans. Work should be a viable enough excuse not to go at all, but she knows that Glimmer has the best intentions – both to keep an eye out for Adora, and to avoid disappointing Perfuma. Perfuma puts a lot of effort into her grand Halloween party every year. Adora sighs heavily.

“Okay. Fine. I’m wearing the same thing as the last three years though,” Adora replies. Glimmer makes a victory crow.

“We’ll be back Saturday morning and then I expect all the gossip,” Glimmer replies. She sounds happy, but that isn’t assuring to Adora. It’s exactly what she doesn’t want.

“I have no gossip,” Adora says. It’s such a bold-faced lie there is no way she would get away with it in person. She hardly manages it over the phone. Glimmer outright scoffs at her.

“Adora, your ex is back and a dominatrix,” Glimmer replies. Adora blushes, mentally scrambling for a distraction.

“I still don’t know how that happened. We haven’t gotten to talking about it yet. Like I said, we’re being careful. She’ll tell me when she’s ready,” Adora replies. Glimmer laughs, a short bark that doesn’t help Adora’s embarrassed flush, but she thinks she got away with that. It’s true, but Adora does know *some* things – like what style of dom Catra really is.

“You can’t tell me you’re not dying to know,” Glimmer replies. Oh, absolutely.

“I’m going to ask as soon as I think she’ll answer, but I probably won’t tell you the answer,” Adora responds. Glimmer’s answering noise of affront makes her grin.

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Catra wasn’t looking forward to the Halloween party, but she wasn’t expecting it to be a fucking *disaster*. Not the party itself, that is mostly fine, but what happens after they arrive isn’t – actually, it started before they even left for it. Scorpia has been acting weird all week, but it isn’t until Catra walks out of her bedroom in her “costume” that she starts to realize what is going on. It gets even more obvious after they arrive.

Catra is supposed to be a mobster. Entrapta pulled a dark button-down shirt from the back of her closet, paired it with one of her few pairs of dress pants, and brought Catra her own pair of black suspenders to complete the look. Catra’s hair is down, as slicked back as she can make it without using some hair product that she doesn’t own, much less want in her hair. Catra left almost all the buttons undone. Between having the shirt tucked in and the suspenders, her tits aren’t about to fall out, and she likes the casual power of the open-chested shirt look. She has fluff instead of chest hair to reveal, but it works.

She adds a pair of her fingerless gloves – she has a few pairs that she wears when domming just because she likes the look and it keeps her palms from getting chapped on paddle handles or rope – but the addition is last minute, and her roommates only saw the outfit on a hanger when they put it together. They didn't see it on her, and certainly not with her tits out. She consults herself in the mirror before stepping out, deciding she passes as a mobster but she also just likes the look and will definitely be adopting it into her rotation of dom outfits with her now-signature ponytail instead.

She is still thinking about that when she joins her friends in the kitchen, Entrapta doing a last check of her many pockets to make sure she has everything she needs. Catra is in the middle of making a joke about how Entrapta is a traveling army camp – seriously, she has fucking provisions for if she starts getting nippy while out – when she catches onto Scorpia's scent. Catra valiantly doesn't react, refraining from looking over at Scorpia and acknowledging the mooning eyes she is sending her.

It's a good outfit. Catra doesn't blame her for finding it hot – Catra feels hot as hell in it, and at least someone is appreciating her effort – but it becomes clear that the reaction was merely a precursor once they get to the party. Scorpia is generally outgoing and highly social. Catra prefers to quietly drink in the corner with her friends until she has emptied an entire bottle of hard liquor and starts thinking it is a good idea to kiss people. They have very different approaches, but despite knowing exactly nobody at the party, Scorpia wraps an arm around Catra and drags her around from group to group as they explore and go hunting for the host.

It is probably the biggest party Catra has ever been to – in both the attendance and the decorations – but it isn't crushingly loud. It isn't quiet, don't get her wrong, but the music is at a gentle, ambient level, and the noise comes from the giant crowd of people that is overwhelming what appears to be a small country cottage in a suburb just outside of the Bright Moon city limits. There's a fucking haunted maze – made from *actual hedges* – in the side yard.

There are easily two hundred people here, mostly humans, but this is definitely more of a stoner crowd than a drunk music-blasting one, so things are tame despite the mass of people. Catra still doesn't like crowds. Despite the interesting mix of people that makes up the attendees – Catra has spotted four separate drag queens so far – everybody seems to just be having some fun on a weekend night. Maybe work being tomorrow for most is keeping them tame, but Catra is just relieved she won't have a noise headache tomorrow, especially not when she is having to deal with an unanticipated problem.

Scorpia is being bizarrely *jealous*. She is doing a full overprotective girlfriend act. Catra doesn't understand it. Scorpia lets Entrapta get distracted by following the pipes of the outdoor irrigation system for the small artificial stream system in the garden, trying to figure out how it generates movement, but she sticks close to Catra's side and pointedly wraps an arm around her whenever somebody starts eyeing her. She hops in with stories about Catra when given the chance like she is proudly showing off her partner.

It takes Catra nearly thirty minutes to figure out what is going on. She doesn't know what triggered this until she looks back over the last few days and remembers Scorpia *somewhat* casually asking Catra about who she was calling last Saturday morning. The answer was

Adora when Catra needed to calm her dom drop, but she dodged the question by pointing out that she can't give out client names and Scorpia wouldn't know them anyway. Scorpia brushed it off as a question born of curiosity since it was an odd thing for Catra to do. Catra was too busy panicking about the fact that she was right and that it seemed like Scorpia was onto her to think twice about the question then, but it is the only odd thing that has happened in the last week.

Scorpia, apparently, doesn't like the idea of Catra being close with one of her subs even without knowing that it's her ex. Catra is guessing that it has made her insecure, because this display tonight doesn't make sense otherwise. It *still* doesn't make sense. Scorpia has no right to hold her back from anyone else. Not that Catra wants to catch someone's attention tonight, but she doesn't want Scorpia's either. She likes when people appreciate her - when they want her - but she has no intention of letting them *have* her. She built her career on it, and Scorpia is no exception.

Catra has told her that she doesn't want a relationship, she even tried to be gentle about it and say she wasn't interested in one with anyone and that it had nothing to do with Scorpia herself, but she still keeps making these weird pushes trying to be more. Maybe Catra's mistake wasn't telling her outright that she wasn't interested in her. It felt unnecessarily cruel, but she can't help but wonder if Scorpia is still holding onto false hope that Catra will somehow fall for her. It's so frustrating, trying not to ruin and lose another friendship while also trying not to hurt her friend or *herself*.

Catra is opening up – against all attempts otherwise and her better judgement – but she isn't going to magically develop feelings for Scorpia. If over two years of refusing to kiss her – and even back when they did kiss, only ever doing it in loaded make outs or as foreplay – isn't enough to convince Scorpia to move on, she doesn't know what will be. Most of the time they are just friends and they are both fine with it, but then days like this happen. Catra really has no clue why Scorpia is hung up on her considering their obvious incompatibility before feelings even get involved.

It says a lot about the awkward situation she is caught in that she feels herself perk up at the unexpected intrusion of Adora's voice. At least Adora has agreed to be honest with her and has been upfront about her intentions and expectations. It only makes the situation with Scorpia more stark in its discomfort. Unfortunately, that thought reminds her that Scorpia doesn't know that Adora is back in her life yet. Fuck.

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Adora shows up thirty minutes late, but in her defense, she wasn't planning to come before this morning. She got to hand out candy to two trick-or-treaters before she resigned herself to the fact that it was time to drive over to Perfuma's. She reluctantly put on her ears, not changing out of her track pants or t-shirt, and got in her car. Perfuma's annual Halloween party is costume-mandatory, but Adora isn't putting on an uncomfortable costume – much

less spending money on something cheap and mostly pointless – so she has been wearing the headband that technically fulfills the requirement every year that she has been coming.

Halloween feels like lost opportunities to her. Everyone with a normal childhood got to experience it, but she and Catra never got to do anything related to it. Adora was looking forward to a day of just giving candy to cute kids in costumes. Perfuma's parties are always so crowded. It feels like half the city is packed into the small cottage by the time Adora gets there.

She manages to spot what she swears is Perfuma's big cape from her drag days back before she realized she was more herself "in costume" than out of it, but when Adora makes her way through the room, there is no sign of Perfuma or the cape wearer. Adora doesn't know how someone wearing a nine meter cape could move that quickly in a party this crowded, so she must have been mistaken. She just wants to find Perfuma to put in her token appearance and then head home and go to bed at a reasonable time for work tomorrow.

She is trying to make her way through the packed cottage before trying the backyard when she stops dead in her tracks, staring through a gap in the crowd before someone shifts and it closes again. No, it *can't* be. That doesn't even make sense. It has to be someone dressed as a fucking cat. Adora shoves her way through the crowd. This time, her target doesn't move. This time, she was *right*. Adora stares at Catra's back. It doesn't matter if she is seeing her from behind – or inexplicably hanging off the arm of some woman – she would know Catra's silhouette in any context, at any time.

"Oh yeah, Catra finished there last year. Did you two ever meet each other? It's not that big, right?" the woman, some scorpioni with an arm around Catra's shoulders, is saying. Adora feels her heartbeat pounding through her chest. Okay, she can absolutely handle Catra not wanting to pursue a relationship together – she just apparently can't handle the idea of her being with someone else instead. She can't think of another explanation for the casual ease with which the woman slings her arm around Catra's shoulders. Catra always hated anyone but Adora touching her.

Adora maybe didn't examine her unconscious biases enough, or maybe she just assumed that Catra would have said otherwise, but between her being a professional dom and the ease with which she has teased Adora about stuff, Adora assumed she was single. She had her small freak-out on the phone last week, but it was seconds before it was abated and she very quickly shoved it from her mind. She clears her throat as she steps forward to insert herself into the conversation despite how the only person that she knows in it is Catra.

"Hey, Catra," Adora cuts in. Catra's ears twitch and her whole body seems to stand at attention as her eyes abandon the lycan she and her *friend* were facing to lock eyes with Adora instead. Her gaze is burning. Adora swallows. Time to find out what the hell is going on - and if her sudden appearance is going to piss Catra off. She didn't think about that until she stepped in, but now the worry breaks through into her thoughts.

To her dismay, Catra's eyes quickly dart up to look at the absolutely ripped woman she is tucked into the side of. It's a bad sign that Catra is looking to her. She must be trying to gauge her reaction, because Catra doesn't look to anyone for permission. She is far more likely to look you in the eye defiantly as she breaks the rules. The woman, for her part, practically

twitches, looking down at Adora with wide eyes before narrowing them. Adora is doing her level best not to glare at the woman – posturing is *not* going to endear her to Catra, especially not if this is her girlfriend – but the two of them are engaged in somewhat of a stare down.

“Didn’t think this was your scene, princess,” Catra returns, looking back to Adora as she straightens out her shoulders. Adora watches as the woman tries to tighten her arm around Catra’s shoulders, but Catra remains standing tall and sending Adora a look she knows to mean *wait*. She doesn’t know what she is supposed to be holding back if Catra is fine with openly calling her princess.

“It isn’t, really, but Perfuma works hard on the party. The least I can do is show up and steal some food,” Adora returns. Joking is hard when she wants nothing more than to demand to know what is going on with the other woman, but she knows she is already out of line with her jealousy. She doesn’t need Catra deciding that Adora can’t respect her boundaries – she doesn’t need her to be *right* – and walking after all the progress they have already made. Adora absolutely cannot fuck this up with jealousy.

“Sorry, I don’t believe we’ve met,” the scorpioni tells her through a strained smile. Catra’s tail lashes behind her. Adora doesn’t get to open her mouth before Catra cuts her off.

“We *work together*, Scorpia,” Catra replies, looking up to make pointed eye contact with the woman – Scorpia, apparently. Adora can't help but wonder why Catra phrased it like that. Clearly Scorpia knows, and Catra seemed to have no shame about being a dom. Is there someone else here who she doesn’t want to know? Was that what the look was about, trying to keep Adora from casually mentioning her work?

Adora gives Scorpia a tight smile when she glances back to her and shrugs. She can’t exactly ask Catra without pulling her aside. Can she ask who Scorpia is, or will that prompt too many questions about how she knows Catra in return? This whole situation is weird. Now that the immediate jealousy mist is clearing, Adora has also finally registered what Catra is wearing. It isn’t helping her to be normal. Why the hell is she dressed like this if not to break someone’s brain? Why is she hanging off the arm of some goth lolita?

“Are you an artist too?” the lycan asks, probably trying to steer the conversation back in a less awkward direction. Adora kind of forgot about them, distracted first by the strange woman and then by the completely unbuttoned front of Catra’s shirt. She turns around, blinking for a moment and thinking of what answer she can give that is honest and not going to fuck up whatever double-blind Catra is running.

“Uh, no, I’m in vendor management. I work with people selling all kinds of things,” Adora returns. All those are vendors that her company has a relationship with, and none of them sell art that isn’t the mass-produced home décor variety you would find in the supermarket, but it is an ambiguous enough truth that she hopes it will pass.

It works. The lycan bemoans not thinking to bring their business card while Adora does her best to downplay her own importance – she really doesn’t get to decide what she buys, her job is just intercompany relations, so she wouldn’t be able to do anything for them even if she did regularly work with art. In the corner of her eye, she sees Catra relax a little bit as she

watches Adora flounder. Beside her, however, is the looming question of who the hell Scorpia is.

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Adora takes the hint and she doesn't protest Catra only introducing her as princess. Catra doesn't want Scorpia causing a scene in the middle of this party where they don't know anybody. Luckily, Adora is more attentive to Catra's signals than Scorpia. Scorpia keeps trying to tuck Catra tighter against her side. Catra would shrug Scorpia's arm off now that she has realized what she is doing and why she is acting like this, but there is just one problem: Catra kind of likes Adora's reaction.

Catra can clearly see she is jealous of the arm slung over her shoulders, but she is trying not to be. She is keeping one eye on Catra, attentive to her signals, while she tries to carry the conversation forward from its awkward stalled point by asking the lycan about Mystacor. She is trying to learn more about Catra's time at university, probably, but Catra isn't bothered by that. She is mostly impressed that Adora, despite being the one actively talking to fill the silence in the air, is *listening* to her. She is picking up on Catra's signals like she used to be able to when they were together.

It is the easy understanding that Catra desperately missed when they were long distance. Its absence was one of the many things that made it feel like Adora lost interest in her. Catra is well-aware of what this must look like to Adora. If she suspected Adora of having a secret girlfriend she hadn't told her about, she would have stormed out of the party and blocked her phone number all over again. Adora was never a champion of restraint. The amount she is managing to show in this moment is medal-worthy for her.

"You didn't go to Mystacor, right? How did you and Catra meet?" Adora asks Scorpia, almost innocently, when the lycan turns away to listen to their lizardfolk friend that has tapped them on the arm. The lycan is quickly edging their way out of the conversation now they have an excuse to duck out gracefully. The conversation has been *awkward* with Scorpia eyeing Adora. Scorpia should fucking drop it while Catra is talking to someone from the professional world she is trying to get into – especially someone who might judge her for the other one that she is currently in – but she doesn't seem able to contain herself.

The lycan glances back at the three of them to wave, quickly muttering a goodbye before they turn and disappear into the crowd with their friend. Catra wanted to network with them – she didn't come here with that expectation or she would have buttoned up her shirt, but they seemed to appreciate the view and already turned her onto a gallery in the conversation they had before Adora showed up – but she doesn't dare go after them and leave Adora and Scorpia alone together. It would be awkward when they already excused themselves anyway.

"A mutual friend introduced us years ago," Scorpia tells Adora. Catra barely suppresses a snort of laughter, her tail curling with amusement behind her instead. Scorpia, the idiot, is trying to establish *seniority*. Catra's first memory – well, first good memory – is Adora lifting

her up out of the box she was cowering in for some sense of safety. Catra tried to fight her, just like she fought the adults who tried to extract her before Adora, but Adora was too young, dumb, and determined to be put off by Catra's snarling and flailing claws. She hauled a still-battered Catra, the only survivor of the car wreck, into her arms and started petting her.

Catra stopped flailing, though it took a solid ten minutes for her to stop growling. They have been locked together ever since, orbiting each other. For a long time, Catra considered Adora her sun. Watching Adora raise a brow at Scorpia and then shoot a conspiratorial look to Catra, Catra suddenly feels like she has become the center of the orbit instead. Inexplicably, her cheeks heat and she ducks her head. It is just the memory resurfacing, she tells herself. It is an emotional one, especially remembering how Adora had *no reason* to approach the snarling box that Catra's case worker had given up on extricating her from.

Maybe Adora was just a three-year-old, too stupid and lonely to leave her alone, but after Catra's initial fear faded, it felt meant to be. She latched onto Adora, only ever purring for her. They were best friends, becoming lovers when the time was right, and it felt like they would be together forever. Catra never felt shit with Scorpia. At the time, it was comforting. Emotions got her hurt before. Caring ruined her life, she thought, but she felt more with Adora when they were at their worst than she ever did with Scorpia. The thought disquiets her now. Her tail stops curling behind her. Instantly, she sees a wrinkle of concern appear in Adora's brow.

"How exactly did you and Catra meet?" Scorpia asks above her. Catra instantly scowls. She knows Scorpia is- alright, she doesn't actually know what Scorpia is thinking tonight considering she has no right to act like this, but she does know that Scorpia is trying to determine if Adora is a threat. Yeah, she is a fucking threat alright. Catra actually has feelings for her. It doesn't matter what Scorpia's intentions are or why she is asking the question, though: Catra already gave her a clear sign not to discuss her day job at the party and now she is probing at it.

Catra has told her roommates never to say what she does to anybody without permission, well-aware of the stigma in outside circles that could potentially lose her opportunities when it comes to her art. She doesn't give a fuck about being friends with people who wouldn't understand, but her art is extremely important to her and she doesn't want to do anything to jeopardize any opportunities for it. Just because Scorpia knows Adora is from that world doesn't mean she has blanket permission to discuss it, especially not where other people can overhear.

Luckily, Adora doesn't seem to know how to answer that, sending Catra a questioning look because she is a good girl who actually listens. Before Catra can decide how she wants to answer that question, they get interrupted again by a friend spotting them. Unfortunately, it isn't Entrapta. It's a blonde woman Catra *knows* and she seems to materialize by Adora's side already mid-sentence.

"I'm so glad you could come, Adora!" Perfuma greets. At Catra's side, Scorpia stiffens.

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Perfuma is, in fact, wearing her nine meter cape. Adora really should know better than to underestimate her. Adora has never seen her perform for real, just show their friend group little routines at parties such as this one, but even though she didn't meet Perfuma until after she semi-retired from drag and had transitioned, she has seen enough to know she is damn good at it. She startles a bit when Perfuma appears, a little too focused on looking to Catra for some kind of sign of what she is allowed to say. She turns away from the lingering question quickly, smiling to Perfuma.

"Yeah, sorry, I forgot to RSVP. I'll probably have to leave early to rest for work tomorrow, though," Adora tells her, hugging Perfuma carefully when she lifts her arms to prompt Adora for it. Adora doesn't want to mess up her gown or anything so she doesn't squeeze too hard. Perfuma looks stunning, done up like a Hollywood bombshell from a parallel dimension where everything is just a bit more fantastical. Perfuma nods sympathetically at her words.

"Fewer people could make it this year because of work on Monday, but the opportunity to have the party on Halloween itself was too good to pass up," Perfuma replies. She seems to notice Adora's companions as she finishes speaking, her eyes catching on Catra. Adora can *see* her trying to figure out how she knows her. She can also see that Scorpia's eyes have gone wide and that Catra is maybe internally panicking.

Perfuma's jaw drops a little with realization as Scorpia's eyes snap onto Adora, outright glaring her down now. Her arm around Catra tightens in a way that tells Adora all it needs to. Catra wasn't just trying to keep her job private – she was trying to avoid a fight breaking out. Adora never would have fought, but Catra's new girlfriend seems willing to if her possessive grip is anything to go on. It's fucking painful to see. She thought Catra would have *told her* if she had a girlfriend. Apparently they weren't growing as close as she thought.

"Hang on, you're a client now?" Scorpia asks, turning on Adora suddenly. Adora flinches, as does Catra, though Adora's wince is hurt and Catra's is more *annoyed* as her ears pin back. Perfuma looks on with wide, blinking eyes, looking between the two of them – and Catra – with flushed cheeks. She can't know what prompted the outburst, but she has definitely recognized Catra. Catra didn't want her work to be exposed at this party. Fuck.

"Catra told you we *work together*," Adora answers Scorpia, mostly to remind her to shut up about Catra's work. She doesn't know what else to say, especially with Perfuma watching. Scorpia's arm around Catra is getting tight – too tight. Adora watches panic from the restriction flash in Catra's eyes, but before she can react, Catra does it first. Catra growls, rolling her shoulders to shrug off the arm around them and darting out from under Scorpia's arm. She immediately turns back to glare at her.

"Let *go* of me. I'm tired of your jealousy shit. You're worse than Adora," Catra tells her, and with that, she turns and fists her hand in the front of Adora's shirt. Adora feels her eyes go wide as Catra hauls her closer to her, taking a step back and yanking them into the crowd. Adora stumbles forward after Catra, her ears buzzing and barely registering the start of surprise behind them. What Scorpia has to say certainly doesn't matter to her as Catra drops her shirt to grab her hand instead. Catra turns to actually look where she is going as she leads them through the crowd.

“I can go back to tell Perfuma not to talk about your work-” Adora starts, having to raise her voice a little to be heard. Catra cuts her off with a growl and Adora falls silent, blinking down at their hands as they reach the front porch and the cool night air hits them. Catra doesn’t take a deep breath and calm down now that they are outside. Instead, she turns to Adora, her tail lashing behind her as she pointedly glares over Adora’s shoulder. It seems they’re being followed, but to be fair, Adora would do the same if Catra ran out on her.

“Where’s Swift Wind?” Catra demands, her gaze darting back to Adora. Adora blinks in surprise. Catra hisses when she doesn’t answer fast enough, her tail still lashing. Adora swallows, hastily reaching into her pocket for her car keys with her free hand.

“In the driveway of the next cottage to the right. They let Perfuma use-” Adora starts to explain, but she gets cut off when Catra turns and starts hauling them down the steps again. Catra spots the classic Mustang that Adora inherited when she turned eighteen and she heads right for it. The second they reach the car, she turns and she shoves Adora up against it, kissing her hungrily.

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Catra snapping has been building in the four years of her and Scorpia awkwardly maneuvering around each other and especially tonight, but *this* – the crash of her and Adora’s bodies together – is about her and Adora as much as it is about Scorpia’s possessive shit. It has been building ever since Catra tried to cut herself loose for the sake of her own heart and found herself missing the space in her chest where it used to be instead. Adora releases a startled groan when Catra shoves her up against the car, and that is *right*.

It is the first thing that has felt right all night after Scorpia spent the entire party barreling through boundaries like a linebacker. Adora was jealous, but she was jealous thinking Catra has a girlfriend that she hadn’t told her about. She had a right to that jealousy considering it once seemed inevitable that they would get married. Catra can’t take Scorpia’s jealousy and she doesn’t want her trying to stake her claim on Catra. Catra isn’t hers – she isn’t *anyone’s*. She does the owning, and right now, Adora’s mouth is hers.

She doesn’t know if Scorpia is watching. She kind of hopes she is, just so she gets the message that Catra is done dealing with this when she never even agreed to hook up with her exclusively, much less be in a relationship, but the rest of her warns her that she will regret that vindictiveness in the morning. They should have talked it out, just like she and Adora should have, and then it wouldn’t have reached a breaking point like this, but in this moment, Catra feels nothing but excitement as Adora finally gets with the program and kisses her back.

Fuck, yes. Catra moans and she doesn’t even care, her tail lashing behind her as she tries to press forward as if they aren’t already plastered together from head to toe. Catra’s body is on fire as Adora’s hands come up and lightly rest on her hips. Catra knows she has to be confused and two steps behind, but she still holds her almost respectfully as she lets Catra

claim every inch of her mouth. Against her hip, Catra feels the car key in Adora's palm dig into her. She reaches down, squeezing Adora's wrist pointedly as she ducks down to bite harshly at Adora's neck, causing her to give a muffled cry into the night.

"Unlock the car, Adora," she instructs before biting down again. If Scorpia was watching, she must be gone by now. This isn't a show and Catra isn't acting – she just needs it. She needs someone to respect her and make her feel alive. She needs someone she trusts to touch her. Fuck her, she needs to be taken care of and have every one of her moans listened closely to until they reach just the right pitch. She and Scorpia had decent sex, but they never had *that*. That was always something she shared with Adora.

Adora fumbles with the keys, biting her own lip and moaning as she struggles to unlock the door in the dark, but eventually Catra hears the click and she pulls just far enough away for the car door to be opened. As soon as it is, she shoves Adora back towards it. Adora scrambles to scoot back into the seat. She doesn't protest as Catra crawls into the car, straddling over her and then reaching back to slam the door shut behind them.

She has just enough presence of mind to hit the lock button before she swoops down and kisses Adora again. Domming is a high like nothing else, but fuck, she missed kissing and having it *mean* something. It doesn't matter that they aren't together anymore, Catra still loves Adora, and she doesn't think Adora's feelings for her have faded all that much either. She has given no indication of even attempting to move on.

"Is she your girlfriend?" Adora manages to pant out between the frenzied kisses. She hasn't kissed Catra *once* of her own accord, but fuck does she meet her with a passion when Catra initiates it. Catra almost wants to laugh. No, absolutely not. All Catra ever wanted was a friend, not a girlfriend who would listen to her even less than her old one and go talking about her job after Catra explicitly told her not to.

"She *wishes*," is Catra's reply before she bites down hard on Adora's lower lip and tugs. Adora's moan feels like it could rattle the windows. Adora is panting and squirming beneath her, reeking of desire. Catra feels maybe a touch feral, manic from the tense emotions of the evening – of the last few weeks, truthfully – and feeling hungry now she has Adora desperate beneath her like this. The next time they part, she feels her heart drop when Adora quickly turns her head away. Maybe she just needs to gasp in some air, but her eyes are fixed on Catra. She can see worry in them around the dark cloud of lust.

"Give me a color, Catra. Are you sober?" she asks. The question actually startles Catra into pulling back a bit, blinking down at Adora with her ears twitching. Adora seems relieved by the reprieve, drawing in a few breaths and then propping herself up a little to eye Catra. "I want you, I always do, but I want to make sure you're okay. Almost all the food at Perfuma's parties has weed in it, and I'm sure there's alcohol somewhere," Adora returns. Catra's heart is beating out her chest as she blinks down at her.

"I'm sober. Nothing but water, pinky swear," she returns. She sounds a little dumbstruck, but she *is*. Some tension in Adora's shoulders releases as she smiles, small and hopeful, up at Catra. She reaches up, brushing Catra's hair out of her face and trying to tuck it behind her ear. It is long enough to snake around it and still fall in her face, so it doesn't do much, but fuck does Catra want to lean into the lingering touch.

“Color? I can’t do this if it’s going to ruin things. I can’t lose you again,” Adora tells her, breathless. Catra swallows, feeling her ears twitch as she blinks down at her. Catra is emotional and reckless in this moment, but she is more than capable of consenting. She isn’t going to turn away from Adora later and punish her for giving her what she wants. She isn’t in the mood to punish fucking anybody - unless you count what just happened with Scorpia, but she doesn’t know what Scorpia expected after overstepping like that.

“Blue,” Catra breathes. Fuck, that feels like admitting a weakness. She is supposed to be the one in charge making *others* say their words, but this isn’t actually a scene. Adora isn’t trying to dom her, just checking in. Adora’s hand shifts to pet over her mane, her touch firm so Catra can feel it through her mass of hair. Catra holds still, soaking in the attention. After a long moment, Adora hooks her hand around the back of her head and gently tugs her down. Catra follows in an instant, letting herself be drawn into a kiss with Adora in the lead this time.

It is messy, open mouthed and filthy, but less forceful than the ones that Catra gave her. It’s exactly what she needs. The utter debauchery of it is enough to slide it firmly into territory she is comfortable with, nothing too sweet and meaningful that tips it into emotional territory, but the slower pace and gentler force lets Catra maintain more control over the interaction. Catra doesn’t want to talk, just fuck and find comfort in someone who is always going to know her no matter what.

When they part, it is slow, Adora nipping and tugging at Catra’s bottom lip until they part enough for it to steadily pull from between her teeth, a smooth drag that causes Catra’s tail to lash behind her. Fuck, yes, this is exactly what she wants. She lets her eyes open slowly, mostly hooded still as she watches the answering smile spread on Adora’s face. It is a smirk, satisfaction clear, but she also just seems happy, her hand on the back of Catra’s head running down the length of her back in a long pet as she travels down towards Catra’s tail.

Catra gives a low growl. She fucking loves having her tail pulled under the right circumstances, but not right now. She is way too volatile for it. Adora’s smile softens, but it doesn’t fade. Her eyes are hooded too, fixed over Catra’s shoulder to watch her tail twitching tensely as she continues her quest down, and, to Catra’s shock, gropes her ass. Catra doesn’t quite squeak, but it takes her by surprise, causing her face to heat instantly. She likes it, though. She has a fantastic ass and she likes when someone appreciates all the squats she does.

“What do you want, Catra?” Adora breathes to her, leaning forward to ghost the words against her lips. Catra’s eyes fall shut as she nearly shudders at Adora’s hot breath against her lips. She wants Adora to *kiss her*, devouring her and giving her everything she has. The thought is more fantasy than anything else, though. She wants it, but it isn’t what she needs right now.

“Service me. Say your words if it’s too much for you,” Catra tells her. She almost says *this doesn’t change things*, but she isn’t that much of a liar. Things are going to be different tomorrow morning, but they don’t have to be worse. They aren’t going to wake up magically healed, but this doesn’t have to damage them either. Adora’s breath hitches beneath her,

excitement in her scent. Her tongue darts out to wet her lips before she takes Catra's words as the permission they are and kisses her hungrily.

"Yes, sir," Adora breathes when they part, squeezing Catra's ass one last time before she slides her hand around to begin undoing her fly. In just two words, Catra relaxes. Catra wants vanilla sex. She wants Adora to touch her. This isn't a scene, or at least not the kind she has experience with, but those words assure her: Adora may be touching her, but Catra is still in charge. She is being listened to. Adora will do what she tells her.

"Fuck me like you mean it, Grayskull," Catra orders. Adora moans in response.

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This is far from the first time they have had sex in Adora's car. She inherited the Mustang from her mother, but she couldn't claim it until she was an adult at eighteen. That was also when she aged out of the foster home and she joined Catra in being essentially homeless. They both had inheritances waiting for them, but it didn't make either of them rich and finding an apartment was rough when they both knew the money would quickly run out. They lived out of the car for several weeks before they found the hole-in-the-wall apartment they shared until university split them up and Adora moved to Bright Moon.

The walls at their apartment were thin. They had sex in the backseat before they moved into it and again after. They had their first kiss in the front seat right after Adora received the car and thus their ticket to freedom. In their encounters in the car – and especially their later encounters in the privacy of a space they could call home - Adora discovered that Catra has a thing for clothed sex. She doesn't try to undress Catra, just slipping one of her suspenders off her shoulders to give Adora more room to work and undoing her fly for access.

She doesn't bother with foreplay. It isn't what Catra needs right now and it isn't what she asked for. The make out was enough. She kisses Catra hungrily as she slips her hand into her underwear and touches her. Fuck, it feels so good to have her hands on Catra, slipping amongst her folds. Adora doesn't touch her directly, feeling her out again and letting the excitement work through her. She isn't wet to start like usual, so Adora doesn't want to force anything before she is ready. Catra rumbles and awkwardly rolls her hips into Adora's touch. They really aren't in a good position for this.

"Straddle me and ride my fingers?" Adora asks when they part from the kiss. She is breathless from the embrace, but she can't explain away the excitement in her voice as easily. She doesn't know if Catra wants penetration tonight, but Adora really wants to feel her heat all around her again. She needs her to move to accomplish that, and she knows Catra will want her to ask rather than to go ahead and rearrange her. Catra groans at the words, shifting her hips to rub herself a bit against Adora's fingers before she pulls back reluctantly.

She makes burning eye contact with Adora as she shifts to straddle her hips, raising herself up on her knees and bowing her head to accommodate the roof of the car. It's an awkward

position, but so is every arrangement of bodies you can make in the backseat of a car this size. Catra grips the back of the seat with one hand and uses the other to brace herself against the seat right beside Adora's head as she gets in position.

Adora props herself up on one arm as she slips her hand back into Catra's underwear, half pulled out by the maneuvering. She is starting to get wet now. Adora eagerly rubs against her entrance, watching Catra's eyelids flutter and soft, contented sighs spill forth from her lips. It is a quiet moment, beautiful vulnerability and pleasure on Catra's face, before Catra surges forward and kisses her again, hungry and biting. The embrace is desperate, needing more than Adora is giving.

If Catra wants it, then Adora will give it to her. Adora touches her, working her up until Catra is moaning, whimpering, and squirming. When she seems ready, Adora cautiously slides back to her entrance and presses in with one finger. Catra takes it easily, sighing against her lips with an air of relief, so Adora pulls back and presses in with two this time. Catra's breath hitches and there is a moment of resistance, but her body takes the intrusion, her walls relaxing and letting Adora press in.

Adora holds her fingers there for a moment so Catra can adjust, grinding her palm against Catra to replace the loss of stimulation to her clit as she waits. Catra allows the pause, though she gets *nippy* during it, biting hard on Adora's bottom lip and tugging almost painfully. Adora, being who she is, groans and shudders in response. Catra's kisses have always driven her wild and it is still true five years down that line.

She is eager to do what Catra asked, though. She begins moving her fingers cautiously, but when she only gets excitement and gasping in response, she begins to slowly thrust her fingers. Catra meets her, twitching her hips until she can't take it and she starts working herself down to meet Adora's small thrusts, limited by the restriction of her clothes. Her hair bounces along with her tits, her shirt falling open and half off her shoulders as she moans and pants with exertion, high whines on every breath.

It is all so fast after that. Adora can't look away, entranced by the beautiful sight of Catra above her, still in charge and yet completely undone and in disarray. Sometimes Catra manages to kiss her, but mostly she rides her fingers and releases a symphony of quiet sounds that make Adora's mouth dry at the same time that her underwear clings to her. The closest she comes to looking away is when she recognizes the raise in pitch in Catra's moans and pulls her fingers out.

Catra growls in protest, but Adora silences her with a kiss as she quickly pulls her hand out of Catra's underwear. A quick turn of her head and she plunges her own soaked fingers into her mouth. She groans when Catra's taste hits her tongue, lapping a bit greedily at her fingers knowing full well Catra is watching, but she does also need to clean some of the slick off her fingers. The fact that she is just as much of an addict for Catra's taste now as she was before is just a bonus.

Fingers wet but significantly less slippery, Adora pulls them out of her mouth and slides them back into Catra's underwear to touch her clit again. She makes eye contact with Catra to find her gaze burning, golden and lightning-blue flames boring into her soul with their desire for several long seconds before Catra surges forward and kisses her again, whimpering and

moaning as Adora touches her properly. Catra usually gets off on being fucked, but she needs more than that to actually come.

It doesn't take long of Adora working her clit before Catra is tensing, her moans getting even higher before she cries out and writhes weakly in Adora's arms. It is too much movement and too messy to keep kissing, but their faces stay close together as Catra works through it, whimpering and moaning as her tail lashes. Eventually, she goes limp above Adora, barely holding herself still braced above her. Adora is so turned on she feels like she could come just from squeezing her thighs together.

Carefully, she pulls her hand out of Catra's pants. Her fingers are slick again. This time she wipes them off on her pants, quickly drying them before she reaches up for Catra. Gently, she tugs her down to drape onto her chest. Catra's post-orgasm purr is beginning to rumble through the car now, but she doesn't open her eyes, letting Adora flop back against the car seat with Catra tucked down onto her chest. Her purr fills the heated and damp air of the car as she nuzzles against her face, rubbing their cheeks together.

It makes a new flood of heat work its way between Adora's legs. Intentionally or not, Catra just scent marked her, and Adora is going to smell like hers at work tomorrow. She wraps her arms around Catra's back and squeezes her close in a hug before she relaxes and switches to just gently cradling her. The air is filled with the sound of Catra's contented purr as she relaxes into the post-orgasm satiation in Adora's arm. Adora feels no need to hurry them past this moment.

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Adora wraps her arms around her back, holding her close for the several moments it takes Catra to get control of her body back after coming that hard. She hasn't been fucked by anything other than a toy or tongue in five years and she didn't quite *forget* how good it is, but her body definitely isn't used to it. Adora cuddles her through it, like she always used to. No matter how turned on Adora is, she is always eager to snuggle with Catra afterwards, humming along with her purr and happily letting Catra rub her face into her like she loves to do afterwards.

The fire in her finally feels cooled as she tucks her face down into Adora's neck. It feels so good to be held with the endorphins coursing through her. Turning her face to peek up at the windows with one eye reveals them a little foggy, trace evidence of what just happened. They really should get out of here before someone comes wandering over. Catra should at least button up her shirt – her clothes are in disarray, her shirt mostly pulled out of its tuck from all the movement with her pants undone and her tits out – but right now she is covered up by the virtue of how she is draping over Adora.

The haziness of frustration sparking pure need has cleared, and with its departure reality is beginning to sink in. She really should have gotten off after her session with Adora last night. Catra absolutely does not want to go back to the party and deal with the consequence of this.

If Scorpia knows her at all, she should know that something like this is the inevitable result of pushing her too hard, but Catra knows she should calm down more before she sees her again. She will be hurt despite how Catra has been telling her she doesn't have feelings or want to be exclusive from the start.

Catra can't run forever – they *live* together after all – but for the moment, they need room to breathe. Catra just wants to leave now. She wants to climb into the front seat and let Adora take her home. She wants to lie in her arms and never move. She wants to give up on relationships forever, because clearly she isn't good at them. She can't even tell if others have hurt her or if she has hurt herself. She is definitely in a small spiral. Adora's hand stills its petting and then drops to her shoulder to squeeze gently as she bends down and presses a soft kiss to the top of Catra's head.

"Doing okay down there?" she asks, her voice soft. She must have picked up on Catra tensing up or something. Catra sighs, nuzzling her face against Adora's neck and breathing in. She reminds herself that her relationship with Adora falling apart definitely wasn't totally her fault. It's possible they both can still learn how to do shit like this. Catra doesn't have to be doomed to a life of loneliness and hurt. Adora is right here, after all, concerned even after taking care of her.

"Yeah. Just don't want to deal with Scorpia," Catra sighs, slowly dragging her cheek along Adora's neck. Adora does nothing to protest the mark. It is more evidence that maybe they aren't completely doomed. Not that Catra is any more eager to fall into a relationship than she was yesterday – *clearly* she isn't ready for that – but there is hope for them, whether that ends up just being as friends or everything Catra dreamed they could be since middle school. Adora gives a low hum of acknowledgement as she shifts back to petting Catra.

"Who is she? If talking about it doesn't make it worse, I mean," Adora asks, her voice still soft, though her curiosity is obvious. Catra snorts a little. Oh, it will probably make her feel worse, but Adora has already done a lot for her tonight and she kind of owes her an explanation at this point. That whole exchange had to be odd to witness from the outside. Catra can't imagine what fucking Perfuma thought. She just had the misfortune of wandering into it at the breaking point.

"One of my roommates. I have two. Lonnie introduced us when I moved here. We used to hook up. Still do sometimes, I guess, but she caught feelings. I told her I didn't want that, but she has been jealous lately," Catra explains with a heavy sigh. If she and Adora are having sex again, even just on occasions like this, then she deserves to know Catra has had another partner in the meantime. Adora draws in a breath beneath her and holds it. She is processing her own jealousy, probably. The car is silent for several long moments before she lets the air go.

"Come home with me? I'm not expecting anything more, I just don't want you to have to go back to that tonight. My door is always open for you," Adora asks her, voice small. There is a tinge to it – hope or desperation, it's hard to tell – but Adora doesn't have to hope. Catra reluctantly nods against her neck. She doesn't want to go back to the party, but going back to the townhouse also means confronting Scorpia, just a little bit later tonight than if she went straight back into the party.

Adora seems relieved, breathing a bit easier as she pets down Catra's mane and shifts to press a kiss against the base of her ear – and then another against her ear itself, and another, scattering a half dozen soft kisses there until her breath tickles Catra and she flicks her ear involuntarily, smacking Adora in the face with it and causing her to chuckle as she drops her head back down against the seat.

"You want shotgun or are you staying back here?" Adora asks, returning to petting. Catra just rumbles and nuzzles against Adora. She needs to soak in the last few moments of the cuddle while she has them. She probably shouldn't be allowing Adora to kiss her casually like this, but Adora would kiss her ears sometimes even before they are together. In the afterglow, it doesn't have to mean something more than Catra is ready for it to.

"Shotgun," Catra returns. As much as she wants to just lie out on the backseat and relax, she always rides shotgun when she is in a car. It's where her car seat was when she survived the accident. She doesn't trust any other seat in the car. Adora knows this about her. Whenever she asked her that question before, it was always as a prompt so Catra could move seats and get comfortable before Adora got the car going.

"Alright. I got the car serviced two months ago," Adora assures her, squeezing her close one final time before she finally releases Catra. Catra just nods vaguely and then turns to climb over the center console, plopping down heavily in the passenger seat. Adora isn't as agile as her. She unlocks the side door and walks around to the driver's side instead as Catra sets to fixing her clothes. They don't need to look great when they are just going back to Adora's, but she has to redo her fly and button up her shirt at least some.

Adora has a small smile on her face as she drops down into her seat and turns on the car. Catra can see Adora watching her for a long moment out of the corner of her eye, but she refuses to acknowledge the look despite how it makes her blush, continuing to do up her buttons instead. Eventually, Adora reaches for the stick shift and puts the car into drive. Catra breathes a bit easier as they pull out of the driveway, passing all the cars parked along the sides of the street and leaving behind the party. As much as she has been telling herself to keep Adora at arm's length, she is looking forward to falling asleep in her arms again tonight.

Chapter End Notes

I adore Scorpia, but pursuing someone uninterested in you isn't good or healthy. I've tweaked their situation from canon some for this AU (mostly with the hooking up thing, because Scorpia did try to ask Catra out and got jealous over Adora in the show too), but it's an uncomfortable situation to put someone else in regardless of who is doing it. Of course it's messy because you hurt when your feelings aren't returned, but someone else not feeling the same way isn't their fault, so I've been wanting to explore the messiness of that situation for a long time (this is, after all, an AU I've been sitting on for like 9-10 months). Scorpia will get her own happiness in due time, but she has to learn to let Catra go first.

The Morning After

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the messiest AU ever conceived.

Adora texts Perfuma after they arrive back to her house, apologizing for the scene and letting her know that she and Catra left early. She doesn't get a text back, but she doesn't really expect one. She sent the message to let Perfuma know they're gone as much as she sent it so someone at the party knows Catra made it home – not to the place she has been living, but *home* – safely. If Adora were Scorpia and Catra had stormed out on her like that, she wouldn't rest until she found her again or at least knew she was safe.

Catra wilts on the drive home, clearly tired and spent. Her ears twitch with interest as they pull into Adora's driveway, but though her eyes dart around the house while the garage door opens, she doesn't make the effort of moving her head. Adora parks without speaking. She isn't going to overwhelm Catra tonight. She is a little worried that she shouldn't have gone along with things and had sex in the back seat. Her desire for Catra won out, but she really doesn't want to ruin things again or take advantage of her.

Adora knows Catra, though, and she was the kind of volatile that required defusing. More damage would have been done if Adora refused. Catra wouldn't have been mad at her in the long run, but she might have done something that she would regret more than the hookup. Adora cautiously takes Catra's hand when they step out of the car, leading her into the house and to the kitchen. Catra leans up against the counter, eyeing Adora's space as Adora gets them both water. Catra didn't ask for it, but she must need it after sex like that.

The first sound Catra makes is a small, muffled squeak when they step into the bedroom and she spots her painting hanging up on the wall opposite from Adora's bed. Adora shrugs, sending her a sheepish look, but Catra seems even more embarrassed than her, crossing her arms and quickly looking away as her cheeks blaze. Her tail is lashing behind her, her fur a little fluffed up from her fluster. It's adorable, but Adora knows better than to point that out on a good day.

Catra accepts a borrowed pair of pajamas from Adora's closet. Despite what they just did, they both turn away from each other to change. Adora doesn't actually wear pajamas to bed anymore, preferring to sleep naked now that she lives alone, but she isn't alone tonight, and she has plenty of comfortable loungewear she can use. It's worth it when she lifts the sheets and Catra crawls in after her, wrapping around her back and latching on like someone might try to take Adora from her. It makes Adora's breath catch.

They have cuddled tightly like this since they were small children, but Adora wasn't expecting to experience it again so soon after reconnecting. And yet here Catra is, rubbing

her face between Adora's shoulder blades like she used to when she was truly contented. Her tail thumps with satisfaction as a happy purr begins to fill the room. Adora feels a bit like her heart might burst, pure joy warming her chest as she relaxes into the pillow and hums softly.

She doesn't need her white noise machine tonight. She has the real thing.

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Catra wakes to the steadily escalating and deescalating tones of Adora's rolling alarm. It isn't blaring – it is the same wake up alarm that Adora has always used, designed to be effective at waking up hybrids without shrieking their ears off – but Catra growls a little as she buries her face deeper into the warmth and heat surrounding her, pinning her ears back to try to block out the sound. Her warm cocoon shifts, trying to *pull away* from her. Absolutely not. Catra growls, clinging on tighter. The chest beneath her chuckles as a soft beep signals that the snooze has been hit.

"I have to get ready for work," Adora points out, her words vibrating through her chest, which Catra is currently tucked against. She swears she went to sleep as the big spoon, but now she has her face buried in Adora's chest and is wrapped tightly around her. If Adora teases her about this, she is going to insist this is just because she wanted to bury in her tits. They are a great pillow. Catra growls again, more half-hearted this time. Adora is right – she can't stay, and Catra shouldn't even be asking her to.

With a reluctant sigh, Catra lets her go, turning over to bury her face in the pillow instead. Behind her, Adora doesn't get up, instead shuffling closer and wrapping an arm around Catra's waist to squeeze her close for a moment more. As she does so, she drops a soft kiss to Catra's shoulder. Catra feels her cheeks heat immediately. The thin layer of her borrowed t-shirt does little to dampen Adora's body heat against her. Fuck, she absolutely shouldn't be letting Adora kiss her so casually like this.

Has she walked right back into a Scorpia situation, Adora thinking their relationship rekindling is inevitable now they have slept together? How badly Catra wants Adora doesn't magically fix their issues. She isn't going to get them both hurt all over again by rushing into something neither of them is ready for – except she kind of *did* do that last night, at least if Adora isn't on the same page as her. Around her waist, the arm shifts as Adora slides back to rest her hand on Catra's hip and squeeze gently. Catra realizes her body has tensed up, her tail twitching anxiously on Adora's bed.

"Hey, it's okay. I've got it, that's too much. I just need you to tell what you're comfortable with. I didn't know if you would ever be ready for something like last night again, and we've already proven that I can't read your mind," Adora tells her, voice gentle and encouraging. Catra blows out a slow breath. Adora has a fair point. She has been extraordinarily well-behaved, never pushing Catra too far, but she can't know what too far is if Catra won't tell her. The big problem is Catra doesn't really know what is too far either.

When Adora first reached out to her, she didn't think she was even going to allow sessions, but then Adora dropped the bomb about flunking out on her and she decided to give her a chance. The professional relationship felt so good, Catra didn't really question it once it started. They have gone barreling through several stages past professional now. Catra made Adora promise to be honest with her. She hasn't lied to Adora, but she hasn't been as open with her in turn. If they are ever going to trust each other again, this has to be a two-way street. Catra sighs.

"Give me some time to think. You want another session this weekend? We could talk then," Catra tells her, feeling her tail thump once against the mattress, unsure. Adora has been booking every week and it will give them something to do if Catra can't handle the idea of hanging out like *friends* or something by the time they are done with their talk, but it feels weird to be the one proposing this – especially given how much a session with her costs. Fuck, she hasn't really been considering that at all.

The idea of Adora paying her feels weird now that they have slept together. Now that she thinks about it, Adora did mention that their sessions were going to have to get more infrequent the last time they were planning. Clearly Adora can afford a house, and a pretty nice one at that, but her inheritance wasn't that much and it must have run out by now. Can she really afford to suddenly be spending hundreds a month? At her back, Adora hums and squeezes her hip.

"Gladly," Adora promises her. Catra still has some doubts to have a crisis over later, but she gives a quiet, involuntary trill at the words, her cheeks blazing as she turns to quickly rub her face into the pillow just to hide her reaction.

Adora's snooze goes off for the second time before Catra has to chance to say anything more.

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Catra pokes around Adora's bedroom while she is getting ready in the bathroom, and then she prowls around the house while Adora fixes them breakfast. She is silent as she does so, but the house has a fairly open floor plan and Adora can see glimpses of her as she slowly explores and familiarizes herself with Adora's new place. It gives Adora hope. The fact that she is assessing the space and mapping it in her head likely means Catra is, on some level, planning to be in it again. She only returns to the kitchen when Adora calls that breakfast is ready.

They eat quickly. Adora is running a bit late for work as it is and she still needs to drop Catra off. Catra checks the Bright Moon metro app as they get in the car, finding a bus stop near Adora's work that is about halfway to her place – which is apparently a townhouse in the old and neglected part of the city. Adora drives them to the bus stop in the same relative silence that surrounded them as they arrived home last night and got ready this morning. It isn't an uncomfortable silence, even if it is a weighty one. Catra is clearly thinking. She is probably going home to a mess, after all.

She is wearing her clothes from last night, though she borrowed a sweater. Adora wasn't about to leave Catra to stand shivering at the bus stop without one. Her suspenders are slung around her hips now, the collar of her button down peeking out from the neck of the sweater. She looks like a college professor stumbling into her lecture hungover from the night before. She is so cute that Adora wants to wrap her up in her arms and pepper her face in kisses, but she already got pretty clear instructions that kisses were off the table.

"Focus on the road, idiot," Catra mutters. Adora quickly tears her eyes from Catra's pink cheeks. She is stopped at a light, but Catra has a point. Adora is an extremely conscientious driver mostly because Catra had periods of anxiety around cars growing up – she unfortunately remembers flashes of the accident that took her parents' lives – so Adora always keeps her eyes on the road while driving, trying to be the best driver she can to help assuage her fears. Adora is still a good driver, but she has started to let her focus wander a bit more while parked in the last few years.

She focuses this morning. This is important. Catra has enough to worry about without having her anxiety run up by Adora's driving. Adora was always proud of how comfortable Catra was in Swift Wind. Back then, Adora thought of it as *their* car, even if Catra always called her a dork for naming it. Over the five years of silence, it has definitely become just her car – it used to be her mother's, after all – but she always wants Catra to be comfortable in it. She is hopeful this is the first of many morning afters, even if what the mornings are *after* is just cuddling and falling asleep in each other's arms like they did growing up.

She parks outside of a gas station down the street from the bus stop so Catra doesn't have to worry about getting out on the sidewalk. She waits until she has the parking brake on before she looks up to Catra again. Catra is turned to look out the window, but her tail is twitching on the seat beside her. Despite her act, Adora knows that Catra was watching her out of the corner of her eye. She pauses, wondering what she should say for a long moment.

"If things get too awkward with your roommate and you need somewhere to lie low, you can come to my house. I won't push you to talk about anything until you're ready. I'm just here if you need anything," Adora tells her, cautiously reaching out to place her hand on Catra's leg. On the seat, Catra's tail upgrades from twitching to thumping as she hunches her shoulders a little, but she seems more embarrassed than anything else. Biting her lip, Adora quickly withdraws her hand. After a moment more of hunching, Catra awkwardly clears her throat and turns back to face her. Her cheeks are red.

"I want to take space to think, but if I need to, I'll call you," Catra tells her. Adora blows out a breath and smiles hopefully to her. Catra's answering smile is small, but she returns it. Well, she returns it until her eyes zero in on something over Adora's shoulder and go wide. "Bye!" she rushes out, turning and flinging herself from the car. Adora blinks in shock, watching Catra sprint around the hood of the car and take off down the street.

Ah. The bus is pulling up at the stop. Adora allows herself several long moments of watching Catra's tail wave in the wind behind her as she sprints like a madwoman to catch it. She makes it, flinging herself up the steps just after the last person who was waiting at the stop gets on. Adora smiles to herself as she puts her car back in drive. It doesn't matter how much time has passed – Catra is always going to be adorable.

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Catra returns to an empty house. She can't decide if she is relieved or not. She knew Entrapta would be at work, but Scorpia doesn't work consistent hours over at her mothers' tea shop, so she really had no idea if Scorpia would be working today. Either it's a half shift and she'll be back after lunch, or it's a full shift and she will be gone all day. The latter would mean that Entrapta would be back by the time Scorpia gets home, but their roommate isn't much of a mediator, and Catra kind of wants to just get this over with.

Catra doesn't even know if there is going to be a confrontation. She made her point last night, and she isn't eager to belabor the point if Scorpia is willing to let it – *her* – go. Catra just wants them both to move on with their lives, but they live together and this is sure to be awkward. Part of her – the part that always goes worst-case scenario – warns that Scorpia could even want her to move out due to the awkwardness or anger. Emotions are messy. It would be nice if they weren't, but Catra would be married and settled down with her high school sweetheart if that were the case.

Scorpia could be mad at Catra for doing something well within her rights to. It was harsh, but Scorpia kind of deserved it. Catra just wants her to get home so she can gauge where they stand. She isn't about to apologize for fucking Adora – that was the best sex she has had in a long time – but they need to talk about it in some capacity. Catra doesn't want to deal with Scorpia being jealous like that again. At some point they are going to have to address the tangled mass of thorns that resulted from their ill-advised relationship.

The idea of waiting until evening to find out how upset Scorpia is gives Catra anxiety. She doesn't know how much Entrapta knows either and, if Scorpia is upset, if that has upset Entrapta in turn. Catra wasn't there to defend herself last night. Catra logically knows that Scorpia isn't the type to spin a situation to create a victim narrative for herself, but she is also paranoid from years of childhood abuse. Even worse, Scorpia could actually think Catra did something wrong and believe herself justified to paint her as the villain to their roommate.

By noon, Catra resigns herself to a miserable day of waiting. She is just glad that she doesn't have any appointments booked right now. She has the odd appointment that is booked weeks in advance, but right now she has nothing on the schedule for this week except for her tentative appointment with Adora this weekend. She compulsively cleans her room, packing things away just a little as she does so – she can't help it, she has to be cautious – and she goes for two separate runs around the block just trying to burn off her nervous energy.

Catra is curled up in a ball at the head of her bed, her face smashed into her pillows and her mind a jumbled mess as she thinks about how nice it was to wake up with Adora and how conflicted that makes her feel, when she hears the front door open. Catra's ears twitch as she listens to the unmistakable sound of Scorpia shuffling inside and pausing in the kitchen. She has to be noticing Catra's keys on the hook. She knows that Catra is home now, but Scorpia continues on past her door to head to her room.

Catra waits, her ears straining as she listens to the sounds of Scorpia moving around in her room for a bit before getting in the shower. Maybe she isn't mad then? She didn't come straight over, so the part of Catra's mind that she always knew was ridiculous for even worrying about it quiets down about the possibility of her getting kicked out. Scorpia isn't fine, though. Catra doesn't know how upset she is, but she isn't singing in the shower. She doesn't always do that, but usually she at least hums. Today she is silent.

Catra sits up in her bed, frowning as Scorpia gets out of the shower and heads to her room. She moves around for a bit, likely getting dressed and getting comfortable, but then things fall silent again. Great, so she is avoiding her then. Maybe just temporarily, but it's avoidance nonetheless. Catra can't keep waiting. She just needs to know where they stand. She forces herself to get out of bed, slipping out of her door and walking to Scorpia's room.

If Catra wasn't worried a confrontation was still coming, just later on tonight, she would leave things be. As it is, she can't take the limbo. She knocks. Scorpia jumps in her chair, the chair legs squeaking a little on the laminate wood floor. Catra holds her breath, waiting. Eventually, she hears Scorpia stand and cross the room. She walks to the door slowly. Catra silently backs away from the door, leaning against the opposite wall in the hall to wait.

When Scorpia opens the door, she is visibly anxious. She practically winces as she looks at Catra. For a long moment, they just stare at each other. Eventually it becomes clear that Scorpia isn't speaking first. Catra doesn't know what she expects her to say. She doesn't know if the flinch was from guilt or personal hurt. She sighs, wrapping her arms around herself. She hates how fucking anxious she is. All she did was exactly what she always told Scorpia she was going to do – hook up non-exclusively.

"I tried to let you down gently for years. I didn't want to break your heart, but that the jealousy stuff last night felt like shit-" she cuts off when Scorpia flinches. That isn't going to help. It isn't talking about it, not really. Trying to make Scorpia understand why Catra did what she did is the exact shit that Adora pulled on the breakup call. It only drove them further apart. It made Catra feel like she was continuing to dismiss everything that she felt. She swallows, looking away.

"I know things are going to be rough between us for a while. But I always valued you as a friend, and I still want to be that to you," Catra tells her instead. It's the kind of thing she should have said to Adora five years ago. She would have quickly realized that Adora really did still love her if Catra gave her the chance to show it, but the idea of seeing her or having her in her life at all after Catra felt so discarded already was too painful to even consider.

It wasn't Catra's fault she was in love with Adora and desperately needed reassurance. She never would have said this a month ago, but it wasn't Adora's fault that she couldn't give Catra enough while they were long distance to make her feel like her feelings were returned. Similarly, it isn't Scorpia's fault that she fell for Catra. It only starts being her fault if she acts jealously, whether because of spite or as part of a genuine attempt to get them to be together. Last night felt like they were beginning to go down that road.

Maybe Scorpia didn't think about the implications of her jealous behavior last night, but they were there. It made Catra uncomfortable even before Adora showed up. She probably would have put her foot down and slipped away into the crowd in the next few minutes if things

hadn't come to a boiling point at the sound of Adora's name. Catra was standing up for herself last night as much as she was being reactionary. She chances a glance back at Scorpia. She looks largely dejected.

"If Adora hadn't shown up, would you have-" Scorpia starts to ask, her voice a bit desperate, but she cuts off when a growl rises in Catra's chest. Catra doesn't mean to do it, but she can't hold it down. This doesn't have fucking anything to do with Adora. Her tail lashes as she resists the urge to glare at Scorpia.

"This isn't about Adora. This is about you and me. I wanted to be your friend, Scorpia. Adora has only been back in my life for weeks, but we haven't kissed in years," Catra returns. She manages not to sound angry despite her bluntness. Silence stretches between them following the statement. Catra kind of just wants to go back to her room if talking isn't an option. With a sigh, she unfolds her arms and shoves off the wall. Finally, Scorpia reacts, her pincer raising in a clear *wait* gesture.

"I ended up talking with Perfuma a lot last night. The host. She's really, like, smart and in-touch. She, um, talked me through a lot of stuff about letting go. I'm gonna work on that. She said something about it being the only thing fair to both of us," Scorpia manages. It isn't an apology, but it is an acknowledgement at least. Catra nods stiffly. Yeah, that really is the only thing that can help them both. Catra rolls her shoulders, awkward and unsure what to say now.

"I'll give you space," she settles on saying. It's a promise as much as it is a goodbye. Scorpia just nods awkwardly. Released, Catra flees back to her room. It sucks that she considers that to be that conversation going *well* – no one cried or has to find a new place to live, at least – but now she is going to faceplant into her bed and spend the rest of the afternoon obsessing over this awkward situation she has managed to stumble into with Adora.

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Adora worries about Catra while she is at work. She doesn't know what Catra's roommates do or if they are even home right now. Adora tries not to worry as she gets home and busies herself with cooking dinner – all the concern is making her hungry – but it doesn't work very well. She isn't going to sleep tonight if Catra doesn't text her before then. With a sigh, she decides that it isn't overbearing to text your ex, sorta-dom, sorta-friend to make sure they haven't been kicked out of their house. She waits until she has dinner in the oven, and then she fires off a cautious check-in text.

She wanders out to her sunroom as she waits for a reply, settling on the ridiculously comfy outdoor bench she has there. She spent awhile bouncing between crappy apartments and only settled into this house a year ago, but when she saw its photos, she immediately fell in love with the sunroom. She told herself it would just be a cool place to work out in, but she knew the truth: even with four years stretching between them, she couldn't help but think about how she always wanted a room like this for Catra.

Catra wasn't in her life anymore. The closest to her that Adora could be was choosing the house with a room that reminded her of Catra. Adora sighs as she switches apps on her phone to set a timer for when her food will be ready. There is a chance that she will get to see Catra stretch out for a nap on this bench now, she just doesn't know what the odds are. She is shocked when she switches back to her messages and sees that Catra is typing already.

Just wanted to check in and make sure things were okay.

I promise not to be nosy after I check that you still have a pulse.

Scorpia doesn't even kill spiders.

She puts a little cup over them and takes them outside before I can squash them.

Adora smiles a little looking at the messages. Catra is alright. She would probably have opened with it if she got into a huge fight. Adora wants to ask for details, but she knows better than to pry, and she promised this morning not to ask questions. Best to keep things light and see how much Catra is up to talking.

Waste of all that muscle. She would make a great bug-killer.

Those guns are for carrying ceramics, but nice to know you were eyeing my roommate.

All I want is her workout routine, scout's honor.

Well you're in luck. I usually go with her but I'm flying solo now.

She's taking space to get over me and I hate counting my own reps.

I don't think my gym allows guests, though. Does yours?

Adora stares down at her phone screen, a little shocked. She can't believe Catra is suggesting they go to the gym together. They have had the sessions, sure, but they haven't actually hung out once since reuniting. Catra said she wasn't ready before. Just this morning she said she wants space to think. This offer seems counterintuitive to that, but it gives Adora hope. Her heart feels a bit lighter as she taps her reply.

I can only have one a month or something.

We have day passes though. I can get you one.

I'd love to work out with you. Just don't make me do pilates.

That wasn't even advanced stuff. Got to increase your flexibility somehow.

We can talk about gyms this weekend. My availability is open for a session whenever.

Friday night? My friends are probably gonna drag me out Saturday or Sunday.

She doesn't get another text. After an offer like that, she wasn't expecting more anyway. An email pops up with a booking notification for seven on Friday to signal the end of the conversation instead.

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Catra spends the week in disarray. She doesn't get a booking – well, not a real one, she gets two of the usual emails that clearly aren't interested in actually hiring her and just wanting her to reply with some wank-fuel – so she has plenty of time to lie around and think. She goes to the gym alone twice, spending only half the amount of time there that she normally would. She likes to stay in shape, but she doesn't like working out alone. She checks her gym's guest policy – they don't allow them – but doing that just reminds her of the Adora question.

The week is hard because things are awkward between her and her roommate, but also because Catra spends half of it thinking about Adora and half of it trying to think about anything but her. Catra doesn't know that she was ever mad at Adora, but she was certainly hurt by her. It eased over time, especially as Catra began to accept that it was possible Adora did care the same way and just couldn't show it. Reconnecting finally proved that to her, but it still doesn't mean they can just pick up again and have it work now.

Catra isn't ready to trust Adora with her heart again, but fuck does she want to be friends. She wasn't sure about even that when she first reunited with Adora, but after a month of Adora being true to her word and a tentative bond reforming between them, Catra wants their friendship back desperately, and she thinks they could at least make that work.

There was a familiarity to riding home in Swift Wind that she didn't realize she missed until she got a taste of it again. Even Adora's house felt familiar in a way. It was soaked in Adora's scent and her personal touches. That's not to mention the sex, which was the best that Catra has had since- well, since the last time she and Adora had sex. Everything about Sunday night just felt *right*. As Catra spends the week awkwardly passing Scorpia in the hall, she wishes she was waking up with Adora's arms wrapped around her again.

Catra spends Wednesday night lounging around in the living room with Entrapta as they watch *Etherian Makers* together, but despite normally finding the creative process of

inventors inspiring when it comes to her own art, Catra can't focus. She is thinking about how she and Adora would spend the summers cuddling as they channel surfed on their thrifted tube TV.

She just misses Adora and wants her back. She has been trying to deny it for weeks. Well, no, even she can't lie to herself that much, but she has been trying to convince herself that a loose friendship, not letting Adora in again enough to hurt her, would be enough. It would never be enough. Nothing Adora gave her ever was, how could Catra settle for barely speaking with her? She spent all of the last week looking forward to their session. Their sessions are another factor in her crisis of what they are and what she is ready for them to be.

The fact is that Catra isn't ready for a relationship. She wants love desperately, but Adora is fucking important to her. After Sunday night, she can't pretend that she doesn't know that the last thing she wants is to lose Adora again, but she wants them to find their footing before addressing the question of romance. She needs to be friends with Adora – actually friends, not just two estranged lovers who fall into comfortable banter when they meet – before she can assess if they could be together again.

Catra knows that, logically, that means they should stop the sessions. The problem is she doesn't want to do that in the slightest. The hookup felt good. She doesn't want to give up a piece of what they used to have now that she has experienced it again. She can justify it to herself a number of ways – she has already proven she has no problem having sex with friends, domming is just her job, getting intimate with Adora while only expecting friendship helps her assess how they would work without breaking her heart – but the truth is she just wants it.

She wants to keep domming Adora. She wants to keep fucking her. She has never experienced mixing the two with anybody before, but she would like to, and she would like to do it with Adora. On top of all that, she sits down and actually does the math on how much Adora has paid her since they reconnected. The number makes her instantly uncomfortable. First bookings are discounted, and when she took payment that day, it kind of felt good. It was enforcing distance between them, making their relationship transactional.

Catra didn't think about it in the previous session, just used to the routine of how they go and desensitized to her own prices. She stands by them, but there is a difference between charging what her specialized skillset is worth and Adora paying hundreds to spend time with her. Transactional worked for her on that first day, but she doesn't want that now. Catra doesn't want Adora to be any part of her financial support. She has been doing just fine on her own and she doesn't need to add her own hurt pride to their list of problems.

Moreover, if hooking up was more than a one-time thing – and fuck does she *want* it to be – she doesn't want to accept a cent from Adora while they are doing that. Catra is well aware that sex workers are a vital part of her industry, but she isn't one of them personally, and more than just her personal discomfort, there are legal ramifications to her being seen as one. She isn't sure about even accepting payment for their session this coming weekend, and if Adora isn't paying her for it anymore, then either they need to stop, or a lot needs to change.

As she gets dressed for their session Friday night, Catra selects one of her more casual outfits of black leggings and a skintight black sweater. She has worn this outfit to the store before

without raising eyebrows. It is tight, but it's a casual outfit to take the pressure off during the conversation that they need to have before they can play. Catra has a *proposal* for Adora and she needs her to be able to focus on it and think clearly.

Part of Catra is worried that Adora won't be able to accept it if they start down this path only for Catra to later decide that they won't ever work as a couple and should always remain as just friends. She can't walk back into another Scorpia situation, but Catra has at least learned a few things since their breakup, and she will give Adora a chance to speak for herself while they are both level-headed this time.

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Adora checked her phone an inordinate amount throughout the week, but Catra never texted her again. Not that Adora expected her to after it seemed like she and her roommate managed to reach an uneasy peace, but she was kind of hopeful that Catra would text her just *because* and not only because she needed somewhere to stay. Still, she isn't surprised that she doesn't hear anything. She heads to Catra's studio on Friday night buzzing with nervous energy. Adora never texted Catra a proposal for this session, unsure if she *should* since Catra was the one who asked for it, and she really has no idea what to expect.

The Catra that answers the door is a different one than Adora has seen at her previous sessions. She doesn't have the easy confidence about her that drives Adora wild. She doesn't seem nervous, but- actually, no, she is incredibly nervous, she just is trying to hide it. Catra's tail twitches tensely behind her as she offers Adora a smile that is a touch performative and steps aside to let her in. Adora's heart beats like a hammer in her chest as she offers Catra a smile back that she knows is probably too hopeful, but Catra's nerves make her anxious too.

Catra picks up on it. After closing and locking the studio door behind them like usual, she shocks Adora by walking up to her side and hesitating for a long moment before she carefully looks away. Eyes focused on the couch in the corner, she reaches out and blindly takes Adora's hand in her own. Adora draws in a short breath, her fingers spasming in Catra's own, and finds herself quickly cut off by Catra clearing her throat and starting forward, practically dragging Adora to the couch with her.

No words have to be passed between them for Adora to understand that Catra is anxious but doesn't want that anxiety to pass on to Adora and make this conversation even harder than it has to be. Adora lets herself be pulled to the couch, settling on the cushion at Catra's silent direction. Catra sits beside her, a few inches between them. It isn't a yawning chasm, but Catra drops her hand as she sits, biting her lip and looking out into the studio. Adora hesitates, unsure if she should speak first.

Catra clearly has something she is building herself up to, though, and Adora doesn't want to interrupt any internal momentum towards saying it she has built up. She tries to sit there nonjudgmentally, offering Catra an encouraging smile when she glances to Adora. Catra's cheeks instantly flush and she looks away again, her tail thudding against the couch cushion.

After a long moment, she draws in a deep breath and forces herself to make eye contact with Adora again.

“I want to try to be friends - like we were in high school. I’m not ready for more again. I just don’t trust that it will work out, but I want to… spend time with you and stuff,” Catra offers. Adora blinks at her, a bit surprised. She didn’t know what to expect, but given how anxious Catra was, it wasn’t for her to offer Adora exactly what she was hoping for. Adora may desperately *want* to date Catra again, but her priority is them being a happy part of each other’s lives going forward. Catra is right that rushing into things again risks them crashing and burning.

“Okay. I think that’s probably the best thing for us,” Adora agrees. Catra’s ear twitches as she looks at Adora for a long moment. Adora is fairly certain she is scanning her for deception. Adora isn’t lying, but Catra’s proposition does bring up another question. “What, uh, does that mean for the sessions?” Adora asks. Catra invited her over on the pretext of having one, but that seems to be at odds with her statement. If she changed her mind during the week, that would explain her nerves now. Catra’s cheeks blaze and her tail thuds on the cushion, but she doesn’t break eye contact.

“I had a lot of fun on Sunday. I’m okay with continuing to do things with you as long as you aren’t expecting a relationship to magically form out of it. I can’t have another Scorpia situation, but obviously I don’t mind having sex with a friend. I have fun with you, and I’d like to explore more, especially things I wouldn’t normally do with a stranger,” Catra tells her, shrugging as if that can make her statement casual. Adora feels her cheeks heat. She is going to hang onto *I have fun with you* for a while.

The mention of sex – implying *actual* sex, not just sessions – also raises her blood pressure. Is Catra just saying that because of Sunday night, or is she implying that she would like something like that again as more than a one-time event? She apparently has been hooking up with her roommate up until now, so clearly Catra wants to be having sex in some degree. Is she implying she would like to do that with Adora now? Catra’s gaze finally darts away, fixing on her rack of crops instead of looking at Adora.

“I need you to be *sure* you’re okay with that, though. I know you enjoy BDSM, but if you’re going to spend every time we’re together thinking that this is the day where I finally decide to settle down with you, then I can’t do that. I really need to just be friends right now,” she adds, her voice a bit forceful, though the projected confidence is thin. Adora opens her mouth, but she closes it again when Catra’s gaze instantly snaps to her, her gaze burning as they lock eyes.

“Shut up and think about it for a second, Adora. Are you really okay with doing this just as friends? It’s going to be more comfortable than the last few weeks, probably, but the feelings are going to be more intense too,” Catra tells her. Adora closes her mouth, blinking at Catra for a long moment. Her gut instinct is yes, absolutely, but Catra’s expression is intense. Given the shitshow of Sunday night, Adora doesn’t blame her for needing to be certain. She owes it to Catra to think twice about it.

She imagines a scenario, five years down the line, where they are still just friends. They are comfortable like they had been in high school, each of them the most important person in the

other's life, but they still aren't together. Adora knows exactly what Catra tastes like, but she isn't allowed to experience it again. Despite hanging out, goofing off, and being there for each other, the closest they come to dating is when Adora drops to her knees for Catra, giving herself over in the vulnerable way that she always wanted to in a relationship.

Adora doesn't know how much of a difference there is between that and them truly dating. There would be obvious things missing – things that Adora craved in the five years apart and still does – but they would have a lot together. She would be happy with that. She would be a lot happier than she was during their breakup. At times, yes, she would wish they could be more again, but she would be doing that whether or not Catra was domming her.

They could be mere acquaintances or having sex together and Adora would still wish to hold Catra's hand and be her one and only. Adora draws in a deep breath and breaks eye contact. It isn't for her sake. She wants Catra to have privacy as she speaks, no pressure to school her expression as Adora finally barrels into the one thing they have danced around entirely. They have talked about breaking up and being together and *feelings*, but these words they have carefully avoided saying.

"I still love you, Catra. I won't lie that I don't want you back, but I do think we should be friends first, and if it looks like getting back together would be unhealthy for us in the long run, then I don't want to do it and lose you. I won't be hoping for you to change your mind, not if I know what to expect as a possibility for us," Adora tells her. Catra twitches in her periphery, but Adora manages to resist the urge to look at her. She draws in a steadying breath, giving that a moment to sink in before she continues.

"My feelings will exist whether or not you're domming me. Any level of intimacy you're comfortable with is one less layer for me to miss. I honestly think our friendship will be happier if we're doing BDSM than if we weren't. It lets us explore some of that stuff we're missing in a controlled way. At least for right now, I want to keep going with it. If we decide a relationship down the road wouldn't be good for us, maybe we should reassess that, but right now I like what we're doing," Adora adds.

There is the added wrinkle of the fact that Adora really can't afford to keep going at this pace, but that is a separate issue and she isn't bringing it up until they decide how they feel. Adora wasn't actually going to book a session this weekend. It would have just been too irresponsible given her finances, but then Sunday happened and Catra offered it as a time to talk. Adora couldn't say no then. She isn't in danger of not making rent or anything, she just definitely can't book again until the end of the month.

She is kind of worried about getting worked up in the meantime, like BDSM withdrawal or something, but her priority at the moment is her and Catra's relationship. She really wants to look at Catra and get any indication of what she is thinking, but she keeps her gaze fixed away. She knows that admission of so much emotion is putting Catra on the spot. She will wait until Catra is ready to speak. A few seconds pass by before Catra finally shifts in her periphery.

"What about jealousy?" Catra asks. That startles Adora a little. She turns to blink at Catra. Her face is schooled into an attempt at a carefully blank expression and her voice gives nothing away, but Adora can see a sparkling of emotion in her eyes and her tail is twitching

by her side. For a moment, she just blinks at her, unsure of where the question came from or what kind of jealousy she means, but if Catra is really worried about another Scorpia situation, Adora can guess.

“Clients don’t bother me if it’s just work. It’s not like getting to be friends outside of sessions will make me more jealous. Just, um, tell me when you start hooking up with someone again, please? Even if it’s just platonic, I may have jealousy issues if I’m surprised by it,” Adora returns. She knows she was a bit jealous at the party, but it was over the idea of Catra actually dating someone else specifically. That jealousy might actually be lessened if she is also getting to be intimate with Catra.

Catra’s eyes spark a bit and then a small smile quirks at the corner of her lips before she rolls her eyes. Adora feels her heart skip at the downright playful expression spreading across her face as she turns towards Adora and then practically *prowls* closer to her. Adora flushes and absolutely *doesn’t* squeak as Catra settles on the cushion beside her, raising up on her knees so she can grin down at Adora. In an instant, things have turned from serious to heart pounding in a very different way.

“I can’t believe I forgot what an idiot you are,” Catra tells her, and then she raises her leg and swings it over Adora’s lap, settling to straddle over Adora’s thighs. Adora can’t deny that she squeaks now as Catra rolls her eyes almost fondly. When she is done, her gaze settles on Adora’s face again, clearly enjoying the mess she has made of Adora in just a few movements. Adora would defend herself but she doesn’t actually know what she *did* to earn that comment.

“I mentioned sex, Adora – as in I want to know if you are comfortable hooking up with *me*. I like domming you, I’m comfortable with you in general, and I had a lot of fun Sunday night. There is a lot of BDSM I’ve never gotten to explore because it involves sex. That’s why I need you to be certain you’re comfortable with this and not going to get jealous,” Catra explains. Adora’s brain short-circuits.

She- she *thought* Catra was implying something about sex back at the beginning, but the thought left her mind quickly. Apparently it should have stayed. Adora gapes up at her. Without really thinking about it, she raises her hands and places them on Catra’s hips, squeezing as her heart pounds in her chest. Every inch of her body is saying *yes, yes, yes*. She swallows, flexing her hands absently as she tries to get her train of thought back on the tracks so she can speak again.

“I, uh, want that. Definitely. And it wouldn’t make things harder for me. Fuck, I miss you,” Adora returns. She breaks, leaning forward to rest her forehead on Catra’s chest and nuzzle into her. It’s a shame she is wearing a turtleneck today. She looks hot as hell in it, the shift of her muscles visible through the tight fabric, but Adora would love to breathe in the comfort of her fur. She still gets a comforting sensation though – Catra purrs with amusement and reaches up to lightly stroke her hand down the back of Adora’s head.

“Good girl. There are going to be rules to it, but I think we’ve done enough talking today. You seem like you need release, princess,” Catra tells her, her hand shifting to rest on the back of Adora’s neck and squeezing. Adora resists the urge to whine. She doesn’t know how she is supposed to think about anything ever again except Catra domming her while having

sex. Fuck, how is that even going to work? It's going to destroy her *definitely*, but this place isn't exactly built for real sex. It also takes them back to the other topic they need to cover today.

"I, uh, can't schedule another session for a bit. I want that – I *really want that* – but I'm out of spending money at this point. I just want you to know that this is going to be our last session for a while and I'm not avoiding booking because I'm uncomfortable or anything. You're worth the price. I'll be back after I get paid," Adora tells her, nuzzling a bit into her chest just because she can. She does want to make sure that she warns Catra in case she starts to fear that Adora is pulling away when she stops scheduling.

Catra rumbles an acknowledgement, apparently content to cuddle for the moment. Adora is happy to take the time to gather herself a bit. This is everything she wants. Well, not everything, but close to it. Her and Catra will start spending time together again, Catra will be coming to her for sex and not have to deal with roommates who can't take a hint, and Adora gets to explore even more of BDSM. The thought definitely isn't helping Adora gather herself, but she gets lost down a mental rabbit hole until Catra clears her throat above her.

"I told you in our first session that sex work has a shittier income tax. Some asshole in the revenue office might call it sex work if they find out that I'm sleeping with a client at the same time that they're hiring me and I can't afford the lawyer fees to prove them wrong. We'll have our session for free today and meet at your house from now on. No charges, just text me when you want me," Catra tells her. Adora's heart leaps out of her chest. She pulls back, staring up at Catra in awe.

Catra is flushed up to her ears, looking quickly away as her tail lashes to one side and then jumps again to the other. Her ears are pinned back, but she isn't *upset*. Adora has never seen her this flustered with her clothes on. Her cheeks are red as she raises both her hands and places them on Adora's shoulders, squeezing tightly. It's a warning not to say anything. Adora really wants to say *a lot*, but she isn't going to push Catra.

"Whenever I want? You're really going to come over six times a week?" Adora asks her instead. She is just kind of running her mouth, trying to ease Catra's concerns about things getting too emotional, but also to rile her up a little. It works – it *really* works. Catra squeaks, her tail fluffing up and lashing behind her. She shoves at Adora's shoulder as Adora grins up at her, more than satisfied with the reaction.

"Shut up, princess, or I just might change my mind about what we're doing for our session today," Catra returns. She is trying to slip back into her persona, but her cheeks are still blazing as her tail continues to sway excitedly behind her. Luckily for her, Adora isn't interested in calling her out on her bullshit – at least not when she offers her a distraction like *that*. Catra notices her reaction, grinning down at her.

"I have something special planned. I can bring crops and candles to your house, but there is something we can only do here that you haven't gotten to try yet, and it's on your list," Catra tells her. The easy confidence of her persona comes through now, her cockiness revived by Adora's reaction. The revelation that Catra has *plans* for them already has heat flushing beneath Adora's skin.

She doesn’t know what Catra’s plan is, but she knows she is damn excited to try it.

Friendship

Chapter Notes

As you can guess from the last chapter, there's BDSM in this one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora is already breathing heavily as Catra lifts her bound wrists and hooks them onto the crossbeam of the metal frame. The frame has been lingering in the corner for every session they have had so far. Catra had Adora help her pull it out. She sets it up herself, unfolding it and sliding thick heavy bolts to lock it in place. Adora got ridiculously turned on just watching Catra's muscles flex as she arranged it. It ended up being a box frame, standing somewhere around six feet.

Catra had her step in the middle and bound her wrists to suspend them above her head from the crossbeam. Two thick cuffs made out of leather cushion her wrists with a soft fabric lining. Catra clips the ring binding her wrists together onto a strap hanging from the crossbeam of the frame, adjusting the length of the thick strap so Adora can just barely stand flat on her feet. Adora tugs a little, cautious and experimental, but the frame doesn't budge. The frame seems to be sturdy despite its metal bolts.

"It's rated for three hundred pounds before you have to worry about it moving with you. You can squirm as much as you want, princess. You're staying put," Catra promises her, grinning a little as she steps closer, just an inch in front of Adora. Catra is right: for the first time since they have started their sessions, Adora is truly trapped and entirely at Catra's mercy. The previous times, Adora was under Catra's control because she chose to be. Of course she is still choosing this – Catra proposed it and Adora enthusiastically agreed – but there is a physical restriction keeping her in place and not just Catra's orders.

Adora is soaking just thinking about it. The restriction tugging at her wrists is driving her wild. She is so glad Catra thought about utilizing this frame before they switch to sessions at home. She is just shy of panting already, tugging at her wrists and finding no give. It's enough to send a jolt of excitement through her. Catra is grinning now, downright predatory as she sweeps past Adora towards the cabinet where she got the cuffs and prepped a few things.

She asked Adora to clear every item she pulled off the rack or out of the cabinet before they got started. Adora gave her clearance without hesitation for all but the whip. It is now settled on Catra's hip. When she saw Adora pausing, she asked if Adora would be okay with her having it and cracking it but never making contact with her skin. Adora agreed to that quickly. Catra seems fond of the whip, and if she promises not to hurt Adora with it, Adora has no problem with its presence. When Catra comes back from the cabinet, she stops behind Adora.

Adora could twist around to look at her, but that isn't the point of this. The point is for Catra to have Adora completely at her mercy, crops and paddles and feathers and claws all at her disposal. Adora is bound and has to take what Catra gives her. She took off her jacket and shirt before stepping into the frame, though she still has her sports bra and leggings covering her. The point wasn't to bare her, but rather to give Catra more room to work. Catra's claws in particular were at risk of damaging her clothes, and the soft press of her fur or the tickler would be less effective over them.

Behind her, Catra stands still, waiting. Adora doesn't know what she has. Catra said she would blindfold her, but if she preparing to do that, why is she just standing there? Adora has the distinct feeling that Catra is purposely waiting so the anticipation can build. Adora tugs at her wrists again, her breath catching when they don't give and Catra doesn't react. Adora squeezes her thighs together where she stands, stretched out and at Catra's mercy.

"Catra," she whines softly. She barely gets the word out before a black blur shoots passed her with a loud *crack*. Adora jumps where she stands, jarring her wrists a little when she comes back down. Her heart pounds in her chest as Catra flicks the whip back out of Adora's immediate line of sight. Fuck, okay, Adora gets why Catra likes it now. It's a power move and Adora is paying *attention*.

"We're in a scene, princess. You call me sir," Catra reminds her, a satisfied curl to her voice. The tone is enough to fuel the fire sparking beneath Adora's skin. She swallows, jerkily nodding her head. She got so caught up in their earlier conversation and the idea of them just getting to be friends again that she forgot that regardless, when they're in a scene, Catra isn't her friend – she is her dom, and she wants to be addressed as sir. Adora shudders a little at the thought. She really does love following Catra's orders.

"Yes, sir. I'll be good," Adora promises her, voice a bit breathless. She doesn't want to be punished today – hurt, yes, but she wants to be good for Catra, to *succeed*. The entire set up is that Catra is going to strike and tease her, but none of it is supposed to be punishment. Behind her, Catra purrs. Adora wants to turn to see her – she bets her tail is swaying with satisfaction and she wants to appreciate it – but she forces herself to hold still, to *be good*.

"Good girl. You just want to be good for me, don't you? To take everything I give you, every soft touch and painful sting?" Catra asks her, light fingertips resting on Adora's shoulder and tracing slowly down. On the word *painful* she slides her claws out. Sharp tips press into Adora's skin, not enough to cut, but enough to make her twitch. A spike of panic quickly turns to excitement.

Her skin tells her she is in danger, but blood play is only on her *Will* list – Adora really isn't sure about it overall – and Catra didn't ask her about it today. She will trail her claws along Adora's skin, maybe even dig in with them, but she won't hurt her with them, not really. Not in a way that Adora won't like. She blows out a slow breath, trying to gather herself enough to answer Catra's question.

"I want to be good for you. I want everything you give me," Adora returns, her voice trembling just a little with anticipation. Catra purrs and Adora relaxes a little. Her need isn't abated by the sound, but it soothes her as Catra pulls her hand away. A moment later, Catra reaches over her head, pulling the blindfold over Adora's face. Adora swallows as she closes

her eyes. As soon as the cool satin of the wide band settles in place, the intensity seems to kick up several notches.

Adora latches onto the rhythmic rolling of Catra's purr as an anchor. She draws in a sharp breath when Catra steps forward and presses her front against Adora's back, letting her feel the soft knit of Catra's top and the rumbling vibration of her gentle, low-level purr. A second later, Catra's fingertips trail featherlight over Adora's ribs, enough to have her muscles spasming in the ghost of a laugh at the almost ticklish sensation.

"I'm going to give you every sensation you can imagine, princess. You belong to me and I decide when and what you get to feel. Understand?" Catra asks her. Her tone is hard and confident, but there is a warmth to it – she is *smiling* as she speaks. Adora swears she can hear her tail swishing from side to side behind her, but the roll of her purr could be causing her to imagine other sounds. She nods eagerly, flexing her arms absently above her. Catra's purr only rises in volume.

"So *eager* for me. I can always smell how desperately you want me to dominate you, you know," Catra tells her, shifting to purr the words directly into Adora's ear. Adora flushes. She does know that, actually, even if it isn't usually on the top of her mind. She thinks she has a good handle on Catra's range of senses after growing up with her. Catra told her back when they were dating that she could always smell Adora getting turned on when they were making out anyway.

"Use your words if you need them," Catra adds, her voice softer as she bends her head and drops a light kiss to Adora's shoulder. She steps away before Adora can react, but it would probably just be with a pathetic whine anyway, so maybe that is for the best. Adora is flushed with heat and excitement, but she still somehow feels cold as Catra steps away. She especially misses the buzz of Catra's purr-

All thoughts about what she misses go flying out of her mind as the paddle comes stinging down onto her ass. Pain and excitement shoot through Adora as she jerks away from the hit instinctively and moves only a few inches, tethered in place by her wrists. Her heart pounds in her ears as she realizes that the tethering is only intensifying everything along with the blindfold. She has nowhere to go and no hope of seeing the hits coming. She won't even know if they *will* be hits. She swallows thickly in the midst of gasping to catch her breath.

This session is going to *ruin* her.

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The only downside to doing this in her studio is that Adora is largely clothed. Catra would love to see the heart shapes imprinted on her skin from the cutout in the center of the paddle, but she will just have to bring this paddle over to Adora's house for some scene in the future. The paddle isn't all she has at her disposal, and her focus isn't even on exploiting Adora's masochism today.

She wants to take Adora straight to subspace and play with her there. She doesn't anticipate it taking long and it doesn't seem to. Adora gasps out, whining and moaning and jerking away from hits, but she can't outrun the impacts when she is tethered in place. Adora goes limp with relief when Catra replaces the sting of the crop with the soft brush of her tail along Adora's flushed and sweating torso. Catra notices how she strains for her and starts interspersing warm hugs into the routine as well.

She didn't think of it until Adora seemed almost distressed by Catra stepping too far away, but it has never been something she would have done with one of her clients before, so of course it didn't occur to her. Catra happily snuggles up against Adora's chest and purrs for her as just one more sensation to add to the assortment she is running her though. It makes Adora shudder just like Catra's dragging claws did. They left raised lines on her skin, just firm enough without drawing blood to leave a temporary trace.

Catra has many tools at her disposal beyond just pain or the threat of it. She has a silk ribbon she dances along Adora's skin, a leather flogger she not only uses for striking but also to drag along her skin so Adora can feel the soft leather fringe, and a metal spreader bar she is temporarily repurposing so she can press the cool metal against Adora's reddened skin to play with temperature as well. It is as soothing on her skin as it is shocking in contrast and it makes Adora gasp.

Adora is soaking. Catra can actually see a damp spot on her leggings when Adora spreads her legs in her twisting and writhing, either trying to get closer to Catra or further away depending on what sensation she is delivering in the moment. Catra enjoys the sight of it as much as she likes the way Adora's arm muscles bulge as she strains at her restraints and gets nowhere. She has held still decently in the previous scenes that called for it, but Catra doesn't want her to try to restrain herself now.

This time, Adora is restrained enough physically that any effort to hold still would be pointless. Catra likes watching her struggle. She likes breathing in the heavy scent of her desire. Adora moans with every new sensation, giggling and whining when Catra dances her fingertips across her ribs, not quite tickling her but seeming to have the effect regardless. Adora is utterly lost in it, reacting to every brush of contact.

"Cat- sir. Please," Adora whimpers, rubbing her thighs together and arching her back to press her chest forward into Catra's touch. Catra smirks to herself, pulling her hands away and drinking in the whine Adora gives. It is a punishment, but a soft one. Adora almost lost herself and used Catra's name again, but she corrected. Not giving her what she wants is a soft reminder of who is in charge.

"I decide what you get, princess - unless you think you can beg prettily enough to change my mind," Catra reminds, a purr in Adora's ear as she sweeps her tail up along Adora's side to brush the softness against her skin. In her blind state, Adora's muscles give a small jump with the new touch as her brain scrambles with the signals it receives to figure out if it's a good thing or not. By the time the message reaches her brain, Catra has dropped her tail and left only air.

Adora strains towards something that is no longer there. She releases a quiet, almost disappointed moan. Catra grins and decides *fuck it*, ducking and biting at the join of Adora's

shoulder and neck. Adora instantly cries out, writhing and scrambling to keep her feet under her as her body twists on the axis of her hung wrists. Adora smells the kind of filthy and turned on at this point that makes Catra's mouth water.

Catra purrs as she digs her fangs in just a touch more before releasing her shoulder and shifting to rub her cheek against the spot instead, offering soothing softness in its place. Adora manages to straighten out where she stands, breathing in deeply. Her muscles are relaxing suspiciously fast. She might have just come. It's certainly a possibility given the worked-up state she is. Catra is ridiculously turned on herself, and that thought makes her twitch down on nothing. A possessive flare burns in her chest, satisfaction at the release that she has brought to her sub.

"There, doesn't that feel good, princess? I take care of you," Catra purrs in Adora's ear. Adora moans in response, giving a single, weak nod. Catra grins, raising her hands to run them soothingly down Adora's sides, squeezing a little as she assesses where they are at. They have only been playing for half an hour, but Adora's skin is littered with fading red marks and she has managed to orgasm or at least get some form of release close to it.

Catra isn't charging, so she doesn't have to worry about trying to get them as close to an hour of play as is reasonable. She is having a lot of fun with Adora, but after the emotional conversation at the beginning, it is probably for the best that today's session is short. Adora is spent anyway, sweating and panting. Catra doesn't want to hurt her arms either. It's probably for the best they stop now.

"You've done so well for me, princess. We're going to stop for today, but we'll play again soon," Catra promises Adora, closing her eyes and resting her head against the side of Adora's for a moment just to have a moment of contact before she steps away to start freeing Adora. Privately, she agrees with the groan of disappointment that Adora gives in response.

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The assault of sensations felt *incredible*. Adora is grateful Catra tied her up because trying to keep herself still would have taken too much of her concentration away from what Catra was doing. This way she got to soak it in, giving in to every twitch and jerk that her body felt the need to give. Despite how good it all felt, she may have come just from how intense it all was by the time that Catra bit her – she *really* wasn't expecting that and the sensations combined with shock were too much to push it down – and the idea of falling limp into Catra's arms is becoming more attractive with each passing second.

The aftershocks have worked through her by the time Catra has undone the blindfold and freed Adora from her restraints. She leads her over to the sofa and arranges them so Adora is sprawled out half in Catra's lap. Catra sets to massaging along Adora's sore arms and shoulders to soothe them and work out the tension of being strung up above her head. Adora's entire body is flushed with endorphins, her mind feeling a little hazy. She doesn't

know if it is just because of the conversation they had before the session, but she is feeling particularly needy this time.

Adora likes the feeling of Catra's hands massaging her, but fuck, she needs *Catra*. She needs cuddling. Catra has been fine with that for the previous sessions, but she didn't initiate it this time. Is that because she really does find relaxing the muscles after being tied up important, or is she uncomfortable with it? It could be that Adora isn't the only one feeling more emotional after their talk. Adora wants to sweep Catra up and crush her against her chest as Catra rubs her cheek against her and purrs, but she doesn't want to push. Right now she feels far too fragile to even think about asking for something.

"Doing okay down there?" Catra asks her, a small smile quirking at her lips. She is amused by her own reference to Adora's words in the car last weekend, but there is a spark of concern in her gaze. Adora blinks at her a few times as she tries to draw herself out of her thought spiral. Her body still feels warm, relaxed from the endorphins, but her heart is straining. Adora swallows as she blinks up at Catra's expression, which is only growing more concerned with every passing moment.

Adora doesn't want to ask for anything. Catra already gave her an orgasm and an amazing experience, not to mention opening up to her before the session started and agreeing to give Adora nearly everything she could dream of. She hesitantly nods and Catra's concerned frown only deepens. Adora swallows. She didn't buy it. Fuck. Adora promised not to lie to her. She can't go back on that when they are just making progress. She is going to ruin everything. She just has to trust that asking isn't as bad as lying.

"I don't know," Adora responds, her voice small. She does, but she doesn't. She likes Catra's hands on her, but she needs more – she needs *assurance*. She always has. As excited as she is for this upcoming change in their relationship, she is nervous for it too. She is nervous about messing it up and Catra withdrawing again. She is worried about doing that right now, actually. Catra's gaze softens as she looks down at Adora. She still looks worried, but there is a gentle, almost desperate affection there too.

"Come on, princess. You were perfect for me. You deserve a reward," Catra promises her, shifting on the couch. Adora feels her heartbeat jump as Catra rearranges them so she is stretched out beneath Adora, guiding her to rest her ear on Catra's chest, right above her heart. Adora can hear its heartbeat, quickened by leftover adrenaline or maybe anxiety. Catra's touch is calm and gentle as she carefully pulls out Adora's hair tie and sets to petting through her hair.

"You're such a good sub, Adora. Your reactions are *beautiful*, just like you," Catra praises her. Adora suppresses a shiver, turning to nuzzle against Catra's shirt right over her heart. This is exactly what she wanted. She could have gone without it - she fully intended to - but she is so grateful that Catra offered it. A quiet purr begins to roll through her chest that has Adora sighing gently and sagging against her, letting the tension in her body go.

Catra murmurs more soft praises and assurances to her as she holds her. It takes several minutes of this for Adora to realize she was being ridiculous and should have just asked Catra to hold her, but Adora has always struggled with asking for things. It is one of the things she has gotten better at over the years, but apparently it is harder for her as she is coming out of

subspace. Or maybe that is just a *today* thing. Regardless, she is grateful Catra recognized what she needed without her needing to ask.

Catra is incredibly attentive as a dom. Adora can't quite believe her luck to have found her again, not only because they get to rebuild their relationship and be there for each other again, but because she can't imagine anyone else taking care of her like this. If a random domme had been hired for the bachelorette party, Adora likely would have reached out to them by now to book a private session, but Adora can't imagine them treating her like this. How could they when Catra already knows her so well?

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"Feeling better?" Catra asks after several minutes, her voice soft. She pauses her petting and just cups the back of Adora's head, holding her close as she waits for a response. She felt a small bead of dread when she realized Adora was tensing up beneath her hands, but Adora quickly relaxed again once Catra set to cuddling and praising her. Catra intended to get to that once she was finished making sure her arms didn't seize up, but Adora doesn't seem to give a shit about her arms as she nods against Catra's chest.

"Yeah. Thanks. Everything was kind of sharpened but hazy in the comedown there. I'm good now, I just like cuddling," Adora assures her, squeezing her arms a little where they are framing Catra's torso on either side. Catra chuckles, resuming her petting. Adora has seemed to perk back up, but she needed to check and be sure. Despite her purr rising with her chuckle, Catra can't help but worry about Adora's anxiety ramping up so quickly after a session. Catra definitely places some of the blame on them talking about hard things right before it, but that was fast.

"Remember when I mentioned sub drop during the aftercare talk at the bachelorette party? I skimmed over it to keep things light, but it can lead to depression, Adora. That looked like the very beginnings of it to me. Doubts starting early can lead to a bad crash once the endorphins drop off," Catra tells her. Her tone is cautionary, doing her best to sound informational and not like she is trying to accuse Adora of hiding things. Catra is pretty sure she picked up on something happening at the same time that Adora did.

She hopes that Adora would have told her in the next few minutes if she needed assurance. Sometimes it takes a bit to work up the courage to ask for help though. Catra knows all about that, as does Adora. She just needs to make sure Adora knows how serious sub drop can be. Catra has been on the receiving end of dom drop enough to know it isn't something to play around with. She wants to make sure that Adora knows the signs and that she can come to Catra if they appear.

"I don't know. I just needed assurance but wasn't sure how to ask for it," Adora mumbles, apparently embarrassed. She is doing her best to hide her face down against Catra's chest and blushing a little. Catra draws in a breath and manages to rumble out a purr for her, but the sound is softer now. This is important. Clearly Adora wasn't doing that badly and she is

recovered now, but it could happen again. Catra shifts her hands down to Adora's shoulders and squeezes, encouraging her to look up. Adora reluctantly lifts her head.

"If you ever have sub drop, I want you to call me. I don't care how petty it feels or even if it has been a few days before it sets in, following up is part of aftercare. We can talk or meet up if that's what you need. Just promise me that you'll reach out if you need it. Drops like that suck," Catra tells her, trying to show her seriousness in her gaze without placing too much pressure on Adora. She could still be fragile.

Adora blinks at her for a long moment, just long enough for Catra to worry that she said too much and Adora is going to ask her how she knows all that, but she eventually nods. Catra isn't trying to lie about her own issues with dom drop, but she wants to focus on the topic at hand and secure the promise. Catra is fine right now. She wants to make sure Adora is okay before they even consider approaching a topic like that. Also, she doesn't want to talk about it at all.

"Okay. I will, I promise," Adora assures her. Catra lets out a soft breath of relief, sliding her hands around Adora's back to hug her close for a long moment. Adora smiles a little, squeezing back despite how awkward the angle is for a hug. When Catra lets her go, Adora sits up, though she seems reluctant to do so. Privately, Catra is just as reluctant as she scoots up into a sitting position as well. Adora reaches out and takes her hand instead, squeezing it for a moment.

"I'll take any excuse to call you, don't worry," Adora adds. That makes Catra chuckle, looking away for a long moment. It's a little too close to the emotions that she prefers to skate around, but it is reassuring. She knows Adora is gearing up to leave now that aftercare is done – a glance at the clock reveals they are near the end of their usual hour anyway – so she is grateful for a bit of assurance of her own. Catra thumps her tail once against the couch, shooting Adora an amused look.

"You can just *call*, but I do still have a life too. You want to go to the gym this weekend? I need an obedient little spotter to follow me around and count all my reps for me," Catra tells her, reaching up and pinching her cheek. It's condescending, but it's a joke, and Adora blushes as she laughs and swats at Catra's hand. She shoves her shoulder in response as Catra snickers.

"Bet I can rep more than you," Adora challenges, which is as good as a yes. Catra grins as her tail curls beside her. Catra doesn't actually know that she can rep more than Adora – Adora's biceps are certainly bigger than hers but magicats carry their muscle differently and Catra was stronger growing up – but she is more than willing to take the challenge. She will win as long as she gets to watch Adora's muscles flexing as she tries to match Catra.

"Deal," she agrees.

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Catra sends her a text in the morning to ask if she is still feeling okay, but Adora quickly texts her back to assure her she is. They end up scheduling to go to Adora's gym together the next day, but they don't get to call each other. Adora already has morning plans to meet up with Glimmer and Bow. Technically they got in last night, but landing just after eleven and not getting out of the airport until after midnight doesn't count in Adora's mind. Glimmer and Bow went straight home for some much-needed rest.

Adora drops by their favorite diner that they all fell in love with back in college despite it being out of the way. She picks them up food from the breakfast menu – which, knowing full well how late their main client base sleeps on weekends, they run until noon – and drives over to the house near the suburbs that Glimmer and Bow moved into two years ago. Glimmer is half-asleep when she arrives, grabbing eagerly at the coffee tray that Adora has to hold above her head as she makes her way into the kitchen.

Bow tries to reason with his wife that it won't be good until Adora reheats it. Glimmer ends up going limp in his arms and whining while Adora takes everything out of the greasy paper bags and begins working through reheating it using both the microwave and oven. Glimmer accepts her coffee eagerly when Adora finally gives it to her, smiling a little to herself. Glimmer has an impressive bedhead going despite the fact Bow has had time to get dressed.

"So how was the honeymoon?" Adora asks as she and Bow get the food set up on the kitchen table. Glimmer squints an indignant glare at Adora over her coffee as Bow chuckles affectionately.

"You've texted us that question every few days. You're terrible at distraction, Adora," Glimmer accuses. Adora shrugs, ignoring how her face feels warm. She does care if her friends had fun, but Adora knows the answer to that question by now. She practically knows their entire itinerary at the resort town in Salineas where they stayed. She knows this breakfast is going to turn into an interrogation about her and Catra and she would like to get to eat some of her food in peace first, but clearly Glimmer isn't letting it go.

"Can I ask that no one yells at me no matter how terrible they find my decisions?" Adora asks sarcastically, as she picks up her breakfast burger and takes a bite. Glimmer's eyes narrow as Adora sees an expression dawn on Bow's face that makes it clear he is just now realizing how irresponsible Adora can manage to be when left to her own devices. Adora would argue that everything has worked out and she has only grown closer with Catra, but she knows what her friends' reactions are going to be when she tells them the truth.

"I'm only promising that because yelling takes energy. You're fucked once this coffee kicks in, though," Glimmer tells her. Adora snorts, taking another massive bite just to give herself time as she chews on it. Bow shoots Glimmer a fond look. He won't yell, he'll just look at Adora with that look of touching concern that is somehow even worse. Glimmer on the other hand – if she were fully awake – would be likely to yell from shock alone when Adora says her next sentence.

"Catra is domming me," Adora says, promptly taking another massive bite before Glimmer's jaw can finish dropping. Bow chokes a little on nothing as Glimmer outright gapes at her, apparently too busy being shocked to yell yet.

“Adora, *no*,” Bow tries, looking at her with pleading eyes like Adora is going to suddenly admit she was joking. Reluctantly, Adora finishes chewing her bite and shrugs.

“It’s letting us get reacquainted with each other. We’re rebuilding slowly, but we’ve been doing it ever since the wedding and it has been incredible,” Adora returns before she takes another bite. The downside of the giant bites is that she has already managed to eat almost all of her burger. At least it won’t get cold. Glimmer is still staring. Bow has his head in his hands. That’s honestly a better reaction than Adora was expecting.

“Adora, why can’t you just *talk*?” Bow asks, whining a little. He has that disbelieving quality to his voice that people use far too often with Adora. Adora wrinkles up her nose. She doesn’t finish chewing for a solid twenty seconds, in which time Glimmer manages to pick her jaw back up off the floor, though she seems at a loss for words, which might be a first.

“We did talk. We talked before we started things and we talked again just last night. We promised to be honest with each other and everything. And this is *helping*, so don’t try to talk me out of it,” Adora returns. Glimmer arches an eyebrow, looking skeptical at best and dubious at worst.

“And how long after *talking* did you wait to start subbing for her?” she asks. Adora liked it better when she was too stunned to roast her. She prefers this to Glimmer’s genuine but misplaced concern from when they were talking on Sunday, though. Adora blushes, sinking down in her seat. She could probably stretch the limit of talking and claim it was a day between their first phone call and the session they scheduled during it, but she doesn’t think her friends would consider that much better.

“I’m not talking about my sex life. You know it exists and now I’m closing that door. Catra and I are communicating and I don’t think we’re going to have issues again. We might not get back together, but we’ll be friends at least. I know you’re going to be *worried* or whatever, but I really don’t need to be interrogated about this. I promise I’ll talk to you if there’s issues,” Adora returns, because she absolutely isn’t answering that question. Bow looks unconvinced, but Glimmer gets a spark in her eye that Adora instantly knows to mean she is doomed.

“Catra specifically said that pro dommes don’t do sex,” Glimmer points, with a supreme calm that doesn’t fool Adora in *any way*. Adora flushes, slumping down in her seat a little. Yeah, Catra did say that was the general rule – and her rule – at the party, and Adora did say sex life. Honestly, she is lucky that Perfuma didn’t see them through a window or something. If she had, she absolutely would have texted Glimmer, honeymoon be damned. It would have been a shitshow. Adora picks at her food on her plate for a minute before she gives a reluctant sigh.

“Maybe, hypothetically, she was at Perfuma’s party and we ended up going home together. Maybe,” Adora mutters, her cheeks blazing. For a second, both of her friends gape at her. Unfortunately, Adora’s earlier admission and the coffee have finally woken Glimmer up. Glimmer lets out a strangled exclamation approaching her name at the same time that Bow says it in a downright aghast tone.

Well, Adora knew she couldn’t escape chiding forever.

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They meet at Adora's gym. It's a little place, more like a fitness club than the large rec center Catra uses to work out. It somehow manages to have a hipster vibe despite looking like a regular gym. Maybe it's just the small, personal atmosphere and the music playing. The music is quiet at least, kept at a tolerable level for hybrids. The music at Catra's gym is variable, sometimes just right and other times grating on her nerves. Adora checks Catra in as a guest and then gives her a quick tour of the facility.

Catra is aware of the front desk clerk finding reasons to be near to them, cleaning equipment nearby as if to project an image of cleanliness, but they don't outright approach her about getting a membership, and they return to their post once she and Adora get on the treadmills together. One thing Catra likes about the place is that the hybrid treadmills are intermixed among the regular ones. They are all tacked onto the end of the row at her gym and there aren't as many of them, so it's difficult for her and Scorpia to run together.

She and Adora end up racing. Of course they do. Catra catches Adora sneaking glances at her mile count, and then she picks up the pace, to which Adora ramps up her difficulty in response. It's ridiculous and competitive and so *them* it would leave Catra breathless if she weren't already panting from the run anyway. It feels so good to be joking around with Adora, tossing friendly taunts and insults back and forth. Their sessions have been incredible, but interactions like this fulfill a very different longing, one she wasn't certain would ever be met again.

Adora calls her ridiculous when Catra makes her count all her reps for her, but she does it dutifully and seemingly *happily* despite ragging on Catra for it at first. She spots her and then pointedly puts on an extra pair of ten pound weights on either end of her own bar when Catra trades places with her. Catra's tail curls in amusement. She waits until Adora is lying out on the bench and has begun her reps before she lets her own satisfied smirk curl show.

"You know, I underweighted my bar. I'm going to bury you when it's my turn again," Catra tells her, throwing down her own challenge after the ridiculousness on the treadmills. It's true, though she only did it by twenty pounds on each end, interested to see what weight Adora would start with. She can do even more if she wants to be petty. Adora blows out a gust of air and Catra hovers, already in position to take some of the weight off the bar. Adora manages to glare up at her, give a dubious grunt, and resume her reps.

Catra grins when it's her turn again and she switches out Adora's ten weights on the ends for twenties, adding forty pounds onto the total she was already working with on her last set of reps. Adora doesn't even manage to look indignant as Catra does her reps, flushed as she watches Catra's arms flexing and stumbles over counting her reps. Catra smirks as she presses the weight, giving a slight bow when she finishes and hauls herself up to her feet again.

“Beat that,” she challenges. Adora flushes. Wisely, she doesn’t. She tries, but she struggles on the last few reps and Catra reaches down to catch the bar, lifting it off Adora’s hands to hold some of the weight for her and raising a brow down at her. Adora can match her number of reps, but she doesn’t normally work out at this weight. Ten extra pounds on each end makes a big difference.

“Just match me and we’ll call it even,” Catra instructs her. She only gives the bar back when Adora heaves a sigh – partly reluctant, and partly relieved – and nods. The last few reps are a fight, but she makes it and Catra takes the weight from her afterwards. “Thanks for giving me a chance to ogle your arms again, princess,” Catra quips as she sets the bar down and starts taking off the weights to put them away. Adora flushes, stretching out her arms as she stands.

“Give me a month. I’ll be able to do it. I’ve been slacking lately,” Adora defends, though she doesn’t actually sound bothered by her inability to match Catra’s reps. She was damn close, and she sits at a computer all day. Catra has to be able to crack a whip, set up and position metal dungeon frames, and physically drag clients across the room if they ask regardless of their own weight. Adora works out for fun, which Catra does too, but even painting can involve moving some heavy equipment. Her work requires her to be able to do physical labor.

“Don’t worry, princess. I enjoy your muscles as they are,” Catra assures Adora with a smirk as she passes her and lashes her tail to swat it against Adora’s ass. In the mirrored wall of the gym, Catra watches Adora turn bright red with deep satisfaction.

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Going to the gym with Catra was almost comically fun. When Glimmer comes to Adora’s office for lunch on Monday, she mocks Adora for being such a jock. Adora would point out that working out can give you a chemical rush, which did a lot for her when combined with Catra’s presence – she did learn *some* things in pre-med, after all – but she lets Glimmer roast her. She would rather her friends were gently ribbing her than trying to convince her to change her mind.

Glimmer and Bow made an effort to convince her that letting her ex dom her is a bad idea, but Adora wasn’t going to be deterred. Her friends are still dubious. They spent awhile reminding Adora she can come to them if anything happens, to which Adora replied that it didn’t *feel* like it when they were already giving her a hard time. That seemed to be the wakeup call they needed. Adora knows her friends are just trying to look out for her, but things really are going well with Catra.

They are going so well that when Adora has a bad day at work on Tuesday, she stares at her phone for several minutes after her evening shower before finally convincing herself to text Catra. She isn’t in a bad headspace or anything, but it seemed like everyone she dealt with *was* and she got snapped at not only by a vendor, but by two of her coworkers as well. She just wants to talk with someone to soothe the wounds of the day. Ordinarily she would text

one of her friends, but Catra is willing to count herself amongst them again, so after a few minutes of gathering her courage, Adora texts her.

Hey.

Wow, already horny?

You said we could talk just to talk!

Wow, and flustered too.

I'm teasing. What's up?

Just wanted to talk to you. Are you busy?

I'm watching Entrapta try to untangle cables. It's riveting.

Can I call you?

Catra doesn't text her back for a minute, but then her phone buzzes in her hand. Adora smiles a little to herself as she accepts the call and raises the phone to her ear just in time to hear the unmistakable sound of Catra flopping onto something soft and sighing with contentment. Adora lets her eyes slip closed as she settles down a little further on her own couch.

"Hey," Adora says, no clever greeting coming to her. Catra must be really comfortable, because Adora can hear her starting to purr on the other end of the line. Adora wishes she could feel it. Why did she think calling is a good idea? She wants to go over and actually see Catra in person. Then she could hold her, and they wouldn't have the communication issues they always struggled with over the phone.

"Hey, Adora," Catra purrs back. Alright, scratch that, Adora doesn't wish shit. Being able to see Catra is a two-way street and no one needs to know how embarrassingly Adora flushes and lights up at just those two words. She hums a little to herself, soothed by Catra's presence in her ear. She probably should have thought of something to say before she called her. All Adora wants to do is soak in the sound of Catra's voice.

"You never texted me pictures of that painting of me you said you were working on," Adora points out, mostly as a segue. Catra makes a soft, gentle sound, but she doesn't stop purring.

"I forgot. I can go take a picture of it in a minute. I'm comfortable right now," Catra replies. She sounds it if her purr is anything to go by. In Catra's defense, Adora forgot too, but she just thought about how Catra's art was probably a safe topic to catch up on and it occurred to her again. If Catra is comfortable, though, Adora isn't in a rush for her to get up.

"Tell me what you like to paint these days? I miss your art. I want to see more of it," Adora asks. She really does. She only got to watch Catra paint a handful of times. She saw her

hunched over sketches far more often. Catra would show them to her when she was done before quickly destroying them. It was a safety mechanism. It helped protect her art from their foster guardian, but Catra also once told her that she was determined to succeed one day and she didn't want their guardian to have secretly saved some of her early work and sell it for a fortune when that happened.

On the other end of the line, Catra purrs for several seconds before she launches into an explanation of her most recent series of paintings.

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If Adora actually needed something, she doesn't give it away. She seems to have just called because she wanted to talk. It's embarrassing how Catra instantly begins purring at the sound of Adora's voice, but Adora doesn't call her out on it. Catra is more than happy to talk about her art. She loves to do it when she gets the chance. She lounges on her bed for a while, kneading at the mattress with her free hand and sweeping her tail back and forth over the sheets with her contentment as Adora asks her about what she likes to paint now and the styles she prefers.

Adora knows next to nothing about art, but she has always been Catra's biggest fan. For years, she was Catra's *only* fan. Honestly, she might as well still be. Catra does sell her paintings sometimes, but her website doesn't get a lot of traffic. Catra always did well in the art shows she was a part of in college, but she hasn't gotten a call back for any of the opportunities to put her work out there that she has found since. Talking about it actually reminds her of that gallery she got the name of at the Halloween party. Everything else that happened made her quickly forget it, but when she gets up to take a picture of the painting for Adora, she settles back down at her desk instead of on the bed.

Adora gushes in her ear about how good it looks after Catra texts her the picture. Catra is proud of the painting of the sea meeting the sky. Instead of the sun sinking into the horizon in a classic sunset painting, an ocean goddess whose curves follow the lines of Adora's body suspiciously well can be seen instead, her golden hair spreading out into the waves instead of the rays of the sun. Adora seems extremely flustered by the portrayal. Obviously she recognizes her own body, but the goddess is lying with her back to the viewer and Adora squeaks when Catra refers to the woman as a goddess.

"Would you prefer oceanid? I just wanted to do something magical. You know I always liked the whimsy of the renaissance paintings, even if the religion stuff isn't my bag," Catra tells her as she pokes around on the gallery's website. Unfortunately, the gallery is over in Plumeria. Catra could take a weekend vacation if she has time to plan in advance, but shipping her paintings over there won't be cheap. Still, the gallery's focus on "undiscovered masters" seems promising. Adora manages not to squeak, but Catra *knows* she is still blushing. Adora does her best to huff with annoyance, but she just sounds flustered.

“Forgive me for being flustered over you painting me naked as a *goddess*,” Adora manages to retort back. Catra lets out a squeaky trill, her hand skittering across her trackpad and sending her mouse flying. Alright, she wasn’t thinking about that. She got a little too caught up in Adora’s fluster and said far too much. She shrinks down in her seat, pinning her ears back as her tail lashes at her side. Her only saving grace is that Adora can’t see her. Her silence says all it needs to, though. On the other end of the line, Adora clears her throat awkwardly.

“Can I see more?” she asks. There is an edge of nerves in her voice, probably worried about going too far. Her heart beating fast, Catra sits back upright and returns to navigating the gallery’s site. At this point, filling out the contact form is just a distraction from her own idiocy. She wants to finish this, though, and a lot of her paintings are stored away and not the easiest to take pictures of. As she fills out her portfolio information on the form, she gets an idea.

“I have a website with pictures that I can give you if you promise not to buy anything,” Catra replies. Adora huffs, but she says *deal* with a grin in her voice. Catra rattles off the address as she wills her heartbeat back to normal. The task isn’t helped by Adora finding her gallery and gushing about every picture as she flicks through them. Catra thought getting caught was bad, but it’s nothing compared to the way her blood thrums as Adora compliments how far Catra has come with her use of color. Adora is the only person who can give her that comment and have it be this meaningful. Catra purrs to herself as she listens to Adora start whining about how she wants to see this stuff in person.

“No purchases. I’ll just cancel it if you make one. I want to get my work out there and you already like it. You can come see them at my place once Scorpia has had some space. Right now it just feels like rubbing it in her face,” Catra promises her. She and Scorpia are kind of not talking – as in they definitely *are* talking, but Catra is pretty sure Scorpia considers not instantly greeting Catra every time she sees her or wandering into her room and trying to drag her into going out somewhere with her and Entrapta to be a remarkable show of restraint. Adora actually whines in response.

“But they’re so pretty. I want to have some too. I love the one you gave me. And not because, you know, it’s me. I mean, I like- I would like it anyway- I’m shutting up,” Adora stammers out. Catra can’t help but cackle to herself. Adora talked herself into a fluster there without Catra needing to do anything. Adora hisses between her teeth, clearly embarrassed as Catra continues to laugh. Fuck, she missed Adora. She missed when she would stumble over herself and talk herself into a corner until she gave up on talking to avoid embarrassing herself. She never stopped early enough to save face, though.

“*Shut up*. When do you want to go to the gym again?” Adora asks, a flustered and terrible attempt at distraction. Catra smirks to herself, leaning back in her desk chair and grinning to herself. Her tail thuds against the side of her desk as it flicks with anticipation.

“Oh, I’m *flexible*, princess,” Catra leers. Friends can flirt, right? Especially friends with benefits. This isn’t really outside of her rules. Besides, how could she resist when Adora squeaks so cutely and sputters on the other end of the line. Catra laughs again, but after a moment she takes pity on her. “How about tomorrow? I usually go three times a week. Four if I don’t have any appointments,” Catra proposes. She has four scattered appointments this

week, but getting out of the house where she and Scorpia are still finding their footing again will be good for her.

“Tomorrow evening. I’ll look forward to it,” Adora promises her. It is Catra’s turn to be flustered. She lets out a tiny squeak she desperately hopes the phone doesn’t pick up, but Adora starts humming r, so there is no hope that she didn’t hear it. Catra sinks down in her desk chair again.

“Me too,” she mutters back. Her cheeks are blazing, but the small, happy noise Adora lets out is worth it.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: Handcuffed and blindfolded sensation play with masochism/riding crop/etc use.

Failure

Chapter Notes

BDSM warning in the endnote.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"How busy are you usually with work?" Adora asks after they settled down with their drinks. There is a smoothie place just down the street from Adora's gym. Adora hadn't seemed ready to part yet when they finished and invited Catra along to grab a drink with her. Now they are settled in the corner of the muddily-painted place – it is orange or red, Catra would guess, but the colors are *everywhere* and she knows it must be gaudy – with two smoothies between them. Catra shrugs as she sips hers.

"It varies a lot. I have a decent number of appointments this week. It's a bunch of last-minute people who probably didn't get any on Halloween and need to get some satisfaction, I would bet," Catra tells her, gesturing vaguely in the air. She only has two appointments this weekend, but she has already had four this week and has another two coming up on Thursday. Adora blinks, nodding as she processes that. Absently, Catra taps her claws against the side of her drink.

"End of the year is usually on the busier side, but I still spend nearly all day free. It gives me plenty of time to paint and look for opportunities to show my work. Obviously I would prefer for my art career to take off, but I'm comfortable, and I like domming. Especially since it pays well," Catra adds on. Adora hums as she sips her drink. Catra can see her thinking. She resists the urge to flex out her claws as they itch from her defensiveness. They haven't talked at all about how Adora feels about her job.

Catra knows that Adora doesn't really get an opinion, but she is still nervous about her trying to give it anyway. Adora seems to catch on to the change in Catra. She blinks at her in surprise, frowning a little as she eyes her. Catra sighs, sitting back in their corner booth. Adora seems confused by the shift in Catra's demeanor. Maybe her questions were innocent, but Catra knows that Adora has jealousy issues. There is a reason she asked Adora about them specifically before they started this new arrangement.

"Some people are weird about the job, Adora. There's a reason I don't advertise what I do in my day-to-day life, and it isn't shame," Catra explains, shrugging a little. She doesn't mind Adora asking about her job – people usually have a lot of questions when they do find out what she does – but she is worried these are probing questions working towards an end goal. Inviting Adora back into her life isn't an invitation to judge how she chooses to lead it. Adora almost startles, blinking at her for a long moment.

“I was thinking about how long I should wait before I ask you over without it being weird,” she explains. Catra’s tail thuds on the seat beside her as she does her best to fight down her blush. She almost definitely fails from the way Adora’s expression lights with interest. Despite clearly having been in deep thought about this a few moments ago, there is no trace of sheepishness in her now. She can blurt out the question when it is for the sake of assuring Catra, apparently. Catra looks away, coughing into her hand as she does a mental run through Adora’s usual booking conditions and her availability.

“Friday night? I don’t have any appointments then,” Catra offers. She has a gap between her last appointment tomorrow and her next two on Saturday night. Now Adora has put it out there, Catra doesn’t really want to wait until Sunday. She is eager to have Adora in a bed again. Adora’s eyes widen in time with her cheeks darkening. She eagerly nods.

“Absolutely,” she agrees. It’s a little too quick, so Catra leers at her in response as she takes another sip of her drink. She has some toys to bring along with her and she is already thinking about how fun it will be to watch Adora react as she unpacks them. Some of them are basic stuff – she will need a riding crop at Adora’s place – but others are sure to make her squirm.

One item in particular Catra has been thinking about for weeks, but after their talk over the weekend and the flood of appointments bringing her a little extra cash, she finally went and picked it up Sunday night. Alright, maybe she went straight there after their afternoon at the gym. She didn’t plan to, but working out with Adora got her really riled up. Watching Adora’s flexing muscles reminded Catra of how they had *strained* when she was tied up.

“Your homework is to clear a drawer for me. I don’t want to carry a paddle on the bus every time I come over. I’ll need somewhere to stash the basic stuff. Anything else you’ll have to tell me in advance if you want me to bring over,” Catra tells her, because she has to stop that line of thinking. Adora will get her present Friday, but for now, Catra should avoid getting turned on in public.

Adora is failing that goal, flushing and ducking her head to quickly take a long drink as if the frozen smoothie will help cool her libido. Catra watches with amusement, smirking to herself as Adora surfaces with her cheeks still flushed and nods. She shifts a little on the bench, looking out the window as if desperate for something to latch onto that will redirect her thoughts.

“Can I pay for you to take a rideshare? It’s not like paying for the session or anything, but it’s the least I can do to make sure it doesn’t cost you to come see me,” Adora asks. Catra pauses, pursing her lips as she thinks that over. She can take care of herself and Adora has paid her more than enough in the last few weeks, but accepting would make this feel a bit more transactional without cutting out all the personal nature from it.

“Fine. Only when I’m coming over for sex, though,” Catra agrees. Adora flushes crimson, but she quickly nods her agreement. As much as Catra wants to pounce on her fluster, she forces herself to just sip her smoothie instead. She will get her chance soon.

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Catra texts Adora on Friday night when she is ready to head over. She sends a screenshot of the ride fare and Adora busies herself with transferring the money to the personal account Catra gave her to use now instead of her business one. Adora has no idea what they are doing for the session for the second week in a row now and she is a little worked up just running over the possibilities in her mind. On Wednesday, she had to force herself to wait until after her post-gym shower to clean out a drawer for Catra after she requested one.

This drawer is definitely for… paraphernalia, but Adora is hopeful it will be for more eventually too. Maybe Catra will start staying over and the drawer can expand. Adora would like Catra staying over to be common enough that she needs an entire change of clothes here. She would love for them to be comfortable enough to share a space again, even if it isn't in the context that Adora always thought it would be.

Eventually Adora hears the sound of a car pulling into her driveway and eagerly rushes to the door. She opens it as soon as Catra knocks, which earns her a raised brow and an amused smirk. That smirk shifts into a full leer when Catra notices the way Adora's eyes *stick* on the bag that Catra has slung over her shoulder. It's the same bag that Catra brought to the bachelorette party. Adora knows exactly the kinds of things that Catra can fit into there.

"Go get us waters prepped. You're going to need it," Catra orders her, smug and confident as she walks past Adora and heads straight for her bedroom. Adora's fingers fumble on the deadbolt as she locks it. Catra must hear it, because she laughs as she disappears down the hall. Yeah, Adora is already turned on. She can't help that Catra's whole *confident dom* thing wrecks her. She hurries to get two glasses filled, adding ice cubes to only one.

Catra is weird and doesn't like iced water. Adora doesn't know if these are both supposed to be just for her, but she doesn't mind non-iced if that's the only option, so this will work either way. She carries both the glasses to the bedroom. She finds Catra with her bag dropped on top of the corner of Adora's dresser, standing over the drawer that Adora transferred everything out of and left open for her.

"I assume this is for me-" Catra starts to say, looking up to Adora. Her hands freeze in the middle of unzipping her bag as her gaze sticks on the two glasses in Adora's hands. Adora blinks at her, surprised, before she glances down and realizes Catra is looking at the glass without any ice cubes in it and steadily blushing. Adora doesn't really know why. Did she not mean for the water to be for both of them? She did say that Adora would *need it*. Maybe seeing it is just making the reality set in for the first time that they are about to combine BDSM and sex.

"I, uh, yeah. It's for anything you need to store over here," Adora returns. Catra looks back down to the bag and nods quickly. Adora hesitates before turning to place the waters on the nightstand. By the time she has turned back around, Catra's confident mask is back in place. Her cheeks are still flushed, but Catra pulling the paddle with heart-shaped cutouts out from her bag is enough to distract Adora. Her own flush is back as she crosses over to the dresser and tries to peek at what Catra is unpacking.

Unfortunately, Catra finds the riding crop at the moment and swats Adora with it. She does it lightly, snickering as she does so, but her point is made. Adora pouts at her, but she retreats a few steps with her cheeks blazing. She can still see everything that Catra is placing in the drawer, but she is forced to watch her pull things out from her bag one-by-one rather than peering in and spoiling everything. Despite wanting to know, she can privately agree that Catra was right to punish her, because watching the purposeful way Catra pulls each object from the bag, languid but graceful, does a lot for her.

The teasing is infuriating, but Adora's anticipation only builds as she watches Catra pull one of her floggers from the bag and set it in the drawer to join the paddle and crop. Next she pulls a bundle of shibari rope – that has to be what it is for, it's a deep shade of royal blue and the sight of it alone is enough to make Adora's mouth grow dry – and a length of satin fabric. It's either for tying her up or a blindfold. It excites Adora either way.

The satin bags Catra pulls out next threaten to raise Adora's blood pressure. She doesn't know what is in them, but she knows the kinds of things that come in bags like that. Catra chuckles just watching her reaction. Adora huffs, folding her arms and sending Catra an indignant, pouting look. It only seems to amuse Catra more.

"If I was doing this to you, you wouldn't be any better," Adora defends, her face warm. Unfortunately, that doesn't earn her any pity. Catra zips back up her bag with an air of finality, bumping her hip against the drawer to slide it closed as she does so. She turns to Adora with a wide grin on her face.

"That's where you're mistaken, princess. I wouldn't be in your position. Now be a good girl and show me where your sex toys are," Catra orders her, cocky and confident and *infuriating*. Adora squeaks.

Catra laughs at her.

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Adora tries to sputter out a protest that Catra isn't buying for a heartbeat and then, with her cheeks blazing, opens the drawer two down from the one she gave Catra. Adora is completely flustered as Catra orders her to follow her, but she does it without hesitation. Catra leads her to the bathroom, which seems to confuse her as Adora hovers over her shoulder and watches Catra wash her hands. Catra rolls her eyes as Adora frowns.

"Wash your hands, princess, and then go sit on the couch. I'm going to look over your playthings," Catra orders her, turning around to flash Adora a smirk. Adora immediately flushes. Catra feels warm satisfaction spread in her chest as she watches Adora's eyes widen with the realization that they're close to starting.

Catra throws her a leer before she slips back to the bedroom and pokes through Adora's toys. She has about a dozen, mostly non-realistic vibrators and dildos. Her first vibrator is gone,

but the strap-on they got after a year together is still in the drawer. Catra smirks to herself as she pokes through the selection, unsurprised by most of the things she finds, but one in particular intrigues her. She pulls it from the drawer and sets its bag, red velvet with a satin lining, on the bed near the pillows.

From her own drawer of toys, she pulls one of the black satin bags and places it beside the velvet one. It will be a fun present for Adora. It will lay down the rules of what they're doing as much as the talk they're about to have will. Catra hesitates at the bedside, taking a sip of her ice cube-free water before she heads back out to the living room. She got stupidly flustered by Adora remembering such a dumb quirk of hers, but it's the silent effort that shows.

Adora couldn't do things like remember how she likes her water to show Catra that she cares when they were long distance. A lot of the quiet things Adora did to assure her on a daily basis, plus all their physical affection, were gone even before Adora started to get cagey about calling Catra. Feeling how her heart warms having this back, Catra can easily see how losing it made her feel like Adora fell out of love with her without Adora's actual feelings dimming.

Catra emerges from the bedroom to find Adora sat on the couch just like Catra told her to. Adora has her legs curled up under her, practically kneeling. Heat sparks in Catra, a smirk playing at her lips as Adora eagerly looks up. Adora has color dusted across her cheeks, excitement evident as Catra saunters around the couch and comes to a halt in front of Adora. Adora blinks up at her, expectant and holding still as Catra reaches out to pet the top of her head. Adora's eyes instantly fall closed as she leans into the touch.

Catra grins to herself and slides a claw out, snapping Adora's hairband in an instant. Adora lets out a small noise, her eyes flying open and burning with intensity as they stare down at her own hands, clutching onto her knees now. She likes when Catra exerts her control over her like this. It's something small and insignificant – Catra would bet Adora loses as many hair ties as she is going to end up losing to Catra – but it sends a clear message about who is in charge now.

"We're doing something new, so we need new rules, princess," Catra tells her, conversationally, as she sets to combing her fingers through Adora's hair. Adora is flushed, but she nods, still looking down. Reluctantly, Catra drops her hands from Adora's hair and walks around her to sit down on the couch beside her. As much as she wants to play with Adora, they have to do this first. Adora blinks in surprise, seeming to need a moment to catch up before she reluctantly turns to face Catra. Her reluctance fades some when she sees the seriousness on Catra's face, expression turning expectant instead.

"I have rules I want to propose, but if they won't work for you, I need you to be honest with me about it," Catra tells her, leveling Adora with a look to make it clear that her bullshit isn't going to fly. Adora draws in a breath before nodding almost hesitantly. Catra stares her down with a narrow-eyed look for several long moments. Honesty is even more important now they're having sex again. After a few moments, Adora nods again, more committed this time.

"Just… give me a minute to think about each one before I agree to it so I can think about what I might need?" Adora asks, her voice far too questioning for what should be a solid

request. Still, it's good enough for Catra. She nods, eyeing Adora for a moment as she tries to decide how to phrase this.

"These are at-home sessions, just hookups, so no kissing outside of sex," she says. She kind of already told Adora she didn't want random kisses after the party, but she needs to formally add it to the list. It would take this too far into territory she isn't comfortable with. She watches Adora give a subtle but full body twitch. Catra raises a brow. This rule should have been a given. After a moment, Adora works up her nerve to look Catra in the eye.

"And during aftercare? I don't want it to suddenly stop while I'm coming out of it," Adora returns. Catra's tail thuds once against the couch, surprised. That is reasonable. Depending on how you want to define it, that could even be included in Catra's initial offer of just during sex. She nods, watching the anxiety that was creeping into Adora instantly disappear. She smiles a little, seemingly just from relief. Adora blows out her breath, clearly steeling herself before she makes eye contact with Catra.

"How frequently are we doing this? You never told me what was typical before, but once a week didn't feel like too much when I was at least paying you for the time. I don't want to take advantage on your offer," Adora asks. Catra smirks a little, which causes Adora to flush. The implication that she thinks she wants to do this at least once a week, if not more, is there in the question. Catra hasn't really thought about the frequency of this again since Adora made that joke about asking her over six times a week.

"I'm not coming over every day, princess, but I won't blame you if you want it often. Whatever feels right and that we both have time for," Catra responds. She can't really give a more solid answer than that when they haven't done this even once yet. Adora flushes, but she nods.

"There are some kinks that are left out of my kink contract because they require sex and so I never do them with clients. Stuff like orgasm denial and forced orgasm. You should think about which things like that interest you so we can talk about them," Catra adds. Adora flushes, nodding quickly. The interest on her scent is instant and obvious. Catra leers at her in response. Yeah, that reaction is giving her ideas.

"I assume I can add those to the *Want* list?" she asks, because she has to, and because she enjoys the way Adora squirms a little as she nods in response. Catra grins to herself for a moment, her gaze raking over Adora to take in the flush of desire in her skin and the way she is just a bit *twitchy* from excitement. Catra wants to get her hands on her, but they need to finish the rules.

"You still address me as sir during a scene. I assume everything we used to do in bed together is fine with you?" Catra asks. They are so close. One more rule – one that Adora may very well protest to, though Catra won't really mind if she does, it will just be a shame – and then she can show Adora her surprise and add on the last rule. Then, finally, she will get to have the full experience of having Adora as a sub. Adora's thighs twitch a little at Catra's words.

"Yes. To all of that," Adora agrees, her voice sounding a touch breathless from her anticipation. Catra grins, her tail thumping on the couch beside her. She lets herself leer at Adora for a moment, enjoying how worked up she is.

“Any other rules you need to add?” she asks. Given Adora’s earlier request, she wants to make sure she creates space for Adora to consider her own needs and be comfortable asking for them. Adora pauses, clearly thinking it over, but after a long moment she blushes and looks away. She has to take a deep breath first, and then she shrugs.

“Not really a rule, just, um, so that you know, I haven’t been with anyone since you. Made out with two of my friends and went on a blind date that ended up being a disaster, but that’s it,” Adora tells her, placing her hands on her knees and squeezing, seemingly just for support. Catra immediately wants to know that story, but she forces herself to just nod. As much as the words make her want to *pounce*, she needs to be more neutral during the rule-setting phase. It helps encourage honesty.

She is glad Adora told her that, and not just because she is possessive and always has been. She isn’t going to go *easy* on her by any means – and based off the sizes of Adora’s toys, she can still take everything that she used to – but it does set her expectations for this session. It especially encourages her. Adora might be easier than ever for her given the dry spell, and that plays into Catra’s plans nicely.

“Okay. If you need me to go easier on you, call pink,” Catra reminds her. Adora is still flushed, but her shoulders relax a little with relief and she nods. Maybe she thought Catra was about to call her out, but Catra isn’t touching that topic, especially not right before a session. She saw what emotional discussions right before a session do to Adora and she doesn’t want her to have sub drop after their first real time back together.

Catra has also been doing her best not to think about Adora saying *I’m still in love with you* for the last week since she admitted it. Even though Catra is now accepting that Adora did love her and still could, she isn’t ready to address something so emotional right now, and she would be a moron if she couldn’t put together why Adora has been celibate for five years when she is – or at least, *would like to be* – an absolute freak in bed.

Adora, after a moment of gathering herself, looks to Catra expectantly. It seems that was all that she wanted to add. There is an eager, somewhat questioning look in her eyes. She wants to know if it’s playtime yet. Catra hums, a mischievous smile twitching at the corner of her mouth as she scoots closer on the couch. Adora immediately sits at attention, her breath catching a little when Catra reaches to twine a lock of her hair between her fingers.

“This is rule I want to add as a dom. Tell me if you don’t want to do it, because while this would be restricted to during sessions, it isn’t about sex, just exercising control over my sub,” Catra tells her, still twirling the hair between her fingers. Adora’s hands tighten in a death grip on her knees as she nods quickly. Heat flares between Catra’s legs at the openly excited look on Adora’s face.

“So eager to please, princess,” she purrs to Adora. Adora’s eyes dilate, but she doesn’t even try to argue. She nods, small and maybe a touch embarrassed, but it only makes Catra hotter. She swallows, willing her voice to be even. “When you’re subbing for me, your hair is down. Today was a small exception since we hadn’t set the rule yet, but from now on, the session starts when I take out your ponytail. If you want to negotiate more before getting started, you need to use your safe words once I do that,” Catra proposes.

There is no reason for this other than that Catra wants it. As Adora's dom, that is reason enough. If she wants her sub to do something, Adora should do it whether she chooses to follow the order or Catra has to force her to. As long as Adora doesn't call her word, they keep going. However, Catra has no interest in a twenty-four-hour BDSM relationship, and this is straying outside of pure sex territory. She can make justifications for it – it *will* help them to define when they are having an actual session and not just teasing each other – but she just likes pulling Adora's hair at the end of the day.

Adora, for her part, reacts by flushing a deep shade, her eyes a bit unfocused as she stares at Catra's hand playing with her hair. She seems lost for words. Catra smirks as she continues to wind her fingers through the soft locks, waiting for Adora to get her shit together. Eventually, after just opening and closing her mouth and getting nowhere for a few moments, Adora manages to swallow and make eye contact with Catra again, her cheeks blazing.

"I don't have a problem with that. Though I'll go through hair ties fast if you snap it every time," she manages, her voice a little hoarse. Catra's smirk only grows. Fuck, she's wet already. She can't help it that Adora's reactions affect her in turn.

"Buy in bulk. Now come on - it's time I show you the present I brought," Catra orders her. Adora's whimper is tiny and suppressed, but Catra doesn't miss it.

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Adora stops dead in her tracks when she walks into the bedroom and sees the velvet bag on the bed. The satin bag beside it could be anything from one of her own toys to the apparent present that Catra brought, but the velvet bag she knows immediately. It might just be one of her favorite toys, but the idea of Catra pulling this one in particular has her flushed. It gives her an idea of the kind of thing they're going to be doing today.

Catra smacks her ass. Adora jumps, yelping a little as she turns back to find Catra leering at her and making a shooing motion to usher her into the room. The dismissiveness should be degrading, but Adora just finds herself ducking her head to hide the warmth in her face and hurrying over to the bed. She takes a drink of her water as Catra snickers behind her. Her mouth already feels dry. Catra sneaks up behind her, hands finding Adora's hips and pulling them back to meet Catra's own. Adora manages not to shake the glass as she sets her water back down.

"Turn around, princess. I want to see all of you as you strip," Catra orders her. The words make Adora instantly hot. She resists the urge to rub her thighs together, turning around to face Catra. Catra is grinning widely, a predatory lilt to the smirk. Her eyes run along Adora, not bothering to look her in the face. "Take off your shirt. Show me what's mine," Catra tells her. Fuck, that makes Adora's breath catch as she hurries to pull off her top. Catra still doesn't look at her face, her eyes focused on Adora's newly-revealed skin.

It goes like that for every article of her clothing, Catra ordering her to remove each one individually, right down to each of her socks. Catra never touches her, or looks her in the face, or lets Adora move at all except to turn to set her clothes – which Catra makes her *fold* – on the edge of the bed. Adora is wet and she knows that Catra can tell – her smirk couldn't get any more infuriating and sexy at this point – but Catra makes her stand there as she circles around her and *inspects* her.

Catra knows her naked body already, but Adora feels incredibly exposed as she stands beside the bed and waits for any indication that she is allowed to move. She swears Catra made her fold her clothes just to make her wait longer. She is worked up plenty as it is. She wants to be able to touch Catra or at least *be* touched. Catra comes to halt in front of her, calm and collected as she smirks at Adora. She reaches up towards Adora's head. She didn't give her an order, but Adora ducks her head a little to help Catra as she threads her fingers through Adora's hair.

Suddenly, she fists it and pushes *down*. Adora whimpers a little, but she follows the direction, falling to her knees. She kneels before Catra, wincing at the pull on her scalp despite how *good* it feels too. She has always loved having her hair pulled. Catra has her head forced bowed so Adora can't see her face, but her tail is lashing behind her in excitement, so she seems pleased with Adora's cooperation. The hand in her hair eases, letting go and petting through it gently instead.

"I got a present for you, princess, and I couldn't help but notice that you have some fun toys of your own," Catra says, conversationally, as she reaches into her pocket. Adora risks looking up to watch as Catra produces the remote for the toy in the velvet bag on the bed. Her core twitches, desperate for what Catra is offering. Catra has a firm smirk in place, excitement dancing in her eyes as she *coos* a little to Adora. Adora blushes. It's degrading, but they both know she likes that, at least to some degree.

The remote disappears back into Catra's pocket and Adora almost manages not to whine. Almost. It doesn't help Catra's grin as she drops her hand from Adora's hair and turns away from her. Adora feels like she strains towards Catra, missing not only the touch but the *attention*. Catra doesn't seem to care about Adora's yearning, turning her attention to the bags on the bed and reaching for the velvet one. Adora's heart skips when she hears the slight clink of metal inside.

Before her mind has the chance to run off on dozens of theories, Catra opens the bag and turns back to her with a grin. Adora knows Catra is watching her reaction intently, but she can't tear her eyes away from the collar Catra produces from the bag. Her hands, settled expectantly on her knees, suddenly grip tight as her eyes focus on the collar. It is a deep, royal blue, the leather shining where the light catches it. She can see a soft lining of black fabric inside. The hardware is gold, two twin d-rings bolted in at the throat like she needs the extra security to hold her down.

She doesn't. She eagerly tosses her hair to the side and looks up at Catra with pleading eyes, begging for the collar without words. She wants it. She needs it. She didn't know she needed it until she saw it, but this isn't the same collar from before, plain black and softened from use. This isn't the collar that Catra keeps in the studio for clients to use. This is shiny and

new – *hers*. Catra chuckles to herself, reaching out to pet Adora's hair before she reaches into the bag and pulls out the golden chain leash, which bears a matching blue leather handle.

"So eager to be collared, princess," Catra remarks as she opens the collar and holds it out. Adora does nothing to protest, just ducking her head forward to allow Catra easy access to the back of her neck. "It needs to be broken in, so I'm setting it loose today. The collar doesn't necessarily mean that we're doing pet play. Today I'm just collaring you to show you that you are *owned*," Catra tells her, returning to petting through her hair once she has finished buckling the collar. Adora blows out a steady breath, letting her eyes slip closed as she sinks into the comforting weight of the collar around her neck.

It is stiffer than the one she wore before – and, unfortunately, Catra is true to her word and it is looser – but Adora is more than willing to wear it until it is comfortable. It feels nice to have the weight around her neck, a reminder that Catra is close enough to hold her leash. Adora feels a slight tug on it and forces herself to open her eyes to look up. Catra is still smirking, but her eyes have softened some. For a moment, she just admires the state of desperation Adora is in before she locks eyes with her again.

"The one rule of the collar is you never touch the buckle unless I order you to. No putting it on or taking it off without my orders. Most of the time I'll do it for you. Medical emergencies are the only exception. If you call red, I will remove it. Both of us rushing for it will just make it take longer," Catra tells her, their eyes locked together. It is a moment of seriousness before they get started. One last rule, and one Adora accepts readily, nodding and forcing herself to swallow. Her mouth is dry again.

"Yes, sir," she agrees. Catra smirks, yanking on the leash. Adora feels a jolt of desire run between her legs as she quickly hurries to stand. She barely manages to straighten before Catra is grabbing her and spinning her around towards the bed, a hand fisting her hair as she forces Adora to bend *down*. At first Adora tries to lay out, but a clawed grip on her hip shows her what Catra actually wants. Adora flushes crimson as she bends at the waist, lying her torso on the bed with her feet planted on the ground. Her legs are pressed together but she is still very much on *display* for Catra.

"Spread your legs, princess. Show me what belongs to me. You aren't allowed to raise your head from the bed," Catra orders her. Adora feels herself twitch, well aware that Catra can easily see the reaction. She knows Catra must be smirking behind her, but she can't look to see. She has her cheek pressed against the duvet, staring out into the room to look at… the painting of herself, in Catra's clutches, just like she is now. Fuck, Adora feels so hot all over. She takes a breath and shifts her legs apart until her hips are level with the edge of the bed.

Behind her, Catra purrs. Adora can't help the small whimper she releases. Her breathing is already labored, her core twitching with need and anticipation. Catra is right there, the toy sitting beside Adora on the bed and ready to be used, but Catra doesn't seem to be in a hurry as she rearranges Adora's hands so her wrists are pinned together at the small of her back and then wraps the chain of the leash around them. She isn't tied by any means, but the message is clear, and it has her squirming.

"I'm not tying you up because I know you'll be a *good girl* and hold still no matter what I do to you," Catra purrs above. Adora whines, trying to fight the urge to shift her hips, but fuck,

it's *hard*. She wants to be good, though. She nods a little, the motion small due to the awkwardness of her position and not from a lack of enthusiasm. Catra purrs as she releases Adora's hands. A moment later, Adora hears the sound of Catra's claws dragging across velvet and a drawstring being pulled. Her eyes flutter closed. Whatever Catra wants, Adora is ready to please her.

"You're not allowed to come until I say so, princess," Catra orders her. Oh, fuck.

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The plan was orgasm delay, at least in a way, before Adora even reacted to Catra mentioning it. That is why she mentioned it at all. Adora's reaction was enough to have Catra developing the plan even further in her mind. She bends her over the bed, fingering her while pressing the remote-control vibrator against her clit just to torture her. Adora gets deliciously loud when Catra starts fucking her with the toy. It isn't small, so Catra takes awhile to warm her up first, but eventually Adora can take it thrusting into her hard.

She keeps switching from lying face down, writhing beneath Catra's touch, to turning her cheek out to gasp for air until she gets overwhelmed and tries to hide her face again. She is a beautiful mess, her hair splayed out, skin slicked with sweat, and hormones pouring off from her. Her ass in the air isn't bad either. Catra grabs it with her claws out, or smacks it, sometimes just fucking Adora with the toy, other times touching her with her free hand, and once or twice pulling out completely to listen to Adora's desperate pleading not to.

The pleading cuts off when Catra presses the toy against her clit again. Adora bucks her hips back and moans desperately, utterly lost beneath Catra. She is barely managing to keep her wrists together. Catra keeps having to tug on the leash handle to tighten the chains looped around her wrists. She couldn't tie it if she wanted to and that is the *point*, but Adora seems so far gone at this point that when Catra tugs on the leash again – also tugging on the collar in the process, though only a little from how the leash is thrown over her shoulder – Adora doesn't correct her posture. Instead, she starts begging.

"Please, Catra, I need to-" she starts to plead, only to be cut off by her own loud moan when Catra pulls the toy away from her clit and spanks her *hard*.

"If you want something from your dom, you don't ask like that. And no, princess, you can't come yet," Catra orders, lining up the toy with Adora's entrance and pressing it in again. She is close and she has been for a while. Catra suspects that her order has been the only thing holding Adora back from a screaming orgasm. *Good*. Adora lets out a moan suspiciously close to a sob, her face buried in the sheets again as she tries to recover. Catra doesn't give her a chance, lining up her hand with the red mark on her ass and squeezing.

"I left a handprint, princess. Keep being disobedient and I'll leave you more. Now be a good sub and apologize," Catra orders her, squeezing just hard enough for the tips of her claws to dig in. Adora whines, panting heavily as Catra doesn't give her any reprieve from the thrust

of the toy, setting a relentless pace with it. Adora seems beyond words, but she is far from unhappy, burying her face down in the duvet and moaning loudly.

If Catra had worked her into a state like this just through punishment, she would be worried about Adora needing to use her safe words and being unable to, but she is squirming beneath Catra's touch and pushing back onto the toy as she moans. She manages to turn her face out, her eyes hooded and completely unfocused as she stares out at the room and sees nothing through the lust haze. Her shoulders rise and fall rapidly as she gasps in air.

"I'm sorry, sir. I'll be g-" Adora starts to beg, but she cuts off with a loud whine when Catra releases her ass and yanks on her leash instead to place pressure back on her wrists, reminding Adora once again that she *isn't* being good yet, so the promise she was halfway through making means nothing. It seems to be the final straw. Adora sobs, burying her face back down in the comforter. Catra pushes the toy in and holds it, narrowing her eyes at the back of Adora's head as Adora moans loudly into the bed, rising in pitch and then cutting off as she goes limp.

Limp but *twitching*. Catra pulls the toy all the way out and plunges her fingers in instead to find Adora's walls rolling down on her in waves of contractions. Catra smirks to herself as she pulls her fingers out and wipes Adora's slick off on her own ass. She lines the toy back up and presses in slow, like she wants to torture Adora with it, but really she doesn't want to overwhelm her when she just came. It was explicitly against Catra's orders, but that is the point.

Adora was so fucking ashamed of failing that she lied to Catra about it – by omission, but whatever. She can still barely talk about it. Her need to be assured during their last aftercare session drove the point home that Adora *needs* to see that failure isn't the end of the world. Catra was never going to let her come. The point was always for Adora to fail. After all, Catra has hardly gotten to take advantage of the toy's remote functionality in this position yet. This was just the beginning

She uses the remote, lying mostly-discarded on the bed, to turn the toy's vibrations off. She isn't done playing and she doesn't want it to run out of charge. Adora is spent, panting facedown on the bed. The haze usually starts clearing for Adora post-orgasm, but she also usually isn't this strung out. She tried really hard to hold out for Catra. Catra almost feels bad for stacking the deck against her, but she is going to make sure that Adora enjoys the rest of this, and she can apologize during aftercare.

"That's disobeying twice in a row, princess. It's time for you to be punished," Catra tells her, already moving to unwind the chain from around her wrists. Against the bed, Adora whines.

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Adora tried to focus on the discomfort at her wrists pressed together and *not* the filthy sounds coming from behind her or the low, turned-on growls Catra was making occasionally, but

Catra edged her for too long. Adora tries to hide her face in the comforter, whining when Catra orders her to stand, but Catra is having none of it. Adora doesn't want to be disobedient – not *again* – but she also doesn't want to face failing. Catra doesn't give her a choice, straightening her up and turning her around.

"Color, princess," Catra prompts her, her eyes boring into Adora's. Seeing that look on her face, Adora can't say anything but *blue*. She doesn't want to have failed, but she reminds herself of how good it felt when Catra punished her the last time she was wearing the collar. As Catra settles on the edge of the bed and bends Adora over her knee, Adora reminds herself she can say her word whenever she needs to. Catra has made that obvious.

The spanking hurts, of course it does, but it also has Adora worked up all over again. It feels good, and the toy is still *in*, a weight pressing into her that she feels every time she tries to squirm. Catra adjusts it a few times as she spanks her hard enough to leave handprints behind. She tells Adora as she does it, placing her hand lightly back over the red shape so Adora can *feel* where Catra has marked her. By the end of it she is soaking all over again and whining with every breath.

"You wish you could come again, don't you, princess?" Catra teases, bending to whisper it down into Adora's ear. Adora squirms, nodding a bit desperately. Fuck, she really does. She can't believe this is still going, but she really hopes Catra will let her come again because she is going to be a *mess* walking Catra out afterwards if not.

"Please. I want to come for you," Adora begs, knowing phrasing it like that will drive Catra wild. Catra's tail lashes behind her as her hand on Adora's ass squeezes in a small spasm. Is that enough? Fuck, she hopes it is enough. She *really* means those words.

"For me, huh, princess? And what if I don't want you to come?" Catra asks, her voice still so cocky and in control, like she has Adora right where she wants her. Adora moans, dropping her head to bury her face in the duvet as her cheeks burn. Catra doesn't let her hide, tugging on the leash and pulling her head back. Adora shifts her hips, able to feel the toy inside her but getting nowhere near enough stimulation anymore. Even if it were enough, she can't come without Catra's permission.

"Please. I need it. I behaved for the punishment," Adora begs. She isn't really thinking, just babbling *anything* that might give her some relief. She is worked up – already, that's how much Catra is affecting her – and everything in her is conflicting signals. The strikes hurt but feel good. She is pushed to her limit and yet can't come like this. She wants to come, but she also wants to hold out for Catra.

The toy buzzes to life inside of her. Adora cries out, her voice soft and *strangled* as she desperately shifts her hips, seeking friction, but there is nothing to rub her clit against or to press back against to push the toy deeper inside her. Catra has one hand on her leash and another holding the remote. There is no relief for her. Adora whines, shifting in Catra's lap. Apparently it is too much movement, because Catra tugs on her leash and makes a shushing noise.

"Are you going to be good just so I let you come, princess? You've already disobeyed once," Catra reminds her. Adora whines. Part of her wants to flinch away at those words, but she can

hear the excitement in Catra's voice. Catra is nearly breathless with anticipation. She likes having Adora like this. She isn't mad. She is probably enjoying the punishments herself. Adora takes a moment to catch her breath, a task made difficult by the vibrator – which is set on the lowest level, because her dom is *evil*.

"I'll be good. I'll do anything you want. Please," Adora begs. She sounds lost even to her own ears. Her heart pounds in her chest as the toy suddenly shuts off. Catra's tail is lashing again. Adora closes her eyes, waiting for *anything*. What Catra ends up giving her is a soft, satisfied rumble that makes Adora's breath catch.

"Good girl. You're going to service me, and when you eat me out *right*, I'll turn up the toy. You can come after I do, princess," Catra tells her. Adora's moan feels like it could rattle windows.

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Adora is a disaster. Catra ordered her to undress her – *without touching, princess, just take off my clothes* – and the restraint it took for Adora to keep her hands off Catra's skin as she unveiled it was obvious. Adora climbs onto the bed so eagerly when Catra tells her to get comfortable that Catra almost doesn't bother asking for a color, but as Adora stretches out at the head of the bed and Catra positions herself with a knee on either side of Adora's head, she has to check anyway.

"If you can't say your word, pull on my tail. *Gently*, brat," Catra orders her. Adora, who is giving Catra a taste of her own medicine and refusing to look up from between her legs, nods eagerly.

"Blue. And I'll tug if I need to. Please, let me service you," Adora asks her, breathless. Catra smirks to herself as she shuffles her knees up to get in a better position and lowers herself down onto Adora's face. Adora groans the instant her tongue meets Catra. Catra shudders a little herself, her tail lashing as Adora reaches up to grab her thighs and encourage her into a better position so she can get to *work*. Catra reaches out to brace one hand against the headboard as she fumbles for the remote with the other, her entire body lighting up.

Adora has always fucking loved this. They have only done it a few times – mostly because the one time they did it in Swift Wind, Adora hurt her neck and had to spend a few days carefully stacking pillows to accommodate it, so they were more cautious about doing it after that – but Adora always threw herself into it with enthusiasm. She loves having her face sat on, moaning as she works her mouth against Catra and sends shiver of pleasure through her entire body that turn her breathing heavy.

Catra has been holding herself together for far too long. Seeing Adora so wrecked for her had her soaking through her own underwear. Her whimpers and whines drove Catra wild. The bedroom is soaked in the scent of hormones. Catra's mouth would be watering if it wasn't so dry from how long she has been worked up. She sighs, sinking down into the warm heat of

Adora's mouth. Adora is clumsy at first as she finds her footing again, but soon she is rediscovering how to move her tongue in just the perfect way to make Catra's toes curl.

Catra squeaks, trilling and purring a little as Adora tugs on her thighs to encourage her forward. Normally Catra doesn't let her subs even think about directing her, but in this case, it's in the service of pleasing her, so she lets Adora shift her hips forward. Catra moans as she realizes the new position lets her rub against Adora's face and nose. Adora's skin is already soaking from Catra's desire. Catra knows from previous comments that Adora feels a bit like she is drowning – *"in the best possible way"* – in this position.

As long as Adora doesn't pull her tail, Catra is happy to let her keep drowning. Adora is turned on, groaning occasionally as she works her tongue against Catra and leaves her panting and quivering. It feels so good to be seated on Adora's face again, taking utter control and demanding that Adora pleasure her. Catra had planned to dirty talk to Adora during this part, but fuck, it feels too good. If she opens her mouth, she is sure to moan an embarrassing amount with each word. She clicks up the speed of the vibrator instead.

It's a reward of its own and Adora moans in response, writhing her bottom half but keeping her top steady so she can eat Catra out with determined purpose. She shifts her hands, gripping Catra's ass and groping her as she pulls Catra further down against her, happy to squeeze with her hands and dig in her nails as she buries herself in Catra. Catra leans heavily on her arm braced against the headboard, her breaths labored as she rolls her hips to get more pressure against her clit. Fuck, it feels so good.

Adora takes Catra's movements gracefully – *gladly*. She moans as Catra shifts her hips. Catra clicks up the vibrator and gets another set of moans that make her shiver. At this point her fur is standing on end, her tail lashing as she and Adora both restlessly shift their hips, caught in a feedback loop. Adora working harder just makes Catra turn up her vibrator, which makes her sub renew her efforts all over again. She is desperate, pulling back her hips a little and realigning, desperate for proper stimulation against her clit.

Adora may love to eat her out, but what she really loves is getting her off. She readjusts, sucking and licking against her until Catra is crying out softly with every breath, the sounds ramping up as she gets close. The vibrator speed is maxed out. Catra just has to moan loudly and ride it out now. She leans against the wall, the only relief she can offer a job well done and the promise of an orgasm. Adora works her over until Catra's entire body feels like it narrows to a white hot point between her legs.

Peace sweeps through her, a wave of warmth that almost feels like cool relief compared to the fire that was burning her down. Catra collapses forward, slumping a little against the wall as she quickly adjusts her position again, sitting up on her knees a little so Adora is no longer directly against her and can clean her up. She shivers as the aftershocks roll through her, Adora's tongue lapping over her eagerly. Catra can still hear the buzz of the vibrator.

"Good girl, princess. You did so well. You can come," Catra pants out, resting her forehead against the cool drywall. Adora moans with relief.

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After cleaning Catra up, it only takes a few more moments and Catra's fingers rubbing against her clit for the grand total of twenty seconds for Adora to come again. Catra ramps the vibrator down quickly but steadily this time, pulling it out gently and setting it aside as she unbuckles Adora's collar. Adora is far enough gone not to protest Catra taking it away, just giving a soft moan of appreciation when Catra drops down into her arms and sets to cuddling her while whispering soft assurances.

Adora happily buries her face against Catra's chest, breathing in her softness. She loves having Catra naked in her arms again, especially while she is naked too and can feel her pressed into her along every inch of her body. Adora feels a pervading sense of calm as her entire body relaxes into the peace of post-orgasm bliss. Catra is purring with that deep, rumbly purr she gets after satisfying sex. Adora sighs softly, sinking into the contented bliss.

"You're such a good sub. You did amazing for me," Catra sighs, her voice deeply satisfied. Adora feels a shiver run through her body. The words soothe her, but there is a part of her that protests she *wasn't* good. She tried to be, but she disobeyed Catra. She wants to be good for Catra, to listen to her and do what she asks. She didn't do that today, at least not completely.

"But I disobeyed. I got punished," Adora mumbles, her face still tucked in and hidden against Catra's chest. She is slowly pulling out of it and well aware she *likes* being punished – that's why Catra did it, after all – but part of her mind just can't make peace with Catra complimenting her now. Despite how the words feel good, a part of her tells her that they are hollow. Above her, Catra makes a gentle shushing sound.

Adora draws in a sharp breath as she feels Catra nuzzle against her hair and press a soft kiss to the crown of her head. Despite agreeing kisses were okay, they didn't kiss during the session. It wasn't really possible given their positions. They certainly didn't need any foreplay by the time they were ready to get going. Adora feels like her entire body strains up towards the soft touch, an assurance of affection despite her disobedience.

"Come here, Adora. Let me see your face," Catra instructs, one of her hands coming up to cradle the back of Adora's head. Adora can feel her heartbeat thrumming through her entire body, but she lifts her head. She finds Catra looking down at her with soft eyes. She has a small smile twitching at the corner of her mouth that is surprisingly satisfied. Adora blinks at her for a moment before insistent pressure from Catra's hand on the back of her head reminds her that Catra told her to come here. Adora shuffles up a little and almost instantly finds herself being kissed.

She lets out a soft noise of surprise, but she gladly sinks into the embrace. Catra is gentle but thorough, kissing her slow but with no lack of affection. Adora feels a shiver run through her body, leaving calm in its wake. Catra's kisses have always felt like they either soothe some deep part of her soul or light her body on fire. Today, Adora sighs happily when they eventually have to part for air. Neither of them goes far, Catra turning her head a little to rub their cheeks together. The scent mark is just another layer of assurance.

“Adora, I don’t care if you fail. I never did,” Catra whispers to her before kissing her again. Adora feels her mind go blank for a moment. Oh. Oh, Catra isn’t just talking about sex anymore. It takes her a moment of realization before Adora manages to catch up and start kissing Catra back. This kiss is just as soft and sweet as the last one, Catra cradling the back of her head as if she wants to hold her close as they embrace. When they finally part, Adora is breathless.

“You took your punishment beautifully. BDSM isn’t about always behaving or succeeding. It’s about what makes you feel good. Did you like your spanking?” Catra asks her, still using that soft tone of voice that she started with. The combination of her tones and her words, so filthy and so assuring at the same time, makes Adora shiver. She swallows thickly, holding Catra’s gaze as she nods.

“I did. It felt good,” Adora promises her. Good isn’t even the half of it, but she thinks Catra knows that if her smirk is anything to go by. Catra leans forward, kissing the tip of Adora’s nose softly this time. Adora doesn’t know why that feels like the most intimate of all their embraces – maybe because Catra leans their foreheads together afterwards and the two of them get to just breathe in each other’s air.

“Good. I wasn’t going to allow you to come today until you did it once on your own, anyway. You didn’t fail, Adora. You did exactly what I wanted,” Catra assures her, kissing her cheek now. Adora feels like her brain stalls, trying to process the fact that Catra was apparently bluffing her the whole time. Part of her brain says it isn’t true and Catra is just trying to assure her, except Catra has already done this once before.

The last time Adora wore the collar, Catra told her she was setting her up to fail. This time she didn’t tell her up front, but in hindsight, Catra really did set her up to fail. Adora doesn’t know how she even held out as long as she did. She swallows, nudging her nose against Catra and breathing a sigh of relief when Catra understands the prompt and kisses her properly again. The kiss soothes her as she processes. When they part, she feels much calmer, a bone-deep contentment running through her.

“I didn’t expect BDSM to be so psychological,” she admits, partially as a joke and partially as quiet acknowledgement that she knows what Catra is doing – at least, now she does – and she appreciates it. Catra chuckles, shifting the hand on the back of Adora’s head to play with her hair now she is more settled.

“When you do it professionally, it’s all about the psychology. It’s less whipping and orgasm or more about finding what you truly *need*. I can do both when I’m with you, though,” Catra tells her, turning to rub their cheeks together again, marking Adora as *hers*. Adora hums, a sound that matches Catra’s own contented purr. She already loved what they were doing before, but Catra is right that doing it like this gives them a whole new layer to it.

Adora realizes she may be fucked, but in the best way possible. If today was a taste of how things are going to play out from now on, she doesn’t know how she is going to hold herself back from calling Catra up every day. Right now, though, she already has Catra here, and she feels blissful knowing that she really did do well for Catra. She sets to cuddling her with new enthusiasm.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: Orgasm delay/denial, spanking, and collar & leash with light bondage implications.
I've added an *extremely* rough chapter count to this. In fact, it doesn't even match the number of chapters in my outline right now, but I'm giving myself a slight cushion.

Flexibility

Chapter Notes

> Friendly reminder that Catra is flexible and strong enough in canon to stand on one foot while putting the other one on the back of her own head to help push her helmet off – which means she can not only fold into that position, but get leverage in it.
> BDSM description in the end note.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was expecting their session on Friday to be fun, but maybe not as good as it ended up being. It was even better than when they were in the car together. From the moment they started, to cuddling together afterwards and sharing lazy kisses, to Adora hugging her goodbye at the front door once Catra's car arrived, everything just felt right. It was soft when it needed to be and electrifying otherwise. Getting to come herself during a session only heightened the overall experience.

Higher peaks lead to greater falls. Catra has two regular sessions scheduled for Saturday evening, but she wakes up with her entire body feeling sluggish. Her mind is moving slowly too - except when it comes to anxiety, in which case it is quick to remind her how desperately Adora needed assurance after the session. Her inner demons whisper that she was too cruel for Adora. Catra went too hard, too fast. Adora likes BDSM, but how could she want cruelty directed at her – how could anyone?

It's her old demons, wearing her down after a session. There wasn't even that much sadism, but despite that being her most common trigger for a day of dom drop, days like this can happen at any time. Catra doesn't get out of bed until noon. Scorpia's keys are gone from the hook when Catra wanders into the kitchen, and she can hear the rapid clicking of Entrapta's mouse that signals she is gaming coming from her room, so Catra is mostly left to her own devices as she plods around the house.

On a normal day like this, Catra would invade Scorpia's space or retreat deeper into her own. Despite the fact that Scorpia isn't here to be bothered by Catra curling up at her desk window, Catra opts for the latter. She gets water and fixes herself a single Hot Pocket before she retreats back into her space. She tries to nap off the soreness, but it doesn't help. Yesterday felt so good, but her body is tired, and her heart alternates between contentment and anxiety.

Catra needs to get herself in order for her sessions tonight. With a heavy sigh, she breaks. She reaches for her phone and calls Adora.

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Adora is excited to receive a call from Catra. She isn't struggling with sub drop by any means, but she loves talking to her even if it isn't something she necessarily needs. They talk mindlessly, just like they used to, Adora pestering Catra with questions about what she is painting lately and Catra teasing Adora about what a gym rat she is when Adora asks when they can next go together. They decide to stick to the schedule of going twice a week together on Sundays and Wednesdays, though.

"Plus, that leaves us plenty of days in between to play," Catra teases Adora, purring down the line when Adora draws in a sharp and audible breath. She can't help it – yesterday was *amazing* and she is already desperate for the next time they can see each other like that. In the meantime, getting to have casual calls like this or competitive workouts together is enough for her. They both have a lot to catch up on in each other's lives anyway.

"I'm going to have to go soon. I have a session in two hours and I still need to eat lunch and shower and stuff," Catra tells Adora, reluctantly. Adora frowns, glancing at the clock. Two in the afternoon is a bit late for lunch, but she is also frowning because she just doesn't want Catra to go. She knows she will see her tomorrow, but they have so much to catch up on, and some of it is stuff they can't just chat about while jogging side-by-side on the treadmill.

"Okay. Do you have a bit more time right now? I know you told me some stuff about art school, but I really want to know how you became a dom. It seems like an interesting story," Adora asks. To her surprise, there is a long moment of silence on the other end of the line before Catra sighs.

"I'll tell you some other time. We'll need to have a proper catch-up session. I don't have time for it now," Catra tells her. Adora blinks, feeling her heart stutter a moment before it catches up and starts beating again.

"Okay. I'll hold you to it," Adora responds. Catra chuckles, and Adora *swears* she mutters something under her breath, but she doesn't catch what it is. She has to just satisfy herself with the fact that Catra promised they could properly catch up as they say goodbye.

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"Are you free tomorrow night?" Adora asks as they wipe down the equipment they were using at the end of their workout. Catra tries not to react, but her tail lashes behind her and her ears twitch. She can't hide her surprise – or excitement. She is more than ready to play with Adora again, despite the short window. She doesn't have any appointments on Tuesday so far, so if she does have dom drop issues, she can just deal with them on her own time and not pester Adora.

She didn't bring it up when she called her yesterday. She should have – she really fucking should have, she isn't holding up her end of the honesty bargain by not telling her – but she

just isn't up to talking about it on a day where she is already fighting the insidious thoughts. On days where she isn't suffering from the dopamine crash, she can lie to herself that it isn't that important and she won't need Adora next time. She knows Adora would disagree if she knew the truth, though.

That's the problem with being a professional dom: admitting to struggling with drop yourself feels even more shameful, like she would be admitting that she isn't cut out for the work. She has been handling her drop for years. She doesn't want to discourage Adora from their sessions. If the drops were worse than the highs, she wouldn't still be doing this, but they don't always come, and even when they do, they're kind of worth it for the fun of the session beforehand.

"I, um, oh," Adora sputters behind her, drawing Catra out of her thoughts. Both of Catra's ears swivel back, listening intently, but Adora has straightened and is just looking at Catra where she is bent over the weight bench to wipe it down. Catra's tail is still lashing behind her, which Adora seems to have finally noticed.

"I just meant to catch up? But we can definitely do that too. Not opposed at all," Adora tells her, sounding flustered. Catra can't still her tail, but she manages to school her face into an even expression before she turns around to face Adora. Adora's expression is sheepish as she smiles hopefully at Catra, shrugging a little as she does so. Okay, so maybe she really didn't mean to play, but she is offering it now. Catra isn't about to turn her down, not when she already got excited thinking about it.

"What time?" she asks. Adora lights up, beaming at her and nodding a little, clearly eager.

"Does seven-thirty work? I'll make us dinner, we can talk, and then we'll, uh-" Adora cuts off, her gaze darting around. Catra can feel heat in her own cheeks, but she rolls her eyes as she breezes past Adora to drop the disinfectant wipe she is still holding in the trash can. There isn't anyone within human earshot, and the lycan at the front desk has earbuds in and is reading a graphic novel.

"We'll *play* after dinner," Catra finishes for her. A glance at the mirror wall shows her that Adora is flushed. She nods quickly, so fast that her ponytail whips up and hits her in the back of her own head. Catra snickers to herself as she walks back to where she left her water bottle. She missed getting to see Adora be a giant dork.

When they leave the gym, Adora has a spring in her step and insists on driving Catra to the closest bus stop despite it only being a few minutes away by foot. Catra lets her. She likes being back in Swift Wind, curling up in the passenger seat and finding herself purring at the sheer familiarity in the space. Catra hesitates when Adora parks to let her out, but then Adora undoes her own seatbelt and turns to look at her hopefully, so Catra commits.

She rolls her eyes and leans forward, the only signal Adora needs to light up and hug her. If Catra weren't already purring, she would start when Adora leans forward and wraps Catra up in her arms. Catra happily buries her face down into Adora's shoulder, rubbing her cheek there and rumbling as Adora squeezes her back. Catra doesn't like goodbyes, but she missed goodbyes like *this*, both of them clinging onto the other because they don't really want to let go.

Adora doesn't protest to the scent marks Catra leaves, marking her territory. If she did, Catra would deflect that she is just marking her sub in a less embarrassing way than making her wear her collar out and about. That would certainly shut Adora up. The thought alone is enough to get her excited for what they are going to do tomorrow. Catra quickly pulls away and gets out of the car before Adora can notice her tail beginning to twitch with anticipation or the blush on her cheeks.

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Adora didn't know how to cook shit when she and Catra broke up. They learned within two weeks of moving into their first apartment together that it didn't have a functioning fire alarm because Adora would have set it off after burning dinner if it was at all capable of detecting smoke. At university, Adora could rely on the cafeteria, and during breaks she cobbled her way through meals, with Catra being the more competent chef between them.

Things have changed. They had to after Adora was living – and cooking – on her own. She is actually decent at it now. She has to follow a recipe and she still struggles to tell when things are done just by looking at them, but she doesn't risk setting her house on fire or anything. Adora follows a tried-and-true recipe for dinner, something simple that she can't fuck up. She doesn't have time to cook it twice.

Usually she showers after work unless she is going to be working out, but whatever they end up doing, she is certain it is going to count as exercise, so she just changes into comfortable clothes and watches TV until Catra texts that she is heading over. Adora prepares them both glasses of water – both in the bedroom and at the kitchen table – while Catra rides over. Catra eyes Adora's cooking with suspicion when she arrives, but the lack of smoke in the air seems to convince Catra to settle down at the kitchen table.

After the first bite doesn't kill her on the spot, Catra eats gladly. Catra doesn't even rib her for her cooking, so it must not be half bad. After a few minutes, she seems totally at ease in Adora's kitchen, though Adora notices her glancing around it as they eat. It's the one part of the house that Catra didn't really explore when she was prowling through the house after spending the night. She seemed to want privacy as she invaded Adora's and poked through her house.

"How'd you manage to afford a house?" Catra asks, gesturing with her fork around the kitchen before taking another bite. Adora snorts, shaking her head.

"I'm leasing to own it. In twenty years, but still, it would be nice. I really like the place. It's the kind that I always imagined, uh, us getting one day," Adora explains, shrugging and blushing a little. She doesn't know how to explain that her ideal house never changed even after Catra wasn't in her life anymore. Adora had thought about what they would need for years, and that was still all she could think to want when she went looking for a stable place. Catra's eyes snap to hers, locking on and burning intensely. Adora quickly looks away.

“I was just hopping between dirt-cheap apartments before that. Saved on the cheap rent, but I was moving every year because the apartments all had issues. I needed more routine than that. I went looking for somewhere I could see myself staying for years and managed to stumble on this place the day it was listed,” Adora elaborates, trying to distract Catra from her rampant lesbianism if nothing else.

Adora is certain that Catra already knows that she didn’t let a thing about them go. Adora told her she still loves her and hasn’t really tried to date anyone else, after all, but it’s a lot of pressure to place on someone you’re just trying to be friends with. She doesn’t want to make Catra uncomfortable. Catra clears her throat and nods, not seeming to know what else to say to that.

“It’s a nice place. Seems expensive, though, and I know *I* am. Are you really in vendor relations?” Catra asks as she takes another bite of food. Her tone isn’t accusing, seemingly just curious. Adora supposes that she could have easily been scrambling for a cover during the conversation where Catra found that out, but it was the truth. She shrugs more in response to the price comment than anything else.

“Glimmer’s mom gave me a recommendation and helped me get a job after I dropped out. I’ve been promoted pretty quickly. At this point, I’ll be fucked if I wreck Swift Wind or something big happens, but in general, I’m doing okay,” Adora elaborates. Her job really is boring to describe. Adora doesn’t mind it – the work is either procedural, which she is great at, or social, which shakes things up in her otherwise routine days – but she isn’t going to bore Catra with it.

“As long as the sessions weren’t straining you too much. I know I’m priced as a luxury,” Catra tells her, poking at her meal. Adora feels her cheeks heat preemptively. The sessions weren’t cheap, but she wasn’t putting herself in danger with them. She knows that would have just pissed Catra off.

“You *are* a luxury. But you’re worth it. And I don’t generally spend a ton of money outside of my living expenses, so I could afford it,” Adora replies, trying to smirk, but she is pretty sure it comes out a bit shy. She is nervous about overstepping, but luckily, Catra doesn’t seem bothered. Her cheeks heat and she ducks her head, but she looks more flustered than upset. Her tail lashes against the side of her seat as she takes another bite a bit desperately, like having her mouth full explains why she hasn’t come up with a reply to that. Adora smirks a little.

“Speaking of, how did you become a dom in the first place?” Adora asks. She has been cautious to ask this question – it feels extremely probing – but having time together in private so they could talk about stuff like this really is why Adora invited Catra over in the first place. She is excited to have another session, but she definitely wasn’t brave enough to think about proposing it until Catra brought it up. Catra still seems a bit flustered, but she breathes a small sigh, no doubt relieved that Adora isn’t going to continue to poke at her getting flustered over so small of a comment.

“It’s Lonnie’s fault, actually,” Catra tells her. Catra chuckles when Adora’s brows shoot up to her hairline in response. “Remember how she was working at a leather bar sophomore year?” Catra asks her. Adora nods, her mind already spinning out on how things go from a bar –

regardless of the leather aspect – to full-blown BDSM and domming. Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie were all living in the same small apartment since they moved to Bright Moon after high school graduation.

Kyle was a BMU student along with Adora, though Adora hardly ever saw him since he was a business major. Even knowing that Catra moved to Bright Moon to go to Mystacor, it is a leap to go from a friend's job at a leather bar to domming. Catra must see her disbelief – or maybe just her confusion – on her face, because she chuckles as she takes another bite, chewing it thoroughly before she resumes her story. Her small smile falls, a dark look ghosting over her face as she draws in a breath.

"I was a mess after the breakup. I got accepted into Mystacor, but I wasn't going to make the transition on my own. I visited Kyle's house – you know, where he had that raging party when we were sixteen and his parents almost killed him when they saw the damage? – and got his number from his dads. Called him, asked for Lonnie, and then… I asked for advice on finding a place to stay in Bright Moon. Maybe it was the fact I was asking her for help, or maybe just my voice, but she instantly asked me if we broke up," Catra tells her, swallowing thickly as she looks down at her plate.

Adora's heart beats into her throat as she carefully reaches out under the table and places a hand on Catra's knee, squeezing gently. Adora knew the breakup had to be rough on Catra too, but she wasn't expecting her to have been in this rough of a spot when she was the one who dumped Adora. It really goes to show how badly she needed something that Adora wasn't giving her. Catra takes a steadying breath before she looks up and meets Adora's eyes again, shrugging a little as if the nonchalant gesture can cut how clearly intense the whole thing was for her.

"She was the only person I knew, so we started hanging out some. She told me about a BDSM show that was happening at the bar one night, and I went mostly out of curiosity. All I did that night was watch, but it was put on by a professional domme, and I was instantly intrigued. I was working part-time retail at that point. It couldn't compare," Catra explains, shooting Adora a wry look. Some of the light comes back into her eyes as she talks. Adora nods. She definitely knows what Catra means. It is an experience like no other, so of course it is a job like no other.

"Lonnie made fun of how into it I was, but she always told me whenever Huntara, the domme, was coming back for another show. After going to a couple, I approached Huntara, and she took me on as an apprentice. Lonnie ended up being as interested as I was in what she taught me, and eventually we ended up both leaving our jobs to dom full-time. It pays a hell of a lot better. It's been four years since I started," Catra tells her. Her spark is back, happy to be talking about the passion she found instead of the breakup that led to the discovery.

"You're a great dom. You've come a long way in such a short time," Adora replies. She has seen a lot of growth from Catra in their sessions alone. Only somebody who knew her well before can truly see how much she has changed, but to Adora, she has blossomed into a stunning woman, and she was already amazing to begin with. The compliment makes Catra's

ears twitch, a slight blush coloring her cheeks, but she looks up to Adora with a sly smirk instead of getting flustered like before.

“Oh, I’ll show you coming in a short time later,” Catra promises. Adora temporarily forgets how to breathe.

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They eat, and they chat, but ever since Catra leered at Adora, there is a sense of anticipation in the air. Adora is wearing her hair in a lazy half-up style, and when she goes to gather up their plates, trying to be a good host, Catra reaches out and casually snaps Adora’s hair tie. Adora instantly straightens up, her cheeks flushing as she looks at Catra with wide eyes. Catra smirks at her, her tail twitching on the seat beside her.

“Be a good girl and clean up. Do you have something in mind to beg for today, or should I play with you as I see fit?” Catra asks. Okay, maybe saying the words and watching Adora’s immediate reaction is enough to have Catra turned on already. Adora is already on her way to being a mess, though, so Catra isn’t jumping the gun. Adora opens and closes her mouth a few times, her cheeks steadily darkening. Eventually, she closes her mouth and ducks her head a little as she shakes her head.

“No, sir. Um, just not looking for something pain-focused today,” Adora requests, quickly fleeing to the sink with their plates. Catra cocks her head as she watches Adora dump the plates in the sink with her cheeks blazing. She is fine with taking Adora’s masochism out of consideration for today, and she is more than aware that things that are fun some days can be too much on others, but she also wants to be careful. Adora doesn’t seem anxious as she hesitates and then starts washing the dishes when Catra doesn’t say anything or call her back.

Catra takes a sip of her water and then slides off her seat, silently padding to stand behind Adora. Adora knows she is there – she watched Catra approach in her periphery – but despite a slight hitch in her breath she keeps rinsing off the plates. Catra watches the lines of her body starting to tense up, getting *twitchy* as she opens the dishwasher to put in the first plate. Adora is clearly excited. Catra gives a purposefully-loud *hmph* before stepping forward and reaching her arms around Adora’s torso to grope her without preamble.

“Catra!” Adora immediately squeaks out, jerking a little with surprise as she looks over her shoulder with blazing cheeks. She looks far from upset. Catra lets a slow grin spread over her face as she pointedly pinches Adora’s nipple through her shirt, not even slowing her exploration of her ex-partner’s body. Catra already took out her hair tie and Adora didn’t protest – they have started, and that means Catra can touch her how she pleases.

“When we’re in a session, you’re *mine*. If I want to touch you, I get to,” Catra purrs to her, holding Adora close against her chest to drink in the slight shiver that runs through her in response. “What’s your favorite color, princess?” Catra prompts her, innocently, watching the

corner of Adora's mouth twitch in response. Adora rolls her eyes even as she takes a steadying breath and turns back to the sink. Good. Catra wants her to try to return to her task.

"Blue," Adora replies confidently. Catra purrs to herself as she reaches up to the neck of Adora's tank top – she is wearing a scoop-neck tank, which provides perfect access for Catra – and slips her hand inside, working her fingers under the edge of Adora's sports bra to squeeze at her breast directly. Catra closes her eyes, feeling a building sense of satisfaction as she kneads at Adora.

"Good girl. Is there a reason you want to avoid pain? Knowing the reason for avoiding that can help me avoid other things you might not enjoy today either," Catra asks, hooking her chin over Adora's shoulder and rubbing her cheek against the side of her head. Her sub should smell like she belongs to her. Adora squirms a little in her arms as she thinks about it, her desire obvious and hands clumsy on the dishes.

Catra only lets her go when Adora turns a little to put the plate in the dishwasher. Once she is done and has it closed, she turns to Catra with burning cheeks. They are only centimeters apart and the proximity doesn't seem to be helping Adora think. She bites her lip, worrying at it as she finds her words. There is already a dark light in her eyes, eager for when they finally reach the bedroom.

"I just have work tomorrow and think it would be a bit too much right now. Um, I want to be good for you. I'll behave without it," Adora promises, doing her best to achieve eloquence despite her breathlessness. Catra's tail swings behind her, giving away her pleasure as surely as her purr does. She decides to lean into it, letting a small smile tug at her lips as she reaches up to take control of Adora's chin and tilt it up. Seeing the telltale signs of Catra's pleasure, Adora eagerly lets her head be tilted back, meeting Catra's gaze with an almost-ravenous look in her eyes. She is hungry for praise, as always.

"I can work with that. Don't worry, you won't have the option to misbehave today," Catra assures, watching Adora's eyes dilate in response. She was in the beginning stages of planning out something that would actually require a lot of restraint on Adora's part, but if Adora isn't up for punishment, then Catra can just *restrain* Adora for herself. Catra smirks as she reaches out and takes a flustered Adora's still-wet hands to lead her to the bedroom.

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Catra leads Adora to the bedroom and orders her to sit on the side of the bed while she goes to the drawer where she stashed her things. Before she left last time, she ordered Adora not to look in there. Adora has been obedient, but she already knows the majority of its contents from when Catra filled it. She isn't surprised when Catra pulls the blue rope out of the drawer, but it does make her mouth go dry. Shibari is on her list. It is one of the things that Adora never needed to try to know she likes it. The very suggestion of restriction is thrilling to her. Catra grins at Adora as she sets the rope on the bed.

“Would you like to be bound up for me, princess? Wrapped up and mine to do whatever I want with?” Catra asks, easy confidence in her voice. She knows the fucking answer. Adora nods eagerly.

“I would love that,” she breathes, ridiculously earnest, but it’s true. Catra’s grin certainly doesn’t fade at Adora’s words. She saunters over with a wide grin stretching across her face. The next thing Adora knows, she finds herself crowded against the bed, Catra hands on her thighs encouraging her to lift them to sit on the bed. Once Adora does so, Catra kisses her as her hands roam over her, feeling every inch of the skin that Catra made her claim over clear back in the kitchen.

Adora shudders a little beneath the sudden intensity, kissing Catra back eagerly. She loved what they did last time, but they didn’t get to kiss during it because of their positions, and that’s a *damn* shame. Catra manages to strip Adora with stunning speed as she distracts her with the heat of her mouth. Her hands are possessive as she does so, claws flexing against Adora’s skin and causing her to shiver, but Catra doesn’t come anywhere close to actually hurting her, though she might leave a bruise or two.

Adora certainly won’t be turned off by having a few crescent marks to show for this though, so she arches up into the touch until Catra suddenly pulls away. Adora whines softly as she flutters her eyes open to find Catra sliding off her with a firm smirk in place. Adora opens her mouth to protest the distance and then promptly snaps it shut again when Catra reaches for the rope. Catra’s grin only widens as she begins to unwind the rope.

“Kneel on the bed, princess. It’s time to dress you up,” Catra orders her. Adora is eager to follow orders, shifting to sit fully on the bed and kneel facing Catra, but Catra chuckles and points towards the end of the bed. “You don’t have a mirror in here so we’re going to have to make do. Sit facing the painting. You’re not allowed to look away until I have something more *interesting* for you to look at,” Catra tells her.

Adora flushes, twitching down on nothing, but she does as she is told, swallowing thickly as she turns. It leaves her face-to-face with the portrait of her quite literally in Catra’s clutches. There isn’t anything but the proximity of their bodies to suggest it, but Adora imagines that the two bodies are supposed to be mid-intercourse. The positioning just makes it look like Catra has a strap buried in her, the hands clutching and claiming as they hold Adora still so she can have her way with her. The painting shows her just as Catra wants her now: *owned*.

Catra climbs onto the bed behind Adora, still fully clothed. Adora would really like Catra to be as naked as she is, but she can’t deny that Catra being on a totally different level from her turns her on. Besides, Catra likes clothed sex. Maybe that’s what she is going for. Adora’s breath grows unsteady as Catra’s hands begin to wind the rope around her body. Adora doesn’t know much about shibari except that it is gorgeous and she likes looking at art of it.

She knew she would like it, especially after they tried other forms of restriction, but as Catra begins to knot the ropes, Adora feels her entire body light up. Her *state* isn’t helped by the fact that Catra gropes her as she goes. She covers Adora’s torso in a latticework of rope, grinning as she massages at Adora’s chest and purrs about *how pretty your tits look all bound up, princess*. Adora is fucking soaking. When Catra has her naked like this, there is nothing she can do to hide the fact that her thighs are wet now.

“If you can stay still while I do your arms, I’ll finger you while I tie your thighs,” Catra offers, her voice dismissive and smug. She knows exactly what that offer is going to do to Adora. Adora openly moans, squirming a little but nodding quickly as she tucks her arms behind her back to offer them to Catra, kneeled behind her after finishing the knotwork there. Catra chuckles, taking one arm and carefully bending it up before duplicating the position with the other and pressing Adora’s hands together.

“This is called the *reverse prayer*, princess. Fitting, considering how much pleading you’re going to be doing,” Catra purrs in her ear, her voice hot. Adora gasps, the sound sharpening to a whine when Catra nips at her earlobe before retreating to tie her arms together. The position isn’t painful, but it is difficult to hold without the ropes to help – especially when she is *this* turned on. She is trying to be good, her gaze fixed on the painting, but fuck, she can feel the ropes wrapped all around her and she wishes she could see them as much as she wishes Catra’s hands were between her thighs already.

“When I said I wanted to see more of your art, this isn’t what I meant,” Adora manages, almost a quip if it weren’t for how strained and breathless her voice is. Her chest is straining against the ropes with every breath. They aren’t tight enough to be uncomfortable, but she can feel them clearly, and they especially squeeze on her tits where Catra crossed them just to watch the curve of Adora’s chest swell around the rope.

The comment seems to amuse Catra. Her chuckle is so coy and calm that Adora clenches down on nothing. Fuck, how has Catra reduced her to a soaking mess with a few words and a single length of rope? Catra has bound her wrists together, but her elbows are supposed to be pressed together, and it is difficult for her to maintain without the rope there yet. When Catra drops both her hands to grip Adora’s thighs and tug them open, her elbows part and Catra tuts over Adora’s loud moan.

“You’ll come when I decide. Now hold still,” Catra orders. Adora doesn’t know how the hell she is supposed to do that now her legs are spread and a glance down lets her see just how exposed she is, but she knows better than to try to close her legs after Catra spread them. Her only saving grace is that Catra is behind her. She has to hope the arm bindings are simple and done with quickly.

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When she is done with Adora’s arms, Catra brings the ropes low over her hips, tying them in a similar way over her ass as she did over her chest to show it off as well. Doing so requires Adora to lie on her stomach. She tried to close her legs when Catra ordered her to change positions, but Catra quickly corrected that by spreading them for herself, digging her fingers into Adora’s inner thighs as she did so and watching her *twitch*, her body begging to be fucked. Too bad for her that is far down on the agenda. Catra herself is soaking watching Adora be reduced to such a mess for her and she has no intention of stopping anytime soon.

“So helpless like this. I could fuck you any way I want, however *hard* I want,” Catra purrs to her, leaning down and nipping hard at the meat of Adora’s thigh because she *can* and because the sensation of her beneath her fangs is blissful. Adora moans loudly, panting as her thighs twitch together for a moment before she manages to correct.

“Catra, you promised,” Adora whines, her breathing heavy and tone as whiny as it is lost. Ordinarily Catra would correct a sub for not calling her sir, but fuck, she *loves* Adora whining out her name like that. She chuckles, her tail lashing back and forth behind her as she straightens up and returns to work tying Adora up.

“Soon, princess. But all I promised was to give you a bit of relief. You aren’t coming until I’m done with you,” Catra informs her. Adora’s answering whine is loud. Her squirming ramps up as Catra finishes with her ass. She rolls Adora over herself since she has no way of getting leverage with her top half bound up like this and her bottom to soon join it.

Despite her teasing, Catra follows through, slipping one hand between Adora’s slick folds and fingering her for a few moments until Adora seems like she is enjoying it *too* much and Catra returns to tying her. Adora whines and pants and even *kicks* a little, throwing a quiet temper tantrum and throwing Catra wide, begging eyes, but Catra’s grin just widens as she reaches up and directs Adora’s gaze back towards the painting.

“Keep looking or I’ll wait even longer to get you off, princess,” Catra orders her. Unlike last time, Adora is allowed to come as much as she is able to, Catra just has no plans on giving her a quick and easy orgasm. Adora keeps whining, but she lifts her head back up to look at the painting. She doesn’t manage to be still, but Catra enjoys the twitches and jerks, so she doesn’t correct her further. She slides her fingers between Adora’s folds, giving her the relief of a touch, and then moves on, wiping her fingers off on Adora like she is nothing more than a rag to wipe her hands on.

Privately, Catra thinks the fact that they both know better is what makes it so hot. Being dismissive of her sub – or, well, *pretending* to be – is quite common in Catra’s domming, but the sadistic practice doesn’t usually light her blood on fire like this. When Catra finishes tying Adora’s legs so her heels are pressing into where her thighs join her ass, trapped in a kneeled position, Catra rewards all her beautiful sounds and writhing with several long minutes of uninterrupted bliss as Catra touches her with both hands, fucking her and giving her clit attention until carrying on for another second risks bringing her over.

Catra wipes her fingers off on Adora’s cheek this time. Adora is too busy panting to protest, but she flutters her eyes open – Catra isn’t cruel enough to insist Adora keep her eyes on the painting while she has two fingers in her – and throws Catra a hazy, pleading look. Catra grins as she shifts to push her fingers into Adora’s mouth. Adora parts her lips eagerly, groaning softly as she licks at Catra’s fingers. Catra pumps her fingers in and out slowly for a moment, claiming Adora’s mouth, though Adora gives it to her readily.

“You just love to be used, don’t you? You’re such a good sub, always so eager for me,” Catra purrs to her, voice satisfied and teasing. Adora trembles beneath her, her breath quickening as she gives a pleading moan. That doesn’t make Catra want to let her get off. It only feeds her sadism. Catra grins as she slides back and away from Adora, looking down at her handiwork.

Adora whines as she shifts away, managing to clear some of the lust haze from her gaze to send Catra a truly desperate look.

“Please, sir. I’m so close. Just to take the edge off,” Adora asks, her voice breathless. Normally those cow eyes could crack Catra’s resolve in two, but when combined with the flush on Adora’s cheeks and the shine of her own slick on her lips, Catra wants nothing more than to prolong Adora’s suffering. Catra grins, leaning down again until they are close enough that it is almost difficult to focus on each other’s gaze.

“Keep begging, princess. It won’t speed me up, but I like the sound,” Catra tells her, her tone smug. Adora’s eyes flutter as she whines again. Catra manages to tamp her smile down just long enough to contrast her dismissive words with a light kiss to Adora’s brow before she pulls back and grins down at her again, predatory and *promising*.

“You deserve to see yourself right now, and I want you to remember that with or without the ropes on, you belong to me. Let’s have a photoshoot, shall we?” Catra tells her, pulling away again to pull her phone out of her pocket. Adora flushes a dark shade that will look beautiful beneath the camera lens.

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When Adora said she wasn’t up for pain, she didn’t realize she was signing up for *torture* instead. It doesn’t seem like that is what it is going to be at first, but looks can be deceiving – for instance, Catra looks cute but has a heart of *evil*. Adora thought she just wanted to take photos like she did when they tried wax play, but Catra gets *involved* this time. She moves Adora’s body, posing her beneath the camera.

Adora can writhe a bit in her bindings and that’s about it. She has to take it as Catra poses and touches her, cooing about how beautiful she is and how much she likes her fluster. Adora is flushed with heat all over, soaking and aching, desperate for any relief. She wants to get her hands on Catra so badly, to reduce her to a puddle just like she has made Adora, but more than that she wants to please her, and this is *definitely* pleasing her.

When Catra finishes taking the photos, she finally undresses. She positions Adora where she wants her, kneeling at the foot of the bed, and then she strips slow just to tease her. Adora can’t stop herself from straining at her bindings. As hot as the reverse prayer was when Catra first did it, Adora’s need to touch her has skyrocketed since then. She even growls a little to herself as she struggles to reach for Catra, standing naked in front of her with one hip cocked out and a smug grin on her face.

Despite her cockiness, it is now evident that Catra is just as wet as Adora is. That still doesn’t change their dynamic when Adora is this desperate for her and Catra is perfectly in control of her. Adora is twitching just thinking about the fact that Catra has a picture of her facedown and bound in rope. How is she supposed to go about her life knowing that is resting in Catra’s

pocket? How is she supposed to sleep at night when she is wondering if – *wishing that* – Catra is touching herself to it right then?

“I know you want to touch, but it seems like your hands are a bit *occupied*. Don’t worry, I can take care of things myself,” Catra tells her, smirking as she circles around the bed to climb onto it at the head. Adora feels herself clench on nothing as *horror* dawns on her. She is bound, but her legs aren’t tied together – Catra clearly likes to keep her legs spread – so Adora is able to inelegantly twist and shuffle around until she is kneeled a third of the way up the bed and facing the headboard.

Catra is sprawled out amongst the pillows, her legs spread wide and one hand already draped artfully down into her lap and rubbing between her folds lazily. Her tail lashes with excitement as she smirks smugly at Adora.

And then she bends down and folds in half, ducking her head between her own thighs.

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Catra discovered she could eat herself out a little over a year after the breakup. She had begun training under Huntara, as well as training her own body, and what started as a joking thought became a goal when she realized she was *close*. She can’t bend far enough to get her tongue inside, and she doesn’t know how attractive it looks to others, but she can pump her fingers in and out of herself as she licks and sucks at her clit.

It’s not a very comfortable position, so she doesn’t think she could hold it long enough to get off from it alone, but she does do it every now and then as foreplay for herself. The illicitness of the position works her up enough that the psychological effects compensate for the limited physical stimulation she gets. It keeps things interesting. She suspects it doesn’t matter whether it looks attractive to observers or not – the mere fact that Adora is watching Catra pleasure herself in front of her sends her into a frenzy.

Catra certainly can’t do this and *watch* Adora’s reaction, but luckily Adora is incredibly noisy about how it is making her feel. She doesn’t say it outright, but she breathes heavily, whining a little when Catra moans – mostly for show, though the sounds *are* genuine and she thinks Adora would be able to tell if they weren’t. Most of all, Adora runs her mouth, pleading with Catra to let her touch her.

“You can use my mouth. I’ll take care of you.”

“*Sir*, I’ll do anything.”

“Fuck, please, I want to touch you so bad.”

“Untie my wrists and I’ll fuck you right.”

“I could have you screaming. Or you could use me until I am.”

Despite her incessant begging, the sound of which makes Catra moan and her tail lash with excitement, Adora is good and stays at the end of the bed. The best she could do while tied up like this would be to shuffle up and faceplant into Catra and hope Catra allowed it, but her obedience would be praiseworthy if Catra's mouth wasn't *occupied*.

The plead that finally makes Catra pull up, stretching out her entire body and licking her lips with a satisfied sigh, is "I don't even need to come, I just want to please you, *please*," delivered with such desperation that Catra would break regardless of what words Adora actually said. Adora's breath quickens when Catra stretches out, her limbs shaking with satisfaction as she stretches out of her curled position.

Adora watches her with bright eyes, suddenly quieting and straightening up to sit at attention, the image of a well-behaved sub as she waits. Catra grins lazily at her and watches Adora's eyes dilate, the ropes on her arms straining as she seems to unconsciously try to reach for Catra. Her lip darts out to wet her lips as she flicks her eyes down between Catra's legs before meeting her gaze again.

"Please. I want to service you," Adora breathes out, desperation written over every inch of her body. Catra grins, the tip of her tail twitching with anticipation. She shifts, raising her knees up and spreading her legs wide to make room for Adora between them.

"Do a good job, princess, and I'll think about untying you," Catra tells her. Adora practically scrambles forward.

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Adora doesn't need to do a good job, not really, not when Catra is this turned on. Even without the use of her hands, it doesn't take long. Catra grabs fistfuls of her hair and directs her, tugging her head into whatever position she wants it, exercising utter control over Adora. Half-sprawled out on her stomach and still bound, Adora couldn't resist if she wanted to, and she definitely doesn't. When Catra's moans become loud, high-pitched gasps, Adora feels an endorphin high rush through her whole body.

Adora works her tongue over Catra through her orgasm, shifting to long licks to clean her up when Catra relaxes back into the sheets, her post-orgasm purr rolling through her body. She lets go of Adora's hair, switching to petting through it gently as Adora finishes, licking her own lips and rubbing her face into the sheets for good measure before she drops her head to rest it on Catra's thigh. She sighs happily as she settles down onto her new pillow.

Adora is soaking. Her body spent every second up until Catra settled at the head of the bed *screaming* that it wanted to be fucked, but bringing Catra over brought Adora her own sense of relief. Coming isn't so urgent now, and she loves Catra's post-sex contentment. She is actually disappointed when Catra starts stirring and pulls out from beneath her. Adora looks up, sending Catra a pout, but Catra just smiles softly and shifts down the bed.

Adora lets out a sigh and goes limp when she feels Catra's hands land on the knots and start to undo them. The ropes feel *amazing*, but Adora is also eager to stretch her limbs out. Catra has been dragging out this torture for so long, Adora is ready to settle into cuddles and aftercare. After all the edging, she kind of wants to pass out cuddling Catra.

"You were so good for me, Adora. You're so fun to dom," Catra assures her, dropping a soft kiss to Adora's sweaty skin after she undoes the knot that covered it a moment before. Adora heaves a contented side, nuzzling into the sheets a little but going otherwise limp. Catra keeps coming up with assurances to murmur to Adora as she works to slowly and steadily to unravel the ropes binding her. When Adora can unfold her legs and stretch them out, it might be one of the most physically satisfying sensations she has ever felt.

Stretching out and sinking into relaxation as Catra finally sets to freeing her arms feels as good as bringing Catra over did, just in a different way. Catra instructs her not to move her arms for a minute, her voice firm enough to tell Adora that it is a safety issue, but after she has freed them, massaged them, and given Adora the all-clear to move, her first order of business is to reach for Catra and tug her closer. Adora's arms feel weak after all the restriction and straining, but despite the tug being more of an encouragement than manhandling, Catra falls into her arms, nuzzling against Adora's jaw and rubbing her cheek there.

"I still need to unbind your torso," Catra points out, but she sounds amused and her words are still rumbling. Adora makes a low sound of acknowledgement, ducking her head to bury her face in Catra's mane and breathe her in. She is wearing it down today. Adora isn't great at pattern recognition, but she is good at paying attention to Catra, and she has noticed that she has had it down whenever she has come over. It was down at the party too. She wears it up for professional sessions and working out, but right now it's down and Adora can just bury herself in its familiar and comforting mass.

Catra is purring still. Despite bringing them up, she doesn't seem to actually be that bothered by the ropes still adorning Adora. She lets herself be cuddled as Adora relaxes into the sheets.

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Catra swears Adora is close to falling asleep and she didn't even come. They cuddle for a few moments before Catra can't ignore one of the knots digging into her torso and she pulls back, assuring Adora with firm pets down her arms as she makes sure she only moves as far away as is necessary to finish freeing her of the ropes. Adora finally seems to notice the rope kisses all across her body, temporary but slow-fading imprints of the rope everywhere it was pressed into her.

Adora runs her own hand over the indents, her breath catching as she marvels at them. Catra smiles to herself as she watches. Adora looked beautiful trussed up, but she is beautiful like this too. She stretches out in the sheets until her limbs shake just a little and runs her hands over the marks as she lazily flits her gaze between them and Catra. Catra knows her fondness

is showing on her face as she sets to coiling up the rope again for storage, but expressing affection in any form can be aftercare, or at least help with it.

Adora seems largely content this time, though. Things were intense from a sexual frustration standpoint, but there was nothing emotionally difficult, and Catra didn't even punish her. She walks back to the drawer to stow away the rope and eyes Adora on her reapproach, but Adora seems content, lifting her arms in a blatant request for cuddles as Catra walks back to the bed. Catra rolls her eyes, but she climbs into Adora's arms and settles on her chest.

"You didn't secretly get off when I wasn't looking, did you?" Catra teases, rubbing her cheek on Adora's shoulder. Adora was allowed to, Catra is just pretty sure she would have noticed. At the same time, Adora seems extremely content even without an endorphin release. Adora snorts as she drapes an arm over Catra and begins to absently pet down her arm.

"No, pleasing you just always makes me happy," Adora returns, turning her face to nuzzle into Catra's ears. Catra feels her heart stutter as she sets to marking her sub with renewed vigor if only to keep hiding her face. Why couldn't Adora have used the same crass terms that Catra did? Probably just because she is a massive fucking sub. It's the service top thing too. Adora has always gotten off on pleasuring her.

Catra draws in a deep breath, soaking in Adora's scent but also assessing how she seems. Overall, her body is relaxing and cooling down. She seems to have no interest in getting off herself now. Catra's tail twitches on the bed as an idea comes to her. She has tortured Adora by not letting her get off enough already, but Catra can't help how fun it is, and things can swing the *other* way too. She purrs to herself, earning a happy hum from Adora in return.

"We have two options right now," Catra says, conversationally, a smile tugging at her lips as she feels Adora pause beneath her. "We could cuddle a bit more and then I could finger you without all the dom-sub stuff and just let you have a relaxing orgasm," Catra explains, her words rumbling with her excitement. Adora is relaxed and content beneath her, but her breath still hitches at Catra's words.

"Or…?" Adora prompts back.

Catra grins.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: Bondage/shibari, orgasm delay again (though in a different way), and private exhibitionism/consensual voyeurism (between Catra and Adora in Adora's house).
I teased this during LotD, but ever since I saved a screengrab of Catra doing that foot-on-the-back-of-the-head thing, I knew I needed to do something with her flexibility in a smut scene.

Brat

Chapter Notes

BDSM note at the end, but it's tame.
There was a bit of a "cliffhanger" at the end of last chapter, if you've forgotten lol.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It hasn't even been a day since Catra walked out of Adora's house with a smirk firmly in place and Adora is already realizing this was a terrible idea. When Catra presented her with option two, it sounded like a challenge, and Adora's competitive nature insisted she could make it a week without coming. She was fine Monday night, happy with Catra lying in her arms, and she has certainly gone longer before, so it seemed like success was guaranteed and she would easily earn some praise.

Adora wouldn't have any difficulty meeting the challenge if it weren't for the fact that Catra set it in the first place. Now that she knows she isn't allowed to get off, she can't quiet her libido. She can't stop thinking about the amused curl in Catra's voice when she told her to be a good sub and see how long she can last. The fact that Catra is seemingly determined to make this a true challenge also doesn't help. She calls Adora Tuesday night for seemingly no reason except to purr innuendos to Adora in a sensual voice.

"You're evil, you know that?" Adora huffs, shifting a little in her seat. She is in her sunroom, stretched out and watching the sunset. A week never felt like a long time to go without masturbating before Catra walked back into her life, but Catra *affects* her. The chuckle she gives in response is breathy and satisfied, making a shiver run through Adora. It's a gorgeous sound.

"People pay me for sadism, Adora. That's a *compliment*. What, is this too hard for you?" Catra asks, cooing the final sentence. Adora squeezes her eyes shut and resists the urge to whine petulantly. It's only fucking *Tuesday*. She doesn't know how she is supposed to last until Sunday, especially if Catra is going to keep calling her up just to tease her like this. Catra is enjoying this far too much, purring a little at Adora's inability to talk.

"Wow, princess. I guess you're lucky I have to cancel our gym trip tomorrow. You would be a mess," Catra tells her. Adora immediately feels disappointment spark in her chest as she pouts.

"What are you going to be doing?" she asks, though she can guess that Catra got a booking that conflicts with Adora's schedule. Unfortunately, the time when Adora is free is also the time when a lot of Catra's clients are open and thus want to book appointments with her. To her surprise, Catra is silent for a long moment. The silence only grows more suspicious the longer it stretches, until Catra eventually sighs.

“Nothing. I’m kind of sore, and I have appointments Wednesday and Thursday mornings, so I just don’t want to go to the gym and make it worse,” Catra admits. Adora blinks in surprise. She was shocked when Catra managed to bend herself like she did last night. She has no idea how long she held it for. It felt like an *eternity* before she let Adora up to take care of her, but she is well-aware that the exquisite torture was warping her perception of time. Being in that position for even thirty seconds seems like it could elicit soreness, though.

“Are you alright? I, uh, I didn’t know you could do that *at all*. If you need someone to bring you an ice pack or something, I would be happy to,” Adora offers. She would really love to have a chance to take care of Catra, at least a little. Adora always loved when she had chances to do something for Catra. A gentle rumble at the other end of the line encourages her.

“Nah, I have stuff to handle it. We’ll find time to meet up before Sunday, though. I want to make waiting harder for you,” Catra replies. Adora flushes. Well, that’s not what she wanted, but she can’t deny she likes it.

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Dom drop comes in a lot of forms. Catra wasn’t really having mood issues on Tuesday – especially not after calling with Adora – but her body was stiff and sore. It made her grouchy, if nothing else. Admitting to Adora even just the physical issues that can arise from her job feels like progress. Her heartrate simultaneously sped up and *dropped* when Adora asked if she was alright, but when she didn’t go on to lecture Catra or insist she needed help, Catra was soothed.

She wants to handle her shit for herself and she has plenty of experience with sessions leaving her strung out. The Wednesday morning session only worsens her soreness. Her client wanted whipping, and while Catra is always happy to show off her skills with her whip, it takes a lot of muscle strength. Catra picked up whip tricks to go with Huntara’s ringmaster persona while she was apprenticing under her, but she came to appreciate the whip as a way she could cause pain without feeling the impact of the strike directly herself.

That disconnect makes it dangerous to do without training, but it also helps with her dom drop. She can focus on the cries of pain-pleasure and scent of desire in the room and assure herself that her sub is happy. The physical distance also helps lessen the emotional attachment and thus the later drop. Even with those factors, Catra is feeling sore and listless by the afternoon. She hasn’t been able to paint due to the body aches and it is getting to her. She tries to nap it off, but she wakes up quickly when Entrapta makes a racket coming home from work.

She still feels sluggish. She forces herself to get up and make dinner in a bit of a haze. Now, she kind of wishes Adora would come over and cuddle her. Catra doesn’t need to be babied, but she acutely misses the affection she gets at the end of her sessions with Adora. With her regular clients, their aftercare is usually Catra giving some form of affection – though limited

– and verbal assurance. She has a teddy bear in the cabinet for clients to squeeze if they need it, as well as lollipops, and she makes sure their physical needs are met such as soothing their sore areas and getting them water before they leave.

Subs often ask her if they did well, and sometimes even if she enjoyed herself – Adora isn't her first client to get off on pleasing their dom – but they never assure or soothe her back. They are paying her for the experience, after all. If they know about dom drop, they probably assume that she has it handled as a professional. The emotional distance of domming strangers does help mitigate some of the emotional effects, but not all, and things like the hormone drop and physical demands are issues regardless.

Catra stretches out on the couch after dinner. She isn't going to get back up after she gets back to her room and collapses on her bed, so she waits on the couch for Entrapta to appear out of her room for their Wednesday night evening of *Etherian Makers*. Entrapta comes out of her room ten minutes before eight o'clock like always, greeting Catra cheerily. She isn't deterred when Catra just grunts back. Catra doesn't move from her position taking up the entire couch, but Entrapta just lifts her head up and drops down on the couch with Catra's head now shifted into her lap.

Entrapta hums as she waits for the show to start. Normally she likes to talk now - usually gushing about her current project, either for work or whatever she is doing in her personal time at the moment - but maybe she can pick up on Catra's exhaustion, because she just sets to rubbing swirls on Catra's cheek. Entrapta is the only person who can get away with that. She would let Adora do it too if Adora wanted to, but she has never tried before. She prefers to pet Catra, but Entrapta likes the feeling of Catra's fur swirling beneath her fingers, and she stops if Catra growls to signal she is tugging on her fur too much.

Entrapta first tried to do it on Catra's arms, but her fur is longer there and it hurt to have it twisted. Catra hissed and skittered away from the housemate she was still getting to know. Eventually, when Catra was more comfortable and willing to let her try again with some modifications, they found that Catra doesn't mind it on her cheek. She actually kind of likes it herself. Entrapta does it over her scent glands, and it relaxes Catra to have them rubbed against, some biological holdover that rewards her with serotonin for marking something as her own.

Entrapta's humming instantly silences once the show starts. She makes a lot of sounds in her day-to-day, but she is also an attentive listener when she needs to be. She and Catra like the show for very different reasons, but it's nice to have something to do together, and Catra likes cuddling up like this, even if she'll never admit it. Entrapta talks enthusiastically during the commercial breaks, speculating to Catra what the product of the current artisan or inventor the show is following at the moment will look like when it is finished by the end of the episode, and Catra finds herself purring quiet acknowledgements in response.

Her eyes slip closed during the commercial break as Entrapta talks about how incredibly inefficient the process of the sculptor being followed is. The show follows all types, from artists to inventors to engineers, but apparently this artist is so inefficient that it's bothering Entrapta. Catra is only half listening, but her ears twitch when she hears Scorpia walk by. Scorpia is a mountain of a woman and would have trouble traveling silently if she wanted to.

Her steps are cautious, but she isn't trying to sneak by as she edges into the living room and then, to Catra's surprise, settles in one of their armchairs.

They have two, one reclining and one not. Neither of them matches each other or the couch. Scorpia settles in the farthest one, sitting down slowly like doing it quietly will stop Catra from noticing her settling in. The attempt is somewhat ruined when Entrapta turns to Scorpia in the middle of her speech and asks her for an opinion. Catra listens to Scorpia draw out a long, somewhat anxious *uhh* for several minutes before she – rightly – points out that she knows nothing about art.

"You can't rush the creative process, Entrapta. It isn't about being efficient, it's about expressing yourself," Catra points out, somewhat reluctantly, as she stretches her limbs out slowly and blinks open her eyes. Entrapta is twisting her mouth above her as she thinks that over. Though it's a very different kind of creation, Catra is well aware that Entrapta's work designing automation equipment involves creativity as well, but it's a different kind that she is pretty sure doesn't require a muse. If Catra loses her muse, her art becomes difficult to make.

Even after five years, Adora has still remained her most consistent muse that she returns to often. For a long time Catra had to rely on memories to get inspiration from that source. Now she has Adora back in her life, and she *really* would like to paint, but she has to wait until the soreness has passed or it will just get worse. She can't afford to be in bad shape when her job requires so much physicality, but it has been awhile since she has tried to contort herself like that, and apparently she lost some of her flexibility in that time.

Catra turns her head to look at Scorpia as Entrapta chews that one over. Scorpia is sitting in her chair, looking caught between sheepishness and feigned casualness. She doesn't usually watch TV with them. Scorpia likes fictional shows with storylines and Catra usually sticks to things that are more documentary or competition-based. Scorpia has watched TV with them, but it has been a few weeks since the last time she stuck around in the living room while Entrapta and Catra were watching something.

She and Catra have been carefully avoiding each other ever since the party. They don't ignore each other, nor do they duck away to their rooms the instant they spot the other – well, okay, they did for the first few days but they are both past that now – but they haven't done anything one could call "hanging out" since then. The closest they have come has been being in the kitchen at the same time. Scorpia is clearly testing the waters. It is a bad day for her to be doing it, but Catra doesn't say anything as the show resumes after an ad for a washing machine.

She doesn't mind Scorpia's presence. If Scorpia can actually treat her like a friend this time, she would be happy to treat her the same. This is usually Catra's time with Entrapta, but Scorpia isn't being intrusive or talking over the program like she sometimes does. Catra isn't having a great day, but Scorpia being willing to sit out in the living room while she is there actually makes it a bit better. It gives her hope that they are on their way to being real friends again.

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Adora is ecstatic when Catra calls her on Thursday and asks if she wants to come over to look at her paintings. She is suspicious too – Catra outright *declared* she was going to all but torture her on Tuesday – but she really wants to see not only Catra's art, but where she lives now, so she quickly agrees. She really wanted to just pick up the phone and call Catra Wednesday night, but she didn't want to be overbearing, especially if she was tired after a session, so she is glad that Catra reached out for herself soon after.

Catra texts Adora an address and, after gently ribbing her, agrees Adora can come straight there after work. Adora has never been filled with such giddy excitement while driving in rush hour traffic before. She bounces on her heels as she rings the doorbell on the narrow townhouse that she is *pretty* sure is the right one. It's kind of hard to tell with how close all the houses are on this street, but when the lock scrapes and the door opens, Adora finds Catra on the other side, her ears and the corner of her mouth quivering with amusement at Adora's eagerness.

Adora misses being able to kiss Catra hello, but when she opens her arms hopefully, Catra rolls her eyes and steps aside. For a moment Adora thinks a hug would be too much, ducking her head and hurrying inside before her disappointment can show, but once inside Catra slips up close and hugs her. Adora feels an instant wave of peace sweep through her as she hugs Catra back eagerly, squeezing her to her chest.

"Needy," Catra teases, a low whisper near Adora's ear that threatens to send a shiver down Adora's spine. She was fine on Wednesday – notably, the one day they didn't talk – but Catra was once again teasing on the phone when they talked on Thursday. Catra has barely done anything today, but her physical presence does a lot for Adora. Catra chuckles as she pulls back, sending Adora a knowing look. Her tail is twitching from the effort of holding back, but she doesn't pounce.

Adora is fairly certain she only holds back because they are in the shared entryway of the house. Catra doesn't lead her up into the townhouse proper, instead leading her through the narrow door beside the staircase up. Through it is a utility room, half dedicated to laundry and half filled with painting supplies. Adora didn't know what to expect, but it wasn't for this many canvases to be cluttering the back half of the room. An easel shoved against the wall and seems to need the support as it groans beneath the weight of yet another canvas, this one easily as wide as Adora's armspan and covered in a myriad of bright colors mixing together.

"Whoa," Adora murmurs as she steps into the space, turning her head to look quickly between the many canvases. A lot of them aren't visible at the moment – either because they are covered in painters' sheets, wrapped up for storage, or leaned with their painted side facing away from the middle of the room – but the sheer *number* of them kind of shocks her.

"Please, half of these are crap, I just never get rid of anything unless it's to sell it," Catra scoffs behind her. Adora turns back to her with wide eyes, blinking slowly as she takes in Catra's reddened cheeks and twitching tail. Her arms are crossed and she is looking away. Whether she knows the source of Adora's awe or not, she is flustered by it. Catra's words

make Adora's throat clench painfully. Catra has had to throw away enough of her art, destroying it herself before someone else could get their hands on it and destroy it while mocking her.

Adora swallows, looking at the room overflowing with canvases. This is seven years of work – and primarily just the last five. Catra had canvases all over her apartment before the breakup, but either she has really kicked up her production rate since then, or it just looks like a lot in such a small space, because this is far more than Adora ever expected. She turns back to Catra and reaches for her hand. Catra flushes, her tail lashing behind her as she meets Adora's pleading gaze.

"Show me everything?" she asks.

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Showing Adora all her art is, in a way, showing her everything that happened in the last five years. Her moods can be seen somewhat in her paintings, but Adora also learns the courses she took when Catra comments things like "I didn't want to paint that, I just swear Professor Patterson had a fetish for pears and made us paint them constantly." She learns about some of the places Catra has been when Catra explains where she pulled elements of inspiration from for a piece.

Most of all, she learns just how fucking pathetic Catra is, because Catra is a goddamn moron and didn't think about how often Adora shows up in her paintings. She was just excited to have her over and get to talk about her art. She got an email back from that gallery on Thursday morning and it was discouraging. It wasn't a rejection, but they just said they would "add her to their list" and included their rates for renting out space. Catra isn't going to bother renting out space for a show when she doesn't have any way to attract people to come see it.

Her only hope is being in a larger show with its own advertising or invitation list. She could arrange an art show every month and it wouldn't do her much good if buyers weren't coming. She just needs that first break, and then she can reasonably get an agent, and from there hopefully *opportunities*, but it looks like this gallery won't be it. She was – stupidly – hopeful for it, and she kind of just wanted to talk to someone about her art who would care. Despite how thoroughly it lays her soul bare, she doesn't regret asking Adora over.

Adora gushes about every piece. She might not know anything about the technicalities of art, but she likes things that are pretty, and apparently she finds Catra's art beautiful. She especially talks about how much progress Catra has made, a compliment that really only Adora can give her. It makes Catra flush and duck her head. She has been pretty flustered as they picked through the canvases, Adora's compliments combined with the bright look in her eye when she spots traces of herself keeping Catra blushing.

Catra hasn't painted Adora's face since they broke up, but she is still everywhere in the room. Her golden hair swings over a shoulder as someone with their back to the viewer wades into a field of flowers. Her hand reaches into frame to hold aloft a glass shard with its edges just beginning to dig into her flesh, a single rivulet of red dripping down. Her curves are visible where she is enwrapped in a blanket of ocean waves. Traces of not only Adora's body, but places they have been together, or the bright, bubbling colors Catra always associated with her, are everywhere.

In some of the paintings, Adora could probably still be recognized by someone who knows her, but many are likely to only be recognizable to Catra – and, of course, *Adora*. Luckily, she seems as flustered as Catra is by her numerous appearances across the canvases. Catra is thrown off her footing at first, but she knows how to play with a flustered Adora. Part of the reason for inviting her over was also to toy with her, and now Catra feels the need to do it to establish dominance if nothing else.

"Like that one?" Catra asks in a low purr, slinking up behind Adora as she blinks down at a painting of a naked woman running out into the surf of the sea. Her back is to the camera, but Catra was detailed in her rendering. The woman in the painting even has the dimple on the right side of her butt that Adora has, as well as the small smattering of three freckles on her shoulder.

The woman is painted in the realistic but softly-curved style that Catra has always preferred. It gets compared to renaissance art sometimes by people who don't know a ton about art – a lot of Catra's friends have drawn comparisons to it or a similar art period - but Catra is pretty sure that is mostly because back then they didn't shy away from portraying cellulite or try to remove some of a woman's ribcage to make her look more attractive.

"I, uh, it's, um. Detailed. The ocean looks incredible," Adora stammers out, jolting a little as Catra plasters herself against her back. Catra purrs right in her ear, drinking in the slight shiver that runs through Adora. Catra can feel her heart pounding – she can even hear it – and the interest in her scent is obvious. Catra wraps one arm around Adora's waist, dropping the other one to trail over Adora's thigh. Adora's entire body tenses with anticipation and she sucks in a sharp breath.

"Catra, what-" she starts to ask, and then quickly cuts off. Catra pauses, blinking at the back of her head. She would have thought what she was doing was obvious. She told Adora when she invited her over that she was looking forward to *playing* with her. They aren't technically in a session right now, though, and Adora seems to be struggling a few steps behind. Catra considers her options. She needs to back down, at least some, but backing down too far is going to make this entire thing awkward.

"Adora, what's your favourite color in the painting?" Catra asks, pointed but a touchy breathy, as she reaches her hand up from Adora's thigh and instead presses to fingers to the side of Adora's chin, gently guiding her line of sight back to the painting. Adora draws in a sharp breath, giving a slight twitch as she picks up on the words and their seductive tone.

"Blue," Adora breathes, softly. She says the word like a confession, some of the tension seeping out of her body with it. Catra grins to herself as she lets her fingertips trace down, slowly running down the side of Adora's neck, and then over the swell of her breast, and then

down the subtle lines of her abs as Catra works her way back down to her thigh. This time, her hand lands on Adora's inner thigh, stroking in a slow path towards where her legs meet. Adora's breathing is already heavy, her muscles jumping as she fights to stand still.

"Good girl. I told you I was going to have fun toying with you," Catra breathes into her ear. Adora gasps, the sound tinged with a moan until she claps a hand over her own mouth to stifle it. Her nostrils flare as she breathes heavily, fighting for control of her own body and *losing*. Her body doesn't belong to her anymore. It's Catra's, and right now Catra wants to make her stifle a symphony of noises into that hand. Entrapta was blasting her game audio in her headphones when Catra came downstairs and Scorpia is at work, but Adora doesn't need to know any of that.

"Quiet, princess. I'll make the reward worth it on Sunday," Catra promises her, turning to drop a light kiss just beneath her ear. Adora gives a small, pathetic moan that is probably supposed be an affirmative, Catra combines that kiss with stroking her fingers upward and touching Adora over her jeans. Adora jerks a little in her arms, her knees knocking together as she moans into her hand, but she isn't trying to get away. Rather, her legs almost give out from under her.

"So responsive today, princess. Is a week really *so long*?" Catra purrs in her ear. Adora moans into her hand as Catra rubs against the front of her pants. Adora is wearing jeans, which are far from ideal for this, but that just makes the tease worse. Catra grins as Adora squirms in her arms.

If nothing else, this will distract her from asking about the paintings of her.

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Adora knew that Catra was going to tease her. She should have realized the depths of evil she is capable of after Monday night. Adora is soaking and Catra is reveling in it, purring filthy phrases into her ear as she touches her through her clothes. The touch is nowhere near enough to come from on its own, but the entire situation has Adora's blood pressure skyrocketing, her moans barely dampened by her own hand.

She isn't allowed to touch herself, but fuck, if Catra touches her enough to bring her over now, does that count as disobeying? Adora is moaning too much to remove her hand to warn Catra to stop. Catra should know her signals anyway. She certainly seemed to know while they were playing last week. Adora squirms in her grip, caught between wanting to tell Catra to ease off and wanting to finally come.

Her decision is made when a door bangs open just outside the room.

Catra and Adora both squeak and leap apart, turning in unison toward the door to the utility room, which is thankfully still closed. Adora's heart is pounding in her chest, hormones and adrenaline pumping through her as the movement out in the entryway ceases suddenly.

Alright, so they did more than *squeak*. It was more like two small yelps of surprise. Apparently the intruder heard them. Catra has just enough time to turn to Adora and fix her with a pointed look before footsteps resume and someone cautiously opens the laundry door.

“Catra? You alright?” a familiar voice calls before the door opens fully to reveal Scorpia, looking rather different than the last time Adora saw her. Adora supposes she really should have realized it was Halloween and that was a costume, because Scorpia looks for all the world like a completely average person, dressed in black pants and a purple t-shirt. The goth makeup is gone, her eyes appearing owlish as she blinks in shock at Adora’s presence. Beside her, Catra clears her throat.

“Just startled. Didn’t realize how late it had gotten. I wanted to show Adora my paintings,” Catra offers, shifting from her startled, ready-to-fight to stance to a more casual one. She shrugs as she folds her arms and eyes Scorpia almost warily. After a long moment of Scorpia staring at Adora, she manages to tear her eyes away and look to Catra. Scorpia looks uncomfortable, but Adora doesn’t blame her. Her own cheeks are blazing.

Unless Adora does something obvious, there is no way for Scorpia to know what they were just doing, but it feels like they were caught with their pants down. Well, with Adora’s pants down – and Catra’s hand inside them. Adora shifts back and forth on her feet, aware of the way her underwear clings to her. She would really like Scorpia to go so she can take a few minutes to gather herself and then head home wondering why she ever listens to Catra.

Scorpia doesn’t leave. Instead, she clears her throat and steps deeper into the room, marching up towards Adora. Adora feels a growing sense of dread with every step, but she stands her ground, turning her body to face Scorpia despite how a part of her tells her that if she stays turned away, Scorpia won’t be able to guess what they were doing. She shouldn’t know *anyway*. Scorpia stops in front of her, drawing in a deep breath.

“How well do you know Perfuma?” Scorpia asks. Adora blinks at her, a bit shocked. Of all the things she expected Scorpia to say, that wasn’t one of them. Adora really has no clue why she is asking about this. Did Perfuma say something to her at the party?

“Uhh, pretty well? She’s my best friend’s ex and they’re still close. She was at his wedding,” Adora explains, awkwardly. Perfuma and Bow dated at the start of high school from what Adora knows. Perfuma was an upper classman and graduated first, but they kept in touch even when she went off to university. She only made her way back to the Bright Moon area four years ago.

Catra told Adora during one of their phone calls that she was at the party because her other roommate that Adora still hasn’t met yet knows Perfuma, but sometimes it seems like everybody knows her, so that wasn’t really surprising. Adora’s connection to Perfuma shouldn’t be of interest, but Scorpia’s face falls with obvious disappointment.

“Oh, um, do you know if she’s straight?” Scorpia asks, shifting a little nervously and clicking her claws. Adora stares at her. In her periphery, she can see Catra also staring at Scorpia, visibly surprised and a bit confused. This is not what Adora was expecting at all – especially because anyone who has known Perfuma for more than five minutes should know she isn’t straight.

“Perfuma only cares about gender when she’s subverting it. She usually prefers women, though,” Adora responds. Apparently Perfuma found herself preferring men more before she transitioned, so she jokes that her sexuality is just gayness, but she has a definite type, and it’s anyone built like a linebacker. She said what she liked about Bow back when they dated was his abs. Scorpia looks just her type, and she lights up a little at Adora’s words.

The absolute last thing Adora thought she would be doing the next time she met Scorpia was pulling out her phone to share a friend’s number, but Catra seems amused by the whole thing as Scorpia rambles that they talked at the party and *gosh, she seemed cool*. Adora can’t really argue – Perfuma is probably the most interesting person she knows, and she’ll be shocked if she doesn’t write a memoir by the time that she’s fifty – but she wasn’t expecting Scorpia’s awkward wave as she backs out of the room still thanking Adora.

It leaves her and Catra standing in silence. Adora turns to Catra, not really sure what to make of that. The corner of Catra’s mouth twitches as she shrugs.

“I don’t think she picked up on anything,” Catra says. Adora relaxes. Scorpia was awkward, as was Adora, but considering their last interaction, it makes sense for them both to be cautious around each other. If Catra doesn’t think that Scorpia noticed what they were doing, Adora will be more than happy to continue living under that impression, even if it is a false one. Catra glances back at the room, a blush high on her cheeks as she considers it for a moment.

“Come on, you should probably head out anyway. We’ll see each other on Sunday,” Catra promises her. Adora nods, ducking her head a little with embarrassment. She really can’t wait.

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Catra walks upstairs cautiously after she sees Adora out, but Scorpia is humming cheerfully as she bustles around the kitchen, already fixing herself dinner. Catra eyes her from the entryway for a moment, well-aware Scorpia hasn’t noticed her presence yet. Scorpia seems her usual fairytale princess-level of cheerful, humming some pop song Catra vaguely recognizes as she pulls ingredients out of cabinets. Catra edges into the room, hopping up onto the counter and poking at the useless fruit bowl Scorpia insists keeping beside her just to have an excuse for her presence.

Really, she’s curious. She intended to show Adora out before Scorpia got home from work because, despite them seeing to have made progress, she didn’t know what would happen when they ran into each other. From sniping at each other to Scorpia awkwardly trying to make friends, she wasn’t expecting for Scorpia to all but ask out Adora’s friend. Catra only met Perfuma for a few seconds, so her only impression of her was the glamorous costume she wore that night, but Scorpia was rather complimentary of her the next day.

Part of Catra wonders if she has only been able to start moving on because she has found a new person to target her affections on. As Scorpia turns around, startling at the sight of her and then greeting her warmly with the news she wants to make her mother's pumpkin bowls and so will be fixing food for all three of them tonight, Catra wonders if the reason really matters. Unless the rebound failing somehow sends her running back to Catra, anything that helps her move on is good, right?

Adora said she knows Perfuma pretty well. She probably wouldn't be friends with someone who would mistreat Scorpia. Scorpia seems a bit nervous as she begins chattering to Catra about how it isn't fall without the bowls and she just has to have some today, but Catra would be that's just because she is worried about Catra asking her about it. Catra whole-heartedly endorses any attempt of Scorpia's to move on, though.

That's how she finds herself enlisted as Scorpia's baking assistant for the first time in weeks – maybe months – as Scorpia gets going on her recipe. Her mother is more dexterous with her pincers than Scorpia is and she could really use help to make some parts come out even and pretty looking. Catra doesn't know how to say "I'm excited you're trying to move on", but she hopes that being nearby and chuckling at Scorpia's jokes is enough. Regardless, if feels good to do it again.

--

I'm about to head over, princess.

Take out your ponytail.

Two sentences, and Adora is already flushing. She takes out her ponytail, dropping it onto her desk and shutting down her computer as she texts Catra back that she has done it. She watches the typing bubble cycle through its animation as she heads for the kitchen and prepares them both waters again. She is forced to put her phone away as she carries the glasses to the bedroom, but it doesn't buzz again until she is almost back in the kitchen.

Good girl. You've behaved all week?

Yes.

Go pick your favorite vibrator and make sure it's fully charged.

You're going to need it.

Well, that certainly sets Adora's blood alight. She hurries back to her bedroom with her cheeks blazing. She doesn't know what Catra's plans are, so picking a toy is hard, but eventually she settles on her curved g-spot vibrator just because she knows it holds charge for a long time. She plugs it in to be sure, setting it down to charge while she busies herself with brushing her hair – she actually has time to make herself look nice this week – and then washing her hands.

Finding things to do while she wants for Catra to arrive is difficult. She sends Catra money for the ride fare when she finally shares it with her and then she mostly fidgets with anything within reach and checks her hair compulsively until she hears a car door slam outside. Breathlessly, she hurries to the front door just in time for Catra to ring her chiming doorbell. Adora opens it beaming, grinning hopefully at Catra. Catra is bundled up in a long coat and boots, her arms wrapped around herself. Adora quickly steps aside to let her in from the cold.

"Winters get too cold here for magicats, huh?" Adora asks, rambling a little bit as she closes the front door behind Catra and locks it. She turns around, fully expecting Catra to be rolling her eyes at Adora's mindless small talk, but instead Adora's brain stops working, along with her heart. Catra is already shrugging out of her coat, and apparently it was long for a *reason*. All Catra is wearing underneath is a skintight bodysuit – with a cutout at the chest, too – and thigh high boots. The toe of the shoes is open along with the heel so Catra can still walk normally, but the black leather laces all the way up her thighs.

This is the outfit Catra wore in her profile picture on her website, Adora realizes as her mouth goes dry. In her periphery she can tell that Catra is smirking at her as she hangs her coat up on the rack of hooks in Adora's entryway, but Adora is struggling to look away at the moment. She has never been so glad to have behaved before in her life. If this is her reward, she thinks she could go a month entirely celibate and chaste. It's for the best that Catra isn't a mind reader, though, because she certainly doesn't *want* to.

She wants to get her hands on Catra. She wants to bend her over- no, she wants to lay her out so they're face-to-face and fuck her slow, whispering a thousand dirty praises to her. She wants to wipe that smug smile off her face and replace it with one of absolute bliss. This is the first dom outfit of Catra's that has made Adora just want to take care of her, showing her that she can be in charge too. Or maybe it has nothing to do with the outfit and Adora just really, really wants to touch Catra right now, but the final result – Catra writhing beneath her and moaning – is the same.

Adora really hopes Catra will let her service her today. That was a big part of what made Monday feel special, at least when she thought about it in retrospect. She loved when Catra sat on her face last week, but as much as she likes being used, she also likes getting to take care of her partner on her own terms. Well, and Catra's terms. *Their* terms. Catra has a smug smirk on her face when Adora finally manages to wrench her gaze up to meet her eyes.

"Come on, princess. Let me reward that eagerness."

--

Catra promised Adora a good reward if she could hold out until Sunday. She didn't make it easy on her, but she knows it wouldn't have been a challenge at all if she just left Adora on her own for the week. Besides, they got to spend a lot of time together under the guise of Catra just wanting to torture Adora a little more – and also, she wanted to torture Adora a little more. One of the cornerstones of domming is always giving a promised reward, and making sure it lives up to the hype is important too.

That's why they merely take a break after round nine instead of stopping. Adora's vibrator died ten minutes ago, but after a few soft kisses and some cuddling, Catra leaves to refill their waters and retrieves a new one from the drawer while Adora is rehydrating. She sets the first vibrator aside on the nightstand for later charging and cleaning before crawling back into bed with Adora and instantly finding herself clung to. Adora makes a soft, needy noise as Catra wraps her arms around her in turn.

"I'm right here, princess. Good job drinking your water. We can just cuddle until you're ready to go again," Catra promises her, pressing a soft kiss against her cheek. Adora makes another noise, this one more disbelieving, but she shouldn't be surprised. Catra told her that they weren't finished yet when she first got up to get them water. Catra purrs gently to her, nuzzling their cheeks together. She is having more fun exploring forced orgasm than she thought she would.

Adora isn't restrained simply because Catra wanted to play for longer than she was comfortable having Adora bound for, even if that is typical of something like this. Catra isn't stopping. She is going to keep fucking Adora and bringing her over until she is satisfied. If Adora wanted to tap out now, she could, but ideally Catra would like to go for another three rounds. Today's domming is soft enough that it could be mistaken for regular sex if it weren't for the forced orgasm aspect and Catra spanking Adora whenever she fails to use *sir*.

It is easier on them both – that is why they are able to go this long at all – though Catra is still starting to get physically tired. She knows that continuing is just guaranteeing herself soreness tomorrow, but she kind of doesn't want Adora to be able to walk straight, and if that makes her own legs stiff, she can live with it. She doesn't have any appointments until Thursday right now and she can laze about and remember the beautiful whimpering Adora was reduced to for the last two rounds.

In her arms, Adora clutches onto her, seeming to have hit the *clingy* phase of subbing. She might just be too tired to protest Catra moving verbally and so is doing it physically. She is certainly relaxed and blissed out. She snuggles a little as she buries her face in Catra's hair – her ponytail came out around round five or six – and sighs something that sounds suspiciously like *soft kitty*. Adora hasn't said that to her since they were kids, but Catra doesn't call her out on it. Adora seems to be mostly out of it. They'll need to cuddle for a while before they can think about resuming.

What a hardship.

--

Catra seems to be determined to get Adora's orgasms into the double digits. She promised her a reward, but Adora never imagined it would be all *this*. Their previous record was eleven times spread throughout an entire day, but Catra seems determined to beat that in one afternoon. Luckily, there is plenty of cuddling in the comedowns. Catra gives her more and more time to breathe afterwards each time, until the *intermission* where they take half an hour to just cuddle until Catra starts getting a little mouthy, kissing and nipping at Adora until she can't wait any longer and turns it into a make out.

Of course the make out leads to touching. Adora already knew that Catra wasn't done with her yet. Adora is strung out and she definitely feels *rewarded*, but she doesn't say her word. She doesn't need to stop, and she doesn't even necessarily want to – she wants something else, but it isn't stopping. She has come nine times now. All she wants is to be able to take care of Catra at least once, but Catra seems to have other plans, kissing her hungrily as she slips the new vibrator between them.

Adora is losing her mind. It's all so much. The tenth orgasm comes on her suddenly, leaving her shivering and gasping. Catra's purr is smug and satisfied. She seems delighted with the mess she has made of Adora. She has made her flush with sweat, work her way to calm until the sweat dried on her skin, and then drove her mad until she was a sweaty mess all over again. Adora zoned out for a while after her ninth orgasm, but some time cuddling in Catra's arms – alright, and downing an entire glass of water – turned out to be what she needed to rouse herself again.

Adora's body has been on fire for long enough that her soul is lighting up too. She loves Catra domming her and has no interest in "switching roles" or anything like that, but she is starting to feel feisty in a way she hasn't for their previous sessions. She thinks it was more insecurity holding her back than anything else. Not that she's anxious with Catra, but she wanted so badly to be *good* she couldn't even consider being bratty. Now, she has come ten fucking times and all she wants is to get to touch Catra.

After Adora spends a solid minute gasping for breath following her tenth orgasm, she kisses Catra with a fire she didn't know she had left in her, fueled by her want to *give* as well. At first she was satisfied just knowing that Catra was clearly enjoying this too, but somewhere around orgasm six she couldn't keep ignoring that Catra hasn't come once. Adora gets handsy, revitalized by her determination as she runs her hands over Catra's body, ruffling her fur and earning a shiver.

Adora's heart hammers at the shiver. She has to resist the urge to tighten her hands on Catra. She wants to flip them over and throw Catra's legs over her shoulders. Better yet, she wants to press two fingers into her and get to feel her heat, responsive and twitching, surrounding her fingers. Adora moans at the very thought, nipping at Catra's lower lip just to see how she'll react. Catra's reaction is instant. Her tail lashes behind her, the fur fluffing up as she makes a small noise caught between a purr and a growl.

Adora knows that noise. It doesn't matter that it has been over five years since she heard – she *knows* it. Any inclination to be obedient flies out the window as she drops her hand to the base of Catra's fluffed out tail and tugs. Catra cries out, panting into her mouth and growling as she jerks a little in Adora's arms, but it isn't a bad growl. It is one Adora has to pay careful attention to ensure she doesn't go too far, but right now, Catra loves what she is doing.

At least her body does. Catra pulls back, bracing above Adora and glaring down at her. The glare is cut by her blazing cheek and blown out pupils. Her tail is still lashing behind her from excitement. Adora grins up at her again, tightening her grip in warning and then pulling *slow*, watching Catra's pupils go completely round before a shudder runs through her entire body and sends her eyelids fluttering closed. Adora finishes the tug with a slow pet down the part of Catra's tail that she can reach before Catra starts lashing it again and it slips out of her grip.

"*Princess*," Catra growls, her voice a low warning. Her voice is ridiculously sexy, dripping with desire and warning. If Catra was hoping for Adora to fall in line at the prompt, then she is sorely mistaken. Adora drops her hand onto Catra's lower back and resists the urge to flip them entirely despite how all she wants to do is press Catra into the sheets. She was definitely in subspace earlier, but the long break brought her out of it.

"You were too good to me. I'm satiated. I just want *you* now," Adora admits, watching Catra carefully. Catra's gaze holds hers, burning in intensity but giving nothing away. Adora is well aware that the rules a sadism say Adora just asked for something and so now is the perfect time to deny her, but they are on round *ten*. Surely Adora has earned this by now, letting Catra have her way with her for so long. Surely Catra must want release for *herself* by now.

"Let me take care of you too? I want to make you feel as good as you make me feel," Adora asks, hoping to maintain the submissive angle. It is probably her best chance to convince Catra to let her have a turn on top. She really wants to take care of her. That doesn't just mean following her orders and servicing her however Catra tells her to – it means thinking about what Catra would like and doing it first without prompting. It means fucking her hard and fast in a way that you don't do to your dom.

Catra hasn't exactly been maintaining her persona perfectly in this session, though. She has been softer, playing into Adora's praise kink rather than relying on her masochism. She didn't demand or forcibly take control once – maybe because Adora gladly gave it to her every time, but now she is asking for it back. It is a question, though – Adora is Catra's sub, so if Catra wants to deny her, she easily can. Adora knows this denial won't be the sweet torture that the others have been, but it would keep their relationship within the parameters they defined at the beginning, so she will understand if Catra does it.

Surely subs can top their doms sometimes though, right? Catra is still going to be the one holding Adora's metaphorical leash, Adora just wants to take care of her freely without having to wait for Catra to approve every step. She wants to see Catra shiver and pounce on the opportunity to draw out a long moan from her.

Above her, Catra's eyes bore into hers.

--

Catra can’t believe she’s considering this. Adora’s hand strokes down her back as she waits, her expression soft and a touch pleading. She looks like she wants nothing more in the world than to take care of Catra. Catra isn’t supposed to need someone to take care of her. She is supposed to be the untouchable dom. Sure, Adora has been *touching* her quite a lot ever since they switched to having their sessions at her house, but Catra can’t be that in control when she is beneath her.

With Adora’s hand right above her tail and her expression so soft and hopeful, Catra can’t quite remember why that is a bad thing. She swallows as Adora slides a cautious hand up to her shoulders, her other reaching up to tangle with Catra’s fingers where she is braced on her forearm. Catra sees that expression and a part of her says to *pounce*, but there is another part of her – one that she isn’t that familiar with anymore – that says to *give in*.

“You’re such a good dom. So giving. Please, I just want to give back. Let me show you how good you make me feel,” Adora says. Catra releases a small whine, her eyes slamming shut as her tail lashes behind her. Fuck, she is so screwed. Adora knows what praise does to her, but what Catra always liked before was being called pretty and hearing she was loved. She would fucking love that now, but she likes *this* too. She likes the assurance, right here in words, that Adora is having fun – enough fun to want to reward Catra for it.

Phrased like that, she never stood a chance. Sure, she still wants to grab Adora by the hair and force her to her knees, but she wants to kiss her too – she wants to *be* kissed, letting Adora pour out all her thanks in her touch. Well, some of her thanks. Catra still wants verbal praise too. She opens her eyes slowly, taking a deep breath as she makes eye contact with Adora and forces herself to give a small nod. Adora’s breath instantly hitches. She reaches a hand up, cautiously threading her fingers through Catra’s hair.

Adora fists it slowly. She knows how sensitive Catra is to pulling, whether it is her hair, ears, or tail. In the right mood, with the right pressure, it feels amazing, but outside of that anyone who tries it risks getting stitches. Catra’s fur is already bristling with anticipation, but it isn’t a signal for Adora to stop. Truly, it isn’t bristling at all – her fur is standing on end at the idea of being someone's. *Adora's*. Adora knows how to take care of her, how to make her feel good. She proved that at the party.

She proves it again now. She doesn't pull on her hair yet, maintaining eye contact as Catra flushes and swallows. Adora’s gaze is still questioning, and it isn’t just because she was unsure if that nod was enough consent. Catra picked up the question before now, but the determination in her eyes makes it clear – Adora doesn’t just want to take care of her. She wants control. The hand, so careful in Catra’s hair, is all the assurance that Catra needs. Adora can have it. Catra leans slightly back into her hand, watching as her eyes fall hooded and her jaw flexes.

The intensity in Adora’s eyes flares before she tugs and drags Catra down into a kiss, open-mouthed and hungry. Catra whines, her tail lashing as she parts her lips for Adora. This isn’t how this is supposed to go, but this small taste of being Adora's again feels incredible. She

lets Adora kiss her, claiming her until she has drunken her fill. When Adora releases her, her eyes are darkened with lust. Her tongue darts out to wet her lips as her hands slide down to grip Catra's hip.

Her hands tighten for a moment, a small warning, and then she flips them. Catra almost manages to suppress her squeak as she lies back in the sheets. Though Adora smirks a little, she doesn't comment, just leaning down to kiss Catra eagerly. Catra tilts her head back, accepting the kiss as Adora's hands roam over her body. Catra ended up fully naked somewhere around round… somewhere in the middle of playing, she doesn't really remember when. She mostly did it to torture Adora even more with the fact that she wasn't allowed to touch her at the time.

Adora touches her now, her hands roaming over her as she breathes soft sighs of contentment against Catra's lips, apparently *really* enjoying finally having her hands on Catra. Catra lets Adora have her body - touching and squeezing her, mussing her fur and causing her tail to lash when she massages at her thighs but avoids directly touching her – but Catra claims Adora's mouth through the kiss. Adora seems happy to let her do it, moaning as her hands finally work their way between Catra's legs and find her damp.

She was soaking earlier. She had Adora writhing under her, after all. Catra likes penetration, but if she isn't ready for it and she feels a twinge of pain, she shuts down. Adora knows this, and she touches her slowly and carefully until, no matter how hard Catra tries, she doesn't have the breath left to kiss Adora back, much less lead the kiss herself. That's when Adora presses in, first with one finger, and then with two after a few thrusts prove to her that Catra's ready.

Catra moans, throwing her head back and screwing her eyes shut. Nothing feels like the sensation that sweeps through her body when she is being fucked. She really does love it, whether it is with a toy, tongue, or fingers. She has her issues, sure, but Adora knows to take the time to work around them, and she does it dutifully. She doesn't seem at all bothered by the lag time, instead kissing the side of Catra's jaw and murmuring *filthy* praise to her as she touches her.

"I love the way you fuck me. You make me feel like nothing else."

"You were always sexy, but I don't know what to *do* with myself when you're standing over me as my dom. All I want is to be yours."

"Being yours feels so amazing. It's fulfilling and thrilling and-" That time she cuts off when Catra gives a flustered growl that makes it halfway to a purr. It isn't a signal to stop, but fuck, the praise *does* it for her and it is just shy of overwhelming. Adora gives her a moment to cool down, even slowing her thrusts, before she ramps back up again.

"Our sessions make me feels things I didn't know were possible," is Adora's idea of a gentle introduction back, or maybe she means it to be the finishing blow that it is, because fuck, Catra nearly mewls, and Adora does exactly what she has always done when she hears that sound: she touches her, the thrusts becoming a clumsy afterthought as she focuses on Catra's clit.

Catra comes growling. Purring. Whatever. The distinction doesn't matter to her as she goes limp in the sheets again, blood rushing in her ears and panting. Adora's arms are around her. She doesn't quite know how that happened. She turns into the touch eagerly, already trying to rub her cheek against Adora. Adora makes a soft, affectionate noise as she wraps Catra up and tilts her chin back to let her mark along her neck.

After a few moments of marking, the overwhelming urge eases and Catra drops her head back against the pillow, still firmly nuzzled against Adora but now too relaxed to shove herself closer. She doesn't have to. Adora holds her, scattering soft kisses across her ears as Catra purrs steadily. Adora's breath is hot against her ear as she ducks down and stays there, apparently not on a quest to give Catra another kiss this time.

"That's how good you make me feel," Adora breathes to her before kissing her one last time and dropping her head onto the pillow to join Catra in cuddly bonelessness. Catra purrs louder, but internally, her thoughts can only be summarized as one word running through head over and over.

Fuck.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: overstimulation/forced orgasm.
I tweaked the chapter count a little, but as before, it's still a rough estimate.
Buuuuuuut…. I'm thinking of turning this into a series. There were a lot of…. "ideas" I saved for this fic, but it would be long and weigh it down if I put them all in. A lot are well-suited to smutshots set after the main story, so I'm thinking of turning this into a series. I'll work on this fic until it's done and then I'd sporadically return to add on those oneshots as I have ideas/motivation.

Sunshine & Daisies (and other disgusting shit)

Chapter Notes

BDSM description in endnote. Kinky but not very BDSM-heavy tbh.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wakes up on Monday feeling like sunshine and roses and daisies and all the other happy-go-lucky bullshit that no one but Scorpia is supposed to feel. Even Entrapta has the decency to act like a shuffling corpse for the first twenty minutes she is awake, but Scorpia usually bounds right out of bed cheerful – and apparently, so does Catra, now. Well, she doesn't anticipate this becoming her new standard, at least not most nights, but she isn't stupid – her good mood, unfortunately, has a source.

Okay, so maybe being in a good mood isn't a bad thing, and last night was absolutely incredible, but Catra has been domming for a long time and she has never felt this way after a session. She got off during their last two, so her orgasm isn't the only reason she wakes up early and starts painting sunflowers. They are bending up to the hand of a light goddess whose hair falls in a sheet of sunshine over her face as she bends to give them the kiss of life.

Catra is the fucking sunflower. She has painted some gross romantic shit before, but this really takes the cake. Anyone but Adora wouldn't know this is anything other than a portrait of a mystical, imaginary scene – and hopefully even Adora won't realize the true implications – but Catra can't believe herself. This was supposed to be hooking up. It was supposed to be domming and friendship. She wasn't supposed to wake up smitten and feeling great about herself.

Catra doesn't hate herself like she used to, but a combination of self-loathing, doubt, and trauma is what usually makes her dom drop so bad. Apparently experiencing praise and assurance as part of a session brings her a high that she has no experience with. Her subs don't sing her praises usually. Sure, they might gush about the fun they had afterwards, and that definitely helps with the psychological side of drop, but they don't *beg her* to let them give her the pleasure she gives them.

She feels- fuck, she just feels overflowing with love and happiness and all that disgusting stuff. She isn't supposed to feel like this. This is just supposed to be domming and friendship, not throwing herself headlong into what got her hurt before. Feeling good like this is kind of terrifying. She feels out of control. She has been down this path before, and all that was waiting at the other end was a steep cliff - one that she willing threw herself down to get the pain over with.

Part of her mind says her broken bones have healed and she shouldn't put herself in the position where they shatter all over again. The rest of her says to check the clock and, when

she finds that it is almost lunch, that she should call Adora during her break and invite herself over again tonight. Sunday was too much fun. Catra knows that sometimes her clients get so much relief from a scene that the next day they are immediately desperate for more, the serotonin response they get functioning almost like a drug, but she has never experienced it herself.

Catra is totally out of her element. It has been a long time since that has been true while domming. She doesn't know what to do about her feelings and the fact that they apparently can't be contained, but there is someone she always turns to when it comes to advice about BDSM. Catra doesn't have to give her details, just ask her for advice about dom drop – and as much as she hates to admit she needs to do it, advice on how to talk about it. Catra has never needed to since she has only dommed clients, but she has known for weeks that she needs to tell Adora about it.

Catra puts it off by working on her painting, but the details spring to life quickly. By the time traditional lunch hours are drawing to a close, Catra is scrawling out her signature and marking the back with the date and the painting's title – *The Radiance of Life*. She delays things further by justifying that she is starving and needs to eat, but eventually that is done and she has no more excuses.

With a perhaps overly-dramatic sigh, Catra pulls out her phone and texts Huntara.

--

When they changed the terms of their agreement two weeks ago, Catra gave Adora the extremely difficult homework of thinking about what kind of kinks aren't included in her contract that she would like to add. Adora has kind of been putting it off – she was flustered enough saying yes or no to a list of kinks that Catra was reading off to her, she doesn't know how she is going to fight through the embarrassment of suggesting them herself – but the universe gives her a push.

If all the play on Sunday wasn't enough, she opens her email inbox on Monday night to find a flash sale notification from a toy manufacturer that she has been eyeing for a while. Looking at the notification for the inventory clear out, she knows that she is definitely going to buy one now that she has someone to actually use it with. It isn't until she is staring at the order confirmation page that reality sinks in. If she wants to do this, then she has to ask Catra for it. Asking Catra for one thing in particular somehow feels more shameful than updating the entire contract.

It places more weight on it if it is by itself. It's easier to do multiple at once. She isn't ashamed of her desires – mostly – but that doesn't make talking about them any less embarrassing. She downloads the kink contract that Catra sent her weeks ago, reviewing everything in it and then setting to adding new lines at the end of the document. Some of them are easy to type. Others she deliberates for several minutes. She catches herself trying to

downplay one by adding it in as just *Will* instead of *Want* and forces herself to take a deep breath.

Her knowledge of BDSM may have been entirely theoretical before she started doing things with Catra, but even without Catra's emphasis on it, she knows honesty is important. It is a sub's responsibility to tell their dom the truth about things like this. Thinking about it like that sends a shiver up her spine as Adora reluctantly clicks the box to upgrade the kink to a *Want*. She doesn't add all that much to the contract overall though, unable to think of a lot to add on.

She leans back from the computer and stares at it for awhile. Then she pulls out her phone and stares at it for even longer. Eventually she manages to convince herself to pull up her text conversation with Catra. The last text she has from her is Catra's check-in text that she sent right after five to check that Adora was feeling okay. The answer was a resounding yes. Adora's excitement definitely came across, because Catra sent back a smirking emoji before telling her to drive home safe.

Hey.

Still good?

Yeah.

Remember when you asked me to review the contract?

I was wondering when you'd get around to that.

I had trouble thinking of stuff that was missing from the original.

Added some stuff, but I'm open to suggestions.

We've had an oral agreement for denial/delay, but I want that in writing.

Also forced orgasm. That's what we did yesterday.

Give me a minute to think.

Added those already.

Some things you might want to have your stance on written down, off the top of my head:

Any sex position.

Any toys, especially if there are any that you own right now that you don't want me to use on you without checking.

Kinds of sex (oral, or getting more specific like mouthfucking).

Any roleplays you're interested in that involve sex.

Oh JOI is a kind of orgasm control. Jack Off Instruction. The term might not be the best fit, but it's masturbating under my instructions. And I can punish you if you disobey them ;)

Everything else I can think of right now falls under something already on there.

You can also google. There's lists of stuff online that you might not have thought of before.

Okay.

Want me to come over and review the changes soon?

Yeah. Does tomorrow work?

I've got work stuff tomorrow. After the gym on Wednesday would be better.

Okay. I can drive us back to my place afterwards?

Deal. Are we playing?

We can. Definitely not against it.

Horny.

You brought it up!

You've been filing out the contract. Do you have something in mind?

Yes, but we can't do it until next week.

Vague.

… My order has to ship.

Oh princess.

Alright. No playing this week then.

I want you to be desperate by the time your "order" arrives.

Catra!

You heard me, princess.

I've given you an order. You know what to say now.

Yes, sir.

Good girl.

Well. That's not how Adora was expecting that conversation to go. She slinks down in her seat with her cheeks blazing. The winky face was enough to undo her, and then Catra had to go and give her *orders*. Adora isn't sure if she meant to ban her from masturbating until then too, but she isn't really interested in what she can do with her hand when she could be experiencing so much more with Catra. It isn't that long to go anyway unless Catra decides to torture her again – which she very well might.

Wednesday will be interesting.

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Catra walks into the studio and stops dead in her tracks. Lonnie is pretending to be casual, scrolling away on her phone, but Catra can see the anticipation in her body. She can also clearly see the new riding crop hanging on Catra's side of the rack, right where her heart-shaped paddle used to be. She has two others, so she hasn't bothered replacing it or the crop that she brought to Adora's, but apparently Lonnie saw fit to do it for her.

"Your boyfriends will never find your body," Catra says, her eye twitching as she stares down the crop shaped like a cartoon kitty face. It even has fucking whiskers. Lonnie immediately bursts out laughing. She doubles over as Catra crosses the room and plucks the crop from the wall, glaring at it. A human could use it, but it is just ridiculous and undermines her authority to have it hanging there for clients to giggle at. She bends and shoves it into the cabinet. If Lonnie wants to use it, fine, but Catra doesn't want it in sight while she is domming.

"Aw, come on. I noticed you broke a crop and thought I would save you time on getting a replacement," Lonnie teases. She is grinning from ear-to-ear. Catra narrows her eyes at her as she drops down onto the couch. She didn't break a crop – it happens, so she knows why Lonnie drew that conclusion about one of hers disappearing – but she isn't about to correct Lonnie on it. Lonnie seems amused enough, snickering as she checks over the mirror she was cleaning when Catra entered before she walks over to the cabinet to get out her bag.

"Didn't your appointment get out thirty minutes ago?" Catra asks dryly, because she would like to change the subject from Lonnie's prank. Lonnie rolls her eyes as she walks over to the couch, sitting on the other end of it and dropping her bag at her feet. She lounges like she belongs there – which, fine, she pays rent, but Catra does too and she booked out this time on the calendar for her own use.

"I'm waiting for Huntara, duh. I saw her on the calendar," Lonnie tells her. Catra twitches her ear, but she nods. Huntara taught Catra everything she knows – well, either she did, or she gave her the name of the book or the website where she learned the rest – and Lonnie learned some from her as well, though she did most of her learning by studying. Lonnie learned by

proxy through Catra sharing what Huntara had taught her, both of them then practicing together, more than she learned from Huntara directly.

Still, the woman is like their mentor in a lot of ways. It's nice to see her. Catra was late – well, her bus was, she can't do anything about that – so Huntara shows up only a few minutes later, her knock loud and rattling. She greets them both warmly, clapping them on the back and teasing Lonnie about the leather shoulder harness she is still wearing over a tight black shirt from her earlier session.

"Didn't realize I would be teaching you both something today," Huntara says as she pulls away from giving Lonnie a sideways hug around her shoulders. Catra's tail twitches as Lonnie side eyes her. Huntara, who doesn't do anything by accident, watches them both carefully. All Catra told her over the phone was that she was exploring a new area of BDSM and was looking for advice navigating both it and her drop.

Huntara asked her for more details, but she said she didn't want to talk about it over text and asked to meet instead. Huntara is prodding to assess the situation, though she is likely genuinely surprised by Lonnie's presence as well. Lonnie raises a brow and shoots Catra a look, but she must catch on to the tension in Catra's body because she shakes her head and lets it go, shouldering her bag.

"Nah, I just got out of a session and wanted to see you before I headed out. I've got stuff to do today," Lonnie replies. Catra tries not to breathe a sigh of relief as Lonnie and Huntara exchange goodbyes. Once Lonnie leaves, however, Huntara turns to her with a raised eyebrow.

"Alright, spill. You aren't just trying to learn a new skill," Huntara tells her. That's one of the things that Catra likes about her – Huntara will get straight down to business, no fucking around or tiptoeing around it. Catra tries to do the same when it comes to laying out her sessions. A lot of her usual rules don't apply when she's dealing with Adora, though, and that's how she ended up here, needing advice on how to begin to approach things. Reluctantly, Catra shakes her head and motions towards the couch.

Huntara doesn't say anything as they walk over and settle down. That's another skill that Catra learned from Huntara: waiting someone out. Sitting in silence can be an extremely effective technique. Most people can't stand the quiet and will eventually admit what they want rather than let it continue. Catra has an iron will, but so does Huntara. She knows she can't outlast her, but she isn't trying to. Catra sighs as she gathers her thoughts. She has had this conversation in her head a half dozen times since texting Huntara yesterday, but it still isn't easy.

"I've started doing BDSM in the bedroom. Not with a client, just a friend with benefits," Catra starts, even though Adora was *once* a client. She doesn't want Huntara to think she has started to do full-service work, because Catra absolutely isn't cut out for that and she knows it. She needs advice for the problem that she is actually having and not a made up one based on assumptions.

"Damn, kitty," Huntara whistles, her eyebrows shooting up. Catra feels her tail twitch, crossing her arms and glaring a little at Huntara. She doesn't outright loathe the nickname –

Adora used to call her that sometimes too, although she mainly did it when they were kids – but Catra certainly isn't a fan of it. Huntara gives everyone nicknames, though. Lonnie is *short stack*. Giving her apprentices in particular diminutive nicknames is part of Huntara's dominance thing.

"Let me guess: your drop issues got worse? How have they been since we last spoke?" Huntara asks, eyeing her. Catra is fairly certain she is blushing. Her tail is certainly thudding steadily against the side of the couch. Catra sighs, tightening her arms around herself.

"Until the switch, they were the same. I saw this friend as a regular client when she was dipping her toe in and I still had drop with her. It has been different since moving things to the bedroom, though. The drops haven't been as bad and there are weird highs," Catra explains, gesturing vaguely out into the room. She has mostly had physical dom drop from their sessions in bed, her body stiff from the exertion and any effects on her mood stemming from that. Then there was yesterday – and today, because she is still cruising on that high with a spring in her step, even if she is anxious for this conversation. To her surprise, Huntara raises a brow at her.

"'Weird highs?'" she echoes back. Catra huffs, looking away. Her tail *whaps* against her legs as it curls around her protectively, still flicking. She doesn't know how to explain that part without admitting that she is letting her sub do things that they normally aren't *allowed* to.

"Just feeling good for longer than usual after a session. It's a new realm so I was worried my dom drop would be worse, but generally it has been the same or better," Catra admits, shrugging. Huntara looks outright suspicious. Catra doesn't know why. To her knowledge, her drop issues aren't uncommon for doms, but she has them more frequently than is typical, especially for a professional. Having them go down makes her more normal if anything.

"And you said you were doing this with a *friend*?" Huntara asks. Catra almost squeaks. Maybe she does, actually, but her tail suddenly lashing probably covers up the noise – not that it helps cover up her *reaction*. Huntara's expression is unimpressed. She isn't buying Catra's bullshit for a second. Catra huffs, looking away and pinning her ears back.

"Look, I just wanted to know if you had tips for managing it in the new territory," Catra asks. Maybe she wanted to know more than that, but that's her starting point. Huntara levels her with a look that Catra, unfortunately, knows well: it is the *you're not going to like this* look.

"Yeah, *talk about it*. If it's not a client, then you can do what other doms do and get your own aftercare. Take care of your sub, and then have her assure you, and follow up with her if you need to. You didn't need me to tell you that. It's on google," Huntara tells her. Catra feels indignation rise up, but she bites it down. Yes, she knows that is how regular doms deal with their drop, but the situation isn't that simple.

"It's hooking up. We're not in a relationship. It's not quite the same," Catra points out. Huntara looks at her like she is an idiot.

"You know as well as I do how many doms are in a BDSM-only relationship with their subs. If you wouldn't cut her loose with sub drop, she shouldn't cut you loose with dom drop. But she has to know you have it in the first place," Huntara shoots back. Catra knows she is right,

but she hunches her shoulders anyway, glaring down at where her hands are fisting in her lap. She wants it to be that simple. It doesn't feel like it is.

"I don't know how. I've never told anyone else about it before," she admits, her voice small. Huntara's hard, disbelieving expression softens.

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Catra shocks Adora by hugging her when they meet up at the gym. Adora clings on tightly, happily squeezing Catra against her chest. As they do their warmup cardio – biking, this time – Adora teases Catra about getting a membership at the gym. She was talking with the front desk clerk about pricing when Adora walked in – which, come to think of it, the hug might have been meant to distract from – but she blushes profusely when Adora brings it up.

She tries to deflect by saying that she is already here twice a week and it just makes financial sense to get a membership. When Adora doesn't stop sending her a smug look, Catra threatens to add extra weight to her bar. Adora stops smirking at Catra, even if she continues to do it privately to herself. Catra spouts a lot of bullshit about how Adora's gym has better hybrid equipment, but Adora isn't buying any of it for a second.

"Hey," Adora cuts her off, shoulder checking Catra as they walk over to the weights. Catra huffs, but she looks up at her. Adora smiles, no longer smug and just genuine now. "I like working out with you too," Adora tells her, reaching over to squeeze her shoulder for a moment before she walks ahead and leaves a flustered Catra behind her to process that. Catra, notably, doesn't protest the statement when she finally joins Adora at the weight racks. She also purrs when she climbs into Swift Wind after they are done, happily curling up in the passenger seat while Adora grins to herself and puts the car into drive.

It feels just like old times. There are so many memories in the car. Having Catra in it with her again feels good and it makes the drive back home feel too short. Luckily Adora isn't dropping Catra off this time, instead able to take Catra's hand as they get out of the car and watch her blush as she leads Catra inside of her house. Adora kind of just wants to cuddle her until the heat death of the universe. Instead, she leads her out to her sunroom, watching Catra perk up with interest as she leads her there. Adora doesn't doubt that she explored to when she poked all around the house a few weeks ago, but she is happy to see she was right about Catra enjoying the room.

She has to cling onto that satisfaction when they settle down on the porch swing and suddenly Adora is a blushing mess as Catra prompts her to show her the new contract.

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Huntara's advice was to be vulnerable and honest, asking for her own assurance to be incorporated into the end of their aftercare. It is the last thing that Catra ever wants to do, but she knows that while they are already renegotiating terms is the time to do it.

She *knows* it, she just still can't bring herself to say anything, not even Adora shows her the order confirmation page with her cheeks blazing. The fact that Adora ordered a realistic strap-on molded off of a magicat packing *heat* should give Catra the confidence to ask for something for herself, but instead she finds herself teasing Adora while Adora does her level best to sink down and disappear into the couch cushions.

"It's just- it's *eight inches*. Stop giving me that look," Adora begs, her face a dark shade. She is peeking out between her fingers, her other hand clutching her phone desperately like a lifeline. Catra can see the *similar products* array at bottom of the screen. It looks like this store sells a selection of toys modeled off real people with impressive lengths, but Adora specifically chose the one from a magicat. The toy being molded in a pale lavender doesn't cut that connection.

"Didn't know you had a magicat fetish," Catra says, because she already didn't know how to handle what she needed to do today and she is far from equipped with handling the sudden riot inside her heart from this being sprung on her. Adora groans, sinking a little further down and trying to hide her entire face behind her hand. Catra's tail is flicking behind her as embarrassment, arousal, and anxiety pour off Adora. She is clearly nervous about what she has done.

Catra is pretty sure she isn't reading too much into this. Adora wouldn't be this nervous about it if she didn't choose a magicat toy because of Catra. She seems like she is anxious about Catra saying this is too far. It definitely isn't, even if Catra would be perfectly happy to use their old strap. It wasn't realistic at all, with just a slight bulb on the end of a smooth, black shaft, but apparently that isn't up to Adora's size requirements these days.

Catra swallows. Her thoughts feel chaotic right now. Part of her is twisted in knots at the idea of bringing up the dom drop, part of her is metaphorically sitting at attention, ready to tease Adora, and part of her is in ruin at the thought of Adora wanting a toy that is, at least kind of, connected to Catra. With so many warring emotions inside of her, she doesn't feel up to being vulnerable right now. Talking about her dom drop would be too much, especially with Adora having a small meltdown beside her.

One of Catra's rules as a dom is to never react negatively to someone's desire. Gently teasing is okay and can be hot, but maybe that was too far. She swallows, mentally setting the issue of her dom drop aside. It's not important right now. Huntara convinced her that she needs to talk about it soon, and she still is determined to, but the toy won't be arriving for another week. She has time. Catra reaches out, carefully wrapping her hand around Adora's wrist and tugging her hand away from blazing face.

"Adora, it's fine. I don't mind railing you," Catra tells her, injecting some humor in her voice. Adora's flush is up to her ears, but the words do seem to ease her some as she blows out a breath and sends Catra an almost hopeful look. Catra rolls her eyes, dropping her hand down to Adora's thigh to squeeze and massage it. Adora squeaks, apparently unprepared for the touch, but now when she squirms it isn't from embarrassment.

“Are you sure you can take that much, though? I know you don’t mind pain during sex the same way I do, but there’s a limit to what your body can take,” Catra asks. Oh yeah, Adora is turned on as she quickly looks away and hunches. Catra can’t tell if she’s trying to shrink into herself or if she is just shrugging.

“It’s a bit bigger than what I know I can do right now. I’d like to try it. You’d have to be gentle with me but, um, that’s a fantasy. Of mine. You coaxing me through it. Um,” Adora stammers out, her cheeks blazing. Catra feels herself flush too. Fuck, she does want to do that. It isn’t exactly BDSM, but Adora put size kink on the contract and when trying out a new toy this big for the first time, it’s best not to combine it with any rough stuff.

“Okay, we can do that, princess. Let me know when you’re ready to use it. If it’s too intimidating when you get it, we can plan something else for next week,” Catra promises her. Adora blows out a breath and relaxes beside her. That kind of embarrassment doesn’t just fade in an instant, but she smiles at Catra gratefully. Catra returns the smile, giving Adora one last squeeze on her thigh before she withdraws her hand.

Okay, so this conversation didn’t go how Catra was planning for it to, but she is at least excited for next week.

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Catra made a joke about them spending a week as just friends, but that is what it amounts to as Adora impatiently refreshes her order tracking. When they call each other on Friday, spending an hour just chatting about nothing at all, Catra makes a joking comment – which is likely also a real suggestion – about Adora spending the week preparing with her current biggest toy, but aside from that they mostly keep flirtatious comments to a minimum, adhering to Catra’s original terms of friendship that happens to have domming on the side.

Adora does take Catra up on her suggestion, but that is neither here nor there. This is something she has thought about for awhile and she really wants it to actually work and not just be a painful disappointment. They can always fall back on the old strap sitting in Adora’s drawer if they need to, but Adora doesn’t want to, not after she already put herself out there asking for this.

With how they have been focused on just being casual with each other, Adora is surprised when Catra hesitates as Adora walks her over to her bus stop after their Sunday gym trip and asks when Adora thinks they are going to play next. Adora flushes crimson as she pulls out her phone and checks the package tracking for her third time that day. It still says the expected delivery date is Thursday. The toy didn’t even ship until the night after their talk about it.

“Friday? It should be here then and I don’t want to wait,” Adora admits, ducking her head as she shoves her phone back in her pocket. Catra smirks as they resume walking.

“Sure, princess. Do you have a spare house key I can borrow for this?” Catra asks. Adora feels her nose wrinkle up, shooting Catra a questioning look. Catra glances around the sidewalk to make sure they are alone before responding, which only makes a blush rise on Adora’s cheeks as she realizes that whatever Catra is about to say, it is likely inappropriate.

“I want you to warm up with your biggest toy and be waiting in the bedroom for me. Which either means you masturbate with your front door unlocked, or I have a key to open it when I arrive,” Catra points out. Predictably, Adora’s blood pressure rises as she quickly ducks her head. That makes sense and is the most practical thing to do – both from a preparation for the toy standpoint and a home safety one – but the mere thought has her libido spiking. Adora quickly nods.

“Right, um, yeah. I do have one. Glimmer has it, but I can get it from her and give it to you Wednesday?” Adora asks. Catra is halfway through nodding before Adora amends her statement. “Actually, no, I’ll get another copy made. She would roast me for this,” Adora decides. Catra’s ear twitches before she cackles. Adora is still blushing as Catra lightly elbows her.

“Alright, princess. Whatever works,” Catra replies. Adora flushes. She didn’t realize how much she has missed Catra using the pet name over the last few days.

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Catra let herself not address the dom drop thing by promising she would do it before the toy arrives. She just needed to process Adora wanting Catra to strap her with a toy cock that could conceivably be hers first. The justification made sense, but Catra still doesn’t talk to Adora about it. They talk for hours on Friday, and then again on Monday, and they text on Thursday when Adora excitedly messages her a picture of a shipping box that is larger than Catra expected it to be, but even with the distance of a screen Catra doesn’t say it.

She throws herself into her art, pumping out an entire series of paintings at an alarming rate – not to Catra, but Scorpia comes down to the utility room one day and asks her if she needs to talk with someone, which is a resounding no – trying to process the myriad of emotions in her chest. They riot, showing themselves in an expressionist series of body parts alone in a sea of colors that echo the emotions wrapped around her heart.

Catra doesn’t even worry about color theory or what the paintings would look like to someone else, just painting based on her emotional connection in the moment to the colors that she sees before her. The body parts – a hand grabbing at the cloud of green surrounding it as if trying to hold it down, a clawed foot kicking out from a sea of muddy dark colors with a few bright splashes intermixed, or a heart beating without a body in an aura of soft blues with a few jagged lines of white threatening to come close enough to stab it – are rendered in a soft but realistic style, in contrast to the glaring colors.

Some of the body parts belong to her, and some to Adora. Some belong to strangers. Catra kind of knows what each painting means, but she can't articulate it. They are just her feelings, and they weren't meant for words. Catra still can't find the words to say what she needs, after all. If it weren't for how hung up she is on being perceived as not fit to be a dom, it wouldn't be an issue, but she worries about Adora trying to get her to leave her job once she knows.

Catra is in no position to do that. Talking about her mental health is hard enough, but maybe starting a fight with Adora after things have been so good seems impossible. When Adora gives her a copy of her key on Wednesday, Catra leers at her, but she doesn't say a word. Much like her feelings for Adora that she tries to shove in a corner and ignore, Catra doesn't know how to shatter the peace and give her needs voice.

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Adora is already trembling by the time she hears a knock on her front door and then the sound of it opening. When Adora texted Catra asking if she was ready to come over, Catra texted her back to take down her hair. Once Adora confirmed that she had, Catra told her to put her largest toy in and send her *proof* before she would call a ride. Adora had sent back some desperate texts before Catra confirmed that a picture of her flush would do. Adora's cheeks were already blazing, but she waited until she had the toy in to send Catra a picture of her hiding part of her face.

She took off her shirt after Catra sent her a screenshot confirming she was already halfway there. She left the second Adora texted her, the bastard, but the fifteen minutes left in the trip feel like they might as well be its full length. Catra texts her not to take the toy out – actually, she texts *to keep fucking yourself until I say stop, princess* – so Adora is squirming by the time the front door opens. Catra pads silently through the house, but Adora hears her purr a second before the bedroom door opens.

Adora self-consciously closes her legs as she lifts her head off the bed to find Catra standing in the doorway, dressed casually in a ripped sweater and joggers. She is smirking, but all Adora is thinking about is how easy it will be to tear those clothes off quickly. She has the new strap set on the end table, already cleaned and even prepped with some lube, though the bottle is waiting on the nightstand in case they need more.

Catra's eyes travel along Adora's body as Adora drops her hands to the bed, flushed and squirming a little. The other toy is still inside her. Catra's fangs flash beneath the curl of her lip as she stalks forward into the room, a dark look in her eye. Adora swallows as Catra comes to a halt at the side of the bed, finally looking away from her with a dismissive *hmph* as she eyes the toy instead.

"Spread your legs, princess," Catra orders, reaching out to finger the edges of the harness. "You really want to be full, don't you? You think you can take this now you're seeing it in person?" Catra asks, picking the toy up by the straps. She sends Adora a predatory leer as she

hefts the toy, a drop of the lube falling to get stuck in Adora's carpet with the change in position.

Adora couldn't give a shit about the carpet. She flushes a bright shade, reaching down and pointedly pulling out the toy she already has in to show its size to Catra. She leaves just the tip in, technically fulfilling Catra's request to leave it in until she says she can take it out. In person, the other strap is big, but it doesn't actually look *that* much bigger than the toy she already has despite Adora knowing the difference in their measurements.

Enough of the shaft is showing in this position to reveal the girth of the toy Adora already has in. Catra's eyes snap to it, her smirk growing for a moment before she reaches down. Adora squeaks as Catra places her fingers on the back of Adora's hand and pointedly pushes, forcing Adora to press the toy back inside of herself. A shiver runs up Adora's spine and she whines as she feels her body give way to the toy again. Catra places the harness back on the end table, still incredibly cocky.

"I didn't say you could stop fucking yourself yet, princess. Keep playing while I wash my hands. I'll be back to take care of you soon," Catra promises her, bending to press a light kiss to her forehead. Adora feels her heart stutter, the small part of her brain still capable of non-horny thoughts desperately clamoring for the gentle affection. Catra is still smirking as she pulls away, but her smile softens somewhat when she sees Adora's expression.

"I'll be right back," she promises. Adora lets out a soft breath and nods. Catra's eyes stay on her as she steps away, never looking away from Adora until she is forced to disappear into the bathroom.

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"There you go. Take it slow, princess," Catra assures Adora, one hand on her ass to help hold her up – and to hold her *back* in case she gets ideas about sinking down on the strap too much – and the other at the base of the strap. Catra suggested they do this doggy style, knowing it would likely be easiest to take that way, but Adora had flushed and asked if Catra could lie back so she could ride her. Ordinarily Catra would suggest a position that confers her more inherent power, but she also wants to be careful not to hurt Adora.

Right now, Adora is kneeled over her with her back to her, the tip of the strap just barely pressing into her entrance. Adora gives a low whine as her thighs twitch. She has only been holding herself up for a moment. Catra has seen how much she can squat at the gym. Her legs should be nowhere near giving out right now, but Adora is already panting as she rolls her hips back and rubs herself against the toy. Catra eases her grip on Adora, giving her the room to work her hips down a little more. Catra's mouth goes dry as she watches Adora stretch over the toy, stopping just past the head with a pitiful whimper.

"Good girl. You're taking me so well. Don't rush it, princess. I like watching," Catra tells her, earning another soft whimper, but Adora nods desperately. Catra purrs, offering her wordless

praise and drinking in the soft, happy sigh that Adora gives in response. Adora said her fantasy was Catra coaxing her through it and Catra plans to deliver. Honestly, Catra doesn't think they're going to have much of a problem with this considering Adora already has the head in. The warmup with the other toy and the generous lube applied to the strap definitely helped.

Adora cautiously angles her hips, lifting herself up a little on the strap before she angles back down and presses more of it in. Catra draws in a sharp breath, barely remembering to tighten her grip on Adora's ass to stop her when she gets halfway down the shaft. Adora whines loudly, shaking her head back and forth in the closest thing that she can do to protest right now. Catra just tightens her grip, the tips of her claws digging into the curve of Adora's ass.

"You're halfway there, princess. Just slow down a minute and feel how I stretch you out," Catra tells her, keeping her voice firm despite the tinge of affection to it. She is planning to gently dominate Adora once she is comfortable, but she has to get used to the toy first. Adora nods, though the movement is much slower than when she was shaking her head. Her thighs are trembling, but she holds mostly still, just angling her hips a little back and forth, rubbing herself on the toy and feeling the shift of it inside her.

"Feels so good," Adora manages to pant out, her first coherent words in several long moments. Catra releases the base of the toy, now firmly settled inside Adora, and reaches that hand up to grab Adora's thigh just to offer her a little more support, as well as to ground her. Adora's muscles quiver beneath her hand. Catra is fucking soaking between that and her view of Adora at an incredibly vulnerable angle, stretching around the biggest toy that Catra has ever seen up close.

"You're doing so well. Don't take it faster than you need to. You look fucking gorgeous from this angle, princess. I don't mind admiring the view as long as you want me to," Catra promises. The only response Adora gives is a whine.

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It takes her several minutes to work her way down until she is sitting comfortable on the toy, panting and twitching. She feels like a trembling mess as Catra pets down her back, firm hands soothing her as Catra pours out a stream of praises that has Adora rolling her hips and moaning. In her fantasies, Catra grabs her hips and fucks her now, but it turns out that she isn't ready for that much movement yet. She raises herself up on her knees and pushes herself back down a few times, but it sends twinges of pain through her body.

Once the toy is *in*, though, it sits without causing pain. There is a burning stretch around her entrance and she has never felt this full in her life, but the dull pain signals don't cause a spike of fear in her chest. Adora ends up twitching and rolling her hips while Catra gropes her chest with one hand and touches her clit with the other. Catra doesn't seem at all disappointed by not being able to properly strap Adora this time. She makes it clear in the dirty talk she pours out that she still intends on doing it one day.

“You like the way I feel inside you, princess, even knowing your body is at its *limit*? You have so many toys you could use, but you have to have me inside you. You’re going to keep trying until you can take me bending you over the bed and railing you, aren’t you?” Catra purrs out into her ear as Adora desperately twitches her hips and nods. She gasps for breath, needing to reply, feeling her orgasm building in her but not coming fast enough to give her the release she so desperately needs.

It comes in the form of words instead.

“*Yes*. Yes, I want you inside of me. You feel so good. Fuck, you take care of me so well. I don’t want anything else but you,” Adora whines out, a string of filthy phrases she has fantasized about but didn’t know if she would ever say. It takes the edge off just enough as Adora feels herself clench down on the toy, the burning stretch so close to a dangerous pain signal but edging her even closer to orgasm.

Catra’s hand on her chest tightens and the one against her clit picks up speed as Adora cries out softly. Fuck, she wants more of that. She wants Catra to touch her until it is painful. It feels like the only thing that will get her there with the toy overloading all her body’s senses. Adora gasps out, taking a few whining breaths to steady herself before she babbles more praise just hoping to egg Catra on further.

“You fuck me so well. I’m going to be sore tomorrow and think of *you* all day. It feels so fucking good. You take such good care of me, I start thinking about you domming me again as soon as you leave. It feels so good- *Oh*,” Adora cuts out, almost shrieking as Catra’s hand ramps up the speed and pressure to that painful level she was chasing. It is exactly what she needs. Adora screws her eyes shut, crying out a few loud, broken moans before everything finally goes numb with pleasure.

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Catra’s blood is pounding in her ears as she helps a sex-delirious Adora gently lift off the strap, still whining and twitching. Adora tries to cuddle her while she has the harness on, but the size of the strap means it gets in the way. Catra manages to slide it down off her hips while Adora cuddles with her torso. Adora ends up laid with her head on Catra’s chest, Catra’s arms and legs wrapped around her now she is free to cuddle her close. Adora breathes heavily and comes back to herself.

Adora is going to be sore as hell tomorrow, but for now she seems content to go utterly lax on Catra’s chest, occasionally humming a little softly as she nuzzles into the fluff over her heart. Catra feels like she just ran a marathon, and it isn’t just because Adora was squirming and hard to keep a hold of at the end there. Her heart is pounding in her chest, her body flush with endorphins or *something* after hearing Adora spill out dirty talk and praise like that. Adora isn’t quiet in bed by any means, but she isn’t usually *mouthy* like that. It’s a repeat of last week.

She feels fucking incredible. Clearly Adora does too. Catra always knew she had to talk to Adora about her dom drop because hiding it from her wasn't right, even if knowing about it would probably be an emotional burden to Adora. She was taking time to get comfortable enough to discuss it, but maybe it doesn't have to be an burden on her *or* Adora. Sessions like this feel incredible. If they can modify what they do, Catra might not even have to deal with the drop at all. A combination of praise and assurance seems to skyrocket her mood.

Right now, while Adora is boneless and likely to soon discover her soreness growing, isn't the time to talk about it, but as Catra cuddles her, feeling unprepared to let her go and shatter the moment, she decides that telling Adora about her drop when there seems to be a possible solution to it – at least when she is domming Adora – is easier than just admitting she has low periods that can't be helped. She still isn't looking forward to it, but considering the way her blood is thrumming right now, she doesn't *want* to have another session without talking about it.

Catra purrs as she nuzzles the top of Adora's head. Adora, sleepy and content but still conscious, hums back in response. While they are in the middle of aftercare isn't the time to tell Adora that they need to make sure they incorporate something new into it. For now, Catra just holds Adora. She will have to see how she wakes up feeling tomorrow, but she is pretty sure she knows the answer.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM scene: size kink, fringes of masochism related to size kink, strapping, and referring to a strap as if it is actually a lesbian's dick.
Realistic dildos kind of creep me out (it's just… a disembodied dick), but Adora wanted that Length.
Lonnie's crop. Etsy link, the product listing itself has no inappropriate images, but the recommended products on the page might.

Challenges

Chapter Notes

> No warnings. This chapter is a bit shorter, both because it just ended nicely here and because I just got my COVID booster and it absolutely kicked my ass.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wakes up on Saturday feeling great. Go fucking figure. Catra isn't actually mad about that fact despite how she tries to be. She wakes up early, tosses and turns a bit, and then reluctantly makes herself breakfast as she starts typing out a text to Adora before she remembers she is probably asleep. Catra stares at her phone screen for a long moment, blood pounding in her ears, and then forces herself to shove her phone back into her pocket.

She heads straight downstairs, making her way to the utility room and posting up in front of her canvas, determined to paint until her thoughts settle themselves into some kind of order. Unfortunately, the only order they fall into is pathetic yearning to be in Adora's arms, listening to her stupid early morning snoring as they cuddle. Catra would be disgusted with herself for missing such an annoying sound if it weren't for the fact that she has already had the thought many times in their years apart.

The difference today is that Catra isn't sad. She feels good, but her chest is straining to go back upstairs and pick up the key to Adora's house that is still tucked into her desk drawer. Adora didn't ask for it back and Catra certainly wasn't offering it. Today the feeling isn't about wallowing in her loss, but yearning for something she could very well have. If she showed up at Adora's house right now, with or without her key, she knows Adora would let her inside in a heartbeat.

She would let her into her house, arms, *heart*. And Catra wants to be there. She wants to be wrapped up in her arms, trading lazy kisses and touching each other tenderly. She isn't supposed to want that. She is supposed to dom, own, *subjugate* Adora in bed and just be her friend outside of that, but her heart refuses to follow her own rules.

Catra is so fucked. She doesn't know why she ever thought she could ease into things with Adora. She is still in love with her and, despite doing her best not to think about Adora's confession before their last session back in the studio, she knows that Adora still loves her. Catra still has no idea if either of them is ready to commit to a relationship or if they can do it without breaking each other's hearts again, but she knows that her heart can't settle for this limbo.

They have to talk. Addressing her dom drop is step one. Catra isn't prepared to think about what step two is yet.

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Adora is surrounded by her friends when she sees a notification from Catra and immediately tries not to blush. There is no reason to blush, the message is just a tiny thumbnail of a picture that Adora can't make out on her lockscreen, but it is the mere fact that Catra is on the other end of the line – and the flash of memories from last night that thinking about her elicits – that causes her heartrate to stutter.

Luckily, Sea Hawk managed to start a fire five minutes ago and is still getting yelled at, so everyone else is distracted from Adora pulling out her phone and unlocking it. The picture is of Catra's hand, holding a small thumb drive. There is no caption. It confuses Adora. She glances at the time finds it is just before two. This is Catra's next-day check-in text, she supposes, but she doesn't understand it.

Are you getting into digital art?

I suppose you could say I'm pursuing photography.

Adora flushes, remembering the two times that Catra took photos of her. Adora hasn't actually seen any of the pictures. She awkwardly asked Catra about it during one of their long phone calls and Catra mentioned that she would find a more secure way to get the photos to her than just texting them, but Adora hasn't thought to bring it up again, at least not at a time when it would be good to ask.

It's your photos, princess. They look good.

Adora desperately glances up and breathes out a sigh of relief when she seems Glimmer has Sea Hawk in a headlock and Mermista is cheering them on. Perfuma is sipping her tea while Bow watches with a fond expression. No one is paying attention to Adora or how red her face is. She desperately texts Catra back that she is out of the house, but she would be happy to take the USB from Catra when they meet up at the gym tomorrow.

Aw, worried I'm going to embarrass you?

Glimmer is here. I don't want to explain my face right now.

I want you to have to explain your face right now.

How are you feeling?

You want people asking about our sex life?

I feel fine. I was still a bit twingey when you left, but good now.

Fiiiiine. You're no fun, princess.

Can I come over to your place after the gym? I want to talk about future session plans.

Sure!

Adora is eager to have Catra over again. She is also pretty sure she is right to be excited about whatever these future plans are. If it's a plan she wants to run past Adora before they do it, then it must be something a bit more detailed. Adora feels herself shift a little where she sits, her cheeks warm at the thought.

"Who are you texting?" Mermista's voice cuts into her thoughts. Adora startles, blinking up at the smirk pulling at the corner of Mermista's lips as slowly, the entire table focuses in on her. Adora scrambles to think of a name to give her. Unfortunately, everybody she knows is at this table. Everybody except Catra, at least. From the sparkling look in Glimmer's eye, she has realized that too.

Adora slinks down in her seat. Mermista might as well have dangled bait in front of a hungry wolf and she knows it.

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Catra thinks she does an okay job of being normal when they meet up to work out on Sunday, teasing Adora as she gives her the USB with the photos on the walk back to the car afterwards, but she tenses up over the course of the drive. She doesn't really want to get out of Swift Wind when they reach Adora's house. She likes it in the car. It was, in some ways, their first home together – their foster guardian's house certainly doesn't count – and it holds good memories.

Adora parks in the garage, so it isn't that cold outside of the heated car, but she still doesn't want to get out. Okay, so maybe it has very little to do with the car and it's more about what they need to do when they leave it. Adora has definitely picked up on Catra tensing up over the course of the drive. She is anxious in the driver's seat, the car now parked and turned off

but Adora making no move to leave with Catra still reluctantly huddled in the passenger seat. Catra knows they need to talk, but she doesn't want to.

When she finally moves, it isn't to get out of the car. Instead, she turns and crawls over the center console into the back seat, determinedly not looking at Adora as she does so. It feels safer here. Not that Adora's house feels *un*safe, but it isn't home in the same way that the car is. If Catra can talk about this anywhere, she can talk about it here. She balls up on the bench seat right behind the passenger seat, her ears pinned back as she stares determinedly at the side door and ignores Adora hovering awkwardly in the front.

After what feels like an excruciatingly long minute, Adora undoes her seat belt and gets out of the car. For a moment Catra is worried she'll walk around to her side and confront her head on, but then the other side door opens and Adora slides onto the bench seat behind her. She doesn't get close – or at least, she doesn't get any closer than she absolutely has to considering the bench can only really seat two people comfortably. Catra's tail thuds against the side of the seat as she tries to think where to start.

"Catra, I understand if you want to stop. I'm not going to walk away if you've decided that all you want is to be friends," Adora whispers, her voice heavy. Catra twitches in the seat, immediately jolting up and turning to blink at Adora with wide eyes.

"What? No! I'm just- thinking," Catra cuts her off. Adora's expression, heavy with concern, remains pinched, though at least a bit of the weight seeps out of it. Catra swallows, her tail lashing. Shit. She can tell that she made Adora's worry go nuclear with her silence, but stopping is the furthest thing from what she wants when apparently domming Adora is better than when she has experienced with anyone else.

"I don't want to stop," Catra tacks on, just to hammer it home. Her voice is low and a little rough, but the tension in Adora's shoulders eases. Her expression is predominantly confused now. Catra takes a deep breath, looking away as she wraps an arm around herself. She has to just say it or Adora's worry is going to stick around through the already-hard conversation.

"I wanted to talk to you about adding something onto our aftercare," she mutters. Adora doesn't move except to tilt her head ever so slightly. Yeah, she has right to be confused. Catra certainly is making a big deal out of this. She tightens her hand on her own arm. "Remember when I told you about sub drop? Well, it's called that, but there's dom drop too," Catra admits, staring at the center console. She doesn't dare peek at Adora, but Adora immediately shuffles closer to her.

"What do you need? Would hugs help?" Adora asks, her voice soft and concerned. Catra startles a little, turning to blink at Adora in surprise. Adora's face is pinched with concerned. Catra realizes her mistake. She immediately leans towards Adora, which seems to relax Adora some as she takes it as permission and shuffles closer to wrap her arms around Catra. The position turns out to be ideal. Catra's face is buried in Adora's shoulder, so she doesn't have to see her reactions.

"I don't have it right now. I just realized that I don't have it after our sessions where you… assure me too, I guess. If we make that a permanent part of our aftercare routine, I don't think I would have to worry about it anymore with you," Catra admits, her voice low. Her tail

lashes behind her as she listens to Adora's abnormally-fast heartbeat. Adora turns her head and presses a soft kiss to the base of Catra's ear.

"Anymore?" Adora asks, her voice soft and breath puffing against her shoulder. Yeah, that's the question that Catra has been afraid of. If she can convince Adora this is something that a small change in their routine can prevent, then her dom drop can be something manageable and not an emotional burden that she is laying on Adora to make her feel guilty about their sessions. She just hopes it will help, but everything so far makes her believe that it is.

"I get it sometimes with clients, including you at first. It just leads to a few rough days. Depression stuff," she mutters, nuzzling into Adora's shoulder and marking along it. Her heart is pounding. She is waiting for the other shoe to drop, for Adora to ask more questions. She isn't ready to answer them at the moment, but she is expecting them to come. For several long moments, though, Adora just holds her as her tail lashes.

"Okay. Tell me what you need me to do. I don't want you to ever feel worse because of what we do," Adora responds. Catra doesn't quite whimper, but she releases a small sound as she ducks her face further down into Adora's shoulder and breathes deeply, thinking over not only what the answer to that question is, but how she is comfortable giving it.

"It's the mental stuff that gets to me. Feeling like I hurt you too much and you're regretting it, or feeling guilty for enjoying sadism and punishing you like- like-" Catra cuts off. Adora draws in a sharp breath, her arms tightening around Catra. She gently shushes her, running a hand down the back of her head and scratching at her neck.

"No, Catra. You're nothing like her. I fucking hope she didn't get off on it, but regardless, you *care*. It's consensual. Playing with you makes me feel more alive. I've never regretted something we've done," Adora assures her, her voice low but vehement in its dedication. Catra sucks in a deep breath, squeezing her eyes shut.

"I need you to say something like that when we're all done. Cuddling and stuff helps too. I've called you while I had dom drop before to assure myself, I just didn't tell you it was happening. I didn't need to, just hearing you was enough, but it means that I might need assurance the next day too," Catra admits, her voice scratchy. Adora nods, still holding her tight.

"You can always call me, but tell me what's going on. Please. I'll give you anything you need. I'll drive over if you want me to. I don't want our sessions to hurt you, Catra," Adora asks, her tone a bit pleading. Catra swallows, clutching a little tighter to Adora. Fuck. She was already feeling guilty for not telling her, but now that Adora has accepted her conditions willingly, she feels even worse – and kind of stupid.

"I wasn't ready to talk about it before, but I wouldn't be doing this if the drop was worse than the high. I just need my own aftercare. The guilt will be worse if you don't let me take care of you first, so wait until the end," Catra explains, rubbing her cheek against the side of Adora's neck again to soothe herself. Adora switches from scratching to cupping the back of her neck as she holds her steady for a long moment. She seems to be bracing herself as well, eventually blowing out a breath.

“Okay, I can do that. I wish you told me about this before, but I know why you didn’t. Is there anything else you can think of that would help?” Adora asks, resuming the slow petting down her back. Weakly, Catra purrs. She is so grateful for that understanding, even if she is anticipating Adora bringing it up again later. The truth is yes, she can think of one thing, but she still shakes her head. It isn’t lying. She isn’t ready for Adora to do that *thing* yet and telling her about it now may give her false hope for where their relationship is heading.

It would just be cruel, especially since Catra still isn’t sure of herself. She wants so much, and she doesn’t trust herself with it. The chances that she ruins the best thing she has ever had for the second time aren’t slim enough for her to take the risk. She wants not just aftercare, but nights spent cuddling in Adora’s arms. She wants to sit on the counter and babysit her as she cooks. She wants long drives in Swift Wind, to the store, or work, or nowhere in particular. She wants *Adora*.

“Come inside? We can cuddle in the sunroom and just spend time together. Like we would if you had dom drop and wanted to come over,” Adora proposes. Catra suppresses a shiver as she nods her agreement.

Fuck, she can’t be trusted with any of it, but she really wants her.

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They spend awhile cuddling on the porch swing. Adora avoids asking questions about anything aside from what she can do to help, but after Catra leaves late in the evening, she heads straight to her small office room and sets to researching dom drop immediately. She also sets the USB on her desk, her cheeks heating whenever she glances at it, but its contents are going to have to wait. She has other priorities right now.

She really should have done more research into BDSM on her own. It might have made this whole thing easier for them if she already knew about dom drop before Catra broached the subject. If Adora had been seeing a random dom, she definitely would have done more research – her preferred way to approach unknown situations is to gather as much information as possible and form a plan with multiple contingencies, after all – but she was usually more focused on Catra than the BDSM itself, and she trusts Catra implicitly, so she wasn’t worried about being misled due to being uninformed.

Now she dives into dom drop and what it is. The more she reads about it, the more it makes perfect sense to her that Catra would have the issue considering the way they were brought up. She isn’t able to find any professional domme who talks about having it, but she gets enough of an understanding of how it goes for regular doms that she suddenly understands how Catra was able to recognize her dropping so quickly during their last session in the yoga studio.

Catra recognized it because she has felt it. Feelings of inadequacy, guilt, failure, and cruelty run rampant in the posts that Adora find, not to mention more typical problems like

depression from the dopamine drop or muscle fatigue from a rough session. Reading everything, Adora yearns to have reassured Catra more in the past, but she was worried about overstepping Catra's boundaries at first. The best she can do for her is assure her after their sessions now.

She wishes that Catra told her the first time that she had it. Looking back, Adora can guess that it was the source of the surprise phone call that Catra made after their second session. She is glad that just talking casually helped, but Adora could have helped *more* if Catra had told her. Then again, she knows exactly why she didn't. In addition to having difficulties being vulnerable, one Adora's first suggestions would have been that they pause the sessions while they figure out a solution.

Clearly Catra didn't and still doesn't want that, but if she thinks changing their aftercare will help, then Adora will gladly try it. Adora is determined that, barring unpreventable endorphin drops, Catra isn't going to have dom drop with her again. She still has to ask her how this affects her as a professional dom, but that is a question for another day, when Catra isn't worn down from the effort of vulnerability. Adora will text her tomorrow just to talk – and hopefully as a somewhat-subtle check-in – but she will wait until they are face-to-face to ask more about her dom drop.

She tries not to worry about how anxious Catra was to talk about this and how much it has been an issue for her. She is worried, but Catra didn't need Adora interrogating her. She needed soft, reverent attention, and that's what Adora gave her. It is the kind of thing she thought Catra might consider disrespectful for a sub to give their dom at first and thus she avoided it. She kind of wishes she had given into the urge the whole time, but it also wasn't right then.

Catra said she wasn't ready before. Adora is just grateful that she is now.

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Catra opens her email inbox on Tuesday and stares at it in shock. The subject line *Open gallery slot this weekend* makes her heart pound. In her last few years of reaching out to galleries and shows, first as a graduate student and then as an artist with a masters, she has never gotten an offer back. Reading the email from the Plumerian gallery that she got the name of at the Halloween party, it seems that she wasn't supposed to this time either. An artist dropped out at the last minute and the gallery needs someone to fill the slot on short notice.

When they said they would add her contact information to the list, she didn't expect them to actually call her *back*. She has heard that canned response a dozen times now. It never amounted to anything before. With shaking fingers, she looks up the show. All she finds is a page on the gallery website that calls it an year-end display featuring new and emergent artists who could be household names by the end of the next year. The dates are posted, but not much other information.

Eventually Catra finds a line at the bottom of the page that says digital invites will be accepted as well as paper copies. An invitation-only show explains the lack of information online. If this gallery didn't come personally recommended and well-reviewed online, Catra would worry this could be a scam, but with them only asking for a portion of sales and not an upfront fee, it seems unlikely. She does some additional cursory research and finds the gallery mentioned in a few articles as a host to shows that are sometimes open to the public as well as private sale affairs.

Catra can't believe this. It seems too good to be true. She scans her eyes down the list of invited artists and feels her gaze stick on one. *C'yra*. And just like that, it all clicks into place. A traditional magicat name on the list likely means they invited a token artist for inclusion and then had to scramble when she pulled out at the last minute. It's annoying and grating that this is the way that Catra finally gets her shot, but as long as her paintings are on the floor this weekend, she doesn't fucking care.

She types a response, rereading it three times before she sends it off. Surprisingly, she gets an email back just twenty minutes later. Her heart is still pounding when she gets the reply. She is busy trying to rationalize to herself that the show could be a total flop, but it still can't hurt to go to since she isn't having to pay a fee just to show up. The email back ends all that rationalization. Her heart leaps in her chest all over again at the confirmation that she has the spot locked down, but reading the specifications of how much space she has and how many of each canvas size she can bring causes reality to come crashing down on her head.

This gallery is in fucking Plumeria. It's an hour-long flight away. The show opens in *three days*. The email says that they encourage artists to attend to promote their skills so that they may be able to secure future commissions from attendees, but getting there last minute is going to be difficult. There is no way for her to arrange shipping for her paintings at a reasonable price within that timeframe either. She is more likely to lose them in the post than they are to arrive in time, and shipping them off to an unknown gallery greatly increases her chances of getting stiffed.

On top of all that, the show is three days long. She will have to reschedule her appointments this weekend and get a hotel. Making it all happen is complicated, if not impossible. No wonder the initial email sounded a bit frantic. If they asked other artists first – magicat or otherwise – they likely weren't as desperate as Catra and said no after they assessed the situation. Unless an artist was local, it would be hard to arrange anything on this kind of schedule.

Catra has no idea how she is going to make this work, but she knows that she has to. Not just because she has already agreed to it, but because she *wants* it. All she has ever wanted is to be successful, and a show like this is the first step. She wants to prove their old foster guardian wrong. If she can make it in the art world, then everything that old crone ever said is invalidated. If she was wrong about Catra's art, why should she have been right about her worthlessness?

Catra needs this on a deep, almost spiritual level. She has to figure this out. Renting a truck and driving there makes the most sense, except she doesn't know how to fucking drive, much less have a license-

Fuck. Catra can't drive, but she knows someone who does. Someone who also owns a car that she could fit many of her canvases inside. It's a car she would even be comfortable riding in for four hours, which she doesn't think can be said about any other. She knows exactly how to get to this show, but it's a lot to ask, especially so last minute like this. She swallows as she stares at the email confirmation.

After months of building up all the ways it could go wrong, their conversation on Sunday was hard, but good. Adora accepted Catra's conditions with open arms – literally. She might not be able to help her last minute like this, but Catra needs this, and it would be a disservice to Adora to assume that she would turn her down on sight. She has to at least ask. If it was anything other than this, she wouldn't, but Adora is the only person in the world who knows how important this is to her.

--

It is late in the evening when Adora receives a text from Catra. They haven't talked yet today, so Adora isn't that surprised by Catra reaching out, even if she doesn't seem to have much of a reason to do it. The text is just a simple question about what she is doing. Adora texts back that she is cooking dinner and returns to bustling about the kitchen. There are several minutes of silence, but eventually Catra texts again, this time asking what she is cooking.

Catra proceeds to spend the next twenty minutes quizzing Adora about her dinner. She seems bored, but Adora is more than happy to indulge her as she keeps an eye on her skillet to make sure she doesn't burn anything. Catra asks her about the recipe and ingredients, how many times she has made it, how long it takes, and how much it makes. Eventually, Adora responds to one of the questions by asking why Catra cares about her dinner.

It's mostly a joke, but it's also a segue. Adora would prefer to talk on the phone instead. It is kind of hard to split her attention between cooking and texting. *Because I'm nervous*, is the response that Adora gets. Adora's heart stutters. She texts back asking what is wrong, but she gets no response. She feels her internal panic build as the silence stretches on, but she is chained to the stove and forced to focus on it to avoid burning anything.

She intends to stick to the stove and try texting again when her dinner is done – it's almost there – but her attention is pulled away early by a knock on her door. She doesn't quite startle, but she wasn't expecting it, and possibilities are already running through her head. She turns the heat off just to be careful. It can keep cooking on the residual heat anyway without having to worry about a fire.

She is both surprised and anticipating it when she opens her front door and finds Catra on the other side. Her arm is wrapped around herself and her ears are pinned to the side on her head. She looks anxious, her gaze fixed over Adora's shoulder. Adora opens her mouth, but she halts, not really sure what is going on or what to say. Catra cringes slightly before she rallies, clearing her throat and stepping forward.

“Can I come in?” she asks. Adora closes her hanging jaw, quickly nodding and stepping aside to let her in. Before Adora can welcome her or ask what is going on, Catra continues deeper into the house without even taking off her coat. Adora blinks at her retreating back as Catra makes a beeline straight for the kitchen.

“Okay,” Adora says, processing out loud as she turns back to her front door and closes it. As she locks it, her mind runs through the possibilities. Catra getting in a fight with her roommates seems like the most likely cause for her fleeing to Adora’s house without warning. She could also be in need of physical assurance but too ashamed to ask for it. She is clearly tense about showing up, so she isn’t here just to tease and play with Adora.

Adora steps hesitantly into her own kitchen. Catra is at the stove, tongs in hand and poking at the skillet as she sniffs the air as if she is already checking if the meal burnt in the few moments Adora was away from it. Adora hovers awkwardly just inside the doorway, unsure how to approach Catra. Catra’s tail is twitching as she sets down the tongs and instead just stares down at the stove. She seems unwilling to turn around.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks, her voice soft, as she pads towards Catra and cautiously hesitates just behind her shoulder. Catra snorts in response to that, heaving a sigh before leaning back slightly. Adora eagerly takes the hint and steps up so Catra can lean away from the stove and into her arms. With the burner off, the worst that will happen to her food is that it will get cold.

“Nothing bad happened. I just got a really great opportunity for my art, but without a lot of help I won’t be able to make it work and will have to turn it down,” Catra sighs, crossing her arms as she leans back into Adora’s embrace. Adora draws in a sharp breath. Oh. Oh, okay, Catra is in *mourning*. In their long phone conversations, Catra has talked about her frustrations with breaking into the art world. To finally have a shot but have to turn it away would break her heart.

It explains her odd behavior, her emotions likely running a bit wild. She is coming to Adora for support, but Adora is determined that she won’t have to turn it away.

“What do you need?” she asks.

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Catra called a ride the instant Adora told her she was cooking dinner and thus *home*. On the drive over, however, her nerves built. Every second that passed brought with it another reason that this was ridiculous. She was so busy worrying about the art show that it didn’t even occur to her that she was showing up unannounced until Adora asked why she was nervous.

She was trying to distract herself with the meaningless questions, but her anxiety built anyway. This was a terrible idea to begin with. She just asked Adora to accommodate her dom drop, and now she is thinking about asking her for this too? She almost calls another

ride from Adora's doorstep, but she manages to force herself to knock despite how she has now remembered that, in addition to how much of a favor she is asking, normal people have *lives* and a regular work week they have to adhere to.

Catra can cancel her three appointments this weekend with twenty-four hours' notice, but Adora has a fucking office job. She can't just run off to Plumeria with Catra on short notice and Catra feels fucking ridiculous as she explains the situation to her, waiting for Adora to rightly tell her it won't work. This is too much to ask of anyone – and yet Adora doesn't hesitate to say she'll call in sick. Catra finds herself trying to talk Adora out of it, pointing out reason after reason that it won't work, but Adora refutes every one.

"We'd have to, like, drive until midnight on Friday to get there," Catra points out over dinner. They are both sat at the kitchen table now, Catra eating the second serving that Adora intended to be leftovers. Whatever, she'll come over and cook something better for her tomorrow night. She will certainly owe it to her.

"So? We used to live in it all the time. I don't mind a long drive," Adora shoots back. Catra pouts. Adora just raises a brow at her. Catra wants this, but she has to impose so much on Adora to make it happen, and she hates that. Unfortunately, she isn't close with anyone else with a car. The metro is extensive enough there isn't much need for one when you live in the city proper.

"We wouldn't get back until late Sunday night. You'd have to go to work on only a few hours of sleep," Catra shoots back. Adora snorts, shrugging as she spears a bite of food on her fork and then points to Catra with it.

"I'll call in sick again if I have to. We're going to Plumeria. If I have to drive there by myself and just present *Ecstasy* as your proxy while you sulk at home about how it's impossible, then I'll do it. I want you to have this opportunity," Adora promises her. Catra sucks in a sharp breath, her tail thumping against the side of her chair as it twitches wildly. Adora is determined. She has a smirk of victory on her face as she finally takes the bite off her fork.

Catra isn't actually trying to talk Adora out of this, but she wants her to understand what she is getting into, because Catra certainly didn't think about it when she agreed to come to the show. She slumps in her seat, picking at her meal and taking a few bites as she tries to find another counterargument. Adora is smug in the seat across from her. Clearly she feels that she has won, and most infuriatingly, it seems that she *has*. Catra can't come up with anything that she hasn't brought up already.

"I pay for gas, the hotel, everything. You're already doing enough for me," Catra says, a statement that isn't up for negotiation. Adora opens her mouth and Catra cuts her off with a glare. "Everything. *Be good, princess*," Catra orders her. Immediately, she watches Adora's mouth snap shut as a blush dusts her cheek. Her nod is as flustered as it is reluctant. Catra goes kind of limp in her seat, the fight leaking out of her.

She needs this so badly, she almost wants to sabotage it for herself because she feels like it failing is inevitable. Turning it down outright will stop the disaster from striking just when she is beginning to hope. It is kind of what she did with their relationship too. Of course

Adora was a shitty girlfriend, but if Catra hadn't been so afraid – and if she had some fucking self-esteem – they might have been able to work around that.

"I'll research hotels and everything. I don't want you to do anything for this trip except driving and helping me move paintings," Catra adds. This time she takes a bite after her statement, satisfied that Adora won't protest again. Adora blinks, but she nods, seeming unbothered by the request now. "Good girl," Catra praises, almost absentmindedly, remembering that she gave Adora an order earlier and she followed it. Adora instantly perks up. If she had a tail, it would be fucking wagging. She is too cute.

"Okay, as long as you get to go to the show," Adora responds. Catra blushes. Apparently Adora is more determined to make this work than Catra's own subconscious is. She thinks that is exactly what she needs to make it happen, though.

--

Adora assumed they would spend this week talking on the phone as friends and then maybe have the opportunity to talk more about Catra's dom drop and the future of their sessions this weekend. Instead, they both go light when they meet up at the gym on Wednesday and Catra rides over to her house afterwards to work on the last-minute trip planning. Adora meant it when she said that she was going to make sure Catra made it out to the show.

Catra has told her before that she likes her job. It would be presumptuous of Adora to assume otherwise just because she knows about dom drop now, but she would prefer if Catra had the *option* to lessen her financial dependence on it if she has to. She would also like for Catra's wildest dreams to come true when it comes to her art, and a show like this is a great opportunity on both fronts. Regardless, Adora just wants to see the art of the woman she loves displayed for appreciation.

Catra is wound up over the show, anxious and more emotional than usual. Adora's previous plans for the week are gone. She certainly isn't going to ask about Catra's dom drop until she is done worrying about the show. Despite Catra's anxiety over the show – making it work, how it will go, and her obvious issues with imposing on Adora – Adora is looking forward to going on a weekend trip with her. It won't quite be a vacation, but they can still have fun.

Catra gets cooks her dinner as a thank you and to make up for crashing her last one, even if Adora never asked her to. She isn't going to protest spending time with Catra, even if they end up talking a lot about plans as they eat. Catra lets Adora soothe her some as they eat, and Adora really likes seeing Catra relax a bit over the course of the evening. While Adora washes up afterwards, Catra disappears into her garage to take measurements of Swift Wind's interior so she can gauge what canvases will fit inside.

Adora would like to help her take apart the back seat to make a larger space straight through into the trunk, but Catra glares her into submission and tells her to let her handle it. It isn't like they *have* to convert Swift Wind to carry the paintings right now, Catra just wants to get

proper measurements so she can plan accordingly, and if Adora being hands-off about all this is what it takes for Catra to accept her help, then she can at least try to take a backseat. It is Catra's career, after all.

Catra seems more relaxed by the time she is calling a ride to take her home. Having run her plans past Adora seems to have helped soothe her. She sighs softly when she hugs Adora goodbye, tucking her face into her shoulder and relaxing until her phone buzzes and signals it is time to go.

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"Your music taste hasn't gotten any better," Catra ribs as she climbs into Adora's passenger seat. They are stopped at a gas station. It is nearly nine PM on Thursday. Adora came straight over to Catra's after work with her weekend bag tucked under her seat already. They loaded up Catra's own bag and the canvases and took off. It's a long drive and they have to reach Plumeria before midnight, when the lobby of the hotel that Catra found finally closes.

As long as they don't stop too often or get lost, they should make it. Adora grins at her, setting aside the trail mix she bought at the gas station counter when it was her turn to go inside – no matter how tight their schedule is, they can't leave the car unattended with all of Catra's paintings inside – and dusting off her hands as she goes to put the car back into drive. She is blasting meaningless pop music, the kind of shit they play in malls to encourage people to think positively and spend money.

"And yet you still like me. How embarrassing," Adora shoots back as she pulls out of the parking spot. It is a stunning rebuttal. Catra rolls her eyes as she doublechecks that her seatbelt is clicked. She hasn't heard that phrase – or the common denial Catra used to make that it is referencing – in years, and its return makes her cheeks heat and her ears twitch. She scoffs and folds her arms in the passenger seat.

"Please, you wish. You're just my chauffer, princess," Catra shoots back. Adora hums and doesn't respond. She seems very happy living under her delusion.

--

Adora hums softly when Catra rolls over in bed and tucks under her chin. It is past midnight now and they have to be up in seven hours to take Catra's paintings to the gallery, but they couldn't leave them unattended in the freezing car overnight, so they had to spend awhile carrying them up to the hotel room after they got checked in. The hotel room has two beds, but they aren't using them. The other bed is covered in paintings.

It was supposed to be a temporary measure as they were bringing them in, but Catra dropped down on the other bed with a heavy sigh when they finished hauling everything up. The hotel room's thermostat was set too low for her and she was shivering. Adora took the opening to cuddle her and before long Catra was offering for them to sleep in the same bed tonight *just to make things easy so we can finally go to sleep*.

Well, they went to bed, but they aren't asleep. Catra keeps moving, and she is usually a still sleeper. Adora is tired – actually, she's fucking exhausted after driving four hours – and she isn't feeling on top of her game. The next time Catra shifts to roll away again, Adora rolls with her. Catra squeaks as Adora plasters over her front. Despite Catra's tail lashing against the mattress, Adora sighs with contentment as she pins Catra in place beneath her.

"Go to sleep. You need to be rested for tomorrow," Adora mumbles, rubbing her cheek against Catra's for a moment before she drops her head down onto the pillow and goes limp. She knows that falling asleep isn't that simple, but Catra also needs the rest. Beneath her, Catra sighs, but she wiggles a little as if to settle in and her tail settles down. She doesn't reject the pin, however light it may be. Several long moments pass in silence. Adora is starting to drift off again, but Catra's tail has begun to twitch. Even half asleep, Adora can tell she is anxious.

"Want me to move to the other bed?" Adora asks, her face still pressed into the pillow. She would have to move the paintings, but she will fall asleep faster doing that if Catra just isn't comfortable sleeping together and will settle down after she moves. Catra shakes her head in response, lifting both her arms and legs to wrap them around Adora and hold her close against her. It feels really nice.

"I'm just anxious for tomorrow. You're helping," Catra murmurs, her voice low. Adora's heartrate picks up a little, some of the tiredness fading in the face of that. She turns her head, nuzzling Catra's cheek with her nose this time. Catra's tail stills as she does so. Adora hums a quiet acknowledgement as she thinks about what might help Catra. She was anxious off-and-on during the drive over too, the situation not helped by the fact that she was in a car, especially for an extended period of time.

"At worst you don't sell anything and we got a fun weekend of cuddling and road tripping out of it. Your art is amazing, Catra. It's going to do great," Adora assures, her voice still low and rough with sleep. Catra purrs a little, though she seems reluctant about it. Adora snorts, nuzzling against her cheek as Catra squirms a little beneath her. Her tail is lashing all over again.

"What about people talking to me? What if someone is interested in my art and I put my foot in my mouth and lose them?" Catra asks, her voice anxious. Clearly she has been running in circles in her own head about every single thing that could go wrong. Adora squeezes her a little tighter. Catra instantly clings back.

"Your art speaks for itself, Catra. If you aren't sure of what to say, then don't. Be the brooding artist. No one but me has to know you're a big softie," Adora mumbles into her cheek. Catra squeaks, indignant, but Adora is maybe drifting off and doesn't have much a filter anymore. "Shhh. You're hot when you brood, but you need sleep," Adora assures her,

dropping her head back on the hotel pillow and breathing in. It isn't as comforting as her bed at home, but she has Catra in it with her to make up the shortfall.

Catra sputters a little bit, but either she gives up or she realizes that Adora is going to fall asleep before she can protest, because she ends up just tucking her face down into Adora's shoulder. As long as she is silent and still, sleep with come for her, just like how it is taking Adora down right now. She knows she falls asleep too fast to really tell, but she swears that Catra relaxes after that.

Chapter End Notes

This fic is now part of a series. Subscribe to the series to make sure you don't miss out on future installments. Beg For Me will be the only fic with "plot", but I'll be adding on smutshots after the fic. Don't expect any right away, but I am leaving it open for later additions set after the main story of this fic.

The Art Show

Chapter Notes

No warnings.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra is obviously nervous as they wait for the show to open, flitting around her space to make sure her paintings are hung up perfectly, but once the event gets going, she does well. She takes some time to warm up, but after a few hours she also knows what to expect, and that seems to make it easier for her to talk to people. She hangs out with Adora around her display, ready to pop in if she sees someone eyeing her paintings with intensity. In the time in between talking to patrons, they get to just spend a day being friends.

They have to watch their language and subject matter due to their company, but they reminisce and Adora learns more about Catra's art, both through what she tells her directly and what she overhears when Catra slips away to woo a potential buyer. They don't really know how successful she is being – she hands out a number of business cards, but sales are made with a gallery clerk and the paintings will stay on display for the whole event, so Catra won't find out if she sold anything until the gallery closes tonight – but Adora thinks she is doing a fantastic job.

She watches Catra interact with the visitors as much as she can without being creepy. Partly because she genuinely wants to know everything about Catra's passion that she can and this is a great opportunity to learn, but she also just likes seeing the bright look in Catra's eye and how she lights up when discussing her art. Sure, she stumbles at times, especially when she doesn't click with the person she is talking to, but it's hard to be perfect for an entire day, especially in a new setting.

Late evening hits and Adora watches Catra easily chat with a gallery patron. He introduced himself as a hotel owner, but despite his wealth he isn't a snob, talking easily and naturally with Catra, which hasn't been true for everyone at the event. Adora can't help but beam with pride seeing the person that Catra has grown into. Moments like this make everything worth it. Catra is visibly happy, practically radiant as she talks about her latest series. She might not sell all her paintings, she might not even sell *one* of them, but the sight before Adora right now is worth the entire trip.

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Walking over to the gallery desk at the end of the night is nerve-wracking. Catra isn't sure what to expect. A lot of the people she talked today were property owners, and a surprising amount of doctors or dentists. They were people with money who might need art to display in their businesses and offices, but in Catra's mind they aren't the usual crowd who would enjoy her work. Then again, poor dykes can't really afford to buy it, and Adora herself almost became a doctor.

Still, even if her work does appeal to them, she doesn't know what to expect in sales. She tells herself that she just wants to make back the money for the hotel room and gas, but the truth is she doesn't give a shit about money. The revenue from one gallery show could make her comfortable for a bit, but what she really cares about is getting her name out there. In her mind, however, the best way to gauge people's reaction to her work is through sales.

Adora is by her side when the clerk consults his computer and informs her that she sold one painting. Catra doesn't know what to make of that. It feels good, but what if the other artists have sold out already? Adora doesn't seem to know what to do with her flat reaction as she nods, thanks the man, and turns away. She doesn't ask questions until they are in the privacy of Swift Wind and driving back to the hotel, though.

"A sale is good, right? You didn't lose money on the trip at least. And you gave out so many cards!" Adora says, her eyes fixed on the road but clearly prodding Catra. Catra blinks out of the window of the car. The truth is, she doesn't know.

"I sell a painting online a few times a year, and those paintings are listed cheaper. So yeah, a sale today is good, I just don't know if it's good *enough*," she admits, her voice a bit small as she hunches in the passenger seat. It feels so weak to admit, but she really doesn't know what is considered good for an unknown artist's first real time in a gallery show. She is so glad to be in the familiar comfort of Swift Wind and not a rental car as they drive back.

The hotel room being strange and unknown was another reason she struggled to sleep last night. She is going to have to see if she can come up with an excuse for them to continue sharing a bed tonight just for the comfort of Adora by her side. The paintings won't leave the gallery until the show is over, so the other bed is now completely free for Adora to take, but Catra doesn't want her that far away. In the driver's seat, Adora is quiet for a long moment.

"We had a good day together, I got to learn a lot about your world, you at least haven't lost money on this trip, and you got your name out there. Someone loved your painting enough to pay you hundreds of dollars for it," Adora reminds her, gently. Catra swallows, staring out the window at the city lights passing in the night. Adora has a point. She has several, actually. It doesn't magically heal Catra's anxiety, but it does put things in perspective a bit.

Catra twitches her tail, laying it over the center console and draping it over Adora's thigh. Adora draws in a small breath. One of her hands falls from the wheel so she can squeeze Catra's tail gently before lightly petting it. Offering her tail is the way that Catra knows to thank her, for the moment, but Adora doesn't seem to need more. The car is filled with her quiet humming as they drive back to the hotel.

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Catra doesn't ask Adora to sleep in her bed with her, but she does ask if she wants to watch TV after they have showered and had a shitty dinner in the hotel's restaurant. Watching TV was always code for cuddling before, so Adora isn't surprised when Catra shifts a bit conspicuously to make more room in her bed after Adora agrees. It isn't that late in the day, but they both only got a few hours the night before and had a very tiring day. The gallery doesn't have any chairs and Adora, despite being in shape, is used to working at a desk all day. Apparently rich people are above comfort, though.

It feels amazing to crawl into bed with Catra, the two of them wrestling just a little until they end up in a comfortable position together with Catra happily nestled in Adora's arms and purring softly. As tiring as the day has been for Adora, Catra had more stress to deal with and had to be more social, so she starts drifting off first. When Adora notices her wilting, she quietly reaches for the TV remote and turns the volume down to a whisper. Catra's ears twitch, but she doesn't move aside from that.

A few minutes later, Adora mutes the TV entirely. Catra's ears don't twitch this time. Adora is fairly certain she is still awake, even if she can't see her face where it is pillowed on her shoulder and facing the TV. Despite that, Catra makes no protest when Adora finally turns the TV off completely and sets the remote aside. Adora gets comfortable, shifting down on the bed from her half sat-up position until they are cuddling amongst the sheets. She can tell Catra's eyes are closed now, but she definitely isn't sleeping.

She still lets Adora cuddle her, the two of them wrapped up together. Adora doesn't know if she just wants affection right now, or if she needs some comfort after a stressful day of selling herself, or if maybe Catra's sensitive ears are picking up more noise around the hotel than Adora can hear and she is using Adora as an anchor – even Adora can hear what sounds like TV static coming faintly from the next room, though she isn't bothered by it – but either way, Adora is happy to fall asleep with Catra in her arms.

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Two paintings sold on the second day. Catra was starting to feel worn down by the time they went to visit the clerk in the evening. Now that it has been cemented that the trip hasn't been a loss – and she has handed out more cards – she feels less anxious about it. She can't help but think about what Adora said last night: regardless of what she sells, maybe this trip is just worth it for how they are getting to spend time together during it. Yes, it's exhausting, but she is spending day-in and day-out with Adora, and it just feels… nice. It feels familiar, but it isn't quite stepping into the past and reliving the brief school breaks where they got to live together.

Things are more cautious now, some of the ease gone – back then it was just a *given* that they would cuddle as they slept – but Catra also feels comfortable in a way she wasn't sure she would again. When they get out of the gallery, Catra is quiet as she pulls out her phone and types away on it. She has a few unanswered messages – mostly from her roommate group chat, though she has a number from Lonnie, who has apparently somehow found out that Catra went on this road trip with Adora – but she isn't interested in those. Instead, she searches for popular restaurants near their location.

They just ate hotel food last night, but it wasn't great, and with today's sales Catra can easily buy Adora dinner. It will be a test, too. Something a bit more romantic. They have always been blurring lines, even from their first session together where Catra was too affectionate with Adora to call her a regular client, but this would be an outright breach of terms if Catra didn't owe Adora for making this last-minute trip with her. She can try it out and see how she feels about it, but she can do so under the guise of paying Adora back if it turns out to be too much.

Finding a decent restaurant in the short walk between the gallery and the car isn't easy. Adora is putting the car in drive when Catra twitches her tail over and lightly smacks Adora's wrist to give her more time to browse the list of restaurants. Adora hesitates, leaning around a little to try to peer at Catra's face. Catra glances up, making eye contact and raising a brow at Adora. She is getting awfully close. Adora blushes, pulling back and huffing a little.

"Am I allowed to know what you're doing?" Adora asks, the exasperation in her tone clearly exaggerated. She isn't actually bothered by the delay. She is smiling as Catra blushes and flicks her tail back to her side of the car, curling it up in her lap. She eyes her phone screen. The one she has open right now will have to do. It's close and well-reviewed, so that's good enough for her.

"I'm finding us a place to get dinner. I'm not eating that hotel food all weekend. My treat," Catra tells her, pulling up the map to the restaurant. In the dim streetlight shining into the car, Adora's eyes sparkle. She stares at Catra for a long moment as Catra steadily blushes, but eventually she decides to let her have it, smiling to herself as she holds a hand out for Catra's phone so she can get a look at the route. Catra gives it to her and quickly looks away.

Friends go out to eat sometimes. It doesn't have to be a big deal.

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Adora is about eighty percent sure this is a date, but she is nervous to ask. Catra already insisted on paying for everything on this trip, and she does have a point that their last-minute hotel was selected for its lobby hours and not its dining options. They should go out to eat tonight, but Catra's nervousness around asking, and especially her blush as they walk into the restaurant and the atmosphere hits them, makes Adora suspect this is more than just a necessity.

The lights are dim, the tables mostly seat small groups, and there is soft music playing in the background. The restaurant is designed like a date spot. The hostess warmly greets them and asks if they want a table for two. Catra tries to be normal when they get seated, but her tail is flicking nervously as she intently stares at her menu. Adora isn't sure if she is anxious about Adora assuming too much or worried that taking Adora on a date is going too far.

Adora hesitates, staring down at her menu for a long moment before she sighs and puts it down. Catra immediately tenses, her ears flicking, before she reluctantly lowers her menu as well. Catra pauses for a long moment. Adora doesn't know if she should ask or wait for Catra to get there on her own time, but after several seconds Catra seems to break, looking up and sending Adora a shy-but-hopeful look.

"Let's try it out and see?" she asks, her voice quiet. She could be talking about any number of things, including just the restaurant as a dining option, but Adora draws in a sharp breath, her heart beating in her chest. This is a date, then, but Catra isn't sure of herself. Adora reaches out across the table, and though Catra gives a slight twitch first, she hesitantly reaches back and takes up Adora's hand.

"Just for tonight? To see how it feels?" Adora asks. If they're going to do this, then Adora wants to drive Catra home – or back to the hotel room, whatever – and kiss her goodnight. She wants to show her that she has nothing to fear and that Adora will treat her right this time. She wants to hold hands with her and did she mention that she really, really wants to kiss her? Catra flushes at her words, but she squeezes Adora's hand and nods, still flustered but seeming relieved.

One night. It's enough for Adora.

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The night at the restaurant is fun. Of course it is, it's an evening with Adora. Adora makes a bid to pay for just the tip, but Catra puts her foot down that she is paying for this trip. Adora doesn't insist, but she does take Catra's hand as they stand from the table – she also held Catra's hand *over* the table a lot before their food arrived – and smiles to her as she leads her back to the car.

They almost miss their turn heading back to the hotel in the dark, but nothing catastrophic goes wrong just because she took Adora for a date. It doesn't feel all that different, or scary, or like the world is going to end because they're holding hands now. Catra doesn't know where *just for tonight* ends, but she knows that she kind of doesn't want it to be over yet as they get back to their room. Specifically, she wants Adora back in her bed tonight. She doesn't want the date to ruin things or make them weird.

When Adora reaches out and squeezes her shoulder as Catra unlocks the door, she feels a jolt of worry run through her. She turns the door handle and opens their room before she draws in a deep breath to brace herself and she turns around to face Adora. Adora looks as nervous as

she feels, but her expression is hopeful as she steps close and shifts her hand to lightly cup the side of Catra's neck, making intense eye contact.

"Can I kiss you goodnight?" Adora asks, her voice soft and anxious, but fuck, Catra can hear how badly she *wants* it. It makes her head spin a little as her tail lashes behind her in the open doorway. She knows that Adora still wants her - still loves her - but a part of her traumatized brain is always trying to convince her otherwise. When she gives Adora the opportunity to say things like this, *ask* things like this, even Catra can't listen to her inner demons.

"Yes," she breathes. She tilts her chin back just a little as she speaks, inviting Adora to close the gap of the last few inches. Adora's eyes immediately darken. She shifts her hand up, cupping the side of Catra's head with her thumb just beneath her ear, and draws Catra in as she leans forward herself and meets her in a slow, amorous kiss. It isn't chaste. Adora kisses her with a gentle firmness, licking into her mouth and tilting her head just a little to get a better angle.

Catra's eyes fall closed with a slight whimper as she meets Adora just as passionately. Their mouths are pressed together, but it still feels like they aren't close enough. Catra wants to drown in Adora. She reaches out and grabs Adora's hips, pulling their bodies close together. That is all the direction that Adora needs to step forward and crowd Catra into their open hotel room.

It isn't just a kiss goodnight. It is a kiss against the back of the door when they turn to lock it, and then a series of kisses as they trail deeper into the room, and then a break in the kisses as Adora pulls Catra's shirt over her head and begins tracing her hands over her body. It is Catra moaning when Adora picks her up and lifts her onto the bed, crawling up after her and whispering to her as she does so.

"Is this alright? Do you want this?" are maybe the stupidest questions that Adora has ever asked her.

"Yes," Catra gasps out, before ducking her head and setting to sucking a hickey onto the side of Adora's neck. Adora moans as she braces her arms on either side of Catra so she can avoid pinning her completely.

"Would this make things worse? I want to take care of you, Catra, but you're still my dom," Adora asks next, her voice rough and a touch whining as Catra makes her mark. Catra releases her neck as a slight shiver runs down her back. No, it won't make things worse. She appreciates the assurance, but she knows Adora won't suddenly stop obeying her or respecting her as a dom just because Catra let her top her like this.

"Please," is the only response she can give to that. It isn't even a command, but Adora obeys.

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Adora wakes to morning light filtering through the gap in the hotel blinds and Catra purring happily in her arms, much like she did last night when they settled down after Adora had brought her over. It is the first time she has woken up before Catra on the trip. She lifts her head enough to check the clock and breathes out a sigh of relief when she sees that it's eight. They still have plenty of time to sleep in a bit more before getting ready to head over to the gallery.

It gives Adora time to just enjoy cuddling Catra. The last two mornings, Catra always woke her up at the last minute before she had to get ready to leave so she could get in as much sleep as possible. Today, Adora gets to just watch Catra's face, peaceful and slack with sleep, as she breathes steadily. Her rumbles are soft and somewhat inconsistent, but she seems utterly content in Adora's arms. Her ears flick a little occasionally – seemingly whenever Adora breathes too much on them – but otherwise she is still.

She is so cute, so *beautiful*. Adora wants to pet her ears and kiss her cheeks. She wants to bury her hand in Catra's mane and draw her into a series of lazy morning kisses until both of them have forgotten that they have somewhere to be. Most of the time she is happy with their weird friendship with sex on the side, but after last night, and now waking up like this, all she can think about is everything that they could be. Fuck, the date is making her *hopeful*.

Adora has accepted a lot of barriers – thin as they may be – in their new dynamic while Catra got comfortable. Everybody has boundaries and she would just be a dick to not accept them, but that's a two-way thing too, and apparently dates are hers. She can fuck Catra and, yes, she may love her while she is doing it, but it doesn't get her hopes up or make her yearn like this. Trying out dates does. Adora sighs as she reaches up and gently pets over Catra's mane.

Maybe Catra will wake up and tell her she is ready, but Adora doubts it, which means instead they are going to have to have a talk that Adora really doesn't want to have. She loves Catra too much to be given hope from something like last night. Sex is fine, a way to have an intimate connection together that doesn't necessarily have to lead to romance, but fuck, all Adora can think about is how electric their kisses last night felt and how good dinner was.

It's too much for her heart to take.

--

Catra wakes to gentle squeezing on her shoulder. She grumbles, trying to cling onto Adora, but Adora cajoles her, reminding her they have to get up for the show. Catra doesn't *want* to leave. She wants to stay bundled up in Adora's arms forever. She wants to soak into this warmth until the end of the universe. She woke up purring – she doesn't *do* that, at least not anymore, not ever since she stopped sleeping with Adora.

Catra blames her half-awake state for why she thinks it's a good idea to turn her head and kiss Adora while Adora is trying to convince her to get up. She doesn't even stop purring. It is a long and slow kiss, not that chaste despite Adora locking up and squeaking with surprise

beneath her lips. It isn't until Adora pulls back and blinks at her that Catra realizes what she has done, her mind catching up with her body. She gapes at Adora as Adora stares at her, the racing of her heartbeat filling her ears.

"I-" she starts, and then stops, because she doesn't know why she fucking did that aside from the fact that she got caught up in the fantasy from last night and forgot she isn't allowed to. Adora doesn't look upset, but she doesn't look happy. The kiss wasn't welcome. *Duh*, she was kissed unexpectedly without consent. "I'm sorry," Catra finishes lamely, her voice thin and tail lashing behind her. Adora's jaw clicks shut. She swallows, a determined light flaring in her eyes.

"Catra, I can't do this," she whispers. Catra's heart drops. She feels her ears pin back and her eyes go wide. Adora's expression immediately pinches with concern. She reaches out with one hand to cup the back of Catra's head, holding her close as she quickly shakes her head and shoots Catra an almost pleading look.

"I can't go on dates or kiss unless we're actually committing. I love you, Catra. Friendship and sex are fine, but last night made me want something that I know I can't have right now. Unless you've changed your mind about that, I just can't do this stuff. It hurts," Adora whispers, her expression raw along with her voice. Catra is struggling to breathe, unable to look away from Adora's wide eyes, pleading with Catra to understand.

She does. She thinks she does. She just- fuck. *Fuck*. This is her fault. She pushed too far, focusing on expanding her own comfort zone and not thinking about the consequences to Adora's feelings. That is twice now that Adora has said she loves her without Catra saying it back, even if she would hope that she has shown Adora it in the way she has acted and talked about her since the beginning. The mere fact that Catra continued to try something with her after Adora told her the first time is confirmation that she feels the same, but she hasn't *said* it.

It's hard for her to voice her feelings and give others the opportunity to hurt her with them. She used to know that Adora, at least, would never do that to her, and then the breakup happened. She knows, logically, that Adora won't hurt her now and she didn't do it on purpose then, but feelings aren't based on logic – after all, Catra just woke up and kissed Adora despite it explicitly being against their rules. Catra swallows and nods, feeling mute. She has so much that she wants and *needs* to say, and yet she just can't.

"Adora, I-" she starts, the words dying in her throat as quickly as they begin. Adora's brows draw together and she reaches out, gently sweeping some of Catra's hair out of her face. Catra can feel her inner turmoil showing on her face. She doesn't think she is ready, but she also doesn't want to keep living in this limbo. She just wants Adora in all her fullness. She wants to kiss her as they get ready in the morning and fall asleep in each other's arms. She wants dates and she wants leather and chains. She wants it all. Everything they had before and have now.

"It's okay. I'm happy with what we have been doing, I just can't add anything more unless we're going all in. I care too much, Catra," Adora tells her, assuring her about a problem that she isn't having. Catra swallows, shaking her head and then lurching forward to tuck herself

beneath Adora's chin, drawing in a few unsteady breaths as she tries to ground herself with her scent.

"I care too," is the slightly wobbling response she manages to give, her voice just shy of cracking. Fuck. Fuck, she wants so much, but the least fair thing she could do to Adora right now is rush in before she is ready just because she wants affection or whatever else and ruin them all over again. She couldn't take that. Adora threads her hand through her mane and holds her close against her.

"I know. And I'll be here, whenever you're ready. I think- I feel like it's inevitable now? But I don't want to pressure you into something before you're ready," Adora tells her. She sounds a bit nervous to admit it, like she thinks it might be putting too much of an expectation on Catra. It certainly sends a jolt through Catra. *Inevitable*. Apparently Adora has more faith in Catra getting over her issues than Catra does, but part of her loves hearing it. She loves it because she just likes the idea of them having everything again one day.

"We need to get up. You'll have me alone for four hours tonight. If you want to talk more, we'll have time," Adora reminds her, her voice low. Catra squeezes her eyes shut. Part of her is expecting to find tears gathering, but they are mercifully dry. They go back tonight, driving straight to Adora's house so she can get as much rest as possible before work tomorrow. Catra is going to unload her unsold paintings into Adora's house temporarily, with Adora bringing them back over to her place at a later date. After tonight, they'll be back where they were before, only seeing each other a few times a week.

"I don't want to go home," Catra whispers, her voice small. She wants to keep being with Adora every night. This trip feels like a parallel universe they have fallen into and going back feels like it will shatter everything, all her old doubt waiting at the Bright Moon city borders to rush in and remind her why being intimate with Adora is a terrible Idea. Above her, Adora's breath hitches, her fingers spasming a bit in her hair before she resumes cradling Catra.

"I'll still be there," Adora assures her. Catra swallows. Yes, *Adora* will, but will she, or will her old demons force her to run herself off again?

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Catra is quiet for the rest of the morning, even after they get to the gallery. She hung back a bit more yesterday and technically made double the sales that way, so maybe it is a conscious choice that she is making, but Adora also can't help but feel like their talk in the morning threw her off. She really should have waited until after the show to talk to her about it, but then Catra kissed her and she had to say *something*. She honestly thinks the talk went well, but it was a heavy way to start the morning.

Catra makes an effort to respond to anyone who wants to know about the artist – a lot of the questions seem to be about her other work and her process, like the patrons are scoping out

her range or productivity or something – but she doesn't approach anyone for herself today. By noon, they have given out notably fewer business cards. Adora reaches into her pocket to feel the supply and frowns when she realizes that she hasn't given out a single one for herself or restocked the supply that Catra is keeping in her own pockets.

It might just be that the trip has paid for itself so Catra isn't worried about making sales anymore – maybe she is even trying to go for a new strategy, acting like an aloof artist – but she is also withdrawn from Adora. The last two days, they talked and chatted until it seemed like somebody might want her business card or they approached Catra for themselves. Today, Catra is mostly quiet with both Adora and patrons. She seems contemplative.

Adora did kind of give her an ultimatum earlier, but she didn't mean for it to feel like that. It takes her a few hours to realize that is how Catra took it, but it explains her silence. Adora really just meant that they can't keep doing what they did yesterday and need to fall back to their dynamic from before the trip until Catra is ready for more, but given Catra's quiet state, Adora can't help but wonder if Catra is thinking about the second option that Adora didn't really mean to present: getting back together.

Of course Adora wants that, but she didn't think Catra was ready. Or at least, she didn't before this weekend. It was only last weekend that she was admitting her dom drop like it was a shameful secret, and they still haven't circled back around on that and honestly talked about it and how Catra feels about her job in general. Adora thought she knew the latter before last Sunday, but now she can't help but wonder if Catra's relationship with it is more complex.

A lot of Catra's life is unfortunately complicated. It seems like she gets to enjoy few things stress free. Even art, her passion and escape, is clearly stressful to her when she is worried about establishing herself. Adora watches a pair of patrons – they are two wildly different ages and one seems to be deferring to the other, so Adora would guess the young man is the woman's assistant – stop in front of Catra's paintings, looking them over with a keen eye, but Catra remains standing off to the side, her gaze distant.

Adora reaches into her pocket, pinches one of the cards, and strides forward with a smile on her face.

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Catra is off kilter, worn down from the long weekend, and now in an internal crisis as she realizes just how many times they have violated the bounds of friendship without technically breaking any rules. She is too busy being caught between how much she doesn't want to lose what they have already and fear of everything going wrong if they commit to talk to strangers. She justifies it with the fact that she recognizes some faces in the crowd as previous visitors returning for one last look, but she knows she wouldn't be stepping up if every patron was new either.

She still does her best, but she tells herself that maybe the hands-off approach is better anyway, and thus she stays in her circular thought loops, wondering why she is so afraid when Adora has done nothing but treat her right this time around. She is so caught up, she misses Adora stepping forward, but the sound of her voice finally pulls her out of her reverie. Catra watches, wide-eyed and surprised, as Adora introduces herself as "the artist's assistant" and offers a card for if they would like to see more.

She is even more surprised when the older woman Adora held the card out to - before her assistant took it for her - asks her what materials Catra prefers to use and Adora knows the fucking answer. She shouldn't, Catra was never able to afford the paints she prefers now when they were still together, but apparently she has been listening intently to Catra for the last two days despite how she wasn't a part of any of Catra's conversations with patrons except to bring over cards.

The answer is also complicated since Catra favors oil paint for people, nature, or anything being hit with sunlight, but often uses acrylics for anything else, especially her abstract art. She uses all kinds of paint really, but oil is her favorite despite its expense. Adora manages to parrot information about Catra's paint types and what she has used on the canvases on display without seeming to need to think too hard about it. Catra does her best not to stare, instead hanging back with her arms crossed and her heart pounding.

"She prefers to express herself through her art than her words, but if you have any questions, I can answer them," Adora says for her. That isn't normally true, but today? Sure. It excuses her silence, at least. Catra hangs back with her heart rattling in her chest like it is desperately trying to find a gap between her ribs to slip through and fly free, straight into Adora's embrace. Fuck, she loves her. Adora has always completed her.

That was really why they fell apart. Catra needed her too much and Adora couldn't give her enough of what she needed. Catra has stood on her own for five years, though. She knows she can live without Adora. She doesn't need to rely on her like she used to. They don't have to become codependent if they get back together. It is nice to lean on someone occasionally – to have support on a day like *this* when she can't find a reason to put on her game face – but Catra doesn't need Adora like she did before.

As Catra watches Adora step back, and then step up again when someone else stops for a bit too long in front of her paintings, it occurs to her that while it is possible that they still won't work out, they can't fail in the same way that they did before because they don't *need* each other like they did before. Want each other, love each other? Yes, definitely, but Catra has a job and a fucking master's degree. She has friends – a few, but still there – and she has, most of all, stability.

Adora has the same – well, minus the degree – and now knows that she can live without Catra and *with* failure, if she has to. As Catra watches her with a rabid beat thudding against her chest and into her throat, she realizes one thing, and it might just be the most important thing: this time, Adora knows to pay attention to what Catra actually needs and not what she thinks that Catra wants. She has followed every rule. Even while Catra was frantically kissing her last night, she stopped to ask if this would make things worse long-term.

Catra fucking loves her. She is still afraid, but she knows she can't take holding back forever. Why not start *trying*?

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The car is lighter for the drive back home. Catra sold three paintings on Sunday, though Adora doubts that is a mark of her own sales skills and more due to it being the last day of the show. Still, it makes packing up and heading out easier. They checked out of their hotel that morning, so after a quick stop at a drive-through, they head straight back for Bright Moon. Starting so late in the evening with no traffic, the drive has about twenty minutes knocked off, but it's still a long way to go.

Catra got a bit more talkative near the end of the day. She seemed less closed off, even if she wasn't very chatty. She started approaching people again, at least occasionally, but she didn't protest when Adora did it for her either. In fact, she often watched her with shining eyes as she did so. It didn't make focusing on regurgitating the information she has absorbed over the last few days in easier, but it did make her happy, and Catra never stepped in to correct her, so she must have done alright.

They don't talk for the drive like they did on their way out, but Catra does still comment on things on the road or the radio sometimes as they drive, and occasionally they start up a small conversation before lapsing into silence again. Unlike this morning, it's comfortable. Catra snickers at Adora when she starts singing along with a ridiculously peppy pop song, but a moment later she joins in with her, proving that she knows the lyrics herself.

Adora is too busy grinning to rib her about it at first, but when she does Catra hisses – good-naturedly, it isn't a serious hiss – and claims that Scorpia likes to sing the song in the shower. Having heard a bit about Scorpia from Perfuma at their last group get together – they have been on one date and both seem gone on each other already – Adora totally believes her, but she still snickers as she drives. Catra air-punches at her arm, in a move so familiar that it makes her chest ache.

Catra started doing that as soon as Adora began driving them places, too nervous of messing with Adora's driving to actually punch her shoulder while she was at the wheel, and soon it became second nature to them. Catra doing it now feels like proof that she really is comfortable right now, even if she is quiet. If she was completely twisted up in knots inside, she wouldn't do anything at all. She was probably more anxious on the drive up just from worrying about how the show was going to go, actually.

With that assurance, Adora lets herself just enjoy the time in the car together with Catra.

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They are both tired by the time they pull into Adora's driveway. They stayed well after the gallery closed to take down the paintings that didn't sell, repack them, collect the sales money, and then stow the paintings in the car. On top of that, they stopped at a couple gas stations and got food. It is almost midnight by the time that they reach Adora's house, and the long drive seems to be putting Adora to sleep somewhat.

For the last half hour, maybe hour, Catra chatters mindlessly just to keep Adora's mind engaged. She isn't really participating in the conversation, but she is listening, and it helps keep her alert until they reach her familiar driveway. They still have the time and energy to unpack the car, at least, even if they just drop everything into the hall, only making it a few feet from the door into the garage. Adora releases a satisfied groan when she straightens from placing the last painting and shoots Catra a grateful look.

"I'm so ready to pass out," she tells her. Catra chuckles, reaching out to take her hand and lead Adora to her own bedroom. Adora seems grateful for it, though. Their toothbrushes are still packed, but one night without them won't kill them, and Catra doesn't feel like digging through their bags for them. She would much rather pointedly turn her back to Adora once in the bedroom and pull off her sweater so they can get in bed faster. It flusters Adora, but she quickly turns away and begins undressing herself.

Adora ends up in pajamas while Catra is in just her underwear and a borrowed t-shirt for what is – apparently – a queer-themed sandwich shop. She would be happy sleeping naked together, but she knows that would be several steps too far for Adora. If it weren't for the path her thoughts have taken as the day went on, she would call a cab to avoid leading Adora on by spending the night together.

She has no intention of leading her on. Catra crawls into bed first, balling up beneath the covers on one side, and then waits for Adora to join her with her tail tucked between her legs to minimize its twitching. Adora only briefly hesitates before she crawls into the bed on the other side. Catra waits for several minutes afterwards. At first she tells herself she is waiting for Adora to get comfortable, but then Adora settles into the same position and Catra still doesn't move. She has to do this before Adora falls asleep, though, or it will never happen.

It takes a lot of effort for Catra to roll over and shuffle closer. Adora startles a little as Catra climbs onto her and pillows her head on her chest. It is an infinitely better sleep position. Catra purrs to herself, nuzzling in and rubbing her cheek a little. She is only marking Adora's shirt, but it will have to do for now. Adora allows Catra to get settled against her, even shifting an arm to drape over her. Cuddling like this without reason is another thing Catra *definitely* wouldn't do after their conversation this morning if she could help it.

As is this: Catra shifts as she rubs her cheek on Adora and pointedly flicks an ear against her face. Adora draws in a breath. Five years and she still knows that movement means that Catra wants her to kiss her ears. Adora hesitates for a long moment, and then she reaches up and pets along her ear instead, scratching at the base when she is done. Catra tries to huff, but she ends up purring instead as Adora's fingers hit her just right. Well, this is good too, even if it isn't what Catra wants.

When Adora's fingers slow their scratching and she pets Catra's ear again, Catra turns her head to look up at Adora. Adora has her eyes closed, but she flutters them open in the darkness when Catra shifts to look up at her. Her expression is a bit raw, but she blinks blankly, unable to see Catra with the light off and curtain drawn. From the pale aura of moonlight that radiates around its edges, Catra's eyes can make out the shape of her expression.

She can see that her lips are slightly parted and her brow is slightly wrinkled. She wants to erase that confusion from her face. She wants to kiss her. Her tail lashes behind her as she shifts up a little, close enough to do it, but she can't, not yet, not without fucking saying something. She doesn't want to, but she just might want to kiss Adora and fall asleep in her arms more.

"Adora," she breathes, close enough for her breath to puff hot against Adora's lips. Adora's breath hitches, a muscle tremor running through her beneath Catra. Perhaps unconsciously, her head twitches ever-so-slightly towards Catra. Catra's tongue peeks out to wet her lips before she swallows, telling herself that she can do this: tonight, and tomorrow, and for the rest of time if Adora lets her.

"Kiss me," she requests, her voice thin and tremulous. This time, Adora gasps, the sound seeming as loud as a gunshot in the darkened bedroom. Catra can feel Adora's heartbeat racing in her chest as she parts her lips but doesn't move.

"Catra…" she responds, a warning as much as it is a plea. *I can't* or *don't ask me to* is likely the intended end of that sentence, but she can't seem to make herself say it. Her eyes squeeze shut and her breathing goes uneven, but Catra shakes her head, knowing Adora can't see but can likely still detect the movement enough to know what she is doing.

"I know what you said this morning. Kiss me," she returns, her own heart pounding. Adora freezes beneath her, even her breathing pausing for a moment as her heartrate picks up. Catra swallows, her own nerves skyrocketing the longer that Adora lays motionless beneath her. Eventually, Adora manages to swallow and open her eyes, though she doesn't manage to quite approximate where Catra's eyes are and ends up staring into the darkness at her nose.

"Catra, I need you to say it," Adora asks, a desperate edge to her voice, like it is taking everything in her to hold back and ask this of her. Her body is certainly tense with the effort of saying still. Catra swallows. She can do that. She has to. Fuck, she just doesn't know how. She closes her eyes and takes a slow, steadying breath.

"I never stopped loving you, Adora. I want my muse back," She breathes. The next thing she knows, a hand is clumsily burying in her hair and she is being pulled forward into a desperate kiss.

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The kiss is long, needy and charged with emotion. Catra kisses her back just as eagerly, her tail lashing behind her until they finally part and Catra collapses against her with a sigh. Adora feels dizzy, her heart suddenly racing. It is a jolt of adrenaline that – temporarily – pushes sleep away, though Adora knows she is going to be even more exhausted once it has faded. At the moment, though, all she can think about is the woman in her arms.

“You’re sure? You’re ready?” Adora asks, a bit breathlessly. The question is a little late, but she needs the confirmation. She feels Catra nod.

“You’ve- you’ve been good to me. We’ll have to take it slow, but fuck, I miss you so much, Adora,” Catra promises her. Adora squeezes her close in response. She agrees with that. She didn’t think Catra was ready yet, so she wants to make sure they don’t go too fast and Catra ends up withdrawing again.

“Okay. We can talk about it more in the morning, as long as you’re sure you want to try again,” Adora assures her, nuzzling around blindly in the dark and finding the top of Catra’s head to kiss. Catra purrs weakly.

“I always did. I was just afraid. But after that trip, I’m ready. I believe in you. I just lost faith for awhile and I was too scared to let it form again and risk losing you all over,” Catra whispers, her voice low and rough.

Adora doesn’t know how she is supposed to respond to that by doing anything other than kissing Catra all over again.

“You won’t lose me. All I’ve ever wanted is you,” Adora assures, whispering the words against Catra’s lips between kisses. Catra’s breath hitches and then she kisses Adora back with renewed passion.

Chapter End Notes

I promise there will BDSM again in the next chapter lol

Domesticity

Chapter Notes

> Slight referenced/implied disordered eating behavior. Description of that and the BDSM scene in the end note.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Nothing is healed by a kiss and a night sleeping in each other's arms, but it feels good. Adora clings onto Catra in the morning, unwilling to get up even after her alarm goes off. Catra snuggles under her chin, licking at her a little and sighing softly with seeming contentment at the taste. The contentment is temporary, however, because a moment later she nips at Adora and insists she gets up while Adora is still hissing with pain. Adora isn't more inclined to stand now that she is turned on, but she follows orders.

"Good girl," Catra praises as Adora reluctantly rolls out of bed, causing Adora to draw in a grateful breath before she smiles to herself. Alright, so maybe getting up isn't so bad, even if she has to watch Catra stay lounging in her bed as she shuffles about the room to pick out clothes and find her hairbrush. She is reluctant when she retreats to the bathroom to get ready, not wanting Catra to leave her sight. However, getting ready is more fun knowing that Catra is curled up in her bed just one room away.

Catra mentioned taking things slow, so Adora isn't expecting her to move in or anything, but she hopes that she will stay over sometimes at least. She doesn't want this morning to be a one-off. After four nights of sleeping with Catra in her arms, Adora doesn't know how well she is going to settle into sleeping alone again. She was never that great at it in the first place. She hopes that Catra will at least stay over after sessions. Then they can keep an eye on each other and Adora can assure her by kissing her senseless in the morning.

Changed, washed up, and with her ponytail now in place, Adora emerges from the bathroom and quickly stops dead in her tracks. Catra is right where she left her, so she isn't surprised or anything, but she feels a bit breathless seeing her like this. She looks beautiful, radiating peaceful happiness as she slow blinks at Adora from her spot amongst the sheets. She is a bit rumpled from her night in Adora's arms, her shirt bunched up and the fur on her cheeks mussed from how many times she marked Adora, but to Adora that only makes her look more attractive.

What really does it for her is the unguarded look in Catra's eyes. Catra is looking at her with trust again, no calculations seeming to run in her head about what she is allowed to do anymore. Now they have committed again, there aren't the limits there once were. Adora crosses the room, approaching the side of the bed where Catra is curled up and dropping to her knees in front of her. Catra blinks with surprise, quickly sitting up to peer down at her,

but before she can ask Adora questions, Adora reaches out and pulls her close. She tugs all the bedding off-kilter as she does so, but she doesn't care.

Once Catra is at the edge of the bed, Adora reaches for her hands and sets to scattering kisses along them. Catra squeaks as Adora presses a light kiss to the inside of her wrist. Adora looks up, knowing her eyes must be hooded just from the flush on Catra's cheeks, but this isn't really about desire. She just needs to kiss her. She needs to appreciate Catra in all the ways that she has missed getting to over the last few years.

Adora kisses her on both hands and forearms an uncountable number of times as Catra's tail lashes behind her and her cheeks blaze, but eventually the urge within her feels somewhat calmed by the barrage she has unleashed. Adora finishes with one last kiss to each palm before she drops her head into Catra's lap. She sighs a little, nuzzling in and looking up to enjoy Catra's still-flustered state.

"You're always welcome here. I want you in my bed for any reason," Adora tells her. Catra's blush doesn't fade, but her expression softens a little as she reaches down and pets through Adora's hair. Adora really needs to go fix breakfast if she wants to avoid being late for work, but right now she doesn't really care. Catra's hands on her feel so nice. Maybe they have gone too long without a session, because Adora is internally sitting at attention and ready to please just from the soft touch and the position, but the last week really wasn't right for it.

"I like being here," Catra whispers back, her voice soft. Adora swallows, blinking up at Catra's flustered expression. Her ears are pinned back, naturally defensive as she looks away, but she still forced herself to say it. "I think I'll stay today, if you don't mind. You can drive me and my stuff back home tonight after dinner," Catra tells her, still petting through Adora's hair. Adora nods eagerly. She definitely *doesn't mind*.

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Catra has no intention of moving in – it would be the very definition of not taking it slow – but logistically, it doesn't make a lot of sense for her to get a ride home only for Adora to later drive out to her house to drop off the paintings and then drive back. Catra sends a text to the townhouse group chat that Scorpia – it was definitely Scorpia that did it, even if Catra has no proof since it had that name by the time she joined it – named the Super Pal Trio, just letting her roommates know that she is fine and will be back tonight.

Texting back and forth about how the show went and how many paintings she sold takes up a little time after Adora pulls out of the driveway. Once the messages fizzle out, Catra goes digging through their suitcases. She unpacks for Adora, knowing from the last few weeks of visiting and her general Adora knowledge where she keeps most things, and she even starts a load of her dirty laundry from the weekend for her before she settles down with her laptop and spends the afternoon on managing her calendar for work.

She posted a notice on the Fright Zone site's blog section – which is pretty much exclusively reserved for availability updates or notices of new equipment or training that expands her and Lonnie's offerings – that she would have to take a surprise trip out of town that weekend due to a "family emergency". She did check her emails during the evenings at the hotel, but she fell behind on her calendar management during it. She also needs to actually reply to the emails.

She spends most of the afternoon quietly working. When she is done, she rewards herself with a nap in the divine sunroom that she has been wanting to sleep in ever since she saw it. She dozes for awhile, warm and content, but eventually she has to stretch out and get back up. She turns to Adora's room, setting to plucking through the two drawers that hold their toys as she thinks about the world of possibilities that has opened up to them all over again now that Catra doesn't have to worry about holding back during their sessions anymore.

By the time that Adora gets home, Catra is feeling weirdly inspired and a bit desperate to paint, but she satisfies herself with pouncing on Adora the moment she walks in and pinning her against the garage door with eager kisses. Adora gasps with shock, but she quickly wraps her arms around Catra's waist and kisses her back with just as much enthusiasm. Catra's tail lashes behind her as she happily sinks into the kiss, happy to fulfill a fantasy of domesticity that she has had for years.

"Have a good day?" Catra asks, a bit breathlessly, when they finally pull apart. Adora blinks, seeming a bit dazed for a moment, before she breaks into a smile.

"The best," she returns, already leaning forward to kiss Catra again.

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"You'll stay over sometimes, right? Like after sessions?" Adora asks as she watches Catra – who apparently didn't want to subject herself to Adora's culinary skills – cook dinner for them both. It's kind of weird to sit at her own kitchen counter and watch someone else cook, but Adora would be lying if she said she hasn't fantasized about moments like this before. When Catra cooked for her last week, she was too focused on planning and trying to ease Catra's nerves to be thinking domestic thoughts, but now she is watching Catra and just feeling content.

"Yeah. I think staying afterwards will be good for us both. Maybe I'll stay over on Fridays and Saturdays or something. Depends on when I have people schedule sessions, I guess," Catra tells her, shrugging a little as she turns down the burner and walks over to lean on the counter opposite from Adora, apparently done watching the food for the moment. Adora smiles at her, reaching across the counter and upgrading to a full grin when Catra takes her hand and holds it. The mention of sessions reminds Adora of two things – how badly she wants to have another one, and the conversation that they need to have before they do so.

“I’d really like to have a session this Friday, but I want to talk more about your drop first,” Adora asks cautiously, peering across as Catra. Predictably, her girlfriend tenses up, but she doesn’t completely shut down. Instead, she sighs and looks away, contemplation obvious. Adora doesn’t rush her, just squeezing her hand as she waits patiently for Catra’s thoughts to fall into order. Eventually, Catra sighs.

“What do you want to know?” she asks, looking up. Her ears are pinned back, but she isn’t completely tense. She looks more resigned. She doesn’t want to talk about it, but she is going to. Adora squeezes her hand, trying to assure her that she appreciates the effort.

“I still wish you told me earlier, but I did research and I know it must be hard to talk about. I just wanted to know if there is anything else I can do to help, and what it’s like when it comes to your clients,” Adora asks, doing her best to appear non-judgmental. She understands why Catra didn’t tell her when they were still having their professional sessions, even if she wishes that she had known about it for their sessions at home. Catra’s eye go wide at the mention of Adora’s research, but then hunches her shoulders a little as she nods. She takes a deep breath before she responds.

“Usually it starts the next day for me. Doubt and guilt, like I told you before. That’s why I think staying over Friday and Saturday night would be good for me, but the metro doesn’t go out this far, so I guess that will only work if I don’t have sessions on Saturday and don’t have to go back and forth,” Catra tells her. Adora frowns, squeezing Catra’s hand again pointedly. Catra falls quiet, looking down at it.

“I can drive you there. Or just to the nearest bus stop if you don’t want me driving you all the way to the studio. We’ll make it work,” Adora assures her. Catra’s ears twitch as she looks up to Adora, making eye contact with her for a long moment. Adora gives her an encouraging smile, hoping to coax her into staying. The spell is broken by the stove beeping, causing Catra to twitch. Catra sends her an apologetic look and pulls away to turn back to the stove.

For a few moments it is quiet as Catra changes the heat, adds some more of the ingredients she has prepped on the cutting board to the pot, and then sets another timer. She seems to do it a bit reluctantly, probably not wanting to return to the topic at hand, but it is important. She returns to stand in front of Adora again, and this time she is the one to reach out and pick up Adora’s hand first, though Adora squeezes back immediately.

“When I looked it up, most of the ‘signs’ and stuff just seemed to be standard symptoms of depression. I really want you to tell me when you have it, but can you think of anything I should watch for to tell me you’re dealing with it?” Adora asks. She doesn’t want to sound like she is preemptively accusing Catra of hiding it further from her in the future, but she also knows that Catra recognized her dropping before she realized for herself that it was happening.

Adora, unfortunately, doesn’t think she knows Catra like that anymore. Clearly she doesn’t over the phone, though she can still hope that she would notice it in person. Anything Catra can give her to help could save her a painful afternoon, though, especially if Adora has plans with her own friends and leaves early in the day before it can become too obvious. Catra once again looks at her with wide eyes, seeming touched as she contemplates her.

“If I’m not painting or getting out of bed, I’m probably having issues,” Catra tells her. Adora nods, trying to keep her expression neutral and open so Catra will know she isn’t judging her, but maybe she fails, because Catra quickly looks away and draws in a breath. “Or not eating enough,” she adds in a small, begging voice. Her body tenses with the words, fear of discussing it obvious. Adora’s heart plummets. Denying meals was a favorite punishment of their foster guardian.

It was a way to force them to fall in line without leaving a mark that they could then show as proof of the abuse in the home if they got any ideas about trying to leave. Adora hates the idea of Catra doing anything like that to herself now when she feels like she is following in their foster guardian’s footsteps, but she also knows it is a common symptom of depression. She has been guilty of it herself, especially when she was first on her own and still learning how the hell to cook.

It doesn’t have to mean as much as Adora feels like it does. Letting how sad those words make her show isn’t going to help Catra now, so though she can’t stop her brows from pinching together, she just nods. Catra breathes an obvious sigh of relief at Adora not questioning her further. Clearly Catra can cook, and when they have been together, she has eaten normally. Adora will watch how much she eats over the next few weeks and only bring it up again if she notices a problem.

“Okay. How often do you get it?” Adora asks. That’s an important question. If this only happens occasionally, then it’s a lot less of a problem, but she has the feeling that it isn’t that rare. Catra untenses a little, frowning as she thinks about that with her mouth twisted. Eventually, she shrugs.

“Every few weeks usually? I mean, I’ve gone awhile without it before and then had it multiple times in the same month. Once I get in a dark headspace, it happens more often, but when I’m doing well, it’s rarer. I end up sluggish or sore after a session probably every other week even if I don’t have any mental effects, though,” Catra explains, shrugging. Adora nods. Not as bad as she feared and not as good as she hoped, then. Still, they have been having their sessions for more than a few weeks now.

“How many times have you had it with me?” she asks, trying to keep her tone of voice from changing too much, though it is tellingly soft. Catra’s ears immediately flatten to her skull as she locks eyes with Adora and swallows. Yeah, she didn’t like that question, but eventually she does force herself to look away and answer it.

“After our second session and then again after the first one at your house. I’ve had the soreness stuff with you or drop from a client while we were meeting up outside of those two times though,” Catra admits. Adora draws in a breath and nods. Okay, so she maybe should have guessed that. Actually, she did guess the first one once Catra told her about her drop. Catra did call her after both those sessions at least. Across from her, Catra clears her throat.

“Talking with you helped, even when the drop wasn’t from one of our sessions. I think that just extending our aftercare will be enough,” Catra tells her. Adora feels her breath stutter momentarily. It touches her to know that she can help Catra like that, especially when she doesn’t even know about it. She understands a bit more now why Catra didn’t tell her before

– if she didn't need to in order for Adora to help her with it, it must have been even harder to open up about her mental health.

"Good. I want to do anything I can for you, even if it came from work and not me, okay?" Adora asks her. Catra draws in a sharp breath, her ears quivering as she stares at Adora. For a long moment, she holds her breath, but then Adora watches her shoulders fall as she nods, quick and thankful. Her eyes are shining. Adora doesn't think she is going to cry, but she might be touched enough to do so.

Catra seems very grateful for the distraction when the oven timer goes off again.

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The week is odd. In some ways, it is business as usual. Catra has a few sessions scheduled, her usual emails to answer, and she stays at the townhouse as usual. She spends Tuesday helping Scorpia during one of her baking binges – and stealing as many bites as she can without Scorpia noticing, as is their tradition – and on Wednesday she and Entrapta watch *Etherian Makers* like always. On Thursday Catra sits on top of the counter and listens to Scorpia gush about her second date with Perfuma with amusement, just happy that her roommate seems to be moving on with someone nice. It's all normal stuff.

Even the daily phone or text conversations with Adora are fairly normal at this point, though they feel different. Adora seems to be more willing to ask difficult questions, like about things related to her job and their five years apart. Catra may still feel defensive of her work, but either Adora picks that up or she has no intention of telling her that she isn't cut out for it, because she never seems to judge Catra's responses. Despite Catra's internal defensiveness, she always responds. Now that she has accepted that she wants Adora back into her life like this permanently, it feels weird that they don't know everything about each other anymore like they used to.

Things are both different and the same when they meet in person. On Wednesday, they go to the gym as usual and Adora greets her by sweeping her up into a hug. She hasn't done that before, but Catra has greeted *her* with a hug, so it isn't that far off. Catra half expects to be drawn into a brief kiss – Adora's eyes flick down to her lips for a moment, after all – but Adora seems to be taking Catra's request for them to go slow to heart, because she doesn't kiss her despite how Catra wouldn't mind it if she did. Still, the consideration makes Catra beam as they start their usual workout.

Throughout the week, Catra paints an inordinate amount, thrumming with creative energy from a combination of the emotional boost of selling six paintings in a weekend and, of course, Adora. So much is business as usual, but it all feels different. After a session on Thursday, she texts Adora for herself and asks if they are on for a session the next day, to which Adora texts her back *of course* and asks if she would like to expand her drawer at her place. Questions like that are when things feel different, but Catra texts back *yes* even as her tail lashes behind her and her cheeks blaze.

Anything you know that you want tomorrow?

To be on my knees for you.

Fuck, Adora is getting bold and Catra doesn't know how to handle it. She likes it, but she doesn't know how she is supposed to stay in control of herself when Adora is being a brat like this. She grabs her tail just to silence it as it thuds between her chair and the side of her desk beside her. It seems that Adora is going to keep pushing her limits as a dom in a way that the clients she has no connection with just can't.

I was thinking we could use the old strap.

Your new toy would be too much for my plans.

I'll make sure to clean it tonight.

Are you staying Saturday night too?

I have two appointments Saturday.

I'll drive you. I miss having you around.

I'll make you a deal.

I need some reference photos for my paintings. Help me take them this weekend and I'll come back after my appointments.

Sure!

It isn't much of a condition. The last weekend showed Catra that Adora wants to have as much to do with her art as possible. Catra may be determined to maintain her independence, but she wants to spend time with Adora too, so she isn't about to put up a big barrier to coming over. After all, she is the one asking Adora for a session right now.

There is a lot of BDSM she has never explored. It opened up once before when she and Adora agreed to sessions at home, but even more options are open to them now that Catra doesn't have to worry about going too far or being too obvious. She can also do things that might have been too harsh before when she couldn't hold Adora afterwards and assure her that she loved her, but those aren't in the plans for tomorrow.

No, Catra wants to do something she has thought about for a while, but now it finally feels right.

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Adora is still trying to figure out what counts as going slow. She asked Glimmer and Bow when she met up with them on Tuesday to gush about her and Catra getting together, but Glimmer's response was just to send her an incredulous look. Glimmer seemed like a logical choice to ask because Adora remembers that she and Bow said they started out slow, but they also began dating shortly before Bow got top surgery, so he wasn't totally comfortable with his body yet and they had good reason to hold back.

According to Glimmer, going slow doesn't include domming, and that is definitely going to continue to be a part of their relationship, so she wasn't much help. Adora is on her own when it comes to figuring out what is right for them, but maybe just asking Catra is for the best anyway. Adora still doesn't want to spring it on her in front of others, so she settles for just a hug when they meet up on Wednesday, but she really misses kissing her.

Adora waits by the door eagerly for Catra to arrive on Friday night. When Catra finally knocks to signal her arrival, Adora beams at her as she opens the door, reaching out and taking Catra's hand to pull her into the house. Catra is wearing a leather bustier top with her hair up in a ponytail, the image of the dom that Adora will happily obey the orders of, but they aren't playing yet. Adora sends her a hopeful look as she pulls her into her arms just within the doorway and tilts her head down.

"Kisses before we start?" she asks, her voice hopeful. Really, she just wants greeting kisses in general, but asking before domming in particular seems important. Catra smiles a little, her ears twitching with embarrassment as she nods. Adora breaks into a wide grin, leaning forward eagerly to seal their mouths together. The kiss is soft. They will have plenty of time for passion once they get into the bedroom. Adora happily melts into Catra's embrace. It feels so nice to not have to hold back. In their relationship, there are no more rules or barriers.

Of course there are still rules in the bedroom, but those are for fun. Catra insists on Adora calling her sir just so she can punish her when she fails to do so. Adora is happy for rules like that to stick around. They aren't actually about restriction, but rather exploration. Adora has dearly missed wrapping her arms around Catra's waist and kissing her slow, feeling the slight rumble in her breath as Catra kisses her back, unguarded and unashamed.

"Is it too much if I say I love you right now?" Adora whispers when they part, their faces still only inches apart. Catra squeaks, her ribs jumping with the sudden exhale of air and her tail lashing behind her, but she presses closer into Adora's embrace even as she ducks her head to hide her face in Adora's neck. Adora grins to herself. Flustered Catra is *adorable*. Adora holds her close while Catra rubs her cheek against Adora's neck.

"Right now? No. But if you pull that shit during a session or in public, I'm going to find a way to punish you for trying to turn things around on me," Catra tells her, sounding pleased over her obvious fluster. Adora grins to herself as Catra finally pulls back, having managed to school her face into a mostly neutral expression except for the flush still on her cheeks.

“That would turn things around?” Adora asks, smug. Catra squeaks again, this time much more indignant as she puffs up, but it isn’t the bad kind of bristling. No, it’s the kind that makes Adora want to bury her hands in Catra’s fur and pull her into a hungry kiss. Catra immediately swipes at her, shoving at Adora’s shoulder and pushing her away with a huff, but her claws are sheathed. Adora is still grinning as Catra pushes her away.

“Come on, princess. You need to be put in your place,” Catra orders her, still flustered as she straightens out her shoulders and levels Adora with a cool look. Adora immediately feels herself flush. She drops her grin and eagerly nods. Catra seems pleased by her obedience, her eyes glimmering as she steps forward and reaches up for Adora’s ponytail.

“I’m going to use you today, princess. I want you to show me how good you can be,” Catra tells her as she snaps the band. Adora's breath hitches.

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Adora put both oral and mouthfucking on her *Want* list when she revised the contract. Adora has always desperately loved pleasing Catra, whether with her hands or her mouth, so it wasn’t surprising to Catra, but it did get her thinking about the strap in Adora’s drawer – before she knew that another one was on the way – and how much she likes the sight of Adora on her knees. This isn’t something she would have done before, not when Adora wasn’t actually *hers*, but now Adora’s eyes dilate and her tongue peeks out to wet her lips as Catra pulls the strap over her hips and smirks at Adora.

Nothing but her leather top and a strap-on is a good look for her, she thinks. Adora seems to agree if the spike of desire in her scent is anything to go by. This should be her new weekend attire. Maybe they’ll have a sex marathon soon if Catra gets a Saturday where she doesn’t have any appointments scheduled. Their old strap still fits her hips nicely, though Catra has made muscle gains since they last used it and she is pretty sure she has it on a looser setting now. The toy is probably half the size of Adora’s new toy, but there is no way that Adora could fit that in her mouth.

Catra doesn’t undress before her sub. Sure, she has never undressed with anyone but Adora, but she is deciding that is a rule. Adora is already naked, practically quivering with the effort of staying still as she stands next to the bed and waits. Every now and then she twitches, seeming to want to cover herself. Though Adora has never been shy of her naked body, she is clearly very aware of how exposed she is. Catra is making sure of it, eyeing Adora’s body and reaching out to pinch her ass as she bends to lay a pillow on the ground beside the bed.

“You’re my sub, princess, but I want you comfortable while you’re sucking my cock,” Catra tells her with a wink as she sets down the pillow and then finally settles on the edge of the bed. Adora’s cheeks flush crimson and she quickly ducks her head, nodding gladly.

“Thank you, sir,” she breathes. Her eyes are dilated, already in the mood to please after the process of Catra ordering her to remove her clothing one by one. She isn’t totally submissive,

sending Catra a bit of a fond look as she says it that makes it clear she genuinely does appreciate the thought, but Catra likes that better than utter obedience. Her breath catches as Adora gladly falls to her knees and raises her hands to lightly cup the backs of Catra's thighs, silently seeking permission to tug her closer and get to work.

Adora's eyes are bright as Catra reaches out to thread a hand through her hair and draw her closer. Instantly, Adora's lips part. The sight of Adora so eager to please her sends a shiver through Catra. Her fur fluffs up a little in the wake of the shiver as she tightens her grip on Adora's hair and drags her closer to the toy. Adora's mouth falls open, already trying to take it, but Catra pulls her back again before she can, tilting her head so that they can make eye contact.

"I'm going to fuck your mouth. I'll let you onto the bed and fuck you once I'm satisfied," Catra tells her. Adora's breathing goes heavy as she nods with what limited motion she has and whines as it causes Catra to tug on her hair.

"Yes, sir. Let me please you," she begs, her voice breathy and already dripping with need. Catra suppresses her reaction down to her hand tightening in Adora's hair as she drags her up to wrap her lips around the toy. She swears an aura of peace slips over Adora as she slides down onto the toy. She really, *really* likes to please. Catra easily gets wet watching Adora's eyes close as she sucks at the strap eagerly. This harness is open at the bottom, leaving access for Catra to be fucked too if she wanted, though that isn't the plans for tonight. She is definitely going to leave the duvet cover damp as a result, but she doubts Adora will mind.

She intended to fuck Adora's mouth, knowing how much Adora likes it when she moves her hips while she is eating Catra out or when Catra fucks her mouth with her fingers, but for several minutes she has to just *watch*. When she told Adora to suck her cock, she didn't think she would take it to heart like this. She sucks the strap off with purpose, hollowing her cheeks and moaning softly, her eyes closed and lashes splayed across her cheeks. She looks obscene, but oddly happy and peaceful.

For a moment, Catra can't help but think it is a damn shame that she doesn't actually have a dick, because it seems like Adora would enjoy it, though she seems satisfied with this. After several long moments of Catra watching with her mouth growing steadily dryer, Adora's eyes flutter open. She looks up at Catra, her eyes darkened with lust, as she leans back on her heels and pulls off of the strap. Catra's hand spasms in her hair, but she lets her pull back to swallow and then lick her lips, smiling up at Catra. The smile is almost innocent, but Catra isn't fucking fooled. She is soaking after watching that display.

"Ready, princess?" she asks, her voice rough. Adora is still half-blissed out, but she grins and answers by leaning down again to wrap her lips around the strap. This time she doesn't suck it, looking up to Catra to give her blatant permission. "Squeeze my leg if you need me to ease up or stop," Catra warns her. Adora blinks once, slow and trusting, to acknowledge her words. Catra swallows, taking a breath to rally herself before she tugs Adora down for a better angle and begins moving her hips. She isn't forceful, mindful not to hurt Adora with the stiff silicone of the toy, but she doesn't need to be.

Adora moans softly and goes lax, happily swallowing down Catra's movements. Adora's eyes are soft and warm, loving and trusting, as she tilts her head a little for a better angle and

sighs out of her nose. Catra- Catra thought this was going to be a fun, kinky roleplay. And yes, she likes rocking her hips forward into Adora's mouth, but she didn't expect the look in her eyes as she did so to be the thing that turns her on the most out of the entire situation. Fuck, Catra *loves* her, and she hasn't really thought that while domming her before, but right now it is all that she can think.

"You look so beautiful like this," Catra breathes, tugging on Adora's hair a little to pull her closer. Adora moans, her eyelids fluttering a little, but she doesn't break eye contact. Despite the new angle driving the toy deeper into her mouth, Adora doesn't offer any resistance. "So content to serve. I love when I can see you entering subspace. You look so happy," Catra tells her.

She really, really does. She loves seeing Adora utterly relaxed and blissed out from something that Catra has done for her. Adora whimpers around the toy, the impression of syllables present, but she can't hope to reply with the toy in her mouth. Catra thrusts slowly and steadily, setting a consistent rhythm there is no escape from – but that isn't too fast for Adora to handle – as she grins to herself. She is fucking soaking herself, but right now she is playing with Adora.

"You're my favorite toy. Always so good for me," she continues, grinning as she watches Adora's gaze grow a bit hazier. Whether it's subspace or not, it clearly makes her feel good, and it makes *Catra* feel good as Adora completely lets go beneath her. The praise apparently raises the bar for her. Catra is happy to provide.

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Adora alternates between sucking Catra off and letting her use her mouth. Whatever pleases Catra at the moment and makes her continue to pour out those beautiful praises in her low, gravelly voice is what she wants to do. Adora can smell Catra – she must be *dripping* under the harness – and the scent only makes her mouth water more as Catra pulls on her hair to tilt her head back. Adora manages to flutter her eyes open again to find Catra's gaze burning as it locks onto hers.

"You've gotten me so *wet*, princess. I think it's time I reward you for being such a good girl, don't you?" Catra asks in a low purr. Adora's thighs twitch as she whimpers around the strap. It sounds pathetic even to her own ears, but fuck, as blissed out as she is, she really wants to get up in the bed with Catra. Catra tugs on her hair, and for a half-second Adora is sure she is going to pull her back off the toy. Instead, she stutters a yelp around it as Catra pulls her all the way down to its *base*.

Adora moans, half from being turned on and half from being startled, as her hands fly up to brace herself on the side of the bed as Catra threatens to pull her off balance from her kneeling position. Adora didn't even know that she could take the entire toy in her mouth at once – she *swears* she can feel it bumping against the back of her throat, needing all the space that she has to fit it – but Catra holds her down against it.

“Sorry, princess, I didn’t understand that. Want to try again for me?” Catra teases, a sadistic and pleased twist to her voice. Adora’s heart pounds with excitement and adrenaline as she squirms a little, but Catra doesn’t release her grip on her so all she succeeds in doing is pulling on her own hair. She could squeeze Catra’s leg, but she keeps her hands braced on the bed. She is drooling around the toy. She swallows around it, trying not to make a mess, but fuck can she *feel* it in her mouth when she does that.

She draws in a sharp breath through her nose, her mind finally processing Catra’s words – or at least, processing the order contained in them and not just how horny they make her. She has to swallow twice more and take a few steadying breaths, but she manages to moan out something approaching a *please* even with the strap muffling her words. Above her, Catra chuckles, which only makes Adora more desperate for her. She wants to please Catra. She wants Catra to fuck her. She wants to hear that sound again.

“I want to hear you beg, princess,” Catra instructs, tugging on Adora’s hair to pull her back off of the strap until only the bulbed tip of it is still in her mouth. Adora tries to keep pulling back so she can plead for Catra to fuck her properly, but Catra flexes her hips forward as Adora tries to move back, keeping her lips wrapped around the strap. Adora swallows, blinking up at Catra’s smug smirk, the image of an in-control dom.

“Oh, no. You’re going to beg on my cock. I want to hear how it muffles your pleading,” Catra tells her. When Adora slackens her jaw to gape at her, Catra pulls her forward, halfway back down the toy. Adora squeezes her eyes shut and whimpers, only growing wetter when Catra tuts in response. “Not good enough, princess,” she chides. The low whine Adora releases in response is truly pathetic, but she can’t help that she is in a fragile state. A moment later, Catra’s other hand raises to stroke her cheek.

“Hush. You’re doing well, princess, I just want to hear your voice. I like how you beg. You can squeeze my leg,” Catra tells her, her voice soft as she assures her. Adora blows out through her nose. She remembers. She opens her eyes, looking up to make eye contact with Catra. Both their gazes are soft when they meet, but heat flares in Catra’s eyes when Adora looks up at her beseechingly. If Catra wants her to beg, Adora can *beg*.

It is impossible to say how much Catra understands with the toy muffling Adora’s words, but her eyes go particularly dark at *I want you fuck me until I can’t walk* and *I’ve been a good girl*. It only takes a few seconds of begging for Catra to release her hair. For a moment, Adora stills, blinking up at her with the toy still in her mouth. Catra grins down at her, shifting to cup her face with both hands.

“Good girl, but you can come up now. You’ve earned this,” Catra assures her, before gently tugging to draw her up. Adora eagerly rises up, off the toy and straight into a kiss. She sighs softly as Catra’s pliable lips meet hers, partially because she loves kissing Catra and partially just from the relief to her jaw at finally releasing the toy. She loved doing that with Catra, but she doesn’t usually spend a lot of time with her mouth forced open like that and there is only so long she can take.

Catra shifts back on the bed as kisses her. Adora eagerly follows and climbs into her lap, straddling over her hips now they are far enough back on the bed to do so without the mattress dipping so much that Adora threatens to slip off of it. Catra hasn’t given her

permission to ride her yet, which Adora doesn't doubt that she should ask of her dom, so she settles for rubbing herself against the toy and moaning when it hits her clit.

"You've been so good, princess. Come on, take what you need," Catra breathes to her when they part, shifting to wrap her arms around Adora. Adora shivers, her mind blanking out a little at the words. She can definitely do that.

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Catra guides Adora up onto the strap, praising her as she settles onto it. After that, everything turns soft and slow. Catra ends up scooting back on the bed a little more so she can sprawl out and Adora can lay on her chest – it is clearly what Adora wants, she wraps her arms around Catra's shoulders and keeps pushing her back until Catra finally gives in and lies back for her – and Adora settles in happily, tucking her face into the side of Catra's face and working her hips back.

Catra practically cradles her as she works herself onto the toy, squirming and moaning, but somehow still seeming almost lazy in ministrations, like she is content enough being held and this is just barely worth the extra energy. Catra praises her, scattering kisses across her face as she breathes compliment after compliment into Adora's flushed and sweaty skin. They make her whimper, moan, and pant, words seeing beyond her as she sinks down into bliss again. Eventually, Catra decides that no matter how content Adora is, she wants to finally reward her with an orgasm, and she rolls them over.

"So good for me. Just relax. I want to watch you come," Catra tells her, bracing herself with one arm and reaching between Adora's legs with the other to touch her. The toy is still buried inside her, and Catra rolls her hips occasionally as an afterthought as she sets to working her clit. Adora throws her head back, moaning loudly as Catra brings her over in a matter of minutes. She has had a lot of build up, so Catra isn't surprised when she tenses up, quivering for a few seconds and then going utterly limp against the bed.

"Beautiful," Catra breathes to her. She wraps Adora up in her arms and returns to peppering her slack face with kisses as Adora breathes deeply and sinks into the afterglow.

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Catra asked for new aftercare, but for awhile they just lie in each other's arms and kiss. Adora is blissed out, but she hasn't forgotten. She waits until Catra has fetched her water before she shuffles to the edge of the bed, reaching out for Catra where she is just straightening up from stepping out of the harness and pulling her back into her arms. Catra

squeaks with surprise as Adora molds herself against her back, already dropping a kiss against her neck.

“Cute,” she observes, a pleased curl to her voice. The noise that Catra makes now is indignant. She tries, half-heartedly, to twist in Adora’s arms, but Adora hangs on, playing dirty by nipping along the edge of Catra’s jaw, well aware of what that does to her. Catra stops twisting, shivering a little instead as she arches her back and tilts her jaw a little for better access. “There you go. My dom can be cute. You’re adorable and you’re sexy as hell,” Adora tells her, grinning as she nips along Catra’s jaw again.

Catra’s trill is flustered and her following purr is reluctant. Despite her attempted protests, including swiping at one of Adora’s arms wrapped around her, Catra’s tail continues to sway and she angles her jaw to offer Adora a new spot. This time Adora follows up her nip with a soft kiss, grinning against Catra’s cheek when her purr rumbles louder in response. Adora tightens her arms around Catra, humming back as she tugs lightly.

“Let me take care of you? That felt so good, I want you to feel it too,” Adora asks. Catra’s tail is already lashing, but it picks up speed. Her purr doesn’t cease as she nods almost reluctantly and then shifts back to hop onto the bed. Adora grins as Catra lets her encourage her up to the head of the bed so they can tangle together in a tight cuddle as Adora’s hands trail down over Catra’s body, enjoying the soft curve of her well-defined muscles lurking beneath the padding of her coat.

Adora and Catra both let out twin sighs as Adora’s fingers dip between her legs, setting a steady rhythm against her clit. Catra shifts to wrap her arms around her, tucking her face down so she rub her cheek on Adora. They are basically cuddling as Adora touches her blind, but she doesn’t need to see. She knows Catra, and getting to feel every one of her soft sighs and grateful rumbles feels incredible. She doesn’t care how long it is going to take Catra to come like this – she is going to enjoy every moment of it.

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This isn’t exactly what Catra meant when she said she needed aftercare of her own, but fuck, she isn’t complaining. It feels incredible and intimate in a way that nothing they have done in bed since reuniting really has, especially when Adora begins murmuring soft praises and assurances to her, shit like *I always love playing with you* and *I love the sounds you make* and the one that undoes her finally: *I’m so glad I get to hold you and tell you how much I love you now*.

Adora holds her through it, cradling Catra as she clings tightly to her, purring and growling just a little until she finally goes slack in her arms. The endorphins that sweep over her are nice, but she doesn’t know how much they really compare to just being held by Adora. Catra spent a lot of time running, but fuck, it seems stupid now that she gets to experience Adora bundling her up against her chest and tugging the sheets out awkwardly from beneath them until she can pull the comforter over them.

Catra clings on as Adora settles down again with her head on the pillow, seemingly set on cuddling for awhile more. It isn't time to go to sleep yet, but Catra is still more than content to lie here. When it *is* time for bed, she and Adora are going to be in the same – *this* one – curled together in each other's arms. She can't wait.

Chapter End Notes

Eating behavior: Referenced difficulties eating enough at times (depression symptom) and referenced past child abuse via food denial. It's near the end of the third scene, about three paragraphs long.
BDSM scene: Mouthfucking, referring to a strap like it's a real dick.
Catra's top (SFW Etsy link, though the recommended products may not be).

Healing

Chapter Notes

BDSM description in end note.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wakes up to Catra crawling on top of her chest and nuzzling beneath her chin. She is purring as she marks her, seeming to have chosen this as her preferred method for waking Adora up. Adora, however, has no desire to get out of bed yet. Vaguely, she remembers agreeing to help Catra take photos in the early morning light, but right now she has a purring Catra in her arms. Shivering out in her backyard is the last thing she wants to do.

Adora groans softly, reaching up to wrap her arms around Catra's back and pin her tightly against her chest. With great effort, Adora rolls them over, sighing with satisfaction at the startled *mrrp* Catra makes as Adora pins her down by draping over her. Adora immediately goes limp, satisfied that her weight will be enough to hold Catra down.

"Go back to sleep," she mumbles, already tucking her face into Catra's hair. Catra tries to huff, but she is still purring, so all she really does is amplify and warp her purr for a moment. It's cute. She lightly batts at Adora's back, but Adora is unbothered. She is quite happy to wrap around Catra and go limp.

"It's nine and we went to bed at the same time. You can't be that tired," Catra points out. Adora would protest that if she were more awake. Instead, she nips at the closest part of Catra to her, which ends up being the side of her neck. Catra probably wasn't expecting it, because she trills even as Adora tries to spit out the long strands of her hair that she got in her mouth as collateral damage.

"Not tired, just happy. Wanna cuddle my girlfriend," Adora replies. She is irrefutably only half-awake, but once she gets all the way to awake, she knows she won't be tired anymore. She still would prefer to stay like this for now, wrapped up in blankets with Catra's soft fur and warm body heat beneath her. Catra trills, the sheets jumping around their tangled legs as her tail thumps against the mattress.

Apparently she is willing to use mid-morning light for her photos though, because she goes quiet after that, still purring steadily in Adora's arms as the silence lets Adora drift again.

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Adora's backyard isn't that big, but it has a single large oak in the corner that the light shining through perfectly replicates a sunbeam hitting an otherwise-dim object. Adora's help with taking reference photos mostly amounts to carefully holding objects up for Catra, with Catra positioning Adora and then ordering her to hold still while she takes the photo on her phone. She prefers to move the camera rather than try to explain to Adora the light she needs if it isn't hitting quite right in the lens, so Adora mostly just holds still on Catra's orders.

Catra is enjoying making her series of paintings following how lights bounces and plays off objects, but her memory and lifetime of observations of how it behaves sometimes isn't enough, so the reference photos are important. It has been hard to find helpful ones online. Adora, for her part, just seems to be happy to be a part of Catra's art now that she has gotten to sleep in for an extra half hour. She hums happily to herself as Catra reaches out to tweak her positioning a little to better catch the light.

"You can bring over your stuff and paint here too, you know. That's what the sunroom is for," Adora tells her, not seeming to really think about her words as she says them, but Catra *is*. Adora has her head turned and is watching a leaf stutter across the lawn in the slight breeze, but she eventually notices Catra staring at her. She turns her head and looks back, clearly confused for a moment before finally it clicks for her and her eyes widen.

"I- uh- I mean," she stutters for a moment before snapping her mouth shut, her cheeks still blazing. Catra can't stop staring at her. That doesn't make any fucking sense, but clearly it is true, or Adora wouldn't be reacting like this. Adora drops her arms, lowering the pair of scissors she was holding aloft as she pulls her arms in and withdraws a little into herself. She looks up at Catra sheepishly.

"When I pictured our dream house before, I always pictured a sunroom or something for you to nap and draw in. Even though I hadn't seen you in years, I was still drawn to this house because it had that," Adora admits, looking at Catra like she wants to make sure that is *okay*. Catra's jaw is still hanging open. It had been *four years* since she walked away from Adora when she started leasing this house. She was still thinking about what kind of home would be ideal for Catra despite the fact Catra wasn't likely to ever see it.

Catra's heart is *pounding*. She manages to close her mouth, swallowing thickly. She already knew that Adora loved her the whole time, but this still feels like a revelation. Catra's hands are a bit shaky as she slips her phone into her pocket, taking photos now the absolute last thing on her mind. Adora looks anxious, but her expression lightens when Catra raises her arms in a blatant request. Adora tosses the scissors aside, sending them skittering into the lawn as she steps forward to wrap Catra in a hug now her hands are free.

"You really love me, huh?" Catra whispers, her voice sounding only one degree away from bursting into tears. She is *not* going to cry. She can process emotions like a fucking adult. She clings onto Adora's shoulders tightly as Adora holds her close, blowing out a breath shaky with revelation.

"Yeah, yeah I really do," Adora whispers back, right next to her ear. Catra shivers a little in her arms. She is wearing a warm coat to guard against the morning breeze. The shiver has nothing to do with the winter chill. Catra buries her face against the side of Adora's neck, breathing in her scent mixed with the wool of her jacket. If she needed any further evidence

that she needed to prove to herself that Adora is in it for the long haul, this is it. Catra draws in a deep breath, blinking rapidly to force back the annoying tears that want to surface.

“I love you so much, Adora,” Catra breathes to her. Adora’s breath hitches. Her arms around Catra’s back tighten, squeezing her almost painfully close, but at this moment it is exactly what Catra needs.

All she has ever needed was to be in Adora’s arms, really.

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Catra does paint in the sunroom, although not until the next weekend. It turns out that Catra’s definition of “going slow” is just living apart during the week, which is probably for the best considering how much harder it would be for Adora to get up and go to work if she had Catra in her bed with her on Monday mornings. Their weeks are pretty much the same as they have been, keeping up over the phone and meeting up at the gym, but everything just feels different when at any time Adora can say that she loves Catra and listen to her adorable squeak of surprise.

Sometimes she even makes annoying kissy noises down the phone at her, which always makes Catra threaten to do something to her, usually involving whipping, but despite how Catra finds the noises gross, they also fluster her. It’s fun to just be themselves again without any worries. Sure, *every* aspect of their lives might not be carefree, but when they are together they don’t have to worry about overstepping anymore. Whenever they meet up, Adora pulls Catra into her arms and kisses her without hesitating.

“Look forward, Adora. I’m not above punishing you *tonight* too,” Catra cuts into her thoughts. Adora manages to suppress her response down to a slight twitch, but she snaps her eyes forward again. Catra should know Adora well enough to expect her eyes to wander as much as her thoughts. Adora doesn’t know why she is having her sit for this painting instead of just taking a picture or going off of her memory – she seems to have done that a *lot* if her catalogue is anything to go by – but she likes having an excuse to sit and watch Catra paint, so she agreed to it in an instant.

Catra’s words don’t help her be still, though. Last night Catra put the collar on her and cooed about what a good pet she was as she put Adora through her paces with the riding crop, making Adora thank her after each strike. It felt amazing. Adora has a few hickies scattered over her shoulders that she can’t help but wonder if Catra will include in the portrait. She flushes, doing her best to hold still. Catra hasn’t painted her in a very long time, and even back then she was usually sketching Adora, not painting her, so Adora has no idea how long this is going to take.

At least she is comfortable. The light is spilling into the sunroom through the windows behind her and warming her hair, which is down and spilling loosely over her bare shoulders. Adora doesn’t own anything that is off-the-shoulder, so they’re improvising with Adora being

topless aside from a woolen throw blanket she has wrapped around her arms and torso. Actually, now that Adora thinks about it, Catra definitely insisted on Adora's shoulders being exposed so she could paint her hickies. *Artistic vision* her ass.

As long as Catra isn't selling this painting, though, Adora has no objections. It would be weird for someone else to own this portrait of Adora artfully sex-tousled, but she has a bit of a thing for exhibitionism and wouldn't mind Catra displaying it or putting it up on her website. She has been working on her site a lot in the last two weeks since the show. She has been telling Adora about it, but Adora can also see the work she has been putting in when she goes to visit it, which she does regularly.

Catra has put more paintings up for sale, but maybe more importantly, she has a lot more photos up on the gallery and portfolio sections, with custom links for all her painting series as she sets to documenting her work more thoroughly. She hasn't sold anything since the show ended, but she has seen an unusual amount of visits in her analytics, most likely thanks to the business cards, so she is trying to get as much up as possible for potential buyers or other galleries to see while she is still enjoying the exposure of the show. She even chattered happily to Adora about maybe finally trying to get an agent on Thursday.

She isn't an overnight success or anything, but it's all good news, and it has been giving her the motivation to paint more than ever, apparently. She texts Adora a photo of a new painting every day. She complained this morning about how she had an appointment this evening when all she wanted to do today was paint. It prompted them to finally have a conversation they have been avoiding: where Catra's job fits into her preferred career and their relationship. Adora isn't bothered by Catra taking clients, but she is bothered by the idea of her struggling emotionally thanks to her dom drop, which even Catra acknowledges is always going to be worse with them.

Catra was defensive, but she heard Adora out. Eventually, they came to a compromise. Catra will come to Adora whenever she has drop, no matter what the source is, so Adora can be assured that it isn't hurting her too badly and can help however she can, and if Catra's art career takes off enough, she will start limiting her services more. There are a few kinks that cause her issues consistently. She admitted to Adora that she loves domming, but she definitely prefers to do it with Adora than with clients. She also needs that income, though, and she was very firm about wanting to be financially independent.

Adora has no issues with that, she just wants Catra to be happy.

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Catra has been updating her website a lot, but it isn't the only one she makes changes to. Technically she and Lonnie share *thefrightzone.com* – Lonnie is even the one who learned the coding skills for it that allowed them both to modify the site easily without needing to ask Entrapta for help every time after she set the thing up for them initially – but they both

maintain their own individual profile sections on the site and Catra is free to update hers as she sees fit.

Quietly, Catra takes wax play off her list of services. Established clients will still ask her about it, but it is a small step. She loves doing it, but of everything she does, it is the only thing clients ever undress even partially for, and now that she and Adora are actually dating she feels kind of weird about that. Nothing else feels wrong or like cheating – even wax play doesn't, really – but it just makes her more comfortable to remove it, so she does.

She promised Adora she would think about winding down on the stuff that causes her issues more often, even if she has no intention of leaving domming entirely barring her art career taking off enough that she doesn't need another source of income – which is about a one-in-a-million chance. Still, she rearranges the structure of her profile a little, pushing parties and BDSM education sessions above her one-on-one services. Those have always been the things she preferred doing, anyway, and especially now that she can get the high of truly domming with Adora, she doesn't feel the need to get it via work.

Domming others is just a job to her, and not even the one she truly wants. However, despite the increase in traffic to her site, she isn't expecting a lot to come of the art show right away. It was a first step, and her goal now should be to get an agent. She is shocked when she opens her inbox and sees someone has actually filled out the contact form to enquire about a commission. And fuck, it's a big one.

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It takes nearly two weeks of negotiating after Adora gets the initial phone call where Catra was nearly shrieking with excitement, but the deal gets signed. Thirty-six paintings for a hotel opening in Plumeria this summer. It doesn't set her for life – actually, it doesn't even set her for the *year* – but it is her first large commission, and it helps to put her name out there just like the art show did. Catra now has real cause to get an agent, which would help her promote her art further, even if she is a long way from living off of her art.

Now isn't the time for realistic reflection about how long it takes to build up a name and traction in the art world until you can sell paintings for tens of thousands though – it's the time for celebration. Catra finally gets the signed contract back with a deposit on a Monday night, but she comes straight over to Adora's house, too pent up with excitement to function without getting some of it out. Adora is ecstatic for Catra and she is more than happy to go a couple rounds until they are both limp with exhaustion.

Catra is still smiling and purring as they curl together in the afterglow. Her energy has burned off, but her excitement hasn't faded. It's more paintings than she sold in all of last year combined. She met the hotel owner at the gallery show, though, so this sale can kind of be attributed to last year's count too. Adora presses a kiss to the top of Catra's head as she pulls her close.

“I’m so proud of you,” she breathes. Catra trills in her arms, nuzzling up against her. They just had vanilla sex tonight - even if Catra still smacked her ass a few times and called her princess occasionally - so they don’t really need to do aftercare, but Adora just wants to say this. “You’ve come so far from tearing up your sketches in notebooks to hide them. Next time we go to Plumeria we’re going to stay in that hotel and see your paintings hanging up,” Adora tells her.

Catra trills again, nipping at Adora’s shoulder and hanging on. Adora grins to herself, running a hand soothingly down Catra’s back. When Catra does that, it usually means that she is overwhelmed and needs to soothe herself somehow. For her, biting is soothing. It works out since it turns Adora on more often than not. Catra isn’t upset right now, but good things can be overwhelming too. Adora knows that all too well from subbing for Catra.

“It’s only the start. You’re going to do so many amazing things, and I’m so lucky to get to watch you grow,” Adora continues, still holding Catra close. The teeth in her shoulder flex, painful but *good*, as Catra purrs loudly. Adora smiles to herself, content with her assurance for now. Too much and she risks overwhelming Catra too much, but for now she seems happy to hang onto her shoulder and purr as her tail sweeps over their tangled legs. Adora is more than happy to cradle her back.

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Catra has gone over a month now without dom drop, but the streak had to end eventually. She has been in a great place emotionally since finally committing with Adora, on top of having fewer sessions around the end of the year as everyone takes time for family and regrets their spending over the holidays, but a degradation session with one of her regulars leaves her with an anxious fluttering in her chest. She doesn’t want to jump the gun, knowing if she warns Adora it may be coming on then she is basically guaranteeing that she’ll wake up feeling like shit, so she tries to go about her Wednesday as normal.

She feels a bit better after TV night with Entrapta, but she still wakes up feeling numb on Thursday. She spends awhile just staring at her wall, sighing heavily every time she swears this breath will be the one she sits up after taking and then just *doesn’t*. Eventually she convinces herself to grab her phone off the nightstand even if she doesn’t want to get up, texting Adora to let her know that she feels like shit. Adora is at work, but Catra promised to at least let her know. She intends to drop her phone and go right back to dozing and wallowing, but Adora texts her back before she gets the chance.

You wanted to know when I had dom drop.

I have it. Still in bed. Just don’t feel up to anything.

Thank you for telling me.

You're a good dom, Catra. I know how good they must be feeling today.

I can call you as soon as my lunchbreak starts.

It's just depression stuff today. I'm not really anxious.

I still like talking to you.

I can come pick you up after work, or you can go over to my house now if you want.

I don't really want to get out of bed.

You can sleep in the sunroom if you go over.

It'll be warm and the sun will be good for you.

I'll order Panera for delivery. You'll have soup waiting when you get there.

I'm not sick Adora.

Still want to take care of you.

Is it too much? I just want to make sure you eat if you're too tired to cook.

Let me lay here and think about it.

Okay. Whatever helps.

I want to take care of my dom.

And my girlfriend <3

Catra doesn't really need to think about it, she just needs to lie here motionless for a bit before she gets up. Texting Adora has made her feel a bit better – loved – but she just has very little motivation to *be* today, much less get up and get things done. She is lucky that she doesn't have any sessions today or tomorrow. She has permanently taken Fridays off her availability in another change to her website, mostly because those are for Adora. Even if they sometimes only end up having vanilla sex now, she doesn't want to be thrown off from domming someone else that morning when she and Adora are in bed together.

Catra, despite her desire for them to be able to function independently now, likes having Adora take care of her. After a few moments of burying her face into her pillow, she can't get the images of snuggling up in the sunroom with food that Adora got for her out of her head and she reluctantly rolls over, texting Adora that she's going to get dressed and head over. Adora texts her that she'll order food as soon as Catra is on her way over so it doesn't get there ahead of her. Catra smiles to herself as she walks to her closet.

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Coming home to Catra in her bed is odd. Good – fantastic, actually – but it hasn't ever happened before. They have only been actually dating for three weeks now, after all, and Catra usually only stays on the weekends. Even when she came over earlier in the week to celebrate the commission, she had an appointment the next day and was gone by the time that Adora got home. Today, Adora gets to call out *I'm home!* as she walks in from the garage and hear an answering call from the bedroom. She grins to herself the instant she hears it.

She walks in to find Catra curled up, only the top of her head poking out from the under the comforter. Her eyes are slit and her ear flicks lazily as she slowly blinks at Adora standing in the doorway. Adora feels a touch light-headed, well aware that Catra woke up not feeling great today, but now she just seems content as she watches Adora through hooded eyes. Drawing in a shaky breath, Adora crosses the room. Catra's eyes light up a little as Adora approaches, but she closes them as Adora frames her face with both hands and leans down to kiss her softly.

"I could get used to this, you know," Adora tells her when they part, shifting to press a kiss to Catra's forehead instead. Catra purrs as she flops back in the bed and blinks lazily at Adora. Adora grins down at her. When they spoke during her lunch break, Catra admitted that she was feeling apathetic, likely from an endorphin crash, and that she felt weird about the things she had said to her client even though they requested it and had seemed fine when they left the session.

Adora did her best to assure her and she seemed better by the end of the call, but Adora still wasn't sure what her state would be when she got home. They both know well how some emotions can be hard to gauge over long distance. Adora is relieved to see Catra seeming to nap peacefully, even if she doesn't have her usual passion to her. She is clearly tired, maybe even drained, but she doesn't seem upset right now at least.

"Go take your shower. I wanna refresh my marks," Catra yawns, already tucking herself down into the sheets again. Adora smiles to herself, nodding as she straightens up. She will be happy to shower off the weird dusty smell of the office and then cuddle up to Catra as she sets about reestablishing her scent marks.

"Okay. Anything special you want for dinner?" Adora asks as she walks over to her hamper so she can start undressing. If she doesn't undress right in front of the hamper, she starts dropping clothes on her floor and they quickly pile up. It gives her anxiety. Some part of her brain will always be convinced that their old foster guardian is about to appear over her shoulder to berate her for being a slob when she leaves things on the floor. As she strips, Catra hums thoughtfully over in the bed.

"Not really. Don't feel up to cooking, but we could order something," Catra tells her. Usually Catra cooks dinner and Adora cooks breakfast when she stays over. Lunch is more variable, but Adora can admit that Catra is a better cook than her so she tends to do it more in general.

With her clothes now removed and dumped in the hamper, Adora crosses the room again to peer down at Catra. Catra, predictably, refuses to look her in the face and instead eyes her tits.

“We don’t *have* to order something. Unless it’s really just a matter of taste. I like to cook for you, you know. Glimmer taught me to make pretty decent wings. I’ve got the stuff to fix it,” Adora tells her. Catra can look at her tits without a problem, but those words make her flush as her gaze darts up to meet Adora’s. Adora does her best to smile encouragingly. Catra is clearly flustered, but after a moment she nods. Adora breaks into a wide grin as she straightens and heads back towards the bathroom.

“I’ll start after you’re satisfied with your marks,” she promises Catra. She wants her post-shower cuddles first, which means actually taking said shower. Catra doesn’t seem to have much a comeback to that, hunching down into the covers like pulling the sheet up to her eyes will fool Adora into forgetting about her blush beneath it.

“I’m never satisfied. Not until you’re covered in hickies too,” Catra shoots back. Okay, never mind, she has a comeback alright. Catra chuckles as Adora ducks her head to hide her own blush. She flees into the bathroom with Catra’s laughter following her.

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Catra, logically, knows that she has a few months to fulfill her painting order, and that finishing it early might even be annoying because it will just mean storing the paintings for longer since the hotel is still under construction. She would still really like to get a strong start on the series. She wants the first update she sends to be an exciting one that makes her client glad they chose her over another artist. Unfortunately, the universe has other plans for her. Though she bounces back from her dom drop quickly, in no small part thanks to Adora, she feels like it sapped the inspiration out of her.

She struggles to work for the next week, motivation only seeming to come to her at inconvenient times, like when she is working her actual job and can’t drop everything to paint. Whenever she actually has the opportunity to put a brush to the canvas, her mind goes blank. After a week of struggling through it, she is frustrated, and it is starting to show in her general irritability. By the time that Friday rolls around again, Catra is desperate for some time with Adora to get her head on right.

She hauls her painting supplies all the way to Adora’s despite what a pain in the ass it was the last time that she did it, mostly just because she *really* has to make some progress this week, but she forgets about painting the moment that she gets home. Adora lights up at the sight of Catra hauling her paint bag, hurrying forward to take it from her without prompting, but Catra pointedly sets it down on the floor in the hall and then throws herself into Adora’s arms instead, kissing Adora frantically. Adora, because she is a fucking *brat* when she wants to be, tries to talk even as Catra kisses her.

“Are you going to paint me again or just use the light?” Adora asks, in a few broken rushes of words between kisses as Catra growls. The portrait that Catra painted of Adora last time is now hanging in her home office, a bust painting of Adora against a dark azure background that only makes the light and warmth radiating off her more stunning. She looks like a holy icon in it – if a debauched one – and it might just be Catra’s favorite painting at the moment, but she isn’t planning on a repeat.

“Just need to get work done on the commission. Stuck. Now are we going to talk, or are we going to fuck?” Catra demands, pulling back to raise a brow at Adora, though it is a genuine question. If she isn’t in the mood, then they certainly shouldn’t dabble in BDSM. To her surprise, Adora looks over her shoulder at her abandoned bag and frowns. Catra can see the gears turning in her head. A light sparks up in her eye and finally Adora turns back to her.

“Wax play?” she asks, her voice hopeful. Catra blinks at her in surprise. She didn’t have any specific plans tonight except turning down anything impact play related – it’s not good to engage in when she is keyed-up – but now that Adora says it, wax play sounds perfect. It drives Adora wild, Catra will get to be with her until Sunday night to make sure she is okay afterwards, and it might be enough to get her creative juices flowing again. Catra glances back at her bag, an idea already forming in her mind.

“You have a razor, princess?” Catra asks, turning back to Adora. Adora doesn’t usually shave, so it’s a valid question to ask. Adora frowns, clearly confused, but she nods. Catra grins, her tail twitching behind her with excitement. She knows *exactly* what they’re going to do now.

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Catra tells her to shave everything – *everything*. Which Adora would, but it would take forever with her package of disposable razors that she mostly has just for her friends to use when they pass out over at her place or something. Catra is willing to compromise though – she wants Adora lying on her stomach, wax on her back, ass, and thighs, so that is what she shaves, with a bit of help.

The razor pretty much exclusively covers parts of her body she has never even thought about shaving before. She has never found shaving hot or even understood why people did it before, but feeling the razor run over her and knowing that soon there will hot wax in its place is certainly a turn on. It helps that Catra decides to help her shave, her free hand manipulating Adora – grabbing her thigh, or ass, or hip – as she helps her shave where she can’t really see without cutting herself.

It’s intimate, in a weird way, standing there naked as Catra either helps guide her or does the shaving for herself. Adora is nervous about cutting herself somewhere delicate, but she ends up hair free and absently runs her hands up and down the backs of her smooth thighs as Catra throws a sheet over her couch and lays a pillow on the floor for her to kneel on as she is

working with the wax. The usual preparations – water, another candle to light from, a lighter, and of course the wax play candles – are all gathered on the coffee table.

“Discovering why people shave, princess?” Catra teases, noticing Adora running her hands over herself when she turns to beckon Adora closer. Adora flushes as she follows Catra’s hand and climbs up onto the couch, stretching out on her stomach. Catra offers her a pillow that Adora slips her arms under, raising her head as she rests it on the cushion with her cheek against it so she can watch Catra preparing next to the couch.

“Maybe I understand it more. Feels nice,” Adora admits as she does her best to relax on the sofa despite how her entire body is now twitching with anticipation. Thinking about body hair is easier than looking at Catra’s satisfied smirk as she turns away and lights Adora’s scented pumpkin candle that she is using as her candle for relighting the others off of today. Adora really never got shaving as an aesthetic thing, but the smoothness feels nice to-

Fuck, the pillar candle is lit. Catra turns back to her with the dark blue candle burning in her hand. Adora takes a deep breath, letting her eyes fall closed, and settles in to wait. It will take a few moments for the candle to melt enough to drip. She has time. She shouldn’t get too excited too early. She is just going to work herself up more, and considering how intimate of a location the wax is going this time, she doesn’t think she needs *help* in the regard-

Adora hisses as the first drop falls, landing near the top of her thigh. Okay, she can handle this. She remembers it being way more intense last time- Ah, okay, because the second drop is worse. Better, whatever – the intensity builds. The third makes her twitch and the fourth has her hissing again. How can she already be wet? It’s ridiculous, but it is true. She has her legs pressed together – she is fine with this position, but she wants to make sure the wax can’t drip between her legs and onto her vagina or something equally scarring – and she can already feel the dampness on her inner thighs.

It feels fucking good, especially with her eyes closed. The stinging heat comes unpredictably, the timing varying. From their last session doing this, Adora knows that Catra achieves that by turning the candle, but she has more than just that trick up her sleeve. She is mostly dripping the wax in a concentrated area, building up the pain until Adora is whimpering, but the longer she lingers there, the less sensitive it becomes as the skin acclimatizes to the assault – or more likely, as the wax already around the spot forms a barrier to lessen the pain.

Catra keeps things intense by suddenly and silently moving the candle away from wherever she is currently working. Adora suddenly gasps out as a few drops of wax fall on the base of her spine before the candle is back to hovering over her thighs. Adora hisses as Catra continues to build a pattern of wax radiating out from her where her thighs meet her ass. Fuck, they’re so sensitive, the wax falling dangerously close to her inner thighs and her most vulnerable parts ratchets up the intensity until Adora is breathing heavy and her entire body is covered with sweat.

“Pink,” she gasps. She is instantly met with a sharp gust of air as Catra blows out the candle. A moment later, she feels a gentle hand on her head, petting softly through her hair. Adora flutters her eyes open to find Catra looking down at her with a soft smile.

“Good girl. Say it whenever you need. You’re a beautiful canvas, Adora. I’ll be happy to admire you for as long as it takes to cover you,” she tells her. Adora wants to shiver at that. Instead, her muscles twitch and jump as she quickly nods. Fuck, she can definitely call pink if this is the reward she gets for it.

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Catra covers Adora in wax, listening as she moans, whines, and hisses with the sting of each drop. The noises make her fucking mouth water. Adora sounds desperate and strung along – because she *is* – as Catra covers her thighs and ass with a myriad of colors. Her muscles jump with the stings, her moans echoing off the walls as she pants desperately trying to catch her breath, but she never manages it before the next drop falls, not even when she calls pink. She always wants the candle back before her body can calm down.

“You’re so desperate for the pain, aren’t you? You love being my canvas even more when you have to hurt for it,” Catra coos to her as she grips Adora’s leg at the knee, holding it down after a particularly large jerk that almost pulled her thighs apart and threatened to crack the wax Catra has been working on for so long.

Adora has a decent amount of wax on her, but Catra is only about halfway done. Adora whines into the pillow where she currently has her face hidden, arching her back to lift her hips up off the couch just a little. Catra tuts, moving the candle to hold it above her lower back. She relishes in the sharp hiss of pain as the next wax drop hits and Adora’s hips slam back down trying to escape the source of pain.

“Say you love the pain, princess,” Catra orders, releasing Adora’s knee so she can reach down to her side and grab another candle. She lights it off the one she has still burning and holds one up so it drips onto the top of Adora’s right ass cheek and the other so it will soon begin dripping low on her left thigh. Adora shakes her head, and for a moment Catra thinks she is trying to be a brat – the way Adora is fucking *soaking* proves that she loves the pain – but then she realizes she is resurfacing from burying her face in the pillow and shaking her hair out of her mouth. It got there in her frantic writhing. Adora has to keep her lower half fairly still, so she has been shaking her head a lot and banging her fists on the couch by her sides.

“I love the pain, sir. I love being your canvas,” Adora pants out, opening her eyes, but they are so distant Catra isn’t sure how much she is truly registering. She is gone, so deep in subspace that Catra is shocked she can even say pink when the heat gets to be much. The endorphins released by pain can be one of the most euphoric states for a sub – or at least for a masochist. Adora is lucky she is both. She barely looks lucid with her bliss. Catra gets her own high, her breath hitching upon hearing Adora say the words. She may have told Adora to say them, but fuck, she didn’t imagine them as beautiful as they came out.

“*Good girl*. You’re such an obedient sub. You’ll stay still for me until I decide you’re done, won’t you?” Catra coos to her, the end of her sentence getting a bit lost as Adora cries out

softly from twin drips from each candle landing at almost the exact same time. Adora pants out heavily, a slight whine on her breath as her eyes cast over her shoulder desperately and she seems to notice the second candle for the first time. Her eyes go wider before falling hooded as they cloud over again.

“I’m sorry, princess, I missed that,” Catra taunts, shifting the candle position only slightly before the next drop falls. Adora whines loudly, turning her face to tuck it into the pillow for a long moment as she tries to gather herself. As she does that, two more drops fall in quick succession. Adora’s entire body jumps as she cries out. Her shoulders rise and fall quickly as she gasps for air to calm herself.

She is so keyed up that Catra swears they are at risk of the neighbors overhearing her next cry. She blows one candle out, going back down to just one, though she allows it to keep steadily dripping down onto Adora’s thigh. It takes Adora a few seconds more of fighting her own body – or maybe just trying to remember the prompt that Catra gave her before the two-pronged assault – but she manages to turn her face out from the cushion again and look vaguely in Catra’s direction.

“I’ll be good and still for you,” she promises. Her voice sounds floaty to match her flushed face and the cloudy look in her eyes. Catra grins to herself, ignoring the way she is soaking herself in favor of taking in how absolutely *ruined* Adora is.

“I’m going to rail you on this couch when I’m done,” Catra promises her. Adora instantly drops her head into her folded arms and moans loudly. The pillow does nothing to stifle the sound.

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The photoshoot at the end is *torture*. Adora forgot it was coming. Well, more accurately, she didn’t know that Catra was going to do that again, though she probably should have guessed that she would make her wait. Adora was so ready to be done and finally get some relief before Catra ordered her to stay still for the pictures. She whines as she lies facedown, desperately hoping for Catra to *finish* so she can finally move. She didn’t come from the wax alone this time, but that doesn’t mean that it was any less amazing. She just isn’t as wound up today, and she knows true relief is coming soon.

When it does come, it is in the form of Catra dropping her hands to the insides of her knees and slowly pulling Adora’s legs apart, making her squirm as she suffers through the slow, purposeful separation of the wax. Catra then sets to pealing large sections of it off of her as Adora whines with disappointment. Eventually, she tries begging. Apparently that is what Catra was waiting for the whole time, because she *descends* on Adora, pressing into her hard and fast as Adora scrambles to shift to brace herself.

“You’re so fucking beautiful, princess. So *debauched*,” Catra purrs to her as Adora’s body begins *singing* with the relief of finally being touched. Adora is beyond words. She just nods

desperately and whines as Catra presses into her. She is so overstimulated, she just needs one right touch and it will all be over, but fuck, she can't even imagine what that would be right now. She is utterly surrounded by Catra, her voice purring in her ear as she leans over her and presses *inside* of her.

Nothing else matters but this. Adora is totally lost and at Catra's mercy. She pants and whines as Catra *finally* snakes a hand around to touch her clit. It doesn't take much. A bit of pressure at the right angle has Adora finally crying out and arching her back as she tenses up. Finally, the eternity of being flushed with need, writhing just how Catra wanted her, comes to an end as Adora goes limp against the couch, still panting just as hard, but with relief now.

In an instant, Catra's touch changes. It withdraws for a moment and then returns, soft and reverent as she pets down Adora's back and then carefully reaches for her hips, readjusting her until she is comfortably sprawled out on her stomach so Catra can artfully drape over her, blanketing with the soothing weight of her muscle. Adora takes a deep breath, relishing in how she feels Catra lift up with the expansion of her ribs and then dip back down when she blows out the air.

"You really are beautiful, you know. With or without the wax," Catra whispers to her. Adora shivers. Sometimes she struggles with things like that – not that she cares much about her looks, but that apathy towards herself can sometimes feel more like distaste. The one thing she knows is that Catra's paintings are always beautiful, though, and those paintings often feature her. There has to be some kind of transfer property going on there.

"I know. You're the best dom," Adora hums back. It isn't a great response, but it makes Catra's tail lash anyway. Adora will give Catra proper aftercare once she can think again.

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After a lot of disgustingly sweet aftercare Friday night, Catra finally feels refreshed. She starts painting again on Saturday, sitting in the office chair that Adora wheeled into the sunroom for her and soaking in the winter sun as she works with a throw blanket thrown over her shoulders. Last night's session was exactly what she needed to get her inspiration flowing again. The change in surroundings and having Adora lounging nearby as she works also help. In the sunroom it feels like there is an inherent life in the canvas that Catra just needs to draw out.

Adora doesn't comment on Catra's work, but she is watching fairly closely. Catra can see her reflection in the window when she focuses on it, and occasionally she turns to look over her shoulder to find Adora admiring either the canvas or her. Adora has no shame, grinning at her every time before she picks back up her phone or book or whatever other distraction she isn't even pretending to hide behind. She *is* texting her friends as Catra works, but she is definitely spending more time with her eyes on Catra than on her screen.

“You know I love what we have been doing, but if you moved in then you could paint here all the time and not have to drag your supplies across town,” Adora points out, her tone innocent. Catra raises a brow at her canvas, turning to look over her shoulder at Adora again. Adora smiles at her, expression just as innocent as her tone. It is the kind of innocence that can only come from someone who is guilty. Not that Adora has done something *wrong*, but she knows why Catra stays at the townhouse still during the week.

“It would also make going to work harder, which I need to do more than I need to paint in this room,” Catra points out. Adora pouts, causing Catra to roll her eyes as she turns back to her canvas. There is a bus stop twenty minutes from Adora’s house, but that is more of a walk than Catra has to do back at the townhouse, and even once Catra gets on the bus system she has to make her way across most of town to reach her studio. Catra likes the house, but she has a life established on the other side of town.

“What about just staying here when you don’t have an appointment the next day? Then I can drop you off at the townhouse the night before so you don’t have to ride the bus for an hour. I spend all week looking forward to the weekend right now,” Adora tries instead. Catra feels her cheeks heat, her ears twitching as she carefully puts down her brush. While Adora is flustering her is not the time for precision work.

“Then that just makes you like the rest of the workforce,” Catra points out, eying Adora out of the side of her eye. Adora pouts again. Catra looks back to her painting quickly, her tail twitching behind her. “I’ll think about it. I’m still figuring out how to balance things,” she returns, sighing a little. Adora pauses, but she nods. The truth is, this commission will be enough for Catra to live off of for a few months, and it has her thinking. Alright, the *dom drop* has her thinking. Behind her, Adora is silent for several long moments.

“Would it be pushy to ask about the drop again?” she asks. Catra’s tail twitches. She hates how transparent she is to Adora. She knows that it is a sign of how well Adora knows her and is actually – probably – a good thing, but she is always anxious when this topic comes up. Catra sighs heavily and shrugs. She doesn’t want to talk about it, but it isn’t pushy really, not when Catra is making Adora help her through it.

“I’ve been dealing with it for so long, I kind of forgot how nice it is to go without it. You made it better, I’m just conflicted,” she responds, picking her brush back up again. Dabbing it across the canvas will help soothe her some. Adora shifts behind her. Catra pins her ears back as she hears Adora stand. A moment later footsteps approach, Adora coming around to the back of her chair and hugging her around it. The tension in Catra’s body slowly releases in Adora’s arms. Reluctantly, she tips her head back and soaks in the affection.

“I thought I liked being a professional dom. I think I just like domming. It’s so much better with you. Less stressful, more fun, more *intense*. But I still need an income when this commission runs out, and I do like being involved in the BDSM scene. I even like some of my regular clients, I just don’t like getting drained by work to the point where I can’t enjoy other stuff,” Catra admits. The week has been frustrating, especially because she knows that she *can* dom and not have issues. Adora listens intently, pressing a soft kiss to the base of each of Catra’s ears once she finishes complaining.

“You said your biggest issue is when you feel cruel, right? Could you switch to only doing sadism with me? I don’t want to pressure you into leaving or anything, but I don’t really know what else you can do if that isn’t an option,” Adora admits, her tone cautious. Catra sighs. Yeah, they have had this conversation before. Adora is insistent that she doesn’t mind Catra taking clients as long as she isn’t actually sexual with them, which she never has been, but she also clearly has a lot of concerns about how Catra’s dom drop affects her.

“No, that would take quitting entirely,” Catra responds, though she sounds absentminded even to her own ears. She can’t just stop, and sadism isn’t the only thing that causes her issues consistently, but there are kinds of appointments that are easier to do than others. Parties, in particular. She has pushed those further up on her profile and put them on the top of her priority list when it comes to work, but they just don’t come up that often.

“I think I’m going to call Huntara and see if I can get advice from her this week,” Catra finishes. She didn’t start with one-on-one work and she doesn’t necessarily have to keep doing it anymore. She switched because it paid better and gave her more of a thrill, but now that she is actually making some money from her art – and hopefully will continue to do so – she could switch back just to supplement her income and ensure she has a consistent source of rent. Huntara will know her options, though. Adora nods, dropping another kiss onto the top of her head.

“I support whatever you want to do, whether it’s keeping things up or quitting entirely. I know you don’t want me to support you, but if you need it, I will do it happily. It’s an option if you want to try to dedicate everything to art,” Adora tells her. Catra huffs. Yeah, she may be hopeful this is only the beginning of her career, but she isn’t yet willing to place all her bets on it.

“It isn’t an option,” she returns, though she isn’t annoyed. Adora is silent. After a moment, Catra sighs, dropping her left hand to cover Adora’s own where it is wrapped around her waist. “Thank you. I appreciate it, I’m just not taking you up on it,” Catra tries instead. Her voice still sounds a little gruff, but Adora snorts and kisses her right ear, tightening her arms around Catra.

“I know. I just have to say it. I love you and I just want you to be happy,” Adora tells her. Catra’s heartrate picks up. She ducks her head, smiling a little to herself.

“I love you too. I am happy. I have you,” she breathes back, her voice almost embarrassingly soft, but Adora is the only one around to hear it and the words just make her tighten her arms around Catra. She squeezes her almost painfully tight, but Catra relaxes into the embrace. Sometimes Adora just needs hugs like this, when words aren’t enough but her emotions need to be expressed.

“My muse,” Catra tacks on, turning her head so she can stretch her neck up and press a soft kiss under Adora’s jaw. Adora’s eyes flutter as she leans into the affection. She loves it when Catra calls her that. It certainly sounds romantic. Catra grins to herself. “My love. My inspiration. My source of beauty and light,” she pours out, drinking in the hitch in Adora’s breath and the shiver she gives in response. Her eyes fly open and she looks down at Catra with wide eyes, her expression flooded with emotion.

“I love you so much. I just want to be with you all the time,” Adora breathes to her. Catra’s tail twitches as she blushes herself. She already told Adora why she doesn’t want to move in right away but-

“I’ll think about it,” she promises. She will. Yeah, she wants independence and she wants to make sure they don’t fuck things up again, but she can’t deny she feels the same, especially not when the words make Adora beam at her like she hung up the sun.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM: Wax play/masochism (similar to CH5).

Endings & Beginnings

Chapter Notes

> This is the end of the *main* fic for Beg For Me, but as previously mentioned, this is now a series, which I will add to sporadically in between other projects. I'll add any fics with a "plot" directly after this one in the series and put the pure smut ones at the end. Subscribe here to make sure you don't miss any future installments (though don't expect any right away).
> BDSM description in end note.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hates dropping Catra back off at the townhouse at the end of the weekend. She always volunteers to do it because she would hate waving goodbye to Catra as she sets out on the walk to the bus stop more, but she just doesn't like parting. It isn't like they even spend every second of the weekend together, but dropping Catra off signals the beginning of five days sleeping alone. Adora loves falling asleep in Catra's arms and waking up with Catra cuddled close against her chest. She even wakes up earlier on the weekends now because she sleeps so soundly with her.

Adora would be happy for Catra to move in entirely, or at least start staying over more often, but she doesn't push the topic any further for this weekend. She heard Catra on the phone with Huntara last night. They have a meeting scheduled for Tuesday, so Catra has enough to think about figuring out what options she wants to look at before then. The good news is that she always has the fall back of continuing to do what she has been if she can't come up with anything else. She can dom and come to Adora when she struggles with drop. Adora will be here for her no matter what.

"I love you. I'll miss you," Adora tells Catra, stretching across the center console to hug her before she finishes gathering her bag. Catra purrs in response, rubbing their cheeks together as she squeezes Adora back. She has already thoroughly covered Adora in scent marks since she showered after their gym trip this morning, but Adora certainly isn't going to protest one more. Her only possible complaint is that Catra isn't kissing her, but that's usually the last thing she does before she gets out of the car, so Adora happily rubs her cheek back against Catra's own.

"I love you too. And we'll probably talk *tomorrow*, Adora," Catra points out, like Adora isn't capable of missing Catra when she is just a few rooms away. Not that she is usually that pathetic, but, well, it does *happen* still. Catra starts to pull back a little and Adora tightens her grip for a moment, getting in one last tight squeeze before she lets Catra pull back the few inches she needs to pointedly roll her eyes at Adora. She is grinning though. She isn't actually bothered.

“I’ll miss you too,” she admits, still smiling as she leans in and kisses Adora before she can crow with victory. Adora would protest, but she isn’t going to waste a second of her goodbye kiss gloating. She kisses Catra back eagerly, savoring every moment that she gets before she has to return to her suddenly-lifeless house. She is happy knowing Catra will be back in five days, though. Having her there instantly improves the weekend.

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Catra was smart this time and made up a name for booking time with Huntara in the studio, not that she would care nearly as much about Lonnie snooping around this meeting. She is going to have to talk to Lonnie about what she decides to do seeing as they split the rent on this place right now, but even if Catra does decide to change gears, she isn’t going to drop sessions entirely right away. They both have their names on the lease, after all. Catra can’t just walk out on her friend without warning.

She lays everything out for Huntara when she arrives. She tells her how she always pushed through her drop because she felt like it was just something she had to deal with. She doesn’t detail how the drop wasn’t that much worse than the mood swings she was already dealing with when she first started, but Huntara is somewhat aware of what a mess that Catra was when she started learning under her anyway.

She explains that now that she is starting to make some money from her art, she doesn’t need the income from domming as badly – even if she still needs some of it – and she is looking for alternative ways to stay involved in professional BDSM without opening herself up to drop as much. When she finishes, Huntara surveys her for a long moment with her brow raised, seeming equally suspicious and considering.

“You want me to teach you to do what I do?” she asks. She doesn’t say it like it’s an actual question, but rather a given from the conversation so far. Catra blinks at her. Huntara is a professional domme technically, but her main business isn’t taking on clients. She already has two personal subs and doesn’t have the time for a lot of session slots. She has limited availability every week and usually only sees a handful of clients a month, doing most of her work for her commercial dungeon – or for events like the ones at the bar where Lonnie used to work. Those events are where Catra started as her apprentice, but she has no desire to host them for herself. She shakes her head.

“Bachelorette parties may be my favorite thing to do right now, but I think hosting the kind of events that you do would be way worse for me,” Catra tells her. Really, she is just looking for advice. However, Huntara quickly shakes her head, sending Catra an exasperated look.

“You know how to do shows, even if they aren’t your scene. No, what I actually do. Mentoring,” Huntara clarifies. Catra blinks at her. She is coming to Huntara for advice. She is not in the position to be guiding anyone else through this. Besides, that isn’t even a *job*. She doesn’t pay Huntara for her time. Early on she compensated her some because she was

working for her as an assistant at shows, but that was as much about learning as it was about reimbursing her for her time, and it has been a long time since Catra did that too.

“Do I look like someone who can tell other people what to do with their lives?” Catra responds, a bit incredulous. Huntara snorts, but she manages to compose herself right after, leveling Catra with an unimpressed look.

“You’re good at domming, kitty. You could offer education sessions. For doms looking to learn any of the skills you have, for subs who aren’t sure what to expect and need a confidence boost or to know what to look for in a good dom, or for couples that want to do things just with each other and need to know how to get started,” Huntara explains, gesturing vaguely at the rack of tools on the wall. Catra pauses, tilting her head a little as she thinks about that.

It definitely won’t pay as well, but it would be teaching skills mostly, and Catra can do that. She can’t guide someone through discovering themself, developing a persona, and getting started domming, and she especially can’t provide guidance whenever someone runs into problems like she leans on Huntara for, but teaching someone how to tie ropes or develop a system of safe words? That she can do.

“You can continue to take select clients like I do if you need more income, but most of the time you won’t be domming strangers. It should solve your issues with dom drop outside of what you do with your partner. Don’t think I didn’t notice you upgrading,” Huntara continues. Catra quickly ducks her head, already blushing. She was careful with her wording at first, but she is so used to thinking of Adora as her girlfriend now, she didn’t even think twice when Huntara asked her if she was having issues with drop in her personal life and she responded that she hadn’t really since she talked about it with her girlfriend.

“I just don’t know if teaching is really my thing,” Catra says, steadfastly ignoring the last comment. Huntara smirks. Yeah, she isn’t fooled, and if they weren’t in the middle of an advice session she would probably be mocking Catra way worse for this, but for the moment she just waves her hand vaguely and shrugs.

“I taught you well. If you start passing it down for me, I won’t have to deal with my horde of needy apprentices getting larger. Someone has to teach the boring monogamous couples how to at least have fun with each other,” Huntara tells her. Catra rolls her eyes. She is part of a monogamous couple herself now, though she thinks the last thing you could describe her and Adora as is *boring*.

“We can’t all be perfect and poly like you,” she shoots back, but it’s teasing. Huntara sighs, placing a hand over her heart like it’s a burden.

“I know, you have to manufacture romantic drama to get through the day. One day you’ll learn about reading and realize you can get your entertainment elsewhere and fuck everyone you want, but I’ll be hoarding subs for myself until then,” Huntara returns, heaving a dramatic sigh of disappointment. Catra snickers to herself. She was so anxious last time she called Huntara for advice, she didn’t really get to just goof around with her or relax. Huntara might have a tough exterior, but on the inside, she is disappointingly good at dad jokes.

Catra already feels lighter. She hadn't thought about switching to education, but that is kind of what she likes about parties – she doesn't have to dom, just act the part while she shows people the basics. Private sessions would be more in depth, but she wouldn't be opening herself up to insidious thoughts whispering that she is cruel like she does every time she doms a stranger. She would still need the studio space, so it is at least something good to try for the next five months until the lease is up, and she would have the option of maintaining sessions with her regulars for more income too.

"You really think I'd be good at it?" Catra asks, after a moment of silent thought. Her ears pin back as she says it, hating the doubt in her own voice, but Huntara doesn't immediately pounce on her to be more confident the way she used to when she was first teaching Catra. This isn't a session and Catra isn't trying to be dominant right now. She is asking someone who would know better than her if she has a shot at succeeding in this. Huntara's expression softens – slightly, but it still softens.

"You'd be great, kitty. And I think you'll like it a lot more now that you've got your girl for when you want to whip somebody," she adds, punching Catra's shoulder. Well, there goes the sweetness of that statement. Catra scoffs with indignation as she rubs at her shoulder, but it doesn't hurt. She isn't even annoyed. She's fucking smiling.

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Adora listens patiently as Catra explains on the other end of the line how her conversation with Huntara went. Adora personally thinks the idea of Catra switching over to focus on training sessions is a great idea, even if Catra sounds a bit unsure herself. Adora hurries to assure her, though it sounds like Huntara already tried.

"You taught *me* everything I know, Catra. I can personally say you're a good teacher. And like you said, this way you can transition slowly and open up more slots for traditional sessions if you end up short on cash," Adora tells her, waving her hand vaguely despite how Catra can't see it. On the other end of the line, Adora hears the faint rattling of Catra's purr being distorted by the shitty speaker.

"Thanks, Adora. I'm getting used to the idea, but I think I like it. Hopefully in a few years I'll be to the point where my art is making enough that I won't have to worry about a second job, but I need something until then," Catra says. Adora hums an acknowledgment. She would assure Catra that she really doesn't, but they have had that conversation already. Besides, Adora does agree that it's good for Catra to have her own source of income.

"I'm excited for you. I think this is going to be great," Adora tells her, grinning a little to herself. Catra snorts, but Adora's telling the truth. She does think Catra will be good at this, and even if it won't pay as well, if it makes Catra happy than that loss is more than worth it.

"Your optimism is disgusting," Catra returns, but she sounds more fond than anything else. Adora shakes her head, grinning to herself as she does so.

“It isn’t optimism, I just believe in you,” Adora responds. The flustered trill she gets back is everything that she wanted.

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Fridays are when they usually have their sessions. It just works best since they spend the next two days together. Catra can keep an eye on Adora, thus assuring herself that Adora really is happy and fine, and Adora can keep an eye on Catra, assuring herself that Catra isn’t quietly struggling through dom drop. Still, just because Catra usually doms Adora on Fridays doesn’t mean they can’t have sex other times. Catra spent all of Wednesday thinking about what Huntara said, so by the time she should be getting ready to head to the gym with Adora, she was more than ready for a distraction.

She texts Adora asking to be picked up. Adora says yes, just like Catra knew that she would, and she gets to watch the light in Adora’s eyes when she sees Catra coming down the street to where she is parallel parked with her weekend bag over one shoulder and her giant paint bag over the other. She has a few blank canvases at Adora’s place now just because they’re a pain to haul around so it is easier to have them ready to go there. She will have to turn to them to continue work on her commission over the next few days.

Catra doesn’t have another session until Saturday. She doesn’t know about moving in with Adora *officially*, but after their usual gym trip, Adora drives them back to her house, where Catra intends to stay for the next few days. It is a good place to think, quieter than the townhouse but also invigorating. Adora is ecstatic about her coming early this week, happily helping Catra carry her things inside. Catra lets her do it, but when Adora goes to take her post-gym shower, Catra stops her, drawing her back towards the bed instead. Adora perks up instantly and eagerly follows her.

They could have a session now. It would give Catra even longer to keep an eye on Adora, after all. Maybe they will do that tomorrow, but for now, that isn’t what Catra wants. She just wants to be with Adora. She takes Adora’s hand and pulls her backwards to the bed, hopping up on it and guiding Adora to climb on above her as she does so. Catra hasn’t just discovered the joys of what domming can be with Adora – she has rediscovered the joys of letting all of that go and just being vulnerable and intimate with someone too.

They kiss as they tug each other’s clothes off, and as they lay down together, and even as Adora presses into her with one finger and then two. They kiss in the throes of passion, panting each other’s names against the other’s lips. Adora’s touch is soft and reverent as she roams her hands over Catra. It makes Catra tremble beneath her, eagerly rolling her hips up into Adora’s touch. It feels incredible to just let it all go and trust that Adora will catch her. It is a glimpse of what subbing is like, Catra knows, though she could never let go *that* much.

Even when she is on bottom, she is still in charge in some ways. Adora lets her be an utter brat and she never once tries to tame or correct her. Catra bites her, and growls out orders, and goes pointedly silent when Adora says that she loves her moans. The only one that Adora

pouts about is the latter, which makes Catra finally let go of her bottom lip after forcing herself silent for all of sixty seconds, laughing and then moaning when Adora crooks her fingers and hits her just right.

It feels fucking incredible. The fingers, the freedom, the awestruck look in Adora's eyes. Catra's tail lashes as a series of shivers leave her fur fluffed up in their wake. Adora starts to raise her hand from Catra's clit to pet through her coat, her eyes sparking up with interest, but Catra growls a low warning to her. Absolutely not, she's *close*. Adora isn't allowed to get distracted now. Adora's mouth twists with amusement, but she drops her hand again and returns to her ministrations.

Catra throws her head back, already purring and maybe still growling just a little as everything in her heightens to a fever pitch. When she finally comes, it is with a single, sharp cry as Adora works her through it. Everything suspends for a moment, nothing in the world but the rushing of her blood in her ears and the heat sweeping through her, and then she goes limp back against the mattress. She quickly finds herself bundled up into Adora's soft embrace. Catra purrs happily, turning to bury her face in Adora's neck.

Fuck, that was a good orgasm. She isn't going to be capable of higher thought for at least eight minutes.

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Adora lavishes Catra in perhaps an unnecessary amount of attention as she comes back to herself, but Catra certainly isn't protesting. She is clingy herself, at least once she has the energy to be. She goes from lying limp to wrapping around Adora, rubbing her cheek against her with such force that Adora ends up lying on her back with Catra climbing on top of her, still determined to cling on tight. She isn't satisfied with her marks yet, rubbing her cheek against Adora's jaw, neck, collarbone, and then shoulders.

Catra is still purring. Now seemingly satisfied with the scent marks, she instead buries her face against Adora skin, even darting her tongue out and licking her a few times despite how sweaty Adora is following a workout and sex like *that*. The clinginess is adorable, making Adora chuckle as she raises her arms to hold Catra back just as tightly now that she seems to have settled into a spot.

"I'm not going anywhere, you know," Adora points out, her amusement curling in her voice. Catra's face is buried against Adora's shoulder right now – she can hear her breaths being stifled by Catra's attempt to breathe through her skin, though she doesn't seem at all inclined to emerge despite it – so Adora can't see her face, but Catra's tail lashes in response. She doesn't move though. In fact, she darts her tongue out and licks her again, continuing to lay claim over Adora.

"Shut up. You like it," Catra grumbles back. Adora grins at her flustered tone of voice. Catra is probably blushing a lot. It's a shame that she can't see it. Adora tightens her arms a little

around Catra's back in a hug as she hums her agreement. It makes Catra snort. She finally turns her face out from Adora's shoulder, blinking up at her as she rests her cheek against her collarbone, though she is too close for Adora to look at directly, instead seeing the amusement on her features out of the corner of her eye.

"Bottom." Catra accuses, grinning now. Adora chuckles. She raises one hand, casually petting the back of Catra's mane before she slips her hand higher up on the next pass and takes the tip of Catra's ear between her fingers, gently tugging and watching Catra's tail shoot straight out as she squeaks and quickly twitches her chin back down to hide her blushing cheeks. She growls with discontent, but she likes that – *loves* it, actually – so Adora isn't fooled.

"Who just made you come?" Adora asks, grinning when Catra's growling only grows louder. Her tail lashes behind her for a moment before Catra raises her head and glares down at Adora. Her cheeks are still flushed from desire and embarrassment.

"I'm going to dom the shit out of you tomorrow, princess. Shut your mouth now and I may even let you come," Catra threatens. Dutifully, Adora presses her lips together, though she can't dim her smile. Catra would let her come anyway – at least at the end – but Adora enjoys following her dom's orders, even when she is in a bratty mood. Seemingly satisfied, Catra drops her head back to Adora's shoulder. Slowly, her purr returns.

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Adora is utterly gone, but vaguely she has the thought that Catra has delivered on her threat. Not that it is much of a threat when Adora's entire body is singing. Adora feels hazy, nothing left in her but the endorphins pouring through her as Catra thrusts into her. She bound Adora tightly in a modified child pose, her arms tucked to her sides and her legs tied to her chest, leaving her totally open for Catra to play with as she liked, but so thoroughly bound that Adora can't hope to move a muscle.

That kind of restriction is freeing. There is nothing to do but lie face down on the mattress and let Catra fuck her at whatever pace she likes. The connection of having Catra's fingers inside her feels incredible. She feels like there is nothing but the comforting blanket of the ropes around her and the steady press of Catra's fingers. Sometimes she fucks her hard and fast and other times she slows down to an agonizing pace, but Adora has no choice except to take it all. The only way to take control back would be to say her words, but she doesn't *want* control.

Nothing feels as free as being totally bound for Catra. Nothing else in the world matters. Adora can sigh and moan and twitch beneath her bindings, but Catra will be the one to decide when she can come. Adora doesn't have to even think if she doesn't want to – right now she hardly feels capable of it – and it's like a weight lifted off her shoulders to have no responsibilities. She doesn't even have to be good because there is no way for her to misbehave when Catra has her bound up like this.

She can just slip away and let the sensations roll over her, sighing when Catra's thrusts hit her just right. Her walls clench and she trembles a little at the feeling of Catra's fingers buried so deep in her. They feel like they fill her more than it is really possible for them to, but Adora loves the connection of having Catra inside of her. Toys are fun, but when she uses her fingers, Adora feels her girlfriend, her partner, and the love of her life pressing directly into her, having her way with Adora however she likes.

"You want to come, princess?" Catra breathes to her, her tone commanding but also fond and excited. Adora moans, nodding a little into the blanket. It is the only movement she is capable of. Catra made a comment that Adora *hopes* wasn't a joke about getting her a posture collar too as she tied her up, but she doesn't have one yet and neither of them are comfortable with rope around her neck if that even could hold her still.

"Good girl. You can come. You've earned it. I want to hold you afterwards and praise you for how good you've been, just letting go for me," Catra tells her, dropping a kiss between the ropes decorating Adora's back. Adora gasps out, trying to wiggle her hips and getting nowhere, but Catra ups the speed of her thrusts and gives her what she wants regardless. Already so blissed out, the building pressure makes Adora just close her eyes and sink into the pleasure.

When she comes, it is with a happy sigh.

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Adora is utterly boneless as Catra unties her and carefully stretches out her limbs. Catra's heart feels full to the brim seeing Adora so happy. She lies there, unworried, as Catra gathers her up and stretches out in the bed with Adora draped over her. Once they are settled, she murmurs soft praises to her, telling her what a good sub she is, and how much she loves her, and how beautiful she looks with her face flushed with happiness like this. Catra sprinkles soft kisses across her face as she whispers to her, luxuriating in the heat flushed in Adora's skin from exertion and desire.

Adora is deep in subspace still. Restriction brings her there almost as fast as pain does. When she is bound, she just lets go, all her worries seeming to slip away as she places all her trust in Catra. It makes Catra feel incredible in turn. Sometimes she still has awestruck moments where she can't believe that Adora trusts her like this. It doesn't matter how long she has been domming, the utter trust that Adora shows her takes her breath away whenever she really thinks about it.

"I love you so fucking much," Catra murmurs into Adora's hair as she presses a kiss to the crown of her head. Adora hums, clearly trying to match the cadence of the quiet purr that Catra has going in her own tones. Catra usually purrs during aftercare, both from contentment and to help soothe Adora. Adora is taking a long time to come out of it today, but that is just a testament to how good she feels right now. She doesn't want to return to come out of it yet.

Luckily for her, she doesn't have to. Catra is happy to let Adora bury her face in the fluff over her heart and softly hum for the rest of the day if that is what she wants.

"I love you too. You're the best dom. Always make me feel so good," Adora mumbles back, almost slurring the words into her chest. Catra's heart skips a beat. She grins to herself as she squeezes one arm tightly around Adora's back and lightly pets her hand through Adora's hair with the other. Adora is still working her way back toward higher thought processing, but even now she does her best to assure Catra back. She took Catra's request for her own aftercare to heart, but now they have a system developed and it includes Adora just soaking in the afterglow first.

"You make me feel amazing too, you know," Catra tells her, dropping a kiss into her hair. It is true whether Catra is bottoming for her or if she is getting to watch Adora fall apart beneath her. It all makes her feel good, if in different ways. Adora hums an almost-smug acknowledgement. It would be smug if Adora was capable of making it to that emotion right now, but she is a little too limp for it, so she just hums as she rubs her face against Catra.

Eventually she will wake up a bit more and set to assuring Catra more with soft pets and praises, but Catra doesn't really need it this time, and even if she did she would be happy to cuddle Adora while she waits. Adora always gives her aftercare following their sessions now, even when Catra promises she will be fine without it, so she knows it is coming, but for now she is content. Getting to cuddle a boneless Adora is almost as good as railing her into the mattress.

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Catra doesn't totally move in, and she doesn't even start living at Adora's house every day she doesn't have to work, but she does start to stay over more often. Adora buys her a better travel easel, both so it can live at her house for now and for going to paint out in the world in the future, and Catra continues to complain about the chore of hauling her painting supplies back and forth, but Adora stops sending her pointed looks every time that she mentions it.

"We have three months left on our lease," Catra says one day, her words casual and her gaze fixed on her canvas. The words make Adora draw in a sharp breath. She knows what Catra was implying. Catra isn't going to leave the townhouse completely in the middle of it – her name is on the contract, after all, she has to keep paying rent so she might as well keep having her own place – but once it comes to an end, they can talk about her finally moving in for real.

"I'd love to have you," Adora tells her. The corner of Catra's mouth quirks up. Adora can just barely see it over her shoulder from where she is stretching, preparing to do yoga alongside Catra as she paints. Adora always did some stretching as part of her workout routine, but her love of shibari has motivated her to get into yoga to increase her flexibility and make it easier to hold more complicated positions. It is also something that she can do to be in the same room with Catra as she paints without being disruptive.

“What, last night wasn’t enough?” Catra teases, still grinning. Adora snorts, dropping her pose to sprawl out on her back and stare up at Catra as she takes a moment to rest. Okay, last night she had Catra *plenty* as she used the strap – the small one, Catra has no interest in ever trying the magicat one on herself – to bring her over twice. It was fantastic, but not at all what Adora was talking about

“Stop being horny,” Adora accuses. It isn’t something that she usually says, but after she used the strap on Catra, her girlfriend brought out their *other* one and used it on hers. Adora fucking loved it, but she needs a day to recover. Catra laughs, tossing Adora an amused look over her shoulder. She falls silent though, at least ignoring her amused purr as she focuses on her canvas once again. Adora takes a moment to just admire her before she gets back to her yoga.

She loves moments like this. They’re domestic, happy and comforting. She loves knowing that Catra wants to move in once her lease is up. They have been slowly picking up where they left off and Adora wasn’t certain when Catra would be officially moving in before, even if she is at her house often. She has previously said she would miss Entrapta and Scorpia if she moved out, but she has also said that she misses Adora during the week, so she is going to have to miss somebody no matter where she lives.

Part of Adora has thought of this as *their* house from the instant that Catra stepped through the door for the first time. Even if Catra hadn’t wanted to resume a relationship eventually, Adora always hoped she would at least want to live together again. Once it became clear that they were growing closer in that way again – or rather, that Catra was allowing herself to acknowledge the feelings that they both had been feeling even while they were apart – Adora was eager for it to really *be* their house again.

Catra staying over two or three days a week will have to be enough for now. Adora can definitely wait now that she knows when she can look forward to waking up with Catra in her arms every day.

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Transitioning her work doesn’t happen overnight. Catra spends her free time doing research, updating her site, and sending flyers to local hotspots for the BDSM scene to advertise her new services. She doesn’t even get her first training appointment for nearly three weeks, but it goes well. It turns out that her time doing parties and professionally domming has prepared her well for this. She lowers her regular appointment availability to a few times a week and prioritizes her regulars that she is comfortable with.

It works. She isn’t making as much as she used to, but it’s enough supplemental income to be comfortable. She didn’t see any sales on her site right away after the art show, but after a few months she can confidently say that the number of sales is picking up. She has already sold more this year than she did in previous ones combined *before* she factors in the commission, which she is still making steady progress on.

Once it is done, she'll focus on finding an agent. She is going to keep carrying this success forward. Having her art on permanent display in a public space will be good for exposure too. The momentum she is gaining may be small, but it's a start. In the middle of spring, she gets another request for a commission. It is just one painting this time, but that's good, because it means she can easily take it on in addition to her current work.

It's proof that her success isn't a one-off. It's validation. It makes Catra leap up and run into the other room to hug Adora with excitement, covering her face in kisses as Adora does her best to hold a squirming Catra and ask her what has her so worked up. Adora is laughing as Catra does her best to climb her like a tree and Catra is ecstatic. It might be a tiny commission in comparison to what she already has, but it's no less exciting.

Transitioning what she does for her day job isn't seamless, and it takes a lot of work to make the change. Sometimes she wonders if it's worth it, but the way she has more energy and finds herself overflowing with inspiration is worth it, at least once she has put in the work of learning what the hell she is doing and starts actually feeling the confidence she projects going into sessions. She doesn't think she would be having this success in her art career if she wasn't so inspired.

She is able to list new paintings on her site regularly, whether for sale or in her gallery, and that portfolio is what people judge when deciding whether to commission her. Right now she technically makes less each week, but she is happier, and if her career keeps building and going somewhere, she has a chance at making a lot more. Money doesn't really matter to her anyway – it's all worth it when Adora holds her and tells her that she is proud of her with her eyes shining, everything about her overflowing with love.

Chapter End Notes

BDSM Scene: shibari/bondage. This is the unfortunately-named child pose if you don't know it.
The fic notes are now up. I'll be swinging right over to a vampire project now in celebration of Halloween, so keep an eye out for it!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!